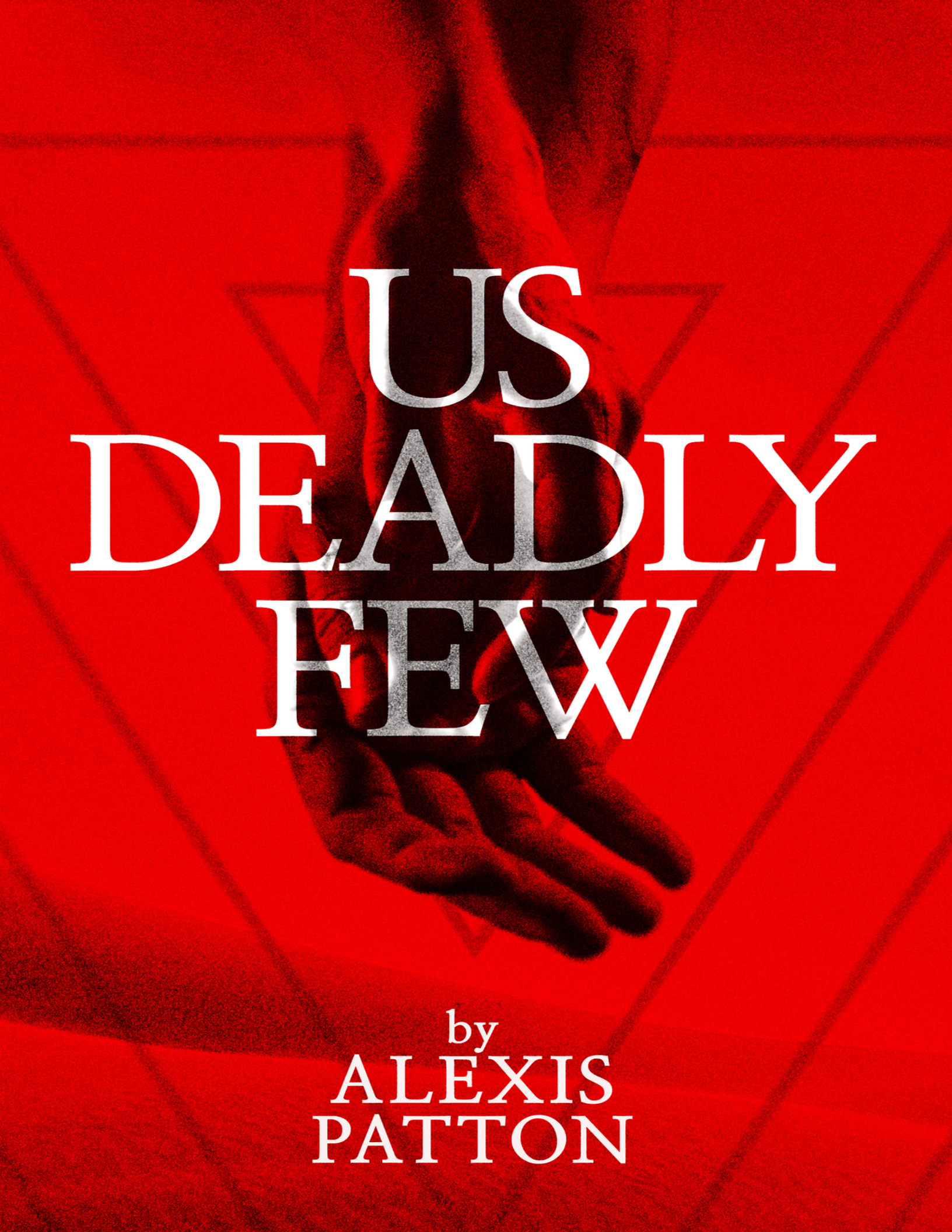

US
DEADLY
FEW
by
ALEXIS
PATTON

US DEADLY FEW

ALEXIS PATTON

OceanofPDF.com

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AUTHOR'S NOTE

I am so excited for you to dive into the second installment of Khalani's incredible journey on the Earth's surface. Before you uncover what happens next, here's a quick reminder:

If you have not read *Us Dark Few*…STOP.

Close the book. Power off the Kindle.

In order to fully understand this story, the characters, and to have the best experience, reading *Us Dark Few* is crucial.

…

…

All caught up?

…

…

Perfect.

Without further ado, I proudly present *Us Deadly Few*.

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DEDICATION

To all those who are clouded with anxiety.
May you dream under the moonlight.
And find solace beneath the stars.

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Us Deadly Few is set in a post-apocalyptic world and takes place in a hazardous wasteland. Elements that might be sensitive for readers are depictions of violence, murder, graphic language, torture, attempted sexual assault, and sexual activities. Please protect your mental health, and if you are ready, prepare to enter the thrilling world of Us Deadly Few.

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1

Tell me about life,
for I already know about death.

Destruction holds a deadly beauty.

Most people overlook it, only noticing the harsh lines, bitter scents, and deformed edges. The lingering damage triggers an innate instinct to keep moving ahead.

Your eyes float to the ground. Your pace quickens.

If you stop, the ensuing devastation could ruin you as well.

But if you take a moment and peer closer into the wreckage, images flicker of what it used to be. Something beautiful, yet pointedly ignored by most.

Because appreciation rarely comes until what you thought would never leave is gone forever.

Khalani Kanes breathed in destruction and all its possibilities. It stretched in front of her, further than the eye could see.

Within the first hour of escaping Apollo, she discarded her grey prison jumpsuit through the broken window of a rusted…

Car?

Yes. That's what Winnie had called it.

Hundreds and hundreds of corroded vehicles lay scattered across the road like an intricate maze.

The sweltering heat of the desert bounced off the thin, beige top and loose-fitting pants that fluttered around her legs amid the strong wind.

Khalani was thankful for the extra, *clean* clothing stowed in their backpacks.

Sweat stuck to her back, and a part of her wanted to strip off her clothes to cool down. But Brock warned her that the long sleeves protected her pale skin from the sun's powerful rays.

For a girl who grew up in darkness, Khalani never believed she would gaze up at the sun, much less walk the surface under its raw power.

Sand whipped against her cheek as she trudged forward, clutching the straps of her black backpack tight around her shoulders.

No greenery was visible on the desolate road. No vegetation or signs of life. All was eerily quiet in the forgotten remnants of civilization.

Khalani's eyes flickered to a black-and-white rusted sign, barely hanging off a metal pole jutting from the ground.

Arizona, Route 66.

She had no idea what those words meant.

So many things on the surface remained confounding to her. Like the tall beams in the sand with thick metallic wires dangling down. The faded numbered and lettered plates stuck to the back of the vehicles. The long road in the middle of an endless desert.

The strangest part was that nearly all the decrepit cars they passed had their doors wide open, as if the vehicles had been hastily abandoned by their owners.

Khalani often wondered what that fateful day must've been like. Witnessing fiery bombs streak across the sky, utterly helpless to stop the impending doom.

If you managed to survive the initial nuclear blasts that devastated the surface—especially the old United States—you most likely would've perished from poisoned groundwater or starvation due to mass hoarding of food. But when nuclear reactors were destroyed as well, the explosive meltdowns unleashed radioactive havoc across the world.

By the time people realized the surface was uninhabitable, the few underground cities had reached maximum capacity and shut their doors. She shuddered at the thought of patiently awaiting your death while your family and loved ones disintegrated before your very eyes.

Up until several days ago, Khalani believed the surface remained uninhabitable. She and every other citizen in Apollo were taught the high levels of radioactive fallout promised nothing but a fatal end to any who dared venture on the surface.

But they'd walked across the Death-Zone for a few days now, and Khalani felt no different.

Maybe it was a trick. In a few hours, she could very well turn into a pile of radioactive goo and melt into the concrete.

The visual was entertaining, at the very least.

All Khalani knew was that 250 miles lay between them and the nearest underground city, Hermes.

“How much farther? My feet are killing me,” Serene, the expressive thief who used to live in the prison cell next to Khalani, huffed. Her vibrant blue hair was knotted and dusted with grit, and the pale scar across her face shone brighter in the sunlight. If anything, it only enhanced her unique beauty.

Serene was more than a friend. She was the laughter you tried to contain and the inner voice of confidence when you falter.

She was the closest thing Khalani had to a sister.

At the front, Brock glanced over his shoulder. “That’s the tenth time you’ve asked today.”

“So? It’s just as true now as it was the first time I asked.”

“We keep walking until the sun goes down,” Brock reiterated. “We’re not stopping just because you’re tired and sluggish.”

“You know,” Serene started, “I liked you a lot better when you didn’t speak.”

“I *never* liked you, period.”

Serene cursed Brock under her breath as he turned decisively and kept moving forward.

The Death-Zoner appeared more at home amid the destruction. Having traveled the surface before, Brock was their only guide, and she prayed he’d be able to lead their vigilante crew to Hermes.

Khalani never believed any of them truly deserved to be imprisoned in Braderhelm. But if they weren’t criminals before, they certainly were now.

Breaking out of prison was one thing.

Murder was different.

But was it truly murder if the person they killed wasn’t human?

She shifted closer to Serene, trying to clear that line of thought before it buried her in an endless void of unanswered questions.

“If you want, I can help carry your pack for a while,” Khalani offered.

“No way.” Serene waved dismissively. “If anything, that’s what the *men on this road should be offering*.”

Serene’s gaze flickered to Derek, whose rich, dark skin glistened with sweat. Derek was more reserved than the others, a talented scientist from Apollo and the first friend Khalani made in Braderhelm.

“My hands are already full,” Derek replied, tightening his arm around Winnie’s waist.

Winnie was the Keeper of the Ordinances in Braderhelm, an avid lover of history, and practically her second mother.

During their prison escape, Winnie had been shot in the shoulder—a horrific sight she would never forget. They changed the bandage as often as possible, but blood stubbornly seeped through.

Khalani refused to believe that Winnie would be anything less than okay. But she couldn’t shake the eerie feeling when the paleness in Winnie’s cheeks didn’t recede, even under the scorching sun. She tried to offer her extra water, but Winnie gently brushed her away.

“Don’t you worry, Khalani dear,” Winnie insisted the previous night. “It would take much more than a stray bullet to get old Winnie down.”

Winnie was too stubborn for her own good, but Khalani recognized the trait well.

Only the stubborn and deadly survived on the harsh surface.

“And you, tiny nuts?” Serene swiveled her head to her older brother. “What’s your excuse?”

Adan, one of the top engineers in Apollo, wore a coy grin as he turned, his bronze hair falling over his forehead. “Oh, sis. I’d never presume to do a woman’s task she couldn’t handle herself.”

“Didn’t mom raise you to be a gentleman?”

“Those still exist?”

“And here I thought pigs were the ones that went extinct,” Serene grumbled.

A low cough sounded behind them. They turned in unison to find Takeshi Steele’s striking face cooling into a hard mask.

Her eyes roved over his strong jawline, bottomless eyes, and soft onyx hair that was tousled in a way that appeared intentional.

Takeshi didn’t have to work to be attractive. He just *was*. The kind of effortlessness an artist aches to capture in a painting. Not pretty, gentle, or subdued, but severe and honed. Like the fine edge of a sword that catches the light.

And when he swung in your direction, you’d witness the captivation of life and ferociousness of death before the very end.

“You have something to say?” Serene glared at him.

Takeshi stared lazily at Serene, raising a thick eyebrow.

Silence stretched across the ruined sands.

Takeshi had always been a man of few words, preferring the dark shadows to people. But the few times he did speak, everyone stopped and took note, begrudgingly respecting him, even if they feared him.

Serene quickly realized that waiting for a response from him was like waiting for bones to decompose.

“That’s it,” she huffed, turning back around. “There’s no hope for men.”

Takeshi was unbothered and shifted his gaze to Khalani.

She sucked in a sharp breath, his pitch-black eyes searing through her skin like every vulnerability within her fragmented mind was laid bare for him.

If she missed an hour of sleep. If she still walked funny from a knee injury that occurred nine years ago. If she harbored a slight fascination with death…he knew.

Takeshi’s black cloak billowed behind him as he openly appraised her for fleeting seconds that seemed to last a lifetime.

Her traitorous heart galloped inside her chest, waiting for *something*.

But Takeshi broke the intense stare-down and focused past her on the ruined landscape, ignoring her once more.

She pursed her lips, feeling the chasm between them widening with each passing day.

Ever since Takeshi killed the Governor, he treated her like a pariah.

Physically distant and emotionally unavailable were gross understatements.

Whenever she tried striking up a conversation, he either responded with one-word answers or blatantly ignored her. When she offered to take the night watch with him, he outright refused. And every night, as the dark clouds lifted over their heads, Takeshi slept as far from Khalani as possible.

The sudden switch mystified her.

When everyone else was asleep, she relived the ghost of his soft touches in prison. The tender night in his bedroom relentlessly lingered and the truths he relinquished never faded.

But one more thing plagued her. The haunting faces of the Braderhelm prisoners who’d been murdered while Takeshi stood dispassionately by.

After that fateful day, Khalani thought the best move was to bury her feelings in the deepest abyss of her heart and keep her distance from Takeshi Steele.

But it was as if he heard her thoughts and said, ‘Oh, you want space? Get ready to feel like an infectious disease.’

Sometimes, Khalani wondered if she’d imagined their forbidden kiss in Braderhelm. Maybe she fabricated Takeshi’s strong hands fastening to the back of her neck and his lips trailing over her skin like a brand. Or the way his obsidian eyes locked onto her stunned face after saving her from Guard Barron’s assault.

Even though Takeshi refused to speak, Khalani often found him watching her at night.

His cool expression revealed nothing of his thoughts. But whenever Brock instructed them to be more vigilant, she noticed Takeshi shifting closer to her, his menacing gaze scanning the horizon for threats.

And if the irritable Captain only wanted to acknowledge her existence when danger was present, she’d grant him the same disrespect.

Khalani continued marching under the heat of the sun, her thoughts in disarray, but she felt Takeshi’s gaze traipse over the back of her neck, like a dagger dragging across flesh.

Just when the heavy pack digging into her spine became unbearable, Brock raised his voice, “We rest here for the night.”

They stood in the middle of the highway, the sun low in the sky, and surrounded by rusty cars.

A split-second pause, then a bulky pack dropped next to her.

“Thank God,” Serene breathed a heavy sigh. “My heels feel like they’re gonna fall off.”

“You realize we have another ten days of hiking, right? That is, if you don’t slow us down even further,” Brock drawled as he loosened the straps around his camelback.

“Can I stab him yet?” Serene turned to her.

“No. He seems the type who enjoys that sort of thing,” Khalani answered, dropping her pack next to a larger, corroded green vehicle.

“She’s right. But don’t worry, you’re too innocent for my kind of foreplay.”

“Shut up before I let her stab you,” Adan interjected, stretching his arms behind his back. “Who’s taking first watch tonight?”

Unsurprisingly, Takeshi swiftly moved forward, palming his handgun. “I got it.”

The deep timbre of his voice sent shivers down her spine as he strode

past her, positioning himself against a large black vehicle a few cars down the road. He crossed his arms, leaning back against the metal, staring across the horizon.

“That one’s called a truck,” Winnie said, slowly lowering herself onto the concrete beside her with Derek’s help.

“What?” Khalani whipped her focus from Takeshi.

Winnie chuckled. “The car he’s leaning against. It’s called a truck. Figured Winnie would let you know since you’re taking such a keen interest.” She gave Khalani a knowing look.

Blood flooded her cheeks. Khalani hastily knelt, stretching her legs out, trying to rid herself of the unwelcome thoughts that kept creeping in.

“Should he really be taking another night shift?” Derek warily eyed Takeshi.

“You’re welcome to ask. Last time I offered, he just glared at me.” Adan shrugged, taking a tiny bite from a protein bar.

Despite having packed plenty of food, Brock insisted they ration their supplies, especially water, as there were only a handful of wells the Death-Zoners used on the road to Hermes.

“Think he gets tired?” Serene pondered.

“What a stupid question. Everyone gets tired,” Brock scoffed, flipping his knife in the air and catching it by the hilt. His other arm was held in a makeshift sling, the result of an injury inflicted by the Governor.

“Humans, yes.”

An uncomfortable silence settled over the group.

The perfect face of the Governor, Alexander Huxley, flashed in her mind. His coy grin suddenly morphed into a silent, open-mouthed scream, his head slowly ripping away from his torso.

Torn wires protruded from his neck as his body twitched hauntingly on the ground. And it was Takeshi that stood over him, a cold vengeance buried beneath his eyes.

Khalani shivered despite the warm weather, noticing similar, tight expressions on everyone’s faces. They rarely talked about Alexander Huxley, as if none of them had fully accepted the impossible truth.

The Governor had never been real. He was a *machine* that ruled over every aspect of their lives.

In the quiet of the night, she dreamt of his soulless blue eyes. Those hollow spheres that held a strange detachment.

Takeshi’s eyes were the opposite.

His gaze was all-consuming. Sometimes, when she looked into his face, it felt as if the entirety of the world stared back, like the depths of his fiery soul couldn’t be contained in one vessel.

“Takeshi’s not like the Governor,” Khalani stated.

“How can you be so sure?” Serene inclined her head.

‘I’ll find some flowers for you.’

His whispered words in prison swept over her. Something within her dark heart recognized him. When he spoke of his deceased mother, the grief in his eyes mirrored her own. That was not something that could be faked.

If there was one certainty Khalani still held, it was that.

“I’m sure.” The finality and confidence in her tone loosened the tension ever so slightly. Serene’s lips were pursed, but she nodded, her trust in Khalani overshadowing her doubts.

As darkness encroached, Khalani looked up at the night sky, a mesmerizing sight she never thought she’d witness. If she stared hard enough, maybe the vast expanse would answer the questions that raced through her heart.

What other lies did Apollo tell them?

Why did the Governor keep them from the surface for so long?

Was he the only machine…

As soft snores began to filter around her, she gently extracted herself from Winnie’s arms. Crouching, she grabbed her bag and carefully tiptoed away from the others, trying not to wake anyone or draw Takeshi’s attention.

She hid behind a small, broken-down vehicle, reaching into her bag to withdraw a sharp blade. The hard edge reflected in her green eyes. Without a second thought, she slowly drew the blade down her palm.

Blood wept from her skin like tears.

Khalani waited.

And waited.

She lifted the bloody hand to her face, peering closer to see if any wires lay hidden within.

But all that remained was broken skin and blood.

Taking a deep breath, she collapsed, ignoring the discomfort as she leaned her head against the car door.

Drawn to the pain, she stared at her palm again, waiting for something

terrible to happen.

But nothing did, just the same as the previous night.

And if Khalani could bleed, that meant she was real, too.

Right?

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2

Try to fix everything and you'll only end up breaking yourself.

"Hum…Humfrie…"

"Humphreys Peak," Brock corrected, standing over the worn yellow sign off the side of the road. "I think it's that thing over there." He gestured toward the far-off horizon, where a towering mound stood proudly above the sandy rocks and rugged terrain.

"Why's it so big?" Adan's jaw hung open.

"That's a…mountain. Yes, that's exactly what the old scholars from the Great Collapse described," Winnie said, her eyes widening. "She read about some on the surface that are double the size of this."

The group mumbled incredulously. Khalani took a step closer, her heart racing at the sheer scale of the raised earth. If she hadn't seen it with her own eyes, she wouldn't have believed something so immense and awe-inspiring could exist on the surface.

"What's that white stuff on top?" Serene asked, pointing to the peak.

"Beats me."

"Oh, Winnie thinks she knows!" Winnie snapped her fingers. "She remembers reading about it in a book. Begins with an s…maybe?" Winnie massaged her temple, mumbling random words under her breath.

"Let's keep going." Brock rolled his eyes, marching ahead. Khalani took another swig of water from her canteen as they begrudgingly kept their steady pace.

Only tiny remnants of a once great civilization remained. Signs pointing to mysterious cities. Abandoned vehicles that they carefully maneuvered around. She breathed a sigh of relief when none of the cars appeared to house any corpses. The thought alone churned her stomach.

"How about we play a game to pass the time?" Serene suggested.

"No," Brock grunted.

“Good thing I wasn’t talking to you.”

“Winnie loves games,” Winnie exclaimed, her smile rivaling the burning sun.

“Perfect!” Serene clapped her hands together. “We’re gonna play the color game.”

Derek coughed out a short laugh, but a single withering stare from Serene made him quickly clear his throat. “So, uh, how does the game work?”

“Simple.” She grinned. “I name the color of an object, and you guess what it is. Easy, right?”

“Sounds boring,” Adan interjected.

Serene kicked a small rock at him. “If it’s so boring, then you should solve it easily. The first color is yellow.”

“That car.” Adan pointed down the unending expanse of broken highway to a small, faded yellow car with all its doors ripped off.

“No.”

“Name something yellow? Derek’s teeth.”

“Thanks, asshole.”

“Nope.” Serene clasped her hands behind her back.

Adan groaned and gestured upward. “Has to be the sun then.”

“Maybe if you’re blind. The sun’s definitely orange,” Brock piped up from the front.

“I thought you didn’t want to play, remember?” Serene scowled at his back.

“If you’re gonna play a stupid game, at least do it well.” Brock flicked a speck of dust off his shoulder as if he weren’t traipsing through a hazardous wasteland.

“You’re such a di—”

“White,” Winnie interrupted. “The light coming from the sun is white. Not orange or yellow.”

“That doesn’t make any se—”

Bang.

Khalani’s head whipped up at the sound of a gunshot.

She scrambled for her bag where her gun was stowed. She glanced back, about to yell at the others to get down, but they kept marching forward as if they didn’t hear the boisterous clamor at all.

She froze, sweat trickling between her brows under the sweltering sun as she scanned the horizon for the source of the explosion.

“How can it be white? A ball of fire is not white,” Adan continued to argue.

A blurry figure appeared before her, wavering until it solidified. The image made Khalani’s heart pound like a gong.

It was the Governor, Alexander Huxley, staring directly at her. His flawless face and golden hair were unmistakable.

Her chest rose and fell rapidly, and she stopped moving, her feet rooted to the shimmering sand. The voices of the others faded to a low, monotonous hum.

The Governor’s lips curled into an ominous smile, and she recoiled at the crimson blood dripping between his teeth.

“Kanes.”

A hole appeared in the Governor’s chest, right where she’d shot him, expanding and bubbling over with blood. Alexander Huxley peered down, staring directly at her, licking the red stains leisurely across his teeth.

Khalani couldn’t swallow. Couldn’t breathe. Like a noose was gradually tightening around her neck.

“That wasn’t very nice,” the Governor whispered.

Her limbs shook as his neck twisted, and the skin peeled away like tape. Lengths of electric wires unraveled beneath his skin.

Reaching for her.

“Kanes!” Someone gripped Khalani’s shoulder and spun her.

She yelped, raising her fists instinctively, but it was Takeshi’s large frame that stood over her. His frown deepened at her too-wide eyes.

“What happened?”

“Takeshi…I…he…” Khalani turned back, but the Governor’s decrepit body was no longer visible. Her limbs trembled and she drew both hands through her hair, feeling like she was losing her mind.

Khalani barely noticed the deep scratches she left on her scalp.

“Tell me what’s wrong.” Takeshi moved closer, scanning the horizon for threats.

“The Governor,” she rasped. “I saw him.”

Takeshi jolted, pivoting his attention back to her. “That’s impossible, Kanes.”

“But I did! He was there. Maybe he’s not dead. He could still be after us. I don’t…I don’t,” her voice shook as she struggled to find the right words.

Takeshi’s probing stare narrowed. Like she was crazy.

Was it all just a figment of her imagination?

Was Khalani finally losing her mind?

The emptiness surrounded her, screaming and laughing. Her skin felt too tight. Like she was wearing a costume of herself.

The scorching heat of the desert burned, and the deafening silence pulled the last threads of sanity from her mind like spaghetti. She crouched down and squeezed her forehead.

“Is she okay?” Serene’s concerned voice echoed from somewhere behind her.

A strong hand wrapped around the nape of her neck.

“Head between your legs,” Takeshi’s deep voice coaxed. “That’s it. Breathe for me.”

Khalani tried to lift her head, but he held her firmly in place. When she felt his fingers prod for knots and lightly begin to massage her neck, she gave up the fight and let her head rest between her knees.

Khalani stared at the speckles of sand, nearly drooling as Takeshi methodically kneaded her muscles.

Who knew hands of death could wring such peace?

“What’s wrong with her?” Brock asked, his voice laced with irritation.

“Go ahead. We’ll be behind you,” Takeshi ordered, focusing solely on Khalani, his fingers maintaining blissful pressure on her nape.

“We need to keep moving, Steele. If you can’t help her, I’ll carry her myself.”

“Back off,” Takeshi growled. “You’re not doing anything with an injured arm. If she needs to be carried, I’ll do it.”

“I think I’m feeling better,” she whispered, but her gaze didn’t leave the misshapen rock in the sand.

How long had the lone rock been there? Was she the first to notice it? To give it one hundred percent of her attention?

Maybe that was all anyone ever wanted—to be truly seen and not just a fading object in the background.

“We’ll catch up. Go,” Takeshi commanded, leaving no room for argument in his tone. She heard the others mumble but eventually walk away, leaving her and Takeshi alone.

And she realized this was the closest they'd been in days.

"You're holding your breath," he observed.

"Not so easy to breathe while you're doing that."

She winced when his fingers dug deeper into her skin, working out a large knot from carrying the heavy backpack for miles.

"You can take it," Takeshi stated.

Khalani swallowed, his words and steady fingers doing strange things to her erratic pulse. "I'm okay now."

"You sure?"

No.

Taking a full breath was arduous, and her temples ached as if someone were digging their fingers into her brain. But if she continued to sit there like mush in Takeshi's hands, she might not get back up.

"Yes."

Takeshi released his hold and stepped back. She stood, inhaling deeply as a bead of sweat dripped from the tip of her nose to the ground. Khalani briefly turned to the spot where the Governor had been.

The sheer nothingness mocked her. Miles of sand and faraway mountains were all that stared back.

Perhaps the baking sun was playing cruel tricks on her mind.

Yesterday, Khalani pointed toward a pool of water glistening on the concrete. She licked her dry lips and hastily marched forward, but Brock roughly pulled her back by the shoulder.

"No. It's a mirage," he said. "It's not real."

Not real.

Not real.

But the Governor's blood-filled smile was clear and vivid, like he was standing directly in front of her.

It's not real, she chanted repeatedly. If she said the words enough, her madness would surely disappear.

It had to.

Deliberately, she faced the road and hoisted the backpack higher on her shoulders. Khalani forced herself to move, determined to outrun the shadows of her past.

Takeshi fell in step alongside her. Though she kept her gaze fixed ahead, she could feel the weight of his lethal energy, a static charge that made the hairs on her arms rise.

“You don’t have to lie, you know.” His deep voice broke the silence

She whipped her head, surprised he was talking to her. By now, he should’ve gone back to blissfully ignoring her.

“About what?”

“About being okay.”

“One, I wasn’t lying. And two, you can stop pretending like you give a shit.”

He went silent for a moment, jaw working as he processed her words. “I’m going to let that one slide because you’re tired. Believing I don’t care would be illogical, even for you.”

Her feet halted. Did he really just—

“You’re joking, right?”

Takeshi also stopped, the sharp lines of his face amplified by the destruction around them. He leveled his irritated gaze at her. “Since when do I joke?”

“You must be! Either that, or we’ve entered some alternate reality where truths and lies are the same.”

“Sounds like the real world to me.”

Khalani gritted her teeth. “Oh, I’m sorry. In your world, does caring mean complete ignorance and pretending I’m invisible?”

“You’re too stubborn to be invisible, Kanes.”

“Wow. I’m just *beyond flattered*. Please, tell me how you really feel, Takeshi.”

“I don’t think I should. You have a habit of punching ineptly when you get angry.”

Her glare hardened. She wanted to claw his chiseled face off. No. She wanted to raze her vocal cords and protest to the heavens for having to travel with the most infuriating and complicated man in existence.

“You know what,” she got up in his face, “it doesn’t even matter. It’s clear that we shouldn’t talk because it always ends in a fight. So, this,” Khalani gestured between them, “whatever we had before…it’s over.”

A muscle in his neck pulsed and his Adam’s apple bobbed. The tempest in his eyes was virulent, as if every waking emotion was leeching out.

She hesitated, wanting to erase the last minute and start over, but a mask of indifference abruptly settled over his features.

“I already knew that. Surprised it took you this long.”

Her mouth fell open.

For a moment, everything halted.

Like the Earth stopped spinning to witness their downfall.

His statement came with too much space. Too much weight.

Too much certainty.

Despite her statement, a small part of Khalani hoped that he would say no and fight for her. To show *something* worth believing in.

She used to believe that one day, somewhere far in the future, they would stare at each other and move a little closer. To a life where the world's problems didn't hover over them constantly and they could find a spot to lie back against the pavement. Only thinking about their next intake of breath.

Khalani imagined chasing that dream forever, their footsteps engraining stories across the sand.

Because she'd rather be insane together than be sensible alone.

But Takeshi didn't take back his ruinous words.

His fists clenched at her visible heartache, so tight she was surprised the skin didn't break.

Her disloyal heart throbbed in return, and Khalani wished she could tear the organ right out of her chest.

If you hated someone, that meant you cared.

She didn't want to care anymore.

She wanted to be like that lone rock on the road.

Enduring. Steady. Able.

Feeling nothing.

So, she let everything go the only way she knew how…

Khalani clenched her fist and punched him directly in the face.

Takeshi's head snapped to the side. He inhaled sharply, nostrils flaring. He straightened and stared back at her, unblinking and resolute, as if he'd let her hit him when he could've easily blocked it.

And that didn't sit right with her either.

She tightened her fist, ready to throw another shot.

"I let you get one in." Takeshi's deep voice lowered. "You won't get a second."

Too bad she no longer cared what he wanted.

She drew her hand back, ready to strike.

One second she was standing there, and the next, Khalani was flat on her back. When she tried to get up and punch him again, he gripped both her

wrists and pushed her arms down on either side of her head. Takeshi straddled her legs, completely immobilizing her with his weight.

“Get off me,” she spat.

“This is for your own good, Kanes.”

She glared at him, eyes wild. “You don’t get to call me that anymore. Now let me go.” She bucked her legs, but Takeshi leaned forward.

“Stop struggling, or you’ll hurt yourself. Then I’ll be forced to tie your wrists and drag you behind me.”

“You wouldn’t dare.”

His black eyes shifted like a predator’s. ‘I’ve thought of a million ways to tie you up since the day we met. Still wanna make that dare?”

Her muscles tightened, the press of his body against hers only amplifying the volatility around them. She itched to slide a knife across his throat and silence him, erasing any weight his words possessed.

Takeshi must have sensed the direction of her thoughts, because he only tightened his grip around her wrists.

Her throat cleared as she prepared to yell or spit in his face out of sheer spite. But knowing him, Takeshi would only follow through on his threat and gag her for amusement.

The sadistic bastard.

She stopped moving and closed her eyes.

Inhale.

Exhale.

Inhale.

Exhale.

Her jaw was still clenched as she tried to focus on breathing. But any semblance of patience was hanging by the barest thread.

“If I ask nicely, will you get up?” she seethed.

“Perhaps.”

“*Please* get off me…or I’m shooting you while you sleep,” Khalani added for good measure.

Takeshi’s stare bore into her when she opened her eyes. He tilted his head as if he were searching for something. A hidden answer in the depths of her resentment. But he’d already decimated any goodwill between them.

She’d treat him the same as a roach crawling along the highway.

With blanket disdain.

Without another word, Takeshi lifted himself off her.

Khalani immediately stood, aggressively wiping the sand off her clothes. Maybe it would erase the vestiges of the weak, naïve girl she used to be.

She looked ahead and noticed the others were still visible on the road, but to catch up, she needed to powerwalk like there was a soft bed waiting for her at the end of the horizon.

Khalani grumbled under her breath and began the long, dreaded march forward. Unfortunately, Takeshi followed, refusing to transform into a rock she could kick along the gravel.

The ensuing silence felt as uncomfortable as nails scraping across concrete.

To distract herself, Khalani focused her mind on another mission. One that Winnie believed was even more important than reaching Hermes.

Project Helix.

She first heard the phrase from Timothy Talbot's journal, which Winnie, a direct descendant of Timothy, had shown Khalani in secret. Timothy was said to have been a brilliant scientist during the Great Collapse, and his journal spoke of a hidden project—one that might hold the key to saving them all.

Neither Khalani nor Winnie knew what Project Helix meant, but Winnie was convinced that it was the key to safeguarding humanity's future.

But as Khalani gazed at the heaps of ruin surrounding her, it was clear that Project Helix—whatever it was—never worked.

She crossed her arms, her head aching, as the sun lowered, navigating around the scattered cars and broken metal parts like an obstacle course.

"Is your plan to still shoot me when the sun goes down?" Takeshi's voice broke through the cold stiffness, surprising her. She hadn't realized he was keeping pace just a few feet away. His black hair fluttered across his face, thick lashes framing his penetrating eyes.

She glared in his direction. "I'm debating whether letting you rot in anticipation will be worse."

"Or a part of you knows you wouldn't be able to pull the trigger." Takeshi tilted his head, his face stoic.

"You'd be a fool to think that." She lifted her chin, letting him see the madness in her eyes. "If I were you, I'd sleep very, very lightly."

"That's fine." He shrugged, as if they were discussing the weather and not imminent murder. "I already keep an eye on you while you sleep."

"Sounds unhealthy," she deadpanned.

“Probably.”

“And psychotic.”

“Stop with the compliments.”

Khalani scoffed and abruptly increased her pace, trying to distance herself from his insufferable presence. A failing effort thanks to his oversized legs matching her stride.

By the time they caught up with the others, the sun was low in the sky, and her calves and thighs were screaming for relief.

“You alright?” Serene asked as Khalani and Takeshi finally arrived at their resting spot under a half-torn bridge.

“I’m better,” she replied, struggling to catch her breath as she dropped her pack unceremoniously to the ground. “Just felt a little woozy back there.”

Khalani didn’t want to spook the others with her eerie vision of the Governor. The last thing she needed was for anyone else to question her sanity. Takeshi already did an incredible job at that.

“Come, sit.” Derek patted the empty ground next to him. “We can share a protein bar.”

The corner of her mouth quirked up, and Khalani groaned as she sat on the hard ground. All the training with Takeshi in Braderhelm couldn’t have prepared her for the miles of hiking every day under the blistering sun.

How humans managed to survive before the Great Collapse was a great mystery to her.

The temperature continued to drop, and Khalani hugged her knees closer to her chest as she ate.

“Be careful with your portions,” Brock warned. “We still have another week before we reach Hermes, and that’s if we don’t run into any storms.”

“What kind of storms we talking?” Adan peered up as he rummaged through his pack.

“Sandstorms. Nasty fuckers that can bury you alive.” Brock’s voice dipped as he stared beyond the bridge. “We’ll be able to spot most from a distance, but they move fast out here. If I tell you to run for the nearest shelter, you don’t ask why.”

“And here I thought the surface would be fun. Next thing you’ll tell me is that there are plants out here that can eat us,” Serene grumbled, plopping down beside her with a huff.

Derek lifted a finger. “Actually, there used to be a carnivorous plant species called the Venus fl—”

“As *fascinating* as this conversation is,” Brock cut in, “we need to figure out who’s taking watch tonight. Steele, you’re not doing it a fourth night in a row.”

“I can do it,” Serene stated.

“No,” Brock clipped. “You don’t even know how to use a gun.”

“Sure, I do. I just aim the pointy end at you and shoot.”

Brock looked heavenward, like he was questioning what he’d done wrong in a previous life.

“I got it.” Khalani rose to her feet. She needed the distraction.

“No way. Didn’t you almost pass out today?” Brock frowned.

“Agreed. It should be someone else,” Takeshi spoke for the first time.

Khalani snapped her gaze to him. He leaned his left shoulder against the pillar supporting the bridge. His posture was too calm against the wicked fervor in his expression.

No one else probably noticed.

“I’m *fine*. And besides,” she palmed her handgun, “I have no problem shooting any psychos that might wander our way. Right, Takeshi?”

“Yes, I’m sure one look at you with a gun will scare anyone straight off.”

If there were a prize for getting under someone’s skin, Takeshi would emphatically win first place. He was worse than a bug. Worse than the bacteria that lived on a bug. And she wanted nothing more than to march over and knee him between the legs to prevent procreation.

Her final gift to humanity.

“You’re so right.” She plastered on a fake smile. “Thank God I believe in shooting first and asking questions later.”

The corner of his lip barely lifted.

“Okay, but if I have to pee in the middle of the night, I’m not gonna get shot, right?” Adan looked back and forth between them.

Khalani rolled her eyes and picked up her bag. “I’ll set post over there.” She pointed to a large brown vehicle that may have been white in the past but was covered in layers of rust. “You guys should get some sleep.”

She strode right past Takeshi, ignoring him completely, and threw her bag onto the car’s hood. Raising her arms behind her back, she let out a groan as the cracks and pops of her stiff muscles echoed in the stiff quiet.

After a moment, Khalani lifted herself on the hood and leaned back against the windshield. One hand rested on the gun in her lap, and the other crooked behind her head.

Soon after, the soft sound of snores filtered through the space. To keep herself occupied, Khalani imagined colors painting across the concrete ceiling. She attempted to conjure a myriad of greens, reds, and purples, reminiscent of the aurora borealis Winnie had once shown her in prison.

But no matter how hard she tried, no image came forth.

Like a thick wall had permanently covered her mind.

All she could see were the Governor’s piercing blue eyes staring back at her. And he never stopped smiling.

As if he knew something she didn’t.

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3

A woman’s worth isn’t in her beauty.
It lies in her resilience.

The heat of the blazing sun was relentless.

Hour after hour, sweat beaded down the side of her neck, dripping down her sore calves. She glanced at Winnie, her heart tightening with concern.

Winnie’s pale skin had taken on a greenish hue, and her gait had slowed progressively. Derek changed the dressing on her wound once more, and they took turns supporting her.

“What’s that?” Serene pointed ahead to a grey building just off the side of the road.

A tall sign stood high over the abandoned structure, displaying white numbers that read: **$30.99** per gallon.

Her eyes shifted to the pallets of wood covering the windows, spray-painted with the words: WE ARE OUT OF GAS. The red block letters were barely legible, like the writer hastily scribbled the message while drunk.

Strange black pillars lay crumbled about outside the building. Even more bizarre was the tiny car folded in on itself like origami, with one pillar piercing its front windshield.

A dull red sign hung crookedly on the front of the building: AS STATION.

“Ass station?” Adan drawled.

“Gas station.” Brock prowled forward, kicking stray debris out of the way. “I’ve rested here on previous runs across the Death-Zone. The infrastructure is solid enough. We can rest here for ten minutes and ten minutes only.” He flicked an irritated gaze toward Serene.

“Yeah, yeah.” Serene waved him off and stepped through the open door, shards of glass crunching under her boots. Khalani swallowed, following her inside.

The interior was a warzone.

Shelves were toppled over. Broken glass was everywhere. Dust specks were visible in the sunlight that streamed through a gargantuan hole in the roof.

A part of her didn't even want to know how that happened.

"There's really nothing left," Derek said, his voice a mix of wonder and dismay as he stepped into the grimy space.

Khalani flinched when a lone cockroach crawled along the back wall and disappeared under an empty cardboard box.

"They're all like that," Brock said in a low voice. "Nearly all the stores on the road were picked clean. Some things were forgotten, though." The corner of his mouth quirked up, the most relaxed she'd seen him, as he headed straight for the back corner.

Her brows furrowed as Brock pushed aside some dusty shelves on the floor, revealing a stack of papers with colorful images painted on top.

"What's that?"

A depraved expression manifested on Brock's face as he flipped the pages around.

A beautiful, busty blonde graced the cover, wearing nothing but brown boots, a weird-rimmed hat, and white panties. Her breasts and nipples were fully displayed as she stared straight at them with a seductive grin.

Khalani's cheeks reddened, her mouth forming an O. Brock continued flipping through the lewd images, each one more salacious than the last.

Adan quickly maneuvered around her, his eyes lighting up.

"Is that what I think it is?"

Brock grinned. "From what I know, they used to sell these in all the Great Collapse stores." When he flipped to an image of two women in bizarre suits throwing mud at each other, Adan's expression transformed into pure awe.

"I don't see what the big fuss is." Serene barged forward, snatching the magazine from Brock's hands. "Those boobs aren't even real. They look like plastic balloons."

"Jealous?" Brock's eyes gleamed.

"Why would I be jealous of ancient bimbos?"

"Be nice, Serene." Winnie reprimanded as Derek helped her sit on the tiled floor. "Women support, not shame."

"*Please* don't give me that look, Winnie." Serene sighed. "They're not

even alive!”

“And we should still celebrate them.”

“I’m in total agreement,” Adan smirked.

Serene grimaced and shoved the magazine into Brock’s chest with one hand while smacking her brother on the back of the head with the other.

Khalani found herself still staring at the pictures.

She didn’t normally think about her body. She’d never had a reason to. In Apollo, status depended on wealth, and she’d been at the bottom of the pecking order. But as she gazed at the women, she couldn’t help but compare herself.

Khalani had a firm backside, and her body was toned from the lack of calories and torturous training sessions with Takeshi in Braderhelm. But her chest was lacking in comparison, and judging by the laughter and teasing in the women’s expressions, their energy drew people in like the sun.

Khalani was dark and depressing. Like a raincloud.

She’d never seen a raincloud, but from what she read in Winnie’s library, they didn’t bring joy. They brought the cold, were gloomy, cried their emotions, and exploded lightning in anger.

That description should have her face stapled next to it.

“Wanna take a closer look?” Brock inclined his head with a knowing gaze, holding the magazine out to her.

That snapped Khalani out of her stupor, and she shook her head fervently.

He chuckled, pulling the sheets back. “Judging by the blush on your cheeks, I think you do. No need to be ashamed if it turns you on.”

“If what turns her on?”

The blood completely leached out of her face, and she closed her eyes, hoping…*praying* that the gravelly tone was a figment of her imagination and the man it belonged to wasn’t standing directly behind her.

“Nothing. Just some light reading,” Brock smirked. Much to her dismay, he tossed the magazine directly behind her.

She dared a glance over her shoulder, and her heart dropped when she saw Takeshi flipping through it.

His expression was impassive as he thumbed through the thin pages. A few seconds passed as she waited for him to have a similar reaction to Adan, but Takeshi appeared *bored*, as if he were sifting through a mundane research paper detailing the chemical composition of limestone.

“Do you have a favorite, Kanes?” Takeshi’s gaze flicked up to hers.

“A favorite what?”

“Picture.”

Someone kill her.

“Or position. There are some good ones in here,” Brock chimed in with a sardonic grin. Takeshi shifted his focus to him.

The inherent brutality in his gaze would make even the strongest man cower, but Takeshi remained silent, clearly wanting to hear her answer more than he wanted to flay Brock’s skin off.

She glanced up at the hole in the ceiling, calculating how fast it would take to disappear through it.

“Well?” Brock prodded.

“I have no favorite,” she said quickly.

“You sure? There’s an interesting one on page sixty-nine here that I’m sure you’d—”

“Say another word, Brock, and I’m shooting you between your legs,” she interrupted with a hard glare, fully prepared to grab her gun and follow through.

Brock chuckled, but Takeshi shifted his focus to him. “Ask again, Death-Zoner. I’m looking forward to the next part.”

The tangible darkness in his voice was unsettling. Brock was quiet for a moment, and everyone tensed, readying for a fight...

But Brock just chuckled.

“I thought *you* of all people would be dying for that answer, Steele. But I guess it’d be more fun to watch you crash and burn. And I can’t let her deprive me of my greatest asset.”

“Highly doubtful,” Serene retorted.

Brock smirked and backed away, casually strolling to another corner of the store as if he wasn’t a breath away from having his tongue snatched out.

Khalani’s muscles relaxed slightly, but the tension lingered with Takeshi just inches away. The heat radiating from him felt like standing next to a carefully controlled fire—one that drew you in before burning you to ash.

“Do you have a favorite?” Adan asked Takeshi.

Khalani peeked up, a little too eager to hear the answer.

For academic purposes.

Takeshi scoffed, handing the magazine back to Adan. “They’re not my type,” he said in the most indifferent tone known to man.

“Seriously?” Adan’s jaw dropped. “Are you gay or something?”

Khalani choked on her next breath, awkwardly thumping her chest.

“Not that we care.” Adan quickly raised his hands at the thick silence. “Whatever beat you drum to, isn’t that right, Derek?”

“Please stop talking,” Derek chimed from the corner.

She didn’t dare look at him. As it was, Khalani feared the answer stamped itself to her face.

“No, I’m not,” Takeshi clipped. “Do you have any other trivial questions, or can we leave?”

“N-no. I-I mean, yes. We can leave.” Adan’s cheeks flushed.

Takeshi immediately strode forward, covering the distance to the exit in just a few long strides, leaving the rest of them behind.

“Nice going, Adan,” Serene muttered.

Adan guffawed. “What? I was just trying to make small talk. I didn’t expect him to look like he wanted to stab me.”

“I don’t think you’re the skin he’s trying to get under.” Brock appeared from around the corner, adjusting the straps of his backpack. Khalani let out a harsh breath, feeling like the sly comment was aimed directly at her.

What they didn’t know was that only thing Takeshi liked getting under was her nerves.

As the others hurried to gather their things, Adan sneakily tucked the magazine into his pack.

“Are you sure that’s essential?” Khalani raised an eyebrow.

Adan smirked and leaned in. “Unless you plan on stripping along the way so I don’t have to stare at Brock’s ass for inspiration, it definitely is.”

“What about my ass?” Brock snapped, glaring at them.

“Nothing,” they answered at the same time.

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4

Doubts signify the disbelief in yourself.

Khalani licked her cracked, sunburned lips. She drank the last of her warm water hours ago, and her canteen was as barren as the desert they trudged through.

Mirages of flowing water spilled across the concrete, torturing Khalani's mind as her feet mindlessly dragged, each step more reluctant than the last.

Brock's steady pace quickened, insisting a Death-Zone water well was nearby and urged everyone to move faster.

She tried her best to keep up, but it might not be so bad if she just lay down on the road…

"C'mon, Khalani," Derek urged, pressing a hand against her back, keeping her upright. "We're almost there."

She blinked multiple times, trying to clear her blurry vision.

No one spoke. The playful energy had vanished.

All that remained was their labored breathing and the sound of heavy boots smacking against the ground.

She glanced to her right. Takeshi had his strong arm around Winnie's waist, supporting most of her weight. As they walked, Winnie's face was unnaturally pale, and her feet dragged like a heavy ball was attached to her ankles.

When Khalani realized she was no longer sweating, even while the sun blazed down the back of her neck, a dreaded apprehension sunk deep into her gut.

"There," Brock said, interrupting the tense quiet. Her knees nearly buckled as he pointed ahead. She scanned the horizon for the beautiful well —their only hope of survival in the Death-Zone.

But there was nothing except the barren road, brown jagged cliffs, and endless stretches of sand.

“Brock, where’s the well?” Khalani croaked, her voice hoarse.

Brock ignored her question and bolted toward a thin green stick protruding from the sand. He knelt, scanning the ground intensely as he muttered under his breath.

“If your plan is for us to eat sand next, I’m definitely killing you,” Serene huffed with her hands on her knees, trying to catch her breath.

“Shut up,” Brock growled, digging frantically into the sand.

Khalani swayed on her feet, her eyelids starting to close when Brock suddenly shouted, “I found it!”

He uncovered a beige hatch buried beneath the sand. A set of numbers were discreetly etched on the surface, and without hesitation, Brock entered a ten-digit code.

With a satisfying pop, the cover opened, revealing a dark hole in the ground and a long rope leading into its black depths.

She warily stumbled forward as Brock began pulling on the rope, gritting his teeth as his forearms flexed. Khalani’s limbs shook, ready to give way, but as soon as Brock lifted a large bucket full of water out of the hole, everyone surged forward, dire thirst clawing at them like ravenous beasts.

“Drink slowly,” Brock instructed as he filled each of their canteens. He lowered the bucket back into the hole and continuously refilled it.

The water was warm, but she didn’t care.

The water could’ve been littered with thick sand and crawling with insects, and Khalani would’ve gulped it down without hesitation.

It was the best thing she’d ever tasted, and as she eyed the deep hole between sips, she felt a dangerous temptation to dive in and wash away her problems with it.

“Who built this? Where does the water come from?” Adan asked, splashing some precious liquid onto his face.

“When Apollo and Hermes were first built, they constructed these wells across the Death-Zone for trading supplies. There are about seven in total. These pumps go deep underground, connected to a large river near Hermes. Colod or Colorda… I can’t remember the name.” Brock shrugged, taking a massive swig from his canteen.

“Weren’t they worried about the water being contaminated?” Derek frowned, eyeing his cup warily.

“Of course.” Brock wiped his lips. “But Death-Zoner radiation suits were designed with special filtrations to purify the water.”

She felt a shift in the air.

None of them wore radiation suits.

If the water was indeed contaminated, they had all just drunk their death sentence.

But Brock's lips thinned, and defiantly, he took another sip. "Since we're all still alive, with no signs of radiation sickness, I'll take my chances on the water."

No one argued with that.

Only when nausea burned in her throat from drinking too quickly did Khalani set her canteen down and lay back against the sand. Her heart slowed, her muscles loosened, and energy gradually returned to her limbs.

She moved her arm over her face, covering her eyes. After a moment, Khalani shifted her forearm, daring to peek at the sun…only to be blinded.

The pain didn't deter her from trying again and again.

Going her entire life without witnessing the sun, only to have it floating right above her and *still* not be able to gaze directly upon it, was infuriating.

Only when her vision filled with white spots and she feared going blind did Khalani finally give up.

"Alright," Brock said a half-hour later. "We have plenty of water, and you've all had your chance to rest. Let's go."

***

Khalani's sweaty arm trembled as she supported Winnie's fragile back. Mile after mile, they walked, surrounded by the broken vestiges of cars, crumbled buildings, and torn-down signs.

She imagined what the apocalyptic road must have looked like before the Great Collapse.

Winnie told her stories of metal buildings that stretched to the clouds. People moving endlessly in the hopes of not getting left behind, because change happened every day, and if you stopped for a moment to breathe, the world would sail right past you.

In one moment, a promising life could be held in your hands, and in the next, everything could wither away, like forgotten sand sifting through your fingers.

What if their journey ended in the same perilous manner as their ancestors?

“You okay, dear?” Winnie asked, her warm gaze sliding to Khalani.

“Yeah,” she absentmindedly answered, staring at the footprints Brock left in the sand.

“Are you sure?”

“I’m fine.”

Winnie cocked her head, frowning at Khalani’s brusque tone. “You know you can tell Winnie the truth, right?”

Khalani inhaled deeply, guilt overpowering her for snapping at the person she loved most. “I’m sorry, Winnie. I’m just worried. What if we reach Hermes and the man on the walkie doesn’t meet us? Or what if we get locked out on the surface? What if leaving was a mistake?” The words spilled out in a rush, her heartbeat quickening with each dire possibility that engulfed her mind.

Success was never a guarantee. In fact, defeat felt more likely every day. But this time, it wasn’t only her life on the line. Khalani managed to convince six people to escape Apollo with her.

If something went wrong, their deaths would fall at her feet.

“It wasn’t a mistake. Because of you, we uncovered the truth about the surface. Isn’t it gorgeous?” Winnie looked around, wide-eyed, as if a kaleidoscope of bright, effervescent colors streaked across the sandy desert.

Khalani lifted her gaze. Dust floated in the air, and in the far-off distance, several buildings were crumpled on the ground, completely abandoned to the wasteland.

“That’s not the word I would use,” she hedged.

“Can’t you hear the grass?”

“What grass, Winnie?”

Winnie shakily lifted her finger and pointed ahead. “Right there, Khalani. Don’t you hear the softest grass whistling in the wind? Can’t you see the oaks and evergreens surrounding us?”

Khalani’s brows knitted, scanning the piles of ruin around them. “I don’t see anything, Winnie.”

“*Try*, Khalani. See it in your mind’s eye, like you used to tell Winnie in Braderhelm. Remember? Just imagine it.”

Her mouth parted. In prison, she’d stare at the ceiling of her cell at night, absorbing tales of the surface from Winnie’s old books. She imagined plants stretching across the stone, the sun and moon peaking over the cracks, ocean waves crashing against rocks.

She'd never witnessed such awe-inspiring acts before. But her mind stretched out and manifested the images, like the memories of those who came before resided in her blood.

But ever since she discovered the Governor was nothing more than a machine, those images faded.

As if the *truth* had obliterated everything in her mind and left nothing but deadly hate. It boiled beneath her skin, forcing dangerous questions to consume her.

Did the Governor speak with her so frequently in Apollo because he found a reflection of himself?

Was she that similar?

That…inhuman?

"I can't see anything anymore, Winnie. I've tried every night, but all I see is black." Her chin trembled. "What if something's wrong with me?"

"There is *nothing* wrong with you."

She shook her head, her throat tightening. "In Apollo, the Governor kept wanting to be near me. He looked at me like he recognized something similar." Khalani paused, and the thoughts she tried to shove away rushed forth with a vengeance. "What if I'm the same as him?"

Winnie jerked to a stop, and Khalani rushed to speak while she still had the courage. "I cut my hand every night. It bleeds—the same color red as everyone else's. But I don't *feel* anything. No pain. Just this strange detachment. Like I'm here physically, but not really *here*," she emphasized, her eyes beginning to water.

"Stop. Look at Winnie." Winnie locked eyes with her, and Khalani swam in the warm brown of the earth. "You are not your fears. Do you understand?"

A lone tear slid down her cheek.

"Khalani." Winnie cupped a cold hand to her face. "Even those who feel the most can feel empty. Do you want to know what it means to be alive? It's not perfection. It's not being okay all the time. It's having fears. Feeling like you aren't good enough. Trying every day to be better. Your tears reflect how beautifully imperfect you are. What could be more human than that?"

Her tears slid through Winnie's fingers. Like drops of hope in an empty desert.

"Please never leave me," she whispered.

“Winnie is right here,” Winnie touched the center of her chest, “for the rest of existence.”

Khalani hugged her tighter, and she imagined they were back in the Braderhelm library, surrounded by stories that made her heart storm out of her chest. The worries in her mind abated, and her thoughts quieted for the first time in weeks.

Suddenly, thin arms shot around them like a cannon, and Serene’s muffled voice came. “I want in on this cuddle puddle of feelings.”

Khalani choked out a laugh when Derek joined the fray and wrapped his arms around them, squeezing tighter. “I have no idea what’s going on. I’m just here to provide emotional support.”

“What are you guys doing?” Adan stopped, glancing over like they’d all finally lost their minds.

“Don’t ask questions,” Serene quipped. “Just get over here.”

Khalani didn’t want to think about how they looked, bear-hugging each other in the middle of the apocalyptic road.

She didn’t care.

She used to think friends were people you felt comfortable with.

But she believed friends were the ones who silenced your doubts.

“What is happening? Why the hell are all of you hugging like a bunch of stuffed toys?” Brock yelled.

“Spoken like someone who’s never owned a toy,” Serene retorted.

“This isn’t the time or place. Stop *touching* each other and start walking.”

“We’re taking a short break,” Winnie said, a firmness in her voice she hadn’t heard before as they let each other go. She patted Khalani’s cheek and smiled, letting her know everything would be okay. Better than okay.

“Absolutely not,” Brock growled. “We keep moving.”

“*No*. We are taking a break.” Winnie dared to defy him.

Brock opened his mouth to argue, but a stronger voice echoed across the desert.

“You heard them, Death-Zoner. They need a break,” Takeshi commanded.

Brock glared at the steadfast Captain, a muscle twitching under his eye, but he eventually threw up his hands and stalked off, grumbling under his breath about stubborn women.

Khalani let out a deep sigh, still sniffling as she set her heavy backpack down on the sandy pavement next to the others. Stretching her arms behind her, she lifted her head to the sun.

She closed her eyes, relishing in the breeze that fluttered past her, something she'd never truly experienced in the underground.

Khalani found kinship with the wind. She too wanted to be everywhere.

Unseen. Significant.

A weighty gaze swept over her skin, and goosebumps slid up her arms. She didn't need to look to guess who was studying the cracks in her carefully cultivated armor. She promptly wiped her nose, trying to hide the evidence of tears.

"You should sit if you're not feeling good."

She startled and realized Takeshi stood right next to her. His large frame blocked the afternoon sun, casting a dark shadow over her.

She took a step back, maintaining as much distance as possible. "I'm fine."

"Why are you crying, then?"

"Got sand in my eye."

"Still love to lie, huh?"

She huffed, sending a vicious glare his way.

Takeshi's cutting words from the other day sprang back to haunt and embarrass her, igniting a fire in her already volatile mood.

"Don't you have better things to do than stalk me?"

He looked around at the barren road. "Not really."

"You see that hill over there? It probably hasn't been glared at in a while."

"You're still mad," he pointed out, cocking his head.

"Wow. Great observational skills."

"If you refuse to rest, why don't you do something about your anger then?"

"If it's something that will make you disappear, I'm all ears." She squared her body to face him, crossing her arms and mirroring his stance.

"Fight me, and I won't speak to you the rest of the way to Hermes." His deep voice carried with the wind, sending chills down her spine.

She swallowed, feeling like she was stepping into a carefully laid trap.

"Why? In our last conversation, you agreed that everything was over between us."

“That was before you punched me.”

“You deserved it!”

“And your aim was terrible,” Takeshi added, ignoring her comment. “The force was there, but your technique was mediocre at best. You’ve already forgotten everything I taught you.”

She gnashed her teeth together. “I know what you’re doing.”

“Do you?” He inclined his head.

“You’re goading me to fight because, for some sick reason, you enjoy seeing me suffer. News flash. It’s not going to work this time.” She straightened, lifting her chin so their faces were mere inches apart.

His gaze drifted down, studying every subtle shift in her expression.

And *disappointment* flashed in his eyes.

“Interesting. I never thought you’d be the one to back down from a challenge.”

He abruptly turned, leaving her behind like an inconsequential afterthought. A fire started from her toes, wiggling up to her ankles, shredding past her legs, warming her stomach, and injecting straight into her heart.

“Now that you mention it.” She walked toward him, and Takeshi paused, glancing over his shoulder. “Punching you again sounds like a *fantastic* idea.”

Takeshi’s upper lip twitched, an indecipherable emotion coiling in his eyes before his expression swiftly hardened, and he continued marching away. Wordlessly, she followed.

Her brows furrowed when he stopped just a few feet away from the others.

Winnie, Serene, Derek, and Adan sat on a soft patch of sand next to the deserted highway. Brock perched on the hood of a nearby black car, one foot bent and planted beside him, the other sprawled straight out as he checked the ammo in his pistol.

“You ready, Kanes?” Takeshi asked. “You look distracted.”

“We’re doing this here? In front of everyone?” Khalani’s pulse quickened as she felt all eyes center on them.

“If you can’t practice with an audience, you won’t be able to fight in real life.”

Khalani wanted to yell as she faced him head-on, but maybe this was good. She had a barrel-load of pent-up energy, and quite frankly, a better

punching bag didn’t exist.

“Are you guys about to have angry sex or something?” Serene asked in a bored voice.

“NO!” she exclaimed a little too strongly. “I’d sooner impale myself on a spiked stick.

A bark of laughter sounded from her left. “Looks like you’re losing the fight, Captain. Better watch your step before someone else races past you,” Brock interjected.

Khalani scowled in his direction. Brock didn’t like her. He just enjoyed egging Takeshi on. As if he wanted to see just how long it would take for a ticking bomb to explode.

Takeshi’s answering chuckle was laced with depravity. “If you’re that confident, Death-Zoner, you can fight me instead. But don’t expect sympathy when I leave you with fewer limbs.”

Her eyes widened as Brock immediately hopped down from the car, palming his gun. Takeshi straightened and calmly pulled a blade from his pocket.

“Whoa, whoa.” Khalani stepped in between them, holding her palms out. “No one’s losing any limbs on my watch.”

“Relax, Khalani.” Brock grinned. “I’ll let you have your turn after. Besides, I won’t kill him. Just some healthy exercise is all, right?”

“Isn’t your arm still injured?” she asked incredulously.

“I’ve handled worse.” Brock took the sling off, flinging it to the ground. “He could use the advantage anyway.”

Takeshi’s body was taut as a bow string, like he’d been patiently waiting for this moment. When he licked his lips, her face paled, genuinely worried for the survival of their only guide on the surface.

Her fear only intensified when Brock announced, “No weapons,” extending his pistol toward her.

“For safekeeping.” He winked.

A split second later, Takeshi’s sharp blade flew a centimeter past Brock’s ear, embedding itself in a deflated car tire behind them.

“I think that’s a great idea.”

Takeshi tossed his black jacket onto the sand and rolled up his sleeves, revealing the corded veins in his forearms.

Oh, boy.

Serene tugged on Khalani's elbow, pulling her a few feet back. "Sit down. We're definitely not missing this."

"Who you got?" Derek asked.

"I'm thinking Brock," Adan replied eagerly.

"I don't know, man. He's big, but Steele has that killer instinct."

Truer words were never spoken.

"Name the limits." Takeshi peered down, assessing his opponent.

Brock rolled his neck. "We go until one of us taps out. I think it goes without saying that I'm not allowed to kill you, much as I'd enjoy it otherwise."

"That's a shame," Takeshi whispered like a walking nightmare. "I was hoping we could play harder."

Brock grinned, stepping back a few paces, and he held his fists in front of his face. "Ready?"

Takeshi nodded, holding his body incredibly still.

Brock's shorter, stockier build contrasted with Takeshi's tall, athletic frame, honed by years of rigorous training.

Everyone froze, waiting for the first move.

Brock shot forward, faster than a sailing bullet, launching his right fist.

Takeshi leaned back, but Brock feinted and sent a punch directly to his ribs. Takeshi smacked his arm away and cracked Brock in the chin.

The impact made everyone wince.

Brock recovered and kicked Takeshi's knee. Takeshi stumbled but drove his elbow under Brock's chin. Brock threw his head back, and Takeshi followed with a powerful blow to his chest

Khalani realized just how much he'd held back in their fights. Compared to this, Takeshi treated her as if she were made of glass.

Brock regained his footing and snatched Takeshi's elbow, throwing him over his shoulder. In the same moment, Takeshi grabbed his neck, bringing Brock to the ground with him.

They grappled fiercely until Brock gained the upper hand and landed a solid punch across his cheekbone. Her whole body tensed, but Takeshi *smiled* and struck Brock in the throat. Brock heaved out, and that's when Takeshi muscled his way on top and threw another punch.

But Brock somehow managed to block it and smashed his forehead against Takeshi's.

Takeshi gnashed his teeth and maneuvered himself under Brock, locking him in a chokehold.

“Stop!” Derek suddenly yelled.

Without hesitation, Takeshi released Brock, and they all spun to Derek, confused.

“What the hell is that?” Derek pointed to the right.

They turned in unison.

Far off in the distance, a massive wall of sand advanced toward them. It had no end in sight and stretched to the heavens.

They all sucked in a collective breath as a stronger wind whipped sand across Khalani’s cheeks.

The storm surged closer, racing toward them with a speed she hadn’t thought was possible.

Brock rose to his feet, and for the first time, true fear reflected in his eyes.

“Run!”

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5

They lived together and died the same way.

Khalani’s feet drove into the ground with all her might as her worn black sneakers kicked up sand behind her.

They raced across the desert like death itself nipped at their heels.

The sandstorm followed, inching closer.

Beside her, Winnie huffed in pain. Her lips twisted as her injured shoulder was repeatedly jostled, but they couldn’t afford to stop.

Any pause meant death.

Khalani stole a glance behind them, and the approaching storm seemed to swallow the entire landscape whole, covering miles in seconds.

“Quick!” Brock’s booming voice yelled. “Into that building!” He pointed to a structure a few stories high, at least half a mile away.

“C’mon, Winnie,” Khalani urged, tugging her harder as the wind whipped around their clothing, stinging their eyes, hitting them like a barrage.

“I can’t, Khalani,” Winnie moaned, her steps faltering.

“Yes, you can.” Khalani’s forearms burned as she wrapped an arm around Winnie, straining to support her weight.

Suddenly, Winnie yelped and collapsed onto the sand, her mouth falling open as she clutched her ankle. Khalani frantically slid her arms under Winnie’s armpits, exerting every ounce of strength to lift her.

“Get up, Winnie!”

A shadowy haze fell over them as the rising sand blocked out the sun. She dared to look behind her, and her heart stopped. The colossal storm inched closer with every passing second.

Khalani’s arms shook as she struggled to lift Winnie to her feet, but her own legs buckled beneath her.

“Leave, Khalani,” Winnie begged as they fell further behind the group.

“Winnie can’t run anymore.”

“Like hell I’m ever leaving you,” she whispered fiercely in Winnie’s ear. She’d drag her across the entire desert if she had to.

Her chest heaved and Khalani yelled, using all her strength to prop Winnie against her body.

Sand swirled around them, gaining momentum. She winced as the rough particles scratched her face, but she continued to heave Winnie’s body through the sand, inch by agonizing inch.

“Khalani!” Serene’s voice pierced through the howling winds.

She whipped her head around, mouth agape as the others abandoned their sprint toward shelter and rushed back to them.

Takeshi was the fastest.

He dashed across the sand like he was born racing through dunes, reaching them in under a minute. Without a word, he effortlessly lifted Winnie into his arms before pivoting his deadly gaze to her.

“I’ve got her, Kanes. Go!”

Violent determination swam in the black depths of his eyes, and Khalani hesitated only for a brief moment before nodding.

No matter what bitterness lay between them, Takeshi was the strongest one there. Winnie’s only chance of survival was with him.

“Come on, Khalani!” Serene danced on her heels, waiting for her.

“Get moving, pixie!” Brock’s voice thundered as he charged toward Serene, his expression contorting in rage.

Ignoring Brock, Serene held out her hand. Khalani’s thighs burned and a sharp cramp pierced her side, but she pushed her legs, straining to catch up. When she finally reached them, Brock all but dragged Serene forward.

Derek and Adan ran several feet ahead, but she was quickly losing sight as a whirlwind of sand swirled around them. She peeked over her left shoulder, and the monumental storm was nearly upon them.

“Don’t look.” Takeshi appeared to her right.

Even with Winnie’s full weight in his arms, he kept pace beside her.

Everything hurt.

The heavy backpack slamming against her lower back. Her calves that screamed for relief as she waded through the thick sand that felt like mud.

But through the dusty haze, a worn grey building loomed closer.

Serene faltered in her steps, but Brock kept a firm hand on her backpack, relentlessly pushing her forward. Adan and Derek were the first to make it

to the building. They held the door open, frantically waving.

“Hurry!” She thought she heard Derek scream.

Khalani’s chest rattled as she tried to run faster, but the punishing wind lashed out at her frail body, and sand pelted her from every direction.

All over her skin.

Her hair.

Her stinging eyes.

Her vision was a sea of nothingness, barely able to make out her own hands in front of her. Khalani opened her mouth to scream, but dry sand trickled to the back of her throat, and she gagged.

Her whole body went numb, and she struggled to get a single ounce of oxygen in. She waved a hand in front of her, blindly moving toward the building.

Or was it the other way?

The heavy particles hit her like broken glass, and she fell to her knees, losing all sense of direction.

No. No. No.

This isn’t how she was supposed to die.

Fight. She needed to keep fighting.

Khalani gritted her teeth and crawled forward, like a roach refusing to perish.

But the vicious storm pressed against her, like the Earth itself were rejecting her presence.

Grains of sand stung her skin and filled her throat. The howling wind screeched in her ears like a deafening protest for all they’d taken away.

Perhaps the Governor was right.

Maybe they were never meant to return to the surface.

Khalani closed her eyes as the Earth enveloped her, suffocating her in its final embrace.

Suddenly, a strong hand seized her arm, pulling her to her feet, and wrenched her in the opposite direction. She stumbled, unaware of whose firm grip held her in the torrent.

Each step was riddled with agony, but whenever she slowed, the steady hand forcefully pulled her closer.

Khalani’s legs were on the brink of collapse before she was suddenly pulled through an open doorway.

The door banged shut behind her, and she fell to her hands and knees on

the white, tiled floor. Gasping for breath, she vomited on the ground, expelling sand, food, and water. Drool dripped from the sides of her mouth, tears blurring her vision, as a smaller hand began rubbing her back in comforting pats.

“Make sure she gets it all out,” Takeshi commanded from afar.

“I got her,” Derek responded, lifting her brown, knotted hair from her face. “Keep going. I’m here.”

She blubbered incoherently, unable to speak. By the time she was heaving dry air, Khalani was certain she’d ejected the entire contents of her stomach.

She stared at the mess on the floor, trying to steady her heavy breathing. A rustle caught her attention, and she raised her head.

Brock pulled a solar stick from his pack, casting a soft, yellow glow around them. The room they were in had small wooden desks piled against the far wall. A dust sheen hung over the empty space.

She flinched when a strong gust of wind hammered the building, and the beige desks rattled like an echoing symphony.

Serene coughed heavily, doubled over with her hands on her knees as Adan checked her for injuries. Brock stood in the corner, stealing glances at them.

Takeshi knelt beside Winnie, who lay against a pillar, tying a piece of cloth around her injured ankle. His brow furrowed when Winnie hissed in pain, but a firm determination set in his jaw as he tightened the knot.

Khalani licked her dry lips, the scratchy pain in her sore throat screaming at her, and Derek pushed a water canteen into her chest.

“Drink this.”

She nearly moaned as the cool liquid coated her lips and tongue, sinking down her parched throat. She gasped for air after gulping the water down, placing a shaky hand on her chest. An erratic pulse beat under her hand with each exhale.

“I thought we nearly lost you.” Derek’s expression was haunted as he watched over her.

She leaned back, running a trembling palm through her hair. “For a second, I did too. Thank you for coming back for me.”

“It wasn’t me who saved you.”

She followed his tense gaze to Takeshi, and she froze in disbelief.

The raw strength it would’ve taken for just one man to drag a person

through that sandstorm was immense...but to hold someone with one arm while dragging her with the other was astonishing.

Takeshi spoke softly to Winnie, the tender care in his eyes the opposite of how he stared at Khalani.

Whenever Takeshi turned his gaze to her, it torched her skin like a brand. His black eyes were either laced with indifference, frigidity, or an inexplicable emotion that made her do a double take.

Khalani's chest felt like it was bottoming out as the unthinkable truth stood before her.

Takeshi saved her.

He turned back for her without hesitation, risking his own life in the process. Why?

Maybe it was out of spite. To make her suffer through life a little longer.

That line of reasoning made her more comfortable.

When he finished wrapping Winnie's ankle, Takeshi stood and marched toward Brock. His long legs swallowed the space, and both men talked in heated whispers, sporting minor cuts on their lips and cheeks from their earlier fight.

She was suddenly knocked over as a small figure barreled into her.

"Don't you dare come that close to dying again," Serene exclaimed.

Khalani wrapped her arms around her, squeezing just as tightly, a slight tremor quaking through her limbs.

Serene nearly died turning back for her. They all did. She wanted to scream and throttle her, but Khalani just bent her head into the crook of Serene's neck, the massive knot in her chest expanding, covering every corner of her fragile heart.

She almost forgot what it was like to have people care if she lived or died.

"You okay, Khalani?" Adan crouched next to her, his concerned eyes focusing on her sandy face.

"I'll survive," she croaked, though another squeeze from Serene might prove otherwise.

"You're not allowed to die without me," Serene grumbled, still holding onto her tightly. "And dying from sand? That would've been a pitiful way to go out."

"I'll be sure to remember that next time."

After a minute, Serene finally loosened her grip, and Brock broke away

from an irate Takeshi and strode toward them.

“The storm will take hours to pass. We’ll shelter here for the night.”

“Are you sure this building’s safe?” Derek asked.

“Positive.”

As if on cue, a large gust of wind slammed into the decrepit building, and the questionably stable walls shook. Dust fell as the grey ceiling trembled above them. They all snapped incredulous gazes at Brock, and he held his hands up.

“If you want to test your luck outside, be my guest.”

The wind howled louder in response, and they sighed in defeat.

“Is being flattened by a building a better way to go?” Khalani joked weakly, tying her sandy hair into a messy ponytail. The tangled strands felt like they harbored a rat’s nest.

Serene looked up thoughtfully. “Killed by an inanimate object is also a paltry way to die. Points for respect though if our bodies get squished like dough.”

“You’re seriously demented.” Brock shook his head at Serene.

“I think that’s the first genuine compliment you’ve given me.”

“Wasn’t meant as one.”

“Even better.”

Khalani quickly passed Brock the gun he’d given her before the fight, leaving them to it. She walked over to Winnie, who was slumped against a pillar with her tired legs stretched out.

“You okay, Winnie?” She bent down.

“Never better, dear,” Winnie replied with a pained smile and coughed into her fist. Her raspy cough had a slight rattle and was deeper than before.

“Drink.” A large hand promptly shoved a canteen in front of Winnie’s face.

Her gaze drifted past Winnie to Takeshi, who stood over them like an insurmountable wall. It was difficult for Khalani to swallow with him so close, knowing how much he’d risked saving her.

“You shouldn’t waste water on Winnie, Kesh,” Winnie admonished in a weak voice, waving off the canteen.

Kesh?

“You can’t expect me to give up that easily, Win. Now, drink your water,” Takeshi instructed firmly, but his eyes were soft as he gently placed the canteen in her hand.

Win?

Why did this feel like mutiny?

Winnie was *her* friend. *Her* family. Family was supposed to hate the people you hate.

She gnawed at her bottom lip as Winnie obeyed and drank from the canteen. Only then did Takeshi nod and walk away, retrieving the gun from his bag and checking the ammunition.

Khalani cleared her throat and stood, side-eying his imposing frame. The black fabric hugged his chest tightly as he handled the gun like it was second nature.

Without thinking, she approached him. But the words “thank you” were stuck in her throat when he shifted his attention to her. The warmth he had for Winnie was absent.

He scrutinized her like an incessant thorn in his side—one he’d like to pluck out and burn.

“Can I ask you something?” she finally asked.

He cocked a brow and motioned for her to speak.

“Why did you come back for me?”

“Would you prefer it if I left you?”

A part of her wanted to shrink from the deep resonance of his voice. But she was tired of running and too exhausted to be anything but honest.

“I’d prefer not to be indebted to you.”

“Why? Afraid I’ll hold that debt over you?” Takeshi pocketed the gun and leaned against the pillar. He crossed his arms, and a lock of black hair fell over his eye.

“Of course.” She lifted her head. “You’re *you*. You always want to be in control.”

“You’re wrong about that.” His dark eyes trailed across her skin like a dull knife. They were only a couple feet apart, but the air between them felt magnetized.

“Care to explain how?” she asked, standing straighter, trying to maintain control of the conversation.

“No. You’ll lose sleep if I tell you.”

“Doubtful. I don’t get scared easily.”

A lie she would take to her grave.

“That so?” He leaned forward, his eyes glinting with an untamed fire. “Then why are your hands sweating, and why is your weight shifting side to

side like you’re ready to bolt through the very doors I dragged you in.”

“That’s not true.” She was fidgeting with her fingers now, and Khalani immediately slapped her hands to her side. “I didn’t come over here to fight.”

“Then why did you really come?”

Say it, Khalani.

Just say it and walk away.

Even if they loathed each other, Takeshi had risked his life for her. Two simple words, and then she could return to blissfully ignoring him, just like he’d done most of their journey.

She took a deep breath. “I came to say thank you.”

Takeshi recoiled as if she’d struck him. His brows furrowed, like he didn’t know how to respond, but he quickly composed himself and nodded. “You’re welcome.”

“But I still don’t like you,” she added, more as a reminder to herself

He snorted and rolled his eyes. “The feeling is mutual, Kanes.”

Oddly, her chest felt lighter.

His body seemed more relaxed too. The lines in his forehead smoothed out and Takeshi’s shoulders slowly eased their coiled tension.

As if they both found comfort in their disdained banter.

“You should get some rest.” He dismissed her in a low voice when they didn’t speak for a few seconds.

Despite his statement, his gaze drew her in like he wanted something more.

Khalani hesitated, her feet feeling glued to the floor. But she nodded, forcing herself to turn and escape, listening to her brain for once.

The raging winds continued to batter the building, and Khalani cuddled with Serene and Winnie against the wall, using their backpacks as rough pillows. Adan and Derek slept on either side of them, while Brock took post by the door.

Takeshi was in the far corner of the room, blending with the shadows, where he was most comfortable.

With her back against Serene, she kept staring at Winnie.

She noticed Winnie’s appetite had been steadily waning.

The glazed look in her eyes was becoming more pronounced, and her voice had grown weaker by the second.

Winnie wasn’t getting better.

She was growing decidedly worse.

The thought made her stomach clench, and she had to steady her suddenly quickened breathing.

Khalani didn’t sleep that night. A strange part of her yearned to venture out into the storm and let the sand cloak her body.

Not because she wanted to die.

She missed being okay with loneliness.

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6

If there's one thing humans love to do,
it's make the same mistake twice.

When Khalani was six, she asked her father what rain was.

"Did you learn that word in school today?" he asked, turning on the lamp next to her bed.

"Mr. Sanders talked about it in farming class today. He said water used to pour from the sky so all the plants and flowers would grow. Is that true, Papa?"

"That's right, blossom." He smiled. "There's a big faucet in the sky. When the flowers are sad, someone turns it on. The rain makes the flowers happy, and they can grow big and strong. Just like you." He playfully pinched her nose.

Her forehead creased, eyes turning downcast.

"What's wrong?" He frowned.

"I wish it rained down here." Her bottom lip quivered. "That means the flowers aren't happy."

His lips curved in a soft smile as he tucked the sheets around her. "Don't worry. You're going to see rain tonight."

"How?"

"In here." He tapped her forehead. "Your mind is so creative and powerful that all you have to do is imagine anywhere in the world you want to go, and when you sleep at night, your dreams will take you there."

"Really?"

"Yes." He kissed her forehead. "Get some rest, my little dreamer."

As he turned to leave, she stopped him with one last question.

"Papa, will we ever go back to the surface?"

He glanced over his shoulder, his smile faltering, as if he knew the next words out of his mouth would be a lie, but he wanted to give her hope.

Hope was all that remained.

"Yes. One day."

Khalani's eyes fluttered open, the warmth of her father's eyes fading as she was thrust back to the cold, abandoned building on the surface.

She rarely dreamed of her parents.

Was the memory even real?

Rubbing the corners of her crusted eyes, she sat up. Soft snores echoed from Adan, who sprawled out to her left. Everyone was still fast asleep.

She stood quietly, stretching her arms, ignoring the never-ending tension in her neck.

Every morning, her sore muscles seemed to whisper,

"Savor this moment, because it's all downhill from here."

She tiptoed around the sleeping bodies. The howling wind had ceased its assault against the building, and she wandered past the barricaded windows.

Streaks of sunlight filtered through the dusty space as she approached the stacked desks against the wall. Her nose wrinkled at the scent of mildewed wood and rusted metal in the air.

The wallpaper caught her eye—a faded pink, littered with strange animals. Nearby, a colorful, tattered sign was partially hung, reading "CLASS OF 2040," and just beneath it was a dusty chalkboard displaying the alphabet.

Her eyes widened in realization.

This used to be a school from the Great Collapse.

Kneeling in front of the open cubbies built into the wall, her fingers brushed against frayed backpacks that were still packed away. She unzipped several bags, her pulse quickening as she searched for supplies. But they were all empty.

She slumped back, sighing in defeat as she picked up the final bag. But it wasn't empty—a small, black notebook was buried inside.

Property of Ana Blackwood

Khalani frowned at the bold words on the cover. She glanced around, as if doing something she shouldn't, but everyone was fast asleep, even Takeshi—the first time she'd seen him blessedly unconscious in a while.

Turning her back to the notebook, she opened the first page.

3/15/2040
Dear Diary,

Daddy got me a puppy! I'm calling him Clover because Mommy said he'll bring us good luck. I hope he does. Maybe Clover can make my parents smile again. They stay glued to the TV every night, not letting me watch cartoons, always insisting I play with the dolls in my room. But they don't know I sneak down the stairs to watch, too. The stern ugly man on TV says big words like nuclear war and underground lottery. I don't know what that means. But as long as I have Mommy and Daddy, I'll be okay.

5/03/2040
Dear Diary,

I'm sorry it's been a while since I've written. So much has been happening. We left our home in Las Vegas and moved a few hours southeast. Daddy says it's just temporary until things calm down. I'm at a new school, and we have bomb drills every day. Sometimes we hide under our desks for hours. I miss my old life. I miss my friends. I just want to go home.

9/11/2040
Dear Diary,

I asked Mommy when we could go home, and she said when the war ends. I hate war. War would never happen if the people in charge had a playdate and talked about their feelings. I said that in class, and everyone laughed at me. There aren't many kids left in class now. My best friend, Mary, told me she was going to Apollo with her mommy, daddy, and baby sister. I don't know where that is. I asked Mommy if we could go also, and she started crying. I heard her and Daddy fight that night. Mommy screamed that they should've been accepted. But daddy yelled that there wasn't enough space.

I don't want to see them cry anymore. I have a plan. I drew them a picture today. It's all of us together outside with Clover. I didn't draw our old house because I want them to know that everything will be

okay as long as we're together. Better than okay. Maybe Mommy will take me back to the park! We haven't been in a—

Khalani's brows furrowed as she flipped through the pages hastily, but that was the last passage Ana Blackwood had written.

A crinkled paper fell out of the torn notebook. It was a crayon stick-figure drawing of three people holding hands outside a yellow house, with smiles on their faces and what appeared to be a small brown dog.

She let the notebook fall to her lap, a sudden pang fluttering in her chest. Something told her that Ana's parents never saw the drawing.

Khalani's fingers fluttered over the paper, tracing the little girl whose dreams splayed out before her in memory.

She tucked the drawing and diary inside her backpack for safekeeping, tapping them gently. She also grabbed the spare pencil lying on the floor.

"What are you doing?"

Khalani whipped her head around to find Brock standing next to the cubbies, gloved hands on his hips, wearing heavy combat boots and a dark brown cloak that outlined his muscular frame.

"I'm just looking around." She flushed, zipping her bag quickly.

"Find anything interesting?"

"No," she immediately replied, standing up, but hesitated at his deeper stare. "Well…yes. It's just an old diary. And before you go on about conserving space, I already know. You think it's stupid. I just don't want to leave it here."

Brock studied her with a blank expression for a few moments, giving away none of his thoughts. But then, he abruptly walked past her, staring through the open cracks in the barricaded windows.

"Have you gotten used to it yet?" he asked, looking outside.

"Used to what?"

"All the destruction."

She moved beside him, peeking through the window.

The dangerous sandstorm seemed to have left without a trace. Remnants of broken-down vehicles were visible on the street, but not a soul lay in sight except for the seven of them in that dilapidated building.

She considered his question, imagining Ana Blackwood's world before the Great Collapse. Waking up to beautiful landscapes, streets bustling with activity, and green trees lining every corner. All the young families laughing

under the sun, blissfully unaware that it would soon disappear from their sight forever.

“I think you can get used to anything,” she said softly.

Brock’s watchful gaze shifted to her. “It’s sad, isn’t it? There’s no place where the world is truly good. Not underground or above.”

“I don’t know if that’s true.” A line appeared between her brows. “What we have here is good.”

“We’re just a few escaped convicts. That doesn’t mean much.”

“It means everything,” she emphatically stated, glancing at the others still sleeping.

Winnie and Serene cuddled together. Derek and Adan snored beside them. Takeshi remained in the far corner, facing everyone, watching over them, even in his sleep.

“Maybe change hasn’t happened because we’ve been waiting for ourselves.” The raw statement escaped her as a whisper, but it solidified in her mind like a promise.

Brock frowned at that, tilting his head as if he were seeing her for the first time.

“And you really believe that? You still have hope that one day this will all get better?” He gestured toward the wrecked building they were housed in incredulously.

There was that word again.

Hope.

Hope was a drink of water in a desert. Intoxicating. Necessary.

You keep going back for more and more. But even the best of things can turn toxic.

And before you know it, you’re craving something that had long since evaporated.

She’d often regarded hope as the enemy, but in Braderhelm, Winnie taught Khalani the importance of fighting for something other than herself.

That one person lighting a candle in a dark room could be the spark that made the difference.

“I have no idea if things will change.” She turned to Brock. “But if stories of me get left behind, I want the reader to know I did everything in my power to make it better.”

He chuckled lightly. “I’ll be damned. You’re a realer, too.”

“A what?”

“Realistic dreamer.” Brock leaned his shoulder against the windowsill. “You know the odds aren’t in our favor. We’ll likely perish up here. So, why keep going at this point?”

“Because we don’t know how to let go of our dreams?”

“Maybe. Or you’re too stubborn to give up on the people we left in Apollo.” His eyes flashed, and the weight of the city and the responsibilities they escaped pressed down on her.

Brock spent more time on the surface than anyone. The city that she grew up in was the same one that threw her in chains. But Apollo was still their true home.

“What are you trying to say?” She frowned. “That we’re supposed to forget Apollo and just let them die?”

“I never said that. Realistically, we probably should, but that doesn’t mean I don’t dream about saving them as well.” His voice lowered as he glanced out the sunny window.

She drew back at the unexpected softness in the Death-Zoner’s voice.

“I never pegged you for a dreamer.”

He smirked. “I’m not. Realer, remember? I have goals I push for and a far-off wish that the world will one day improve. That’s why I joined the rebels in Hermes.”

Brock paused, looking away. A sea of emotion swirled in his eyes, so different from his typical indifference that she was used to.

“But you will never find me sacrificing myself for a lost cause,” he continued. “When the transport is about to crash, I won’t be going down with it. You have to know when to give up. Especially on people.” Brock faced her, suddenly serious. “Do you understand what I’m saying?”

His stare bore into her, and she had to fight not to look away.

She didn’t know how to give up on anyone except herself.

“You two are up early.” Takeshi’s voice, extra deep and rugged in the morning, sounded from behind them.

Her breath hitched. Even with his black hair slightly messy and tussled from sleep, Takeshi still looked like he’d waltzed off one of those magazines they came across in the ancient gas station.

“We were up all night. Weren’t we, Khalani?” Brock grinned, the innuendo in his voice unmistakable.

She glared at Brock, but Khalani didn’t immediately refute his words because a sadistic part of her wanted to see what would happen.

Takeshi silently appraised them, a hint of barely contained violence flashing in his pitch-black eyes. She held her breath, unsure whether round two of their unfinished brawl was about to commence, but Takeshi simply straightened, ever stoic and calm.

“Interesting. I didn’t hear any screams last night.”

“What’s that got to do with anything?” she asked.

“Anyone who knows what they’re doing would make your vocal cords raw.” His dark eyes pierced hers. “Either he’s lying, or it was the most boring lay of your life.” With that, Takeshi turned his back on them and walked away. And somehow, it felt like he was the victor in an invisible battle Khalani didn’t know she was a part of.

She frowned and rubbed the corners of her eyes.

It was too early for this.

Brock snorted and followed Takeshi, but not before he glanced back over his shoulder. “Like I said, if I were you, I’d give up on some people faster.”

Her fists clenched, wanting to punch the nearest wall. Repeatedly. And knowing Brock was right made her want to direct her fists inward.

Khalani retreated to the far corner of the room and preoccupied herself with Ana’s diary.

She was unable to control the chaos or terror that slept in future daybreaks, but she could read the story of a little girl who once was alive, and commit her to memory.

No one deserved to be forgotten. That was why Winnie worked furiously to record Apollo’s history in her book.

The past reminded them of how far they’d come.

After her fifth re-read, she turned to an empty page in the diary, her fingers trembling as she reached for the dull pencil.

Wherever Ana was, Khalani prayed she wouldn’t be upset for the havoc that bled onto her pages.

The quiet yearns to be heard
Those tendrils of loss whispering in the air
Your story screaming out to be heard
Especially when there’s nobody there

The dark demands to be seen
Blank spaces that were once taken

Lives on pedestals for us to judge
Filling dreams that will no longer awaken

The mind needs to be spoken
A cacophony of words slipping off your tongue
Steady is the path for those who listen
Turmoil waits for those who retreat

The heart aches to be chosen
Forgotten feelings daring to peek through
But when your hand extends to break me
I'll cut mine off to be free of you.

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7

I’d rather burn in a fiery blaze than extinguish without a trace.

Days passed on the sweltering surface. The landscape had long since become a monotonous expanse of barren rocky hills, stretching endlessly along the backdrop of an ancient highway.

Pain was her constant companion.

Blisters scabbed over blisters, and her ribs kept cramping.

Khalani forgot what it was like to not hurt.

Their pace had drastically slowed, much to Brock’s frustration.

Winnie’s shoulder was still wounded from the stray gunshot during their daring escape from prison, and her injured ankle barely supported her weight.

Khalani uncomfortably picked at her nails as she watched every wince and sign of distress mar Winnie’s face, even with Takeshi and Derek’s help.

She kept moving forward, reminding herself that Winnie was tenacious. Resilient. One of the strongest people she knew.

But the treacherous road to Hermes was challenging, even for the fittest Death-Zoners, and Winnie’s age worked against her.

“Here, Winnie.” Khalani held a canteen to Winnie’s lips when they stopped at another well. But the water dribbled down Winnie’s chin, her eyes glassy, as though a ghost had taken over.

“Winnie?” She gently touched her shoulder.

Without warning, Winnie collapsed to the sand.

“Winnie!” Khalani crashed to her knees beside her.

Panic erupted as the others quickly rushed over. “What happened?”

“What’s wrong with her?”

“I don’t know!” she yelled.

“Get her on her back,” Derek ordered.

Winnie’s eyes were shut, her skin so pale it looked blue. Only one other time had Khalani seen someone that color.

The image of her dead parents lying on a metal table surged in her mind, and she grasped both sides of her head, wanting to rip the memory out.

Takeshi brandished a knife, and Khalani nearly screamed, but he only cut the hem of Winnie’s white shirt from neck to shoulder. When he lifted the bloody bandage, they all sucked in a collective breath.

Yellowish-green pus leaked from the crusted wound, and the inflamed skin was streaked with red.

“The wound’s infected.” Dread perforated Brock’s voice.

Derek pressed his ear to Winnie’s chest and his palm to her forehead. “She’s breathing, but she’s burning up. The infection could be spreading through her bloodstream. She might go into septic shock.”

Septic shock. Khalani didn’t fully understand the term, but the palpable terror in Derek’s face spoke volumes.

“What do we do?” she rasped, her shoulders hunched over.

“She needs antibiotics,” Derek answered, his voice grim.

“Where can we get some?” Serene stepped forward.

“Hermes,” Brock growled.

“How far are we?”

“Three days out.”

The blood leeched out of Derek’s face. “Winnie needs them sooner, or she won’t make it.”

Brock muttered a curse and stood. “We can’t do anything about that now.”

If Brock had punched her stomach, it would’ve been less painful.

Khalani frantically shook her head. “There has to be another way. Do you know any buildings close by that might have medicine?”

“Look around!” Brock held out his hands. “There’s nothing else we can do for her.”

“Like hell there isn’t.” Khalani seethed.

Determined, she gripped Winnie’s shoulders and tried to lift her. Winnie’s unconscious head lolled, and Khalani gritted her teeth as she pulled her waist up, straining against her dead weight.

Exhaustion enveloped her like a suffocating blanket, but she didn’t care.

She’d search every mountain, crevice, and endure a million lifetimes of pain to keep Winnie safe.

Even if she had to crawl to Hermes with Winnie on her back.

Suddenly, the weight was lifted.

Khalani opened her mouth to yell but froze when she saw Takeshi standing over her. His large body blocked the sun, and rays of light streamed around him as he gently gathered Winnie into his arms.

“Are you crazy?” Brock yelled, moving to block Takeshi’s path. “You can’t carry her for three days straight in the Death-Zone. I don’t want the old woman to die either, but we have no choice.”

“*Get the fuck out of my way*,” Takeshi commanded, his voice deeper than the Earth.

He didn’t wait for permission and shoved past Brock. Throwing a menacing glare over his shoulder, he locked eyes with Khalani and saw the tears streaking down her face.

His brows lowered and his forearms seemed to tighten around Winnie at the sight.

“Get moving. We leave now.”

***

They moved at an incredibly brisk pace, practically running across the cracked concrete.

No one smiled.

No words were exchanged.

The only sound cutting through the stifling air was their labored breathing.

Their heavy backpacks pounded rhythmically against their backs as they trudged forward, while Winnie mumbled incoherently in Takeshi’s arms.

Another fiery cramp shot up Khalani’s ribs, but she gritted her teeth and kept running.

When the sun dipped below the horizon and darkness blanketed the sky, she could barely feel her body anymore.

Time lost all meaning as they sprinted through the deepening shadows.

When they finally reached the underpass of a bridge, they came to a sputtering halt, each of them gasping and heaving desperately for air.

Adan lurched over and vomited. Serene rushed to his side, supporting him, while he emptied his stomach.

“We rest here for a few hours,” Brock declared, wiping sweat from his forehead.

“We can’t,” Khalani protested. “Winnie doesn’t have that long.”

“And we’ll all be dead too if we don’t take a break.”

She opened her mouth to argue.

“He’s right, Kanes,” Takeshi interrupted, carefully laying Winnie down with her back resting against a car tire. “We’ll do more harm than good if we keep up this pace without stopping.”

Khalani wanted to scream her frustrations into the night sky. But she looked around at the others’ pale faces, heard their ragged breathing, and knew Takeshi was right.

Derek propped Winnie’s head on an empty backpack, and Takeshi pulled a long-sleeve black shirt from his bag, draping it over her for warmth.

“I’ll take watch,” Takeshi said firmly.

No one argued, and they set up camp under the bridge, forming a protective circle around Winnie. Before long, everyone drifted to sleep.

But Khalani couldn’t shut her eyes.

She pulled her knees to her chest, and her fingers anxiously tapped the top of her handgun. The disquiet was like a jagged knife slowly sawing through her throat.

She obsessively watched Winnie’s shallow breaths, fixating on the slow rise and fall of her chest.

She timed them—long and slightly rattled, unable to fully inhale.

Khalani’s head thudded back against the metal car. The dark parts of her wanted to bang her head harder. To lose herself in the dark corners of her twisted mind.

Winnie was the only mother she had left. And all Khalani could do was lay there and slowly watch her fade away, like everyone else who used to love her.

A lone tear slid down her face, and she furiously wiped it away.

Unable to endure the bitter silence any longer, Khalani stood and walked over the sleeping bodies, heading toward the edge of the underpass. Her eyes scanned the cars, unconsciously searching for *him*, drawn like an invisible magnet.

Under the moonlight, she spotted him.

Takeshi sat with one leg stretched out and the other knee pulled up, a sharp blade resting in his palm. He leaned his back against the front bumper

of a large, rusted black vehicle a few feet outside the cover of the bridge.

“Mind if I join you?”

He glanced up, his deep eyes holding a quiet strength that grounded her.

“Have a seat.”

She sat a foot away from him, leaning her shoulders against the rusted car, wrapping her arms around her legs. Her skin felt taut, like a rubber band stretched to the breaking point.

“You okay?” Takeshi asked.

Khalani opened her mouth to say yes—an automatic response—but then she realized there was no point in lying. She pursed her lips, chin trembling as she quietly shook her head.

Takeshi’s jaw tightened as he studied her face. Any moment, she expected him to tell her to quit being weak. To accept the consequences of convincing Winnie to join their perilous quest.

Khalani continued to lose herself in her torturous thoughts when she heard a rustle.

“Get up.”

Her brows furrowed as Takeshi loomed over her, his expression deadly serious and his tall form almost glowing in the moonlight.

“Why?”

“Do you trust me?”

“No,” she responded instinctively.

“Good.” He nodded. “Thought I lost for you for a second. Get up, Kanes.”

“What are you—”

Takeshi turned without another word and walked away from the bridge.

The quiet space seemed to close in around her with his absence.

She used to find peace in the darkness but something in the night made her eyes dart around. The silence grew louder, prickling her skin.

The shadows seemed to stare at Khalani. She could hear their demented whispers, and her shoulders tensed, sensing invisible hands reaching out to grab her.

Khalani quickly stood, searching for Takeshi in the dark. She frantically maneuvered around the vehicles but heaved a deep sigh when she found him a few car lengths away. He glanced back at her, silently waiting.

The logical part of her brain smacked her upside the face, urging her to return to the others, where it was safer.

But she followed him, knowing that on the surface of the violent earth, nowhere was truly safe.

Takeshi stopped next to a battered black vehicle that was larger than the others. Winnie had referred to a similar one as a “truck.”

Its entire backside was open, and she wondered if it’d once been used for transporting goods.

She jolted as Takeshi’s hand gripped the truck’s side, effortlessly hoisting himself into the back. He straightened to his full height, standing several feet above the surroundings, like a conqueror in a strange new world.

His soft black hair had fallen over his forehead, and his eyes gleamed with a dark, mischievous emotion she refused to name.

“What are you doing?” she frantically whispered, her eyes darting around. “Get down!”

“Don’t you want to see the view?”

“I can see everything just fine from here.”

He tilted his head. “Nervous, Kanes?”

“I’m not nervous,” she hissed, fisting her hands. “We should get ba—”

Takeshi leaned down and gripped her arm, hoisting her into the back of the truck.

Khalani gasped, holding her hands out to steady herself, and he released her immediately.

She spun toward him, struggling to maintain her balance. He reached out a hand, but she slapped him away.

“Have you lost your mind?” she sputtered.

“You’re just as fucked in the head as I am, Kanes.”

“*God*, I hope not.”

He rolled his eyes, and her breath hitched when he sat down.

Raising a brow in mock challenge, he stretched onto his back, the truck’s rear barely fitting his length.

She stood over him, hands on her hips and a deep scowl etched on her face. “Just what do you think you’re doing?”

“What does it look like?” he asked calmly.

“I don’t know! Like you want to sleep in this…*thing*.” She flicked her hands toward the truck, her lips twisting.

“The last thing I want to do is sleep,” he replied, crossing his arms behind his head.

Her eyes were drawn to the defined muscles in his forearms, and she barely restrained herself from bashing her head into the rear window to rid herself of *those* thoughts.

“This is ridiculous.” Khalani brushed a hand through her unruly hair. “I don’t even know why I’m here,” she grumbled to herself, but Takeshi heard her.

“You’re here because you need a distraction. And I don’t like seeing you sad,” Takeshi muttered, his voice deepening.

She blinked rapidly at his unexpectedly kind words.

“That doesn’t sound like you. You love making me cry.”

“Let me rephrase. I want to make you cry in other ways, but never from being sad.”

Khalani frowned. “Do I even want to question what ‘other ways’ you mean?”

“You definitely don’t.”

She swallowed, the brisk air thickening.

Takeshi stared at her with an unreadable expression, unmoving, waiting for her decision.

Khalani knew for certain that Takeshi wouldn’t hold her there against her will.

He’d simply let her walk away.

And they’d return to glaring at each other on the long, barren road.

For some reason, the thought didn’t bring her joy. It lingered inside of her like a necrotic wound.

Maybe it was the pure exhaustion or the wind picking up around her, but without another word, Khalani laid down next to him in the back of the ancient vehicle.

The tiny space around them was enclosed, and she tried to push her body against the metal, but Takeshi’s large physique left little space between them.

“Now what?” She glanced at him.

“Look up.”

Khalani sighed, letting her head rest against the metal of the truck as she finally turned to face the night sky.

For most of their journey, clouds hovered above their heads like a protective veil. But in the next moment, the full moon peeked through.

Khalani gasped.

She’d only ever seen the moon through virtual windows in Apollo, but now she understood that they were little more than pale imitations.

Nothing had ever truly encapsulated the magnificence that now floated above her.

The sun had always been the focus of her dreams, but the moon was entirely different. Entirely *her*.

Slightly cold. Emerging only in the dark. Often overlooked. It appeared small but held a might that rivaled the world.

She gazed at the celestial being with wide eyes. What further bewildered her were the white dots sparkling in the night sky. She had no idea what they were. If Winnie wasn’t fighting for her life, she’d ask her.

Khalani squeezed her eyes shut, her lips quivering.

“Stop thinking, Kanes.” Takeshi’s voice cut through her fractured thoughts, knowing exactly where her mind had wandered. “Stop feeding your pain. Just lie here and breathe with me.”

Her brows furrowed, and she tilted her head.

“Why are you being nice all of a sudden?”

“Figured I would try it out for the night. See what all the fuss is about.”

“And?”

“Overrated.”

Khalani wasn’t able to contain the laugh that burst out of her. Takeshi’s lips twitched, fighting a smile.

Despite the overwhelming pain, she was grateful for the moment.

Takeshi was one of the few people who kept her feet to the ground. Who reminded her to simply *be present*.

He didn’t panic under pressure. He moved with the chaos as effortlessly as water. Where others faltered, he flowed, commanding the turmoil around him.

“Aren’t you worried my misery will rub off on you?” She glanced back up at the sky, a strange pressure hovering over her chest.

Takeshi was utterly still beside her. At first, he didn’t respond, and she was certain he’d stand up and walk away. But then, he spoke.

“What if I’d rather share your pain than have you bear it alone?”

The night sky swallowed her heavy breaths.

She didn’t know how to respond.

Didn’t know how to deal with the gentle parts of him.

There were moments when Takeshi gazed out at the horizon, his hair billowing in the wind, that fiery determination in his eyes, and it ignited something deep within her. A warmth that made her want to shove him against the ruined vehicles and smash her lips against his, if only to purge her longing once and for all.

The deafening silence stretched on, and her gaze wandered back to the sky. She couldn't bring herself to directly respond, fearing that any attempt to voice her feelings would strip her completely bare.

"Winnie told me humans landed on the moon hundreds of years ago. Do you think that's true?" she asked, desperately grasping for a new topic.

"Not sure how they would've jumped that high," he responded, swallowing, as if he were grateful for the change, too.

She chuckled. "No, she said they built ships that could fly all the way up there."

"Probably why they all died."

"You wouldn't do it?"

His gaze grew distant. "Some things are meant to only be looked at from afar."

"Or maybe you're just afraid of heights," she teased.

"And if I were?" He tilted his head.

"I'd find the nearest cliff and dump you off it the next time you pissed me off."

A deep chuckle escaped him, and she nearly sighed at the rare sound as he looked back up at the moon, his obsidian eyes swimming in its reflection.

"What are you afraid of, Kanes?"

"Me?"

He nodded, the moonlight highlighting his strong jawline and high cheekbones.

It was too easy to get lost in his deadly beauty.

She pulled her attention back to the sky, but it did nothing to quell the shivers racing up her neck.

"I used to believe I was afraid of physical pain. But then I felt so much of it that I became desensitized…" She paused. "Now, I think my biggest fear is the one thing I used to crave the most."

His entire body tensed. "And what's that?"

"Being alone."

Saying the words out loud, exposing that raw truth, was like having a hole punched through her chest.

That's why you should be careful about who you love.

Love wasn't just an emotion in your heart. Love was an offering of yourself.

When you loved someone, you gifted them a part of you.

And if they left, you could never get those pieces back.

But Winnie, Serene, Derek, Adan…even parts of Takeshi, had wiggled their way into her heart. By the time she realized what was happening, it was already too late.

If she were left alone now…there would be no pieces of her left.

"But we don't have to talk about that," she quickly said, rubbing her chest as if it could disperse the ache. "I'm quite content to just lay here and forget my fear of abandonment issues."

"No one is abandoning you." Takeshi's voice was bone-chillingly deep.

"I wouldn't be so sure."

"Kanes." She felt the weight of his sharp gaze.

"You're not gonna drop this are you?" she sighed.

"No."

"Why?"

"Because I see how your friends look at you. They care. They won't betray you. If I had the slightest inkling otherwise, I would've slaughtered them on the road and made it look like an accident," Takeshi said evenly.

His tone held a brutal certainty that would've made a sane person terrified, but instead, her insides warmed and her stomach clenched.

Takeshi's lethalness should *not* be a turn-on.

That would be fucked up.

"Your mind's racing again," he noted.

Her mind was a dangerous battlefield that needed to be studied as an example of what *not* to do in those situations. Because the next words that came out of her mouth were, "Then help me not think at all."

Takeshi went preternaturally still, as if any movement—any breath—might shatter the fragile moment.

She felt his gaze on her, scrutinizing, waiting for her to take the words back.

But only silence and beating hearts hung between them.

Part of her wasn't sure she even *wanted* to take the words back.

Khalani half-expected Takeshi to scoff at her suggestion and leave her in the dark. But one moment she was lying next to him, and the next, Takeshi had her hips in his grasp, pulling her on top of him so she was straddling his waist. She gasped at the swift movement.

Takeshi narrowed his eyes in challenge, like his only goal was to intimidate her into retreating, fully expecting Khalani to end the charade and pull away.

But if he was waiting for her to be the rational one, they were screwed.

She was desperate to feel something other than pain, and Khalani didn't care that it would inevitably return with a swift vengeance come morning.

The moon could tell the sun all about her bad decisions later.

She shifted against him and felt Takeshi harden beneath her, and like the rest of him, he wasn't lacking in any area.

Emboldened, she moved forward another inch, causing a delicious wave of friction, and his fingers bit into her hips as he hissed. But instead of shoving her off, he pulled her closer, rubbing her core against him.

Warmth pooled low in her stomach and she felt her body respond as he got harder, *somehow*.

No inch separated them except for the clothes they still wore. She felt naked, exposed, and with the way Takeshi's eyes roamed over her, she felt like the only woman left on the surface.

Her heart pounded against her chest and she was certain he could hear the palpitations.

He stared up at her like he was ready to slice her throat in one breath and bend her backward to feast like a man starved the next.

Khalani wasn't a virgin.

The first man she'd been physically close with was a coworker at the Food Distribution Center of Apollo. He was handsome enough, flirting with her constantly. And she was miserable enough to settle for his intentions, hoping to experience something different for a change.

It hurt the first time. A lot. Nothing like she thought it'd be.

But then again, life wasn't what she thought it'd be.

She returned to his bed a few more times, but each encounter left her decidedly colder afterward. He never ignited her body with fire. Never made her feel *seen*. Never made her feel like she'd unravel from the pure feral possession in his gaze.

Takeshi’s fingers slid from her hips up her stomach, undoing the buttons of her shirt as he went. He never once looked away from her face, cataloging every response. She licked her lips, and his eyes tracked the movement like a predator.

There was only one button left. Khalani closed her eyes, ready to expose herself. But his hands halted.

“Undo the last button,” he commanded.

She opened her eyes, her chest rising and falling rapidly. “Why did you stop?”

“Because I’ll take many things, Kanes, but never your choice. If you want to surrender to me for just this one night, then undo the last button. If not, you should stand and walk back to the others.”

He was going to be her undoing.

With his silky black locks falling over his face and his shadowy eyes glinting in the moonlight, he’d never looked more handsome or destructive.

Takeshi never hid his darkness. He embraced it.

To him, hell wasn’t a path to avoid but a space to conquer.

Takeshi waited patiently for her to make the next move, his hands clenched at his sides. He raised an eyebrow when she hesitated, as if he knew they wouldn’t continue.

Khalani chewed her bottom lip, and Takeshi’s luminous eyes flickered to her mouth. He held his breath, waiting for the inevitable.

But she wasn’t the same girl he met in prison.

Khalani was free to explore ruin in all its shapes and forms.

Takeshi may very well be her ending.

But she had this one night to dictate how she was destroyed.

Khalani swallowed deeply, and ever so slowly, undid the last button.

The fabric still covered her breasts, but the cool air ruffled her shirt, and her nipples perked.

Letting go felt like liberation. She paused, taking it all in, feeling powerful.

“You’re not done. Keep going,” he commanded, his voice sultry and deep, resonating with an almost primal intensity. Takeshi didn’t glance down her chest. His gaze remained locked on hers, which somehow was hotter.

Her stomach burned as she drew a deep breath, slowly pulling the fabric away on both sides, revealing her naked breasts.

Takeshi still didn’t shift his gaze away from her face, as if watching her cede control to him was the most invigorating act.

He barely touched her.

He didn’t need to.

He was everywhere. Beneath her skin. Sliding through her thoughts. In every breath she took.

“I used to believe the moon was the most beautiful thing on the surface,” he whispered, his gaze flickering back to her eyes.

Her heart soared past the white dots in the sky.

No one had ever looked at her like that. Like they wanted to brand her into memory.

She subtly shifted back, causing delicious friction between them. His eyes narrowed, and he suddenly flipped their bodies.

Takeshi rose above her, his broad chest centimeters from hers. His shadowy eyes swallowed hers and his breaths came slightly quicker.

Every movement, every shift of his body, she studied, just as he did with her.

He shackled both her wrists with one hand, placing them firmly over her head.

“That’s better,” he coaxed.

His gravelly voice sent warmth pooling to her core.

A defiant glimmer rose in his gaze, and she tried to escape his grip, but his hand tightened, not letting her go anywhere.

Like the break of day, he was inescapable.

“What shall I do with you now?” he mused.

“What do you want to do?”

Takeshi let out a dark chuckle. “There aren’t enough hours left in the night to show you.”

Oh…my…

His eyes smoldered, and it pained her how sinfully attractive he was. Her body felt like it was on the brink of exploding.

“I think…” she swallowed right before taking the plunge, “I think I want you to kiss me.”

Takeshi’s lips curled into a slow, seductive smile. He moved down her neck, pausing at her throat. “Here?”

“Lower.”

He trailed kisses down her collarbone. They weren’t sweet. He nipped at her. Burning her to shreds.

His nose skidded along her skin like he wanted to breathe every centimeter of her in. Takeshi occasionally stopped to suck and lick, as if to remind her who was truly in control.

“How ’bout here?”

“If you need a map, maybe I’ll go wake up Brock,” she challenged.

He stilled, his jaw ticking as he looked up at her. “Kanes, you’re *begging* to be tied up to the car naked at this point.” His eyes flared as if he enjoyed the thought. “And it won’t be fun for you.”

“All night?”

“Mhmm.”

Her breath hitched and her heart sputtered like an engine. “And tomorrow?”

“Don’t worry. We’ll go back to hating each other tomorrow. That’s what you wanted, right?”

“Um…” Her mind was a tangled mess. “Yes?”

“Good girl.” Takeshi didn’t bother saying anything else. He bent down and his mouth latched around her nipple.

His tongue swirled around the peak and her back arched, thrusting her chest further into him.

His right hand kept both her wrists caged above her head and his left hand slid up her outer leg, her hips, her waist—leaving each area he touched electrified—and cupped her other breast. He groaned, sucking her nipple harder, letting his teeth lightly bite down as his hand squeezed.

He pulled her closer, as if he couldn’t get enough.

It wasn’t a simple touch. It was ownership.

Her head fell back and her eyes found the moon and the dots in the sky, burning and flickering, laying witness to someone being ravaged. And wanting it with every square inch of their body.

If her soul could bleed, pieces of Takeshi would spill everywhere.

He didn’t just take up space in her mind, he occupied it entirely.

Khalani wanted to thread her fingers through his soft black hair, wanted to feel him everywhere, to memorize every portion of him before daylight washed away their dark deeds.

Goosebumps raced up her arms and neck as he switched to her other breast, making sure every inch of her felt his attention.

It was the most erotic thing she'd ever experienced, and her pants were still on.

"Takeshi…" she moaned. Everything felt good. Too good, like she'd fall apart at any moment.

"You want me to stop?" He lifted his head, his lips glistening and his expression conveying his desire to keep going.

Her breaths rasped, but she shook her head. "No. It's just…a lot."

"Not nearly enough." She thought she heard him murmur.

Takeshi's virulent gaze locked onto Khalani, and relief coursed through her at the sight of his wild restraint.

She wasn't the only one on the brink of losing control. Takeshi just hid it better.

Khalani tried freeing her hands again, but his grip tightened.

"I don't think so, Kanes. I've got you exactly where I want you."

"Bastard," she growled, arching her hips up, craving more. Wanting him *everywhere*.

Takeshi's suddenly stiffened on top of her and his eyes darted around, scanning their dark surroundings.

"What is it?" she whispered, desperate for him to continue.

His muscles coiled with tension, and he lifted off her, crouching beside her. A handgun suddenly appeared in his right hand while he palmed a six-inch blade in the other.

"Takeshi, what's wrong?" she asked, sitting up

"Stay here," he commanded in a low, urgent tone. Without a sound, he leaped off the truck and disappeared into the shadows.

Blood drained from her face.

Khalani quickly buttoned her top, her heart pounding as she searched for Takeshi.

The silence of the night was like a vice around her throat.

A sudden grunt shattered the quiet.

She whipped her head in the direction of the sound, but Takeshi didn't emerge from the darkness.

Something was terribly wrong.

Ignoring Takeshi's command, she scrambled off the truck and moved toward the noise.

In the next moment, a rough hand covered her mouth, and a sharp knife pressed against her throat.

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8

Pray for forgiveness.
Prepare for punishment.

Khalani bucked against the unknown figure holding her hostage. The large knife pressed against her jugular, nicking her skin and drawing blood.

“Ah, ah,” the gruff voice behind her warned. “Move again, and I’ll slice your pretty neck wide open.”

Her breaths came in rapid, shallow gasps, and the rough palm over her mouth stifled her cries.

The crack of a loud gunshot abruptly shattered the night, echoing ominously around them. Her eyes darted, straining to make out shapes in the murky darkness.

She prayed with all her might that Takeshi was unharmed.

If anything happened to him…

Suddenly, a large body was flung over a car and collapsed in a crumpled heap at their feet.

“Varo?” the man holding her gasped. His grip on her momentarily loosened, just enough for her to act.

Khalani bit down on the hand covering her mouth. The man screamed as she tasted blood, loosening his hold.

Seizing the moment, she drove her elbow back into his gut.

Her captor choked out a ragged breath, staggering on his feet.

She lunged forward, desperate to escape, but he grabbed her arm, yanking her back.

Crack.

She swung her fist toward his jaw, and his head whipped to the side from the impact. Getting her first look at him, the strange man appeared to be in his fifties, with deeply tanned skin and a freshly shaven face.

But before she could take pride in the solid hit, he retaliated with a brutal

backhand to her right cheekbone.

The force of the blow sent Khalani careening to the ground. Gritting her teeth against the pain, she scrambled to her feet, preparing for another strike. But the stranger suddenly screamed in agony as a blade pierced through his left shoulder.

He reached behind to yank out the knife hilt, but a larger figure launched forward and struck him viciously in the jaw.

She would know that large silhouette anywhere.

The stranger scrambled back, his eyes wide with fear. Takeshi's expression, on the other hand, blazed with an almost palpable fury as he locked onto Khalani, immediately zeroing in on the mark on her face.

"He hit you?" Takeshi's body froze, his voice dangerously calm, but his hands trembled.

Her pulse raced uncontrollably as words failed her, and she could only nod.

Takeshi's breathing came out slow and heavy as he turned back to the wounded man struggling to his feet.

She could only see the back of Takeshi's head, but the stranger's face went pale at whatever expression stared back at him.

In a swift, violent motion, Takeshi hurled the disoriented man against the side of a rusted car like a ragdoll. The metal groaned on impact as the man collapsed to the ground.

Takeshi wrenched open the door with a loud creak and pulled the man's arm up inside the vehicle. With the man's arm still trapped inside, Takeshi slammed the car door onto the man's elbow, pressing his full weight into it.

Khalani heard the sickening crack from where she stood, and a shiver ran through her at the man's agonized scream.

Takeshi ripped the knife from his other shoulder as pitiful moans filled the air, but Takeshi ignored them, pressing the bloody blade against his throat, just like the man had done to her.

Suddenly, a shadowy figure emerged from the darkness, swinging a heavy club.

Khalani screamed, "Watch out!"

But it was too late.

The club collided with Takeshi's head in a sickening thud. He crumpled to the ground next to the car, the knife clattering beside him.

"Takeshi!" Khalani's cry pierced through the night.

She charged toward him, but a rough cloth was shoved over her mouth from behind. The acrid, chemical stench of the cloth filled her nostrils.

She thrashed against the firm grip encircling her, but her vision started wavering.

No.

Fight.

You have to…fight…

Everything dimmed and blurred.

The last thing she saw was the lingering, cold moon, continuing to stare and judge the violence of humanity, before her head smacked against the concrete and her vision went utterly black.

***

“Khalani.”

A static ringing invaded her ears.

Her limbs were numb. Every inch of her, even the messy hair flowing past her shoulders, felt heavy.

“Khalani.”

A light creaking noise.

A faint whisper permeating the oppressive fog.

Sensations slowly filtered back.

Her shoulders throbbed with pain, and she realized her hands were twisted and bound behind her with hard rope.

She had a hard time opening her eyes, as if her eyelids had been sewn shut. The pull of darkness beckoned her once more, offering an escape that seemed almost preferable.

Maybe if she faded with it, death would claim her and finally finish the job that should’ve been completed a long time ago.

Wake up.

Wake up.

“Wake up!”

Khalani jolted, her eyes shooting open as she heaved rapidly.

She realized she was seated on cold *tiled* floor, her legs stretched out in front of her, and her arms bound behind a rusty metal pole sticking out of the ground.

Serene, Derek, Adan, Takeshi, and Brock were similarly restrained, each

tied to separate poles scattered throughout the empty space.

She glanced around the small, dim room, illuminated only by a single, flickering lightbulb hanging precariously from the ceiling. The weak light cast eerie shadows along the concrete walls.

Dread clawed inside her stomach when she saw a set of dark, rickety stairs that led upward to an unknown destination.

“You alright?” Serene’s voice was strained, breathless.

Khalani turned to her left, wincing from the sharp throb at her temple.

“Where the hell are we?” Her voice came out hoarse.

“I don’t know,” Serene replied, her blue hair matted to her forehead as she scanned the room with a frightened look. “All I remember is waking up to a gunshot, and then someone pressed a strange cloth over my face.”

Khalani swallowed, her nostrils flaring.

The air was thick with a musty, unpleasant odor. It seeped from the concrete walls and buried into her skin. The sharp fragrance of despair lingered on her tongue, as though the room was well-acquainted with the stench of death.

She glanced at the others. Derek and Adan sat to her right. Dark circles hung under Derek’s eyes, lips pulled tight as his gazes darted about the room, sharp fear etched into the lines of his face.

Adan was moving his shoulders back and forth, trying to maneuver his hands out of the rope.

Brock was bound to a pipe in the corner near the stairs, shifting his body in an attempt to free himself, but based on the jagged snarl playing across his lips, he wasn’t getting far either.

Takeshi sat directly across from her. Though similarly restrained, his posture radiated a dangerous calm. Like a monster stirring beneath water.

He obsessively studied every single inch of the room. The stairs. The poles they were tied to. The ropes.

And Winnie…

Utter terror sliced through Khalani’s chest as she frantically scanned the room.

“Where’s Winnie?” she nearly screamed.

“I saw them take her,” Derek’s voice trembled in the dark space. “We don’t know where she is.”

Khalani’s vision blackened, and the walls started to close in around her. She could see it now. Winnie’s dead body lying on a cold table right next to

her parents.

No.

No.

No.

Khalani pulled harder on her bindings, desperately trying to break free.

She needed to find her. Needed to save her.

“This is your fault,” Brock seethed, viciously glaring at Takeshi. “You were supposed to be on watch!”

A vein pulsed at Takeshi’s temple.

Instead of a fire in his eyes, they were ice-cold, mirroring the frigid temperature in the room, as he remained silent, refusing to look in her direction.

The truth hit her.

If she hadn’t distracted Takeshi…

If she had just stayed next to Winnie.

The immediate slam of a door cut through her spiraling thoughts.

Heavy boots thudded against the creaking stairs, and they collectively held their breaths.

Three imposing figures descended the wooden steps. Two of them were men, both stocky and nearly as tall as Takeshi. They had dark hair tied up in buns and wore deep scowls as they glanced at Khalani and the others tied up on the floor, their lips twisting in disgust.

Their loose-fitting beige pants were adorned with geometric patterns and pockets up the sides. Tight tan shirts clung to their muscular frames, while long black cloaks trailed behind them.

In the center of the grim procession stood a smaller, leaner figure dressed in similar beige garb and a flowing maroon cape. It was a woman. She was strikingly beautiful, probably in her mid-thirties, with a heart-shaped pale face, high cheekbones, and red hair that rivaled a scorching fire.

But her green eyes…they were sharper than any blade Takeshi carried.

All three of the strange figures held themselves tall and proud as they halted in the middle of the floor, scrutinizing each of them carefully.

Khalani’s skin crawled, like she was about to be dissected.

“I expected better from Ansel,” the woman broke the silence, her harsh gaze sweeping over her bound captives.

Her focus lingered on Takeshi, who studied her right back with an intensity that made the two men stiffen, hands edging toward the blade

handles sticking out of their pockets.

“I thought the Sinners had better spies, but clearly, we overestimated them. The moon goddess led us right to your camp. And now, it’s time for you to provide some answers.”

With disturbing calmness, the woman pulled a pistol from her pocket. The metallic click of the weapon reverberated through the dim room.

“I want to know the size of Ansel’s forces, the Sinners defenses, and any weaknesses in their walls. You’ll tell me now, or I’ll let Belken here slice you and eat the pieces,” she threatened, gesturing to one of the burly men beside her.

“Great. You’re all fucking crazy, too,” Brock grumbled, prompting one of the men to march over and deliver a brutal punch to his face. Brock’s head snapped back, but he only started laughing as blood streamed from his nose.

“Is that it? My *mother* hit harder.”

The man’s fist clenched, and he reached for his knife.

“Wait! Wait!” Khalani shouted. “We’re not who you think we are! We don’t know any Sinners or this Ansel person.”

The woman’s laughter was cold and mocking as she pivoted her attention to Khalani. “You’re quite amusing. There are only two tribes on this side of the river, the Desert Spring and the Sinners. We both know you’re not from the Desert Spring, so you must be with *them*.” She spat the last word, taking a deliberate step closer.

When the woman raised her gun, Takeshi snapped, “I strongly advise pointing that somewhere else.”

The woman paused, glancing over her shoulder. “And why is that?”

“Because if she gets another scratch, you’d need a much bigger gun to survive.” Takeshi’s chin lowered, his eyes filled with a dark promise of retribution.

The red-haired woman chuckled but Khalani noticed the renewed tension in the set of her small frame. “How touching. *You* are the only one I can see Ansel enlisting as a spy. Varo was one of my best soldiers. No one had ever beaten him in hand-to-hand combat, and you bested him easily.”

The accompanying silence made it difficult to breathe as Takeshi stared at the woman like he was biding his time to ensure she’d be greeted with the same deadly fate.

But even though Takeshi was strong, he was tied up like the rest of them,

and their weapons were gone.

“You have to believe us.” Khalani’s voice rang across the dim room, trying to regain the woman’s attention. “We’re not from here. We came from Apollo, one of the underground cities. We’re trying to get to Hermes.”

At the mention of Hermes, the woman spun around, her eyes widening.

“Hermes?” she echoed with disbelief.

“Yes. Do you know it?” she asked, her heart thumping wildly in her chest.

The two men behind her shifted uncomfortably.

“Under-Dwellers,” one of them snarled.

The woman raised a hand for silence, her gaze narrowing.

“The Under-Dwellers never leave their precious bunkers.” She tilted her head. “How do you know the way?”

Khalani’s eyes instinctively slid to Brock. The woman followed her gaze and walked toward him with deliberate steps.

Brock silently watched her approach. Blood trickled from his nose and he licked it like an untamed animal.

“And who are you?” the woman asked.

“The one who’s going to kill you,” Brock replied calmly, his gaze simmering with vitriol.

“Do you know how many insignificant men have made the same threats to me, only to be gutted by the end of my blade?”

“Good. My favorite part will be slicing your ugly face before I do the same to you.”

The two men surged forward, but the woman held up a hand, stopping them. She waited a long minute and chuckled.

“Your confidence is impressively foolish given your position. I shall only ask one more time. How do you know the way to Hermes?”

Brock lifted his chin defiantly.

Heavy silence wrapped around them, tighter than the ropes biting into their wrists.

The woman regarded him for another moment before rising. “Pity. Let me see who I shall play with first.”

She glanced at Khalani and Takeshi, then slowly walked by Derek and Adan, drawing a sharp blade from inside her cloak.

Khalani shifted, her core tightening as the woman closely studied Brock’s reaction. He remained stoic, his face betraying nothing, but when

she moved toward Serene, the air around him seemed to vibrate, the muscle in his neck jumping.

“You’re a pretty one,” the woman commented, her voice a delicate whisper.

She knelt, brushing a stray lock of hair from Serene’s face with the edge of her knife. “I do so hate having to destroy nice things.”

When she inched closer, Brock shouted, “Stop!”

His breath came in ragged gasps, eyes wide as he fixated on Serene, who sat with her back straight, a fire in her eyes that practically *dared* the woman to try carving her up.

Khalani could almost feel the woman’s cold, calculating smile as she stood and turned back to Brock, lovingly scraping her finger on the edge of the blade.

“I’m a Death-Zoner,” Brock hissed through his teeth. “I’ve traveled from Apollo to Hermes multiple times, transporting resources.”

“Really?” The woman stepped closer, a sharper interest in her tone. “What kind of resources?”

“Medicine. Food. Guns.”

The woman froze at the last word and both men stiffened, an unknown look passing between them.

Khalani discreetly wriggled her hands, trying to free herself from the bindings while they were distracted.

“He’s lying, Chief,” one of the men spat. “He’s probably the one supplying the Sinners with those weapons.”

“Or we can use them,” the other man suggested. “Integrate them into the Desert Spring. Make them supply *us* with more weapons instead. Take the advantage that way.”

“Too risky,” the man said. “I say we kill them all.”

The woman remained eerily silent as the men brazenly discussed their imminent murder.

Khalani’s gaze darted around the dimly lit room, desperately searching for any clue or glimmers of hope that might offer a way out.

Then, a bold idea sparked in her mind.

“What if we help each other?”

The woman scoffed, turning to Khalani. “What makes you think we need your help?”

“If it’s weapons that you’re looking for. We can help you,” she insisted.

The woman's shoulders tensed, Khalani's words striking a chord. But she folded her arms across her chest, her expression inscrutable. "We already have more guns now, courtesy of you."

"Our ammunition will only last you so long."

A heavy stillness filled the room, broken only by the erratic flicker of the overhead bulb. Every eye was fixed on Khalani and she forced herself to remain calm.

"What exactly are you suggesting?" the woman asked sharply.

"If you let us go," Khalani gulped, "we'll bring back the weapons you need from Hermes. But there's something else. There was another woman with us. She was injured." The pounding in her heart increased. "Where is she?"

"Unlike the Sinners, the Desert Spring doesn't kill old defenseless women."

"So, she's safe?" Khalani asked, her voice trembling as she tried to inch forward, but the rope cut into her skin.

"For now," the woman tactfully replied.

Khalani's teeth gnashed together, fighting the urge to scream and demand Winnie's whereabouts but she took a deep breath, trying to hold it together.

"So, will you agree to our trade?" Khalani pressed.

"No."

Her mouth fell open. "No?"

The woman spun on her. "That's right. Even *if* you are who you say you are, there's no guarantee you'll honor your end of the bargain and return from Hermes."

"You're wrong," Khalani protested. "We're good people."

"Ha! Good people still lie."

Khalani's chest caved in as their chances of escape slowly diminished like the sun. "What can we do to prove ourselves?"

"Nothing."

"*Please*. We'll do anything."

The woman hesitated, her focus shifting to the other captives before lingering on Takeshi, whose eyes locked onto Khalani with a mix of frustration and an emotion she couldn't quite place—perhaps anger, or something else entirely.

After a long pause, the woman spoke. "We can't let you leave the Desert

Spring, but maybe you're right. Maybe there *is* some other use for you." She nodded to the one of the men, who abruptly turned, bounding up the stairs.

"Are you sure this is wise, Chief?" the other man asked, his tone hostile as he glared at Brock.

"Are you questioning my authority?" the woman lashed out.

The man flinched, shifting uncomfortably. "N-no, Chief. But how can we trust them?"

"We don't," was the woman's terse reply.

Underlining her chilling words, more footsteps echoed down the stairs. Khalani shifted back against the metal pole as ten more figures appeared, crowding the small space. A few held pistols—ones that looked eerily familiar—while others brandished spears or knives.

"Cut the ropes," the woman ordered.

The strange figures moved with brisk efficiency, sawing through each of their bindings.

When Khalani was released, she gingerly cupped her wrists, rising slowly, limbs aching from the confinement. Brock inched closer to Serene, glaring at the woman.

And Takeshi…he stood like a looming wraith.

She had no doubt that if he were the only captive, he would've already attacked them and found a way to escape. But with Khalani and the others by his side and Winnie still missing, he had no choice but to comply with the strange leader's demands.

The woman nodded, her voice bounding around the room with unquestioning authority.

"You now belong to the Desert Spring. The sun and moon goddesses will decide whether you're worthy to remain within our walls. But understand this…if we detect even the faintest hint of betrayal, you won't merely seal your own fate—you will condemn your entire tribe. And we don't bury our enemies anymore. We spear them from throat to groin and hoist them at the gates for the desert to claim."

Khalani's wide eyes met Serene's, and both of them silently communicated the same thing.

They were absolutely *fucked.*

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9

You don’t have to worry.
I’ll worry enough for the both of us.

“What happened to them all? The ones who didn’t get a spot in the bunkers?” Khalani asked in the Braderhelm library.

“They died.” Winnie’s gaze sank to the floor, as though it might absorb her sorrow. “They were left behind in a poisoned wasteland, with nothing but a slow, agonizing death waiting for them.”

“But why couldn’t they make more room?! What made us more deserving than them to live?”

“Nothing. Absolutely nothing.” Winnie clasped her hands. “Remember this, Khalani. No person is more deserving than another. You can’t control where or who you’re born to. You can’t control your luck. All you can do is recognize your privileges and strive to be better than those who came before you.”

“Not sure if I’m doing a good job of that.” Khalani’s shoulders drooped.

Winnie cupped her shoulder and gave her a knowing smile. “You’re here for a reason. That’s why you’re still alive. I know the road hasn’t been easy. But have you ever considered that you’re meant to walk the hard path so the next person can fly over it?”

Khalani’s thoughts were pulled back to the present as the strange figures pushed them forward. Clad in tan garments and black cloaks, they guided Khalani and the others up the creaky wooden stairs, their swords and spears glinting menacingly under the dim light.

At the top of the stairs, Khalani entered a room that almost seemed trapped in time.

The light was muted, casting a shadowy veil over a cracked, brown leather sofa in the middle of the space. The wooden floor, marked by

countless scuffs and dents, groaned beneath her feet.

She glanced at the white walls, where an assortment of dusty pictures hung in glass frames. A beautiful family smiled back at her, surrounded by plants and trees.

In one of the pictures, two kids stood in front of a brightly lit tree, with wrapped boxes scattered on the floor.

Her gaze narrowed on the couch in the image, strikingly similar to the one planted in front of her.

One of the men tugged on her elbow, pulling her attention away. In the corner of the room was a strange apparatus—an old box with a grey screen and two slender legs attached.

She frowned, trying to get a closer look.

“This way.” The red-haired woman gestured toward a white door on her left.

Khalani’s thoughts raced a thousand miles an hour as they quickly followed their captors. But when they were led out the door, her steps faltered.

It wasn’t the pale moon hovering majestically above them that took her breath away. It was the rows of one-story houses, each painted a different, cheerful color, lining a curved road.

Each house was enclosed by a white picket fence that highlighted well-manicured front yards. The green grass shimmered in the moonlight, meticulously trimmed to an even height. Khalani stumbled, having not seen grass since her first ascent to the domed city of Genesis.

It was a world untouched by the Great Collapse.

The enchanting houses even had yellow mailboxes positioned in front of their fences.

But then, a much larger object caught her eye.

A towering metal wall, twenty feet high, circled the town. A walkway ran along the top of the wall, where figures in black cloaks patrolled with spears. Khalani felt their vigilant gazes upon her, as if they were peering directly into her eyes.

“Let’s go,” the woman commanded, tearing her gaze from the wall.

They walked along a black cement road that ran through the heart of the picturesque town.

A small green sign caught her eye, clinging to a metal pole that jutted from the cracked pavement.

Merry Avenue.

Tall, elegant lamps cast a warm glow on the street, each adorned with intricate swirling patterns on their bronze surfaces.

No one else was on the road.

She glanced at one of the pink houses that had a wraparound porch and a swinging bench. There were no lights or signs of life in the house or in any of the homes they'd passed

But before she turned away, something flickered in the window, the drapes slightly shifting.

"Did you see that?" Khalani whispered to Serene.

"See what?" Serene frowned.

Khalani looked back at the house, but everything was still. As if only ghosts resided behind the window panes.

She scowled, pulling the lapel of her shirt closer as a sharp gust of wind swept through. Her gaze drifted back up to the intimidating metal wall that seemed incredibly out of place compared to the colorful homes they passed.

Many of the shadowy figures lining the wall watched the outer desert. They were vigilant, alert, their weapons glinting menacingly as they scanned over the expansive area.

She shivered, needing to know if the wall served as a barrier to keep threats out…or was it built to contain everyone within?

The six of them trudged along the old road, flanked by strange men and women whose dark cloaks blended with the shadows, led by the enigmatic, flaming-haired woman at the front.

Khalani's skin itched and tingled as she ventured deeper into the town, unable to shake the unsettling feeling of multiple eyes watching every movement she made.

Serene pressed closer to Khalani's side, her focus darting between each person and house with a frenzied intensity.

Takeshi walked a few feet away from her.

He held his head high, each step steady and measured, but his gaze continued to harden, flickering between the sharp weapons of their captors and the fortress that trapped them.

The red-haired woman finally halted at the end of the road where two identical yellow houses stood. Unlike the other houses, the fences had a few posts missing, overgrown grass in their yards, and dusty porch benches that creaked and swayed with the wind.

“This is where you’ll be staying,” the woman announced. “Each house has two bedrooms. Divide yourselves as you see fit—”

“We’re not splitting up,” Takeshi interjected sharply.

The woman tilted her head in surprise. “The Desert Spring is large enough to accommodate each of you and provide you all a place to sleep. You’d disregard our generous hospitality?”

“You dragged us here unconscious and won’t let us leave.” Brock scoffed. “I wouldn’t call that hospitality.”

One of the men stepped forward, thrusting a spear toward Brock’s throat. “Watch how you speak to your Chief, Under-Dweller.”

Brock didn’t flinch and regarded the spear like a child’s plaything. “She’s *your* Chief. Not ours.”

The figures around them bristled, and Khalani noticed them lifting their weapons higher. Everyone tensed, but the Chief raised her hand.

“Relax.” The Chief’s voice was unsettlingly cheerful. “He’s not going to do anything, not when he knows we’ll kill his precious tribe if he does.”

The open scorn and hostility in Brock’s eyes could’ve melted steel, but he stayed silent.

“Now, you all can sleep on the floor if you like. Or the grass. Your comfort means nothing—only what you can do for us. But these are the rules you must follow. Do not attempt to climb the wall. Do not venture to the front gate. And do *not* leave the house at night. If you require anything, Ferren and Jared will be posted outside.”

“We don’t need bodyguards,” Adan said.

“They’re for our protection, not yours,” the Chief replied curtly, turning to leave.

“Wait!” Khalani dashed forward. “What about our friend? When can we see her? How do we know if she’s okay?”

The frantic shaking in her hands grew uncontrollable.

Every second apart from Winnie felt like another shard of her past breaking away, just like the photograph of her parents Dana had torn in Braderhelm.

The unfamiliar houses stood as quiet witnesses to her turmoil.

The woman paused, glancing over her shoulder.

“I’ll let you see her tomorrow. As for her condition…” She looked skyward. “It’s up to the moon goddess now whether she lives or dies.”

“What the hell is that supposed to mean?”

The Chief ignored her and walked away, her cloak fluttering behind her as all but two figures followed.

“Wait! Just tell me if she’s okay!” Khalani’s voice echoed into the cool night, but no one answered. Her bottom lip trembled as the words echoed back in her mind.

“It’s up to the moon goddess whether she lives or dies.”

Lives.

Or.

No.

Khalani couldn’t allow Winnie’s fate to be decided by some mystical force. She took a few steps forward, preparing to knock on every door to find Winnie, but a larger figure blocked her path.

“Takeshi…don’t. Please don’t.” Khalani hated begging, but desperation took over. “I have to find her.”

But Takeshi didn’t move. “We will, Kanes. If they don’t take you to her tomorrow, you know I’ll kill everyone to get her back to you.”

He spoke of death as if it were his burden to bear and gift to deliver.

“But Winnie doesn’t like violence…” She swayed on her feet and blinked rapidly, trying to fight the exhaustion that bore down on her.

“C’mon, Khalani,” Serene’s voice was gentle but firm as she tugged on Khalani’s elbow. “You’re dead on your feet and need to rest. We’ll figure everything out in the morning. No one is leaving, Winnie. I promise. We’re all here with you.”

Khalani’s chin trembled as Derek, Adan, Takeshi and even Brock drew nearer. Their eyes held a shared grief, as if her pain had woven itself into their own.

Like they considered Winnie family, too.

The two male figures who were left behind stepped forward.

One had brown hair tied back in a tight ponytail, while the other’s long, flowing black hair cascaded down his back. Both were tall, deeply tanned, lean, and had the build of seasoned fighters.

“It’s time for you all to go inside now,” the one with the long hair said. His voice was deep and raspy, as if his vocal cords had been charred.

“Do you girls need help?” The one with the ponytail stepped forward, and she felt his gaze lingering on Serene and her.

“They’re fine,” Brock practically growled. “Let’s go.”

Takeshi deftly positioned himself between her and the men, blocking Khalani from view as they entered the house.

The air was still.

As if it hadn't been breathed in years.

The creepy yellow home was covered in dust, with only the moonlight filtering through the window providing visibility. Pink polka dot wallpaper clung to the walls, faded and peeling, while a dirty brown carpet lay across the floor. Sparse furniture was scattered about the room, covered in white sheets.

Serene put her arm around Khalani's shoulders and shuffled her to the nearest bedroom.

She first noticed the white covers and…a bed.

Khalani immediately collapsed onto the bed, a loud sigh escaping her as the soft sheets molded to her body like they were made for her frame.

"Who's taking the other room?" Adan asked, his voice breaking the tense silence.

"Only two beds, so maybe the girls share one, and two of us can take the other bed and the couch?" Derek suggested.

If she wasn't so exhausted, she would've loved to see Takeshi and Brock's faces at the mere notion of having to snuggle together.

The daily act of not killing each other was a magnificent feat.

Brock scoffed, and his hard footsteps thudded against the wooden floor as he drew near. "We should pair each girl with a guy in case someone tries to break in and kill us."

"Absolutely not. Just because we have tits doesn't mean we're incompetent or weak," Serene hissed.

"I didn't mean wea—"

"Just give me one of your guns," Serene cut him off.

"No. They took our weapons in case you forgot."

"So…you're useless is what you're saying."

"On second thought, maybe you can annoy our kidnappers to death," Brock griped.

"Here." Takeshi's voice cut through the argument as he moved closer.

A slight shuffle and a pause.

"A knife? How come they didn't take it off you?" Serene asked.

"I know how to hide my weapons," Takeshi replied cryptically. "If anyone but us tries to get through this door, you stick this in their throat."

The quiet hint of death in his tone was unnerving. Serene held a particular level of distrust toward Takeshi, but she surprisingly said, “Thanks.”

Khalani’s eyes grew heavier as Serene closed the door and drew the blinds close, plunging the room into complete darkness. Serene collapsed onto the bed and when her head hit the pillow, the most contented sigh left her mouth.

“I forgot what a bed felt like,” Serene grumbled face-first into the pillow.

The promise of tomorrow and its looming wrath made her take a deep breath, and she nestled into the pillow, surrendering to the comfort of sleep. Right before blessed unconsciousness overtook her, Serene’s soft voice whispered through the air.

“Khalani?”

“Hmm?”

“What if these people are good?”

Khalani shifted slightly, squinting in the dark. “What do you mean?”

“They have a bunch of houses…and it all looks so nice. Maybe, after we find a way to Hermes and bring them back supplies, they’ll let us stay,” Serene offered, a hopeful lilt to her voice.

“I don’t know. Something about this place gives me the creeps. But if everything turns out okay and they let us continue on to Hermes...yeah. Maybe we can come back and stay.”

She spoke the words, but they didn’t feel genuine.

Before sleep consumed her, a haunting voice in the cool air whispered that the only thing this town could offer was their demise.

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10

If you tried measuring me by my fears,
you'd need a longer stick.

The sun's rays blazed through the window, painting streaks of gold across the bedroom. Khalani groaned into her pillow, her forehead damp. She rubbed her eyes, yawning deeply.

"How long have we been asleep?" she muttered, turning to Serene, only to find her side of the bed empty.

Frowning, Khalani swung her legs over the edge, standing on the grey carpeted floor. She eased the bedroom door open, wincing at the loud creak.

As it swung open, it collided with the soft pink walls of the hallway. Khalani poked her head out, expecting to see the others, but the house was silent. Still.

"Hello?"

Her footsteps were muffled on the carpet as she wandered through the house, the white sheets still draped over the furniture.

"Serene? Adan? Derek? Takeshi? Brock?" she called out.

The answering quiet was tangible.

An eerie shuffle on the porch made her heart race. A shadow of feet appeared under the front door. She waited for something to happen, a knock or shout, but the dark shadow just stayed there.

Her chest heaved with uneven breaths, but she shook her head, trying not to panic.

It's probably just Brock.

With a swift motion, she flung the door open.

But it was just Takeshi's large silhouette standing outside, staring out at the town with his hands on his hips.

"You scared me," she breathed out, releasing a nervous laugh. "Where is everyone?"

Takeshi slowly turned. But his face wasn’t his own—it belonged to Alexander Huxley.

Khalani’s eyes went wide, her muscles clenching tight as steel blue eyes locked onto hers, draining the color from her face.

Scream.

She needed to scream.

It was the only way to release the endless horror ripping through her veins. But her mouth clamped shut, like an iron muzzle had slammed over her face.

“Are you sure you’re asking the right questions?” he sneered.

His pale blue eyes held her captive, a magnet drawing her deeper into an endless abyss.

Khalani suddenly jolted awake, her body drenched in sweat, and her heart pounding.

She frantically glanced over, and Serene was fast asleep in the bed.

Khalani placed a hand over her chest to steady her heavy breathing. After a minute, she quietly crawled out of bed, her muscles stiff. But when Khalani opened the door, she nearly jumped out of her skin.

Takeshi sat outside the doorway, his back resting against the grey couch, its white sheet flung haphazardly onto the floor. One leg was sprawled out and the other bent as he deftly flipped an obsidian blade between his fingers.

Just how many weapons did he have hidden?

Khalani regarded him longer than she should’ve. Takeshi still hadn’t removed his black gear. The way they pulled at his muscles, the casual messiness of his hair, and the deadly focus in his gaze when he tilted his head made her inhale sharply.

“What are you doing on the floor?”

“He’s been sitting there the entire time,” Adan popped around the corner, dressed in dark green sweatpants and a plain white T-shirt. “I don’t think Brock’s gotten any sleep either.”

Adan nodded toward the other side of the couch where Brock was indeed doing push-ups on the floor, his grunts of exertion audible.

“Why?” she asked.

“Someone needs to keep watch,” Brock grumbled, springing to his feet. “I don’t trust these people. I tried going outside, but our two watchdogs made me come back in. She still asleep?”

Khalani instantly knew who he was referring to. “Yeah, Serene’s still in bed. Should I wake her?”

“No.” His voice was firmer. “She needs the rest.” Brock swallowed, and just like that, his expression turned cold before he retreated down the hall.

Her brows pulled low and her gaze flickered to Takeshi, who hadn’t stopped watching her since she emerged from the bedroom.

“What?” She shifted awkwardly. “Do I look like a mess or something?”

“Or something.”

Khalani wanted to press him for his thoughts, but with her wild hair and sunken eyes, he probably thought she looked terrible.

“They still out there?” Khalani nodded toward the front door.

“Yes.”

“Great. We’re stuck in another prison,” she huffed, sliding down the white wall across from Takeshi. She stretched her legs, the satisfying cracks and pops echoing back to her.

Takeshi didn’t respond, just kept methodically rolling the blade between his fingertips.

How he managed to not cut himself was one of life’s greatest mysteries.

“Were you really out here all night?” she asked. “You didn’t sleep at all?”

“I had to make sure no one was going to sneak in and attack.”

She blinked, unable to contain her next question.

“And what would you have done if that happened?”

The atmosphere shifted, and Takeshi slowly lifted his gaze, his dark eyes ensnaring hers.

“Whatever you think I’d do, I assure you it’d be far worse.”

Her next breath came faster while Takeshi stole glances at the door, as if he were hoping for a chance to put his blade to use.

“Do you think they’ll bring us some food?” Adan interrupted, plopping down next to her. “I’m starving and it’s late.”

“Late? We slept through the day?”

“You were tired.”

“And they haven’t returned our packs yet?”

“No,” Takeshi answered grimly, tightening his grip on the blade.

“But look at the town.” Adan gestured around him. “They have to feed these people somehow. We even have tins of water in our kitchen, so there must be a well nearby.”

“Well, that’s good. At least we have water.” She tried to sound hopeful.

“*Or*,” Brock interjected from around the corner, “they’re trying to lull us into a false sense of security because they’re cannibals and plan on eating us.”

They all shot him sidelong glares.

“Dude.” Adan grimaced. “Really?”

“I don’t think I’m hungry anymore.” Her lips twisted as she folded her arms around her knees.

If anyone stared at her limbs too long, she’d find a way to bolt over the walls.

Brock shrugged and moved to sit beside her, but Takeshi shifted his long legs, blocking him.

Brock rolled his eyes. “Territorial much?”

“Don’t know what you mean. I’m just stretching my legs.” Takeshi’s tone was forebodingly serene as he continued twirling the blade.

The silence extended, and Khalani nearly jumped as the front door creaked open.

The man with long hair cascading down his back stepped inside, a hard scowl embedded on his face.

“The Chief wants you to join us for dinner. But you all stink and I can’t have you bringing that stench into our hall.” His nose wrinkled. “Take a shower and change into the clothes left for you.” He gestured to a bundle of beige clothes on the couch

“A shower?” Her eyes widened.

She hadn’t showered since Braderhelm.

The days on the road, under the sweltering sun, had been unforgiving. The only small comfort was that they’d all grown so accustomed to the smell, it barely registered anymore.

“Where does the water come from?” Derek asked, emerging from the hallway, his expression one of scientific curiosity.

“We have wells that feed from the river. Any other questions?”

“Yeah, you mentioned food. What kind of food?” Adan hedged.

“We mostly eat canned food from raids. Beans. Tomatoes. Beef stew.”

“No humans?” Adan asked, and Khalani elbowed him in the side.

“No.” The hate in the man’s eyes intensified. “Hurry up. You have an hour to get ready, or you don’t eat.” The seething guard slammed the door shut, shaking the picture frames on the wall.

“You just had to piss the man off,” Derek grumbled.

“Blame *him* for putting the idea of people eating us in my head.” Adan pointed at Brock.

“Could still happen,” Brock replied. “I wouldn’t let your feet dangle over the bed tonight if you know what’s good for you.”

Adan paled, and Khalani leaned over.

“Don’t listen to him,” she said before laboring to her feet.

She crossed the room to the bundle of clothes left on the couch. The fabric was lightweight and the color of sand. There was even underwear and a bra.

Her lips curved into a slight smile as she inhaled the fresh scent of the fabric. After living months in Braderhelm, clean clothes were a rare and unexpected gift.

An hour later, they were all showered, clean, and stood in the living room, wearing the clothing laid out for them—though their captors didn’t appear to have anything Takeshi’s size. The shirt that was long on everyone else ended slightly above his hip.

Khalani’s gaze lingered on the small stretch of golden skin just beneath his abs for what felt like too long. She quickly looked away, opting to have a love affair with the ceiling instead.

The brusque guard came back, shooting death glares their way as he gestured for them to leave.

When Khalani walked outside, she noticed groups of people in tan garments emerging from their houses. They carried themselves proudly, waltzing along the street and grinning ear to ear as if they possessed all the time in the world.

Some kids played with a ball outside, their laughter echoing in the air. But as soon as Khalani’s group approached, the parents quickly ushered their children away.

With the afternoon light, they had a much better view of the Desert Spring.

The brightly colored houses all had strange metal casings on the roofs that reflected the sun. There were no broken-down cars or crumbling buildings, just charming homes, neatly manicured lawns and smiling residents.

Despite this, the gnawing pressure in her chest refused to subside.

Something made her glance over her shoulder as more people eyed her

with strange expressions. The guards posted on the walls watched them from above, and she fought the urge to turn and barricade herself back inside the house.

“What are your names?” Serene’s voice cut through Khalani’s troubled thoughts.

“I’m Ferren,” said the man with the ponytail. “And this is Jared.” He gestured to his burly partner with long black hair, who grunted in response.

Ferren and Jared didn’t say anything else as they stiffly led them toward a large log cabin. Inside, the room was packed with what appeared to be a hundred people sitting at two long wooden tables. An array of men, women, and children chatted and laughed, their plates empty.

But as soon as they walked in, the crowd’s noise quieted to a low hum of whispers and hard stares.

Parents gathered their children close.

A few men standing guard shifted the tips of their spears closer to their chests. Khalani tried to muster a reassuring smile, but it felt fragile and inadequate.

No one appeared to be eyeing her limbs in a ravenous way, though.

The positives were overwhelming.

The Chief stood in the back of the room, at a head table.

“These are our guests of the Desert Spring. You’ll treat them with respect,” she announced, her commanding voice cutting through the whispers. “However, if you see them attempting to escape, alert a warrior immediately and they’ll be speared to the gates at daybreak. Now, please, sit and eat.”

With that wonderful, not at all terrifying introduction, the Chief settled into her seat, and one by one, figures emerged from a back room, carrying bowls of food.

Ferren gestured their group toward the nearest wooden table. But when they sat, a family of three quickly scooted as far away as possible.

She shifted in her seat, palms itching, muscles pulled tight into knots, when the little girl with black pigtails next to her appeared on the verge of tears.

“Hi,” Khalani smiled at the girl. “What’s your name?”

The little girl’s face turned red, and her chin trembled. She scrambled into her father’s lap, and the family abruptly stood. They moved to another table, shooting her looks of disdain.

What just happened?

Ferren set a steaming bowl of broth in front of her. The scent wasn't unpleasant, but she grimaced at the appearance.

"Where does the food come from?" Serene asked, eyeing her bowl warily.

"We raid the nearby ruins," Ferren replied, setting bowls in front of Takeshi and Brock. "The old cities have plenty of stockpiled food that could feed thousands. Eat up."

The brown color and strange lumps of meat in the broth made her uneasy. But after months of dreadful prison 'food' and tiny ration bars on the surface, she was desperate for an actual meal.

Ignoring the rusty spoon, she lifted the bowl to her mouth, only for a large hand to set it down.

She looked up at the culprit sitting across from her. An endless black pit resided in Takeshi's eyes, and she met him with an equally stormy scowl.

"What do you think you're—"

"Tell me what's in this," Takeshi asked Ferren, ignoring her.

"It's canned beef stew raided from the city," Ferren replied. "As I mentioned earlier."

"Eat it then," Takeshi demanded.

"If we wanted to kill you," Jared said, stepping closer with his arms crossed, "there are much easier ways to do so."

Takeshi's granite expression stayed stagnant as he stared at them.

They didn't realize that arguing with Takeshi was akin to yelling at the ground to stop being hard.

After a tense silence, Ferren dipped a spoon into Khalani's broth and brought it to his mouth for a taste.

"Satisfied?" he asked after swallowing, his throat bobbing.

Takeshi scrutinized him for a long moment before nodding.

"You sure are paranoid," Serene griped before diving into her food.

Khalani wasted no time eating either. She barely took a breath, gulping everything down. Even if the food was poisoned, she still might've gone for another bite.

"We stay alive by questioning everything," Brock answered, agreeing with Takeshi for once.

When they finished eating, the Chief approached, her maroon cloak floating gracefully behind her. She walked with such grace and poise that

Khalani straightened in her seat.

“Come. I will take you to see your friend now.”

***

The Chief led them into a light blue house, one of the few two-story homes in the town. Inside, the house looked well-lived in and clean with shiny wooden floors and creamy leather furniture. They passed a white kitchen with stacks of canned food on every counter.

They followed the Chief up blue carpeted stairs with pictures of a happy family lining the wall.

When they reached the top of the stairs, they entered a warm room where two women wearing long white dresses leaned over a small bed. Khalani’s heart skipped a beat when she recognized the small figure beneath the sheets.

“Winnie!” She rushed forward, crouching by her side.

Winnie lay still under the covers, her pale cheeks almost blending with the white fabric. She wore a clean white shirt, with fresh bandages covering her shoulder. But her eyes were closed, and her hands rested motionless by her sides.

One of the women, middle-aged with dark skin and black hair, was attending to Winnie’s bandages. The other looked slightly younger, with blonde hair tied in a low ponytail. Contrary to most of the people she’d seen in the Desert Spring, her pale skin nearly matched Khalani’s.

The younger woman checked Winnie’s temperature as the Chief asked, “How is she, Ari?”

The blonde girl gave an exacerbated sigh. “You have a knack for bringing them in half-dead, don’t you, Penn?”

“Ari.”

“She’s stable…for now. We’ve managed to reduce the fever and used some antibiotics for the infection. We’ll see if they take.” Ari washed her hands in a basin.

“Antibiotics?” Derek straightened, lines etched in his forehead. “Where did you get them? All the ones from the Great Collapse would’ve expired by now.”

Ari shot a panicked glance to the Chief, who interjected. “We get them from raids. Some of the medicine from the Great Collapse remains

effective. Now, you can see we're caring for your friend, and she's alive. It's time for you to return to the house."

Khalani immediately pulled back.

"No. I wanna stay with her." Her chest felt like it was going to cave in at the thought of leaving Winnie again.

"What her body needs right now is rest," Ari spoke fervently, placing a hand on her shoulder. "We won't let any harm come to her."

She gulped, a lump forming in her throat, but Serene clutched her hand and squeezed.

"Come, Khalani. There's nothing more we can do right now."

Her neck hung as she rested her other hand on Winnie's. Tears formed in the corners of her eyes, but she refused to let them fall in front of their captors.

A few tense moments passed before she reluctantly stood, kissing Winnie's cold cheek. "I won't be far, Winnie. I'll be right here *when* you wake up."

Khalani wiped her nose. What surprised her was when the others, even Brock and Takeshi, touched Winnie's leg or arm, their stares gleaming with sadness, affection, and…love. It looked like love.

The Chief regarded them with an odd gaze as they held Winnie close and quietly left the house.

Night had fallen, and torches illuminated the path.

"Why do you have men patrolling the walls around the clock?" Brock asked.

The Chief's gaze remained fixed ahead. "They're on constant watch for Sinners."

"What's so dangerous about the Sinners?"

The Chief's shoulders tensed, her posture as rigid as the walls that surrounded them.

"The Sinners aren't merely a threat—they are predators intent on extinguishing the Desert Spring. They torment their young and cast them out into the desert. Had they found you as we did, they would've eaten you alive."

"You mean in the metaphorical sense," Serene pressed.

"No. The literal sense," the Chief replied, her voice cutting through the brisk air. "We keep a watch and train our warriors daily because Ansel is waiting for the right time to attack."

“Who’s Ansel?” Derek asked.

“The leader of the Sinners,” the Chief spat, her jaw clenching. “A spawn of the devil who has been trying to conquer our walls for years.”

“And if he does?” Khalani’s voice trembled with apprehension.

“We will prevail. We have no other choice.”

“But if you let us leave for Hermes, we can bring you back more weapons to fight—”

“No,” the Chief snapped, halting in the middle of the road. “The moon goddess watches over us. Stronger weapons or not, she won’t let us fall.” She tilted her head back, but the pale moon didn’t provide any divine reassurances.

When the Chief walked away, Brock scoffed.

“They’re definitely going to die.”

She happened to agree.

From her short, tragic existence, Khalani knew all too well that looking to some mysterious force for saving was a foolish effort.

They’d be waiting until the Earth claimed their graves.

There appeared to be more families than warriors in the Desert Spring, and if they were attacked, she wasn’t confident they would all survive.

The bigger problem was that Khalani and the others were trapped inside the walls with them.

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11

Watch out for the quiet ones.
They've learned how to mask their rage.

That night, Khalani barely slept. She used to find solace in sleep. But sometimes, fears cross boundaries they shouldn't.

Sliding through barriers.

Burrowing into dreams.

Unyielding

Relentless.

She eventually got up and lay on the couch in the living room, her eyes fixed on the uneven white ceiling. The quietness of the room was deceptive. Every creak of the floorboards and distant murmur in the house was magnified.

The front door abruptly swung open, shattering the fragile silence.

The Chief strode in, her long black hair neatly braided down her back. Dressed in beige pants and a brown tank top that accentuated her toned arms, she exuded strength and confidence.

"Get everyone ready," she commanded. "You'll be assigned to your stations today."

"Stations?" Serene appeared from around the corner, her dripping blue hair leaving dark stains on her shirt.

"Yes. In the Desert Spring, everyone pulls their own weight." The Chief crossed her arms. "If you don't work, you don't eat. You have a few minutes to meet me outside." With a decisive turn, she slammed the front door shut.

Khalani quickly roused the others. Wearing the loose-fitting tan clothing and black boots, the six of them followed the Chief into the harsh daylight.

Ferren and Jared stood guard on the porch, their impatience evident. Without a word, the Chief marched through the center of town, leaving

them no choice but to follow.

The only improvement from yesterday was that the few town members on the road didn't flee at their approach. They merely curled their lips in distaste.

"This is the main housing area." The Chief's voice stretched over the hot air as she pointed out various buildings. "Over there is the medical cabin, which you've already seen, and next to it is our dining hall."

Serene stayed close by her side as they listened intently, with Brock, Adan, and Derek not far behind.

Takeshi hung back, scanning the outer walls obsessively.

"Ah, here we are."

The Chief led them to an open dirt clearing beyond the houses. A group of thirty people, mostly men with smaller builds, stood in a circle wearing black cloaks.

"How's it going, Patreus?" the Chief called out.

A taller man in a black tunic stood off to the side, hands resting on his hips. He had razor-short brown hair and a permanent frown etched on his tan face. At the Chief's voice, he turned, his bulging muscles tensing.

"*Please* tell me it wasn't one of these girls who killed Varo," the man rumbled.

"It wasn't." The Chief tilted her head. "But you know better than to judge based off size, Patreus."

Patreus crossed his arms. "Yes, you won't let me forget *that*. So, which one did it?"

The Chief fixed her attention on Takeshi. "What's your name?"

Takeshi's expression hardened like the name he gave her. "Steele."

"You really gave our men quite a beating, *Steele*." Her voice was edged with bitter resentment. "The Desert Spring was built for peace, but we find ourselves needing the kind of tenacity you displayed. Your assignment is to assist Patreus in training our warriors. Think you can handle that?"

Takeshi's frown deepened and his gaze flickered over Khalani and the others for a split second.

"What will their assignments be?" he asked.

The Chief sighed. "I've thought it through. The girls will help wash clothing. You two," she indicated Adan and Derek, "will gather water from the well."

The Chief finally turned to Brock. “And *you* will help prepare meals in the group kitchen.”

Brock’s fierce gaze narrowed. “I’d be more useful training your warriors than wasting time in the *kitchen*.” He spat the word like an insult.

“And the fact that you believe I care what you want makes this moment even more gratifying. Enjoy.” The Chief spun on her heel and marched away without looking back.

Patreus muttered under his breath and directed Khalani and Serene to a white building down the road to meet a woman named Marissa. Ferren and Jared led Derek and Adan to the well, while Brock begrudgingly marched toward the food hall, grumbling obscenities the whole way.

A few feet down the path, she glanced back and caught Patreus giving Takeshi a stern talking-to, his gaze icy and filled with distrust. Takeshi appeared to be listening intently, but his gaze shifted to her.

She froze, but Serene said, “C’mon, Khalani. We don’t want to get in trouble.”

Khalani nodded, continuing on their path. She couldn’t help but peer over her shoulder once more.

But Takeshi never looked back.

***

For the next few days, Khalani and Serene spent their time scrubbing dirty clothes in large water barrels.

They worked until the sun dipped below the horizon and the oppressive heat gave way to a cool chill.

In the evening, they joined the others in the log cabin for a quick, brothy meal. Despite the hard work they put in each day, the Desert Spring residents continued to stare at them as if Khalani and the others were going to murder them in their sleep.

At night, in the stillness of the house, the six of them gathered to discuss escape plans. Adan and Brock searched every corner and crevice to ensure there were no cameras or listening devices. Even though they couldn’t find anything, they still talked in hushed whispers in the bedroom.

Brock and Takeshi were confident in their abilities to knock out Ferren and Jared, the guards who were tasked with keeping a close on eye them,

but the wall presented a more daunting challenge. It was heavily guarded, both on the ground and from above.

Their best idea yet was Adan making a very tall ladder…

So, they basically had nothing.

Their small ray of hope and the only thing keeping Khalani from pulling her hair out was Winnie's gradual improvement.

Each night, Khalani visited her, intently watching the steadiness of her breathing and the hint of color returning to her cheeks.

But Winnie still hadn't woken up.

"Give it time," Ari had said the previous night, her hand gently resting on Khalani's shoulder. "When the body sleeps, it can concentrate on healing itself."

The next day, Khalani found herself scrubbing the dirty clothes harder, the soap dissolving into her skin as the sun set low in the sky. The faster she finished, the sooner she could check on Winnie.

"Why does it feel like we've gone from one prison to another," Serene grumbled, holding up her soaked and wrinkled hands in disgust.

"At least we're not behind bars this time. And we have a shower."

Khalani said this, but a heavy weight had settled in her gut. She couldn't pinpoint the problem, but every time she walked back to the house at night, an unsettling sensation crawled up her spine, and her steps hastened.

Like an invisible monster watched her from behind the curtains.

"Switched out iron bars for a roommate that snores," Serene replied, momentarily distracting her.

"I do not snore!"

"Sure do. I bet even Takeshi can hear it outside the door." Serene imitated an obnoxious noise that sounded like a creature dying.

Khalani gasped and threw a wet, dirty rag straight at her face. Serene retaliated by grabbing the entire water bucket, but it crashed to the floor.

"What the hell is going on?!" Marissa burst through the door, her frizzy black hair tied in a tight bun on top of her head.

Marissa was a rail-thin, middle-aged woman with a face full of freckles perpetually scrunched up in a scowl. In charge of their daily cleaning sessions, Marissa seemed to harbor a deep-seated disdain for Khalani in particular.

She was confident Marissa hated her more than she hated roaches.

And that was saying something.

“Nothing, ma’am,” Khalani said, her back going rigid. “The bucket just fell.”

Serene’s shoulders shook beside her.

The girl was definitely going to get them both killed one day.

But if someone needed to be buried, Khalani would be there with a shovel.

“Since you find this so amusing,” Marissa snapped at Serene, “you can skip dinner until you finish washing these other barrels of clothes.”

“And *you*.” Marrisa turned her harsh gaze to Khalani. “Go collect the dirty rags from Patreus’ training group. They’re usually drenched in sweat by the end of the day, so you get the privilege of cleaning them all. Move it!”

Khalani’s fists clenched as she heaved to her feet, struggling to suppress the expletives forming in her throat.

“Just follow their rules for now,” Derek had said the previous night. “We have a better shot of escaping if they don’t suspect we’ll leave.”

Stay calm. Stay focused. Then escape.

The sun was setting as she walked outside, turning the sky into a fiery canvas of reds and oranges. She took a moment to breathe and stretched her muscles over her head, somewhat grateful for the reprieve from sitting on a hard stool all day.

The only consolation was that the manual labor in the camp was a picnic compared to the horrors she’d endured in Braderhelm.

Speaking of horrors in Braderhelm…

The symphony of loud grunts guided her to the training area.

About thirty men and women were seated in a large circle, and in the center stood Takeshi. Without a shirt on.

Takeshi’s jet-black hair, tousled and wild, cascaded over his forehead as he demonstrated a fighting maneuver.

The sight made her think of the Adonis statue she’d once seen in Genesis.

His body was a work of art, chiseled not with gentle hands or the luck of genetics, but honed by years of grueling discipline to transform the body into a weapon.

Takeshi was currently engaged in a mock fight with a young woman about Khalani’s age.

Her blonde hair was pulled into a low ponytail, and her beige top clung to her chest as Takeshi corrected her stance multiple times.

His touch was brief but precise, guiding her in the same way he'd done with Khalani in Braderhelm.

Even though his hands barely lingered on the woman's body for more than a split second, Khalani found herself struggling to swallow past the knot in her throat.

But she shook her head, reminding herself that it didn't matter what Takeshi did or with whom.

He'd made it perfectly clear to her that she was as appealing to him as a rock in his shoe, and what happened between them in Braderhelm was a mistake.

Any interaction on the surface, including the night she'd thrown away her inhibitions and straddled his lap, were momentary lapses of sanity prompted by the effects of heat and loneliness.

In fact, it was preferable for him to cozy up with another girl who was in the mood for heartbreak.

Khalani.

Was.

Just.

Fine.

Thank.

You.

She marched to Patreus, who incessantly scowled as he shouted at the group to pay attention to Takeshi and the girl's maneuvers.

"Excuse me," she started.

But Patreus kept yelling, "Be ready to pair off! Remember, we can only achieve peace by defeating the Sinners in totality."

"Sir, I was sent—"

"Demeter! Are you too tired to pay attention?"

Huffing, Khalani touched Patreus's arm to get his attention, but he immediately seized her wrist in a sharp grip with one hand while reaching for his pistol with the other.

She stifled a gasp from the bone-crushing pressure on her wrist, but just as quickly as he'd grabbed her, Patreus abruptly released her, as if remembering himself.

"What are *you* doing here?" he demanded.

“I was sent here by Marissa.” Her lips twisted in anger. “She told me to collect any dirty rags that you guys have, but if you don’t need me, I’ll gladly leave.”

Patreus narrowed his gaze sizing her up, but he eventually nodded. “You can go around and ask if anyone wants their gear washed. But hurry up.”

Without a word, she turned away, eager to put distance between herself and the strangely aggressive old man.

The air was charged with anticipation as she made her way around the tense circle of onlookers. She felt Takeshi’s intense focus briefly shift to her, a silent warning in his gaze.

Her stomach tightened into garbled knots as Takeshi picked up the pace of the fight, and the heady grunts from the girl he was fighting amplified.

She needed to leave. Quickly.

The men and women were drenched in sweat and grime and tossed their gear to her with little regard, like she was a mere servant. Khalani’s glare hardened, but she continued collecting their dirty rags.

She reached the last person, her arms full of sweat-soaked and vomit-stained shirts, when a hand slapped her backside.

“Hey, parasite, you forgot my shirt!”

A burly man with curly brown hair and a handsome face laughed along with a few men as Khalani whirled around in shock. Her cheeks flushed as the choking laughter expanded, numbing every sound.

Her eyes flared and her hands shook.

Khalani had been through too much, suffered at the hands of too many men, to let anyone touch her without consent.

The shirts tumbled from her arms into a forgotten heap.

Before the cackling guy had a chance to react, she lunged, her fist barreling into his face. The jarring impact sent him to the ground, and the crowd gasped.

Pain flared in her knuckles, but she ignored it, finding a flicker of satisfaction in his audible groan as he staggered back, clutching his nose.

His friends clamored around him. “Are you okay, Garret?”

Garret brushed them off, spinning on her.

“What the fuck is your problem?” he growled.

“Do you make a habit of assaulting every girl that walks in your vicinity?” she shot back.

“You disgusting h—” Garret stepped forward but was abruptly yanked back.

Takeshi towered behind him, gripping the back of Garret’s neck. His other friends gulped, instinctively backing away.

“What happened?” Takeshi asked through his teeth.

“I’ll tell you what happened,” the man complained. “This bitch hit me—OW. Shit!”

Still clutching his neck, Takeshi kicked him in the back of his legs, forcing him to his knees. He leaned in, digging his fingers into the tendons of Garret’s neck.

“Do you know how many bones there are in your body? Two hundred and six. Call her that name again, and I will break every single one.”

The man whimpered in response, and Takeshi’s head lifted, staring directly at her. “What did he do?”

She crossed her arms and told the truth. “He smacked my ass.”

Takeshi’s left hand balled into a tight fist, while his other—still locked around the man’s neck—tightened. His nails dug into the man’s flesh, eliciting whimpers of pain as the guy squirmed and tried to wrench himself free. But the man’s struggles only seemed to fuel Takeshi’s deadly resolve.

It felt as though the very face of death gazed back as Takeshi reached for the sharp blade hidden in his boot.

“Steele!” Patreus yelled and the crowd parted for the old man who marched into the circle. “What do you think you’re doing?”

“You said you wanted me to *teach*. That’s what I intend to do,” his low, gravelly voice practically had its own wavelength. Takeshi leaned closer to Garret, who looked like he was about to wet himself.

“Apologize to her.”

“I’m s-s-sorry,” Garret stammered, his head hanging.

“No.” Takeshi jerked Garret’s head up, forcing him to meet Khalani’s gaze. “*Look* at her when you apologize.”

Garret’s lips trembled as a drop of blood fell from his nose. He choked out, “I’m sorry.”

Khalani crossed her arms, staring down at him like *he* was the parasite. “You better not touch any girl like that again without their permission.”

Garret nodded vigorously, sighing in relief.

But then, Takeshi hauled Garret by the collar of his shirt, dragging him to the center of the ring and tossing him to the ground like a useless rag.

Garret scrambled to his feet, pure dread in his eyes as Takeshi marched toward him.

"What are you doing? She accepted my apology!"

"She did." Takeshi wiped his lips. "But I didn't."

Garret's eyes widened as Takeshi launched at him like a bullet. Khalani could barely follow the movement as Takeshi struck him in the face, chest, and ribs. Garret flailed, uselessly attempting to defend himself as Takeshi moved like a phantom.

Eventually, he curled into a ball, crying and covering his head.

But Takeshi's wrath was far from quenched.

He moved behind Garret, circling his chest with one arm and wrenching his wrist out to the side.

The same arm Garret used to slap her.

With a savage pull, Takeshi hyperextended Garret's arm behind his back, eliciting a scream of pure agony.

"That's enough, Steele! You proved your point," Patreus yelled.

Takeshi didn't seem to hear him and kept pulling like he was about to rip his arm clean off.

The sound of a gun cocking filtered through the stiff air, and everyone froze as Patreus pointed a pistol at Takeshi. *Her* gun.

"STOP."

It wasn't Patreus that yelled.

It was her.

She didn't know if it was her voice or the gun pointed at Takeshi's head that stopped him, but Takeshi released Garret, who collapsed to the ground, clutching his shoulder.

Takeshi's chest heaved with each breath, and he didn't even flinch at the loaded gun aimed at him. His black gaze turned to Khalani, brimming with resentment and vitriol.

"I'm done for the day," Takeshi hissed. "If you want him to stay alive," he gestured toward Garret, still writhing on the ground, "keep him away from me."

With that, he walked past Patreus, who clutched the gun so tight, she thought it might break.

Everyone held still, afraid to move a muscle.

But Patreus quickly regained his composure, glaring at the trainees.

“What are you all staring at? Back to work! Pair off for fighting exercises. Garret, stop crying like a little *bitch*.”

No one initially moved but then he yelled, “Now!”

Khalani quickly seized the moment to escape. She gathered the dirty clothes on the ground, ignoring the wayward stares, and anxiously made her way back to her cleaning duties.

Serene knew something was wrong.

After Marissa had grilled her with questions for taking so long, Serene whispered several times, asking Khalani if she was okay.

She said she was fine.

She lied.

At night, she retreated to a quiet corner of the house, clutching Ana’s journal, needing to write her scattering thoughts.

But her mind kept circling back to Takeshi.

In that final moment, Takeshi hadn’t looked at her like a protector in her story.

He stared at Khalani as if she were the villain in his.

Do you see me?
The *real* me?
The me no one knows?
The me hiding behind scars?
The me with a heart too big for my chest?

I think I hid for so long
Because I didn’t even want to see myself
Wearing skin that wasn’t my own
Smiling through the invisible tears
Moving when I didn’t know where to go

There was a brief moment
When you looked *into* me and not *at* me
And you poked the walls I carefully crafted
Like tiny dots in the night sky for you to explore
Because you saw the light that created me
When I only saw the darkness that forged me

I forgive who I was

And accept the person I am
But in the silence of a fading night
A truth whispers for no one but me to hear
My darkest parts miss being held
By the deadliness of you.

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12

I am the storm you never saw coming.

Takeshi didn’t join them in the mess hall for dinner that night. Khalani stabbed at the food in her bowl, her frustration simmering just beneath the surface. Beads of electricity coiled in her muscles, crackling, desperate to be unleashed.

She needed to take out the festering energy on *something*. And the lukewarm food in front of her wasn’t cutting it.

Her friends watched her cautiously, as if she might lash out at them with her wooden spoon at any moment.

She finally looked up, slamming her bowl on the table. “What?”

The frowns on Serene, Adan, and Derek’s faces deepened. Brock sighed and reached for her bowl with a casual, resigned air.

“What are you doing?”

“If you’re just going to glare at the food I had to pour for everyone, I’ll eat it instead.” Brock tried to pull her meal away, but she snatched it back, nearly spilling it on herself.

“Do *not* come between me and food right now. I’ll smother you with my pillow while you sleep,” she snapped.

“You on your period or something?” Brock tilted his head.

Khalani’s grip tightened on the bowl, ready to hurl it at his face, but Derek placed a calming hand on her shoulder. “Whoa, whoa. Let’s just relax.”

“Nah, I’ll help you kill him tonight,” Serene piped in.

“No one’s killing anybody.” Adan’s jaw set in frustration. “We need to stick together, or we’ll never make it to Hermes in one piece.”

“Everything alright?”

She nearly jumped out of her seat when the Chief spoke from right behind her, seemingly appearing out of nowhere.

“Yes,” they quickly muttered in unison.

The Chief studied them for a long moment but didn’t press further. “Good. If you’re done eating, come with me to the infirmary. Ari told me that your friend is awake.”

Khalani lurched to her feet, her heart racing as she followed the Chief to the blue building.

Each step was an echo of the hope and dread that raged inside her.

She bounded up the stairs, racing past everyone. The dense weight on her chest didn’t lift until she stepped into the bedroom and saw Winnie sitting up in bed, her brown eyes wide open.

“Khalani, girl,” Winnie said with a smile.

Tears brimmed in Khalani’s eyes, and she didn’t care who saw them. She rushed to the bed and sank to her knees. With as much care as she could, Khalani wrapped herself around Winnie, who had a white bandage covering her shoulder and her arm held up in a proper sling.

“You’re alive,” she whispered, her voice rattling.

“Of course, dear. Love is stronger than death, remember? Winnie couldn’t leave you to write this story alone.” Winnie smiled at her, radiating a warmth that only a mother could.

Khalani hugged Winnie as though they were the last two people on Earth. She heard the others enter behind her, and they each took a turn hugging Winnie, even Brock, who usually kept his distance.

Their own dysfunctional family.

“How are you feeling?” Ari asked, stepping forward with a renewed warmth in her eyes.

Winnie straightened, beaming. “Fit as a fiddle! Winnie’s ready to get back on the road.”

But Khalani caught the slight grimace when she attempted to rise out of bed.

“No, no. Not yet.” Ari gently urged her back down. “We need to give your body a couple more days to recover from the infection.”

“Nonsense. Winnie could run a marathon right now,” Winnie declared.

“What’s a marathon?” Derek asked.

“From my research on the Great Collapse, it was their code word for hell.”

“Sounds like my kind of fun.” Brock grinned.

“You would say that.” Serene glared at him.

As they spoke, Khalani's eyes watered as she kept staring at Winnie like a lost piece of art. Her lungs were able to take deeper breaths. Her skin didn't feel as tight.

"I missed you so much. I thought the worst. I didn't know what to do." The words tumbled out of her.

Winnie cupped Khalani's cheek tenderly, her fingers cold. "Winnie was thinking about you the whole time, even in her dreams. You've been so, so strong."

Khalani shook her head. "I haven't felt strong. I've been so afraid."

"That's okay, sweet girl. Fears aren't always so bad. They remind you of everything you have to live for."

Khalani's chin trembled as the Chief stepped forward.

"It's getting late," she said. "And Ari's right, you need to rest. The rest of you must return to the house."

Winnie grumbled, insisting that she was fit enough to ride a dragon—whatever that meant—before laying back down.

"Can I stay with her?" Khalani asked.

"I'm not sure if that's a good idea," Ari hedged.

"Just for tonight," she pleaded. "She's the closest thing I have to a mother. Please…let me be with her this one night."

A soft look entered Ari's eyes as she glanced over at the Chief, who regarded her closely. Khalani didn't know what the Chief saw in her expression, but she sighed. "Alright. One night."

A small smile graced Khalani's lips as Serene kissed her on the head and the others hugged her and left—Brock included, though his farewell was limited to a one-finger wave.

Khalani lay on top of the covers beside Winnie as Ari turned off the bedside lamp and offered her a gentle smile before closing the door.

In the peaceful dark, Winnie slowly shifted her cold hand until it touched Khalani's. Without hesitation, Khalani intertwined their fingers, and they fit together like two puzzle pieces.

For the first time, her heavy heart lifted, floating freely in her chest like the pale moon hanging beyond their line of sight.

"Winnie?" she breathed out, staring up at the ceiling.

"Yes, dear."

"Those white speckles that come out at night to rest beside the moon… what are they called?"

She could hear the grin in Winnie's voice. "You mean stars?"

"Stars…" Khalani savored the word on her tongue. "What are they?"

"They're like our sun, only burning millions of miles away in space. Some of them have other planets orbiting around them, just like ours."

"Like ours?" She turned her head on the pillow to look at her. "Do they have people, too?"

"Before the Great Collapse, they were still trying to figure that out—whether we were truly alone in the universe or if there were other beings out there. Maybe even doing the exact same thing we're doing." Winnie squeezed her hand tighter.

"If they are, then they're experiencing it, too."

"Experiencing what?"

"The parts that make everything worth it."

***

It was the first night on the surface that Khalani slept without nightmares tearing her apart. She held Winnie's hand the whole time, the only thing keeping her together.

In the morning, Ari entered the room with a pale look of regret and told Khalani that she needed to return to her cleaning duties.

She protested, wanting to stay longer but Winnie squeezed her hand.

"Go, dear," Winnie insisted, her voice tired. "I'll be right here."

Over the next couple of days, Khalani washed clothes with Serene and visited Winnie each afternoon. Ari seemed pleasantly surprised by Winnie's progress, but she still insisted Winnie needed another day or two before she could move around more freely.

Takeshi remained elusive, rarely seen during the day, not joining them for meals, and entering the house only when the moon was high in the sky. He would shower and then sleep on the living room floor without complaint.

Takeshi didn't look at her, much less speak to her. He'd reverted to being cold and distant, treating her as he once did in Braderhelm.

One afternoon, Khalani ventured near the training area. The trainees avoided her as if she were covered in poisonous spikes. She noticed the nervous glances darting to Takeshi, like they feared even looking at her would earn them a one-way ticket to hell.

When she walked by, Takeshi’s glare pierced her, sharper than the blade he kept in his boots. But he swiftly returned to instructing the trainees with Patreus, his voice echoing across the field with a hard, biting edge.

But the first change came the following night when Takeshi joined them in the meal hall, something he hadn’t done in days.

His black hair was tousled, and beads of sweat clung to his face.

Her eyes caught on the protruding veins in his forearms as he drank a glass of water, and she caught the hard bob of his throat as he swallowed.

It was truly unfair how someone like him could look even more attractive while sweaty and disheveled. After an intense workout, her lungs rattled like she was on the verge of death, and her hair frizzed up like she enjoyed cuddling with an electric fence in her free time.

But beneath that allure, a chaotic energy seeped from him that made everyone uneasy as he ate his meal in silence.

“You good, man? We haven’t seen you around lately,” Adan asked, breaking the resounding quiet.

“I’m fine.” Takeshi barely glanced up, eating from his bowl like it was his last meal. Like he wanted to escape as quickly as possible.

“How’s the training going?” Derek questioned.

“Fine.”

“And their warriors?”

“Fine.”

“What’s Patreus like?” Serene chimed in. “Is he…fine?”

“Yes.”

Serene shook her head in exasperation, and Derek chuckled.

Khalani, meanwhile, fiddled with her spoon, pushing around the beans like they might magically gain sentience.

Suddenly, a deafening CRACK echoed through the hall, as if God Himself slammed a fist into the earth.

Khalani gasped, shooting to her feet as Serene, Derek, and Adan did the same, holding on to each other. Everyone else in the room remained seated, staring at the four of them like they’d finally lost their minds.

“What the hell was that?” she exclaimed as a loud patter started pounding against the roof. Her eyes rapidly scanned the ceiling, worried it might collapse on them.

“It’s a storm.” Brock casually leaned back in his chair. “I’ve experienced several in the Death-Zone.”

“W-what was that bang?” Serene clutched her brother’s hand, her voice quivering.

“Thunder.” It was Takeshi that answered.

Derek turned to him with a frown. “How do you know what thunder sounds like?”

Takeshi stayed silent, but Khalani knew the truth. He used to live in Genesis. Even though the dome surrounding Genesis portrayed a serene sky and protected its inhabitants from the ‘radiation,’ it must not have been immune to lightning.

She’d learned about lightning, thunder, and rain in class, but living underground her entire life, she’d never experienced it.

Khalani gradually lowered herself back down to her seat, but each time a thunderclap shook the building, she flinched, struggling to keep herself from hiding under the wooden table.

Takeshi quickly finished his food and stood.

“You’re leaving?” Adan asked in dismay. “In this weather?”

Takeshi gave him a sidelong glance. “It’s only rain.”

He walked out of the hall without another word.

Khalani bit her lip, an uncontrollable urge tugging at her heart as she stared at the empty seat he’d just vacated.

Just ignore him.

She pursed her lips, trying to re-focus on eating from her bowl. The rain continued to pound against the rafters as the empty space across the wooden table glared at her.

Everything was fine, she told herself.

Winnie was healing.

She’d seen no evidence of cannibalism.

Everything was…Khalani looked back at his empty spot again…great.

After a moment, she slammed her spoon down, unable to take the prolonged absence any longer.

“Where are you going?” Brock called out when she stood, but Khalani ignored him.

The storm got louder as she approached the exit.

Her palms shook as she opened the door and faced the wrath of nature. Water poured down like heaven itself had opened and the angels cried. Her jaw was agape, and she nearly dropped to her knees.

As a child, Khalani had always imagined what rain would feel like

against her skin. To let it slide through her hair. Between her fingertips. To tilt her head back and drink the Earth in. But standing at the edge of the doorway, she froze.

What if it hurt?

What if thunder shattered her eardrums in the vast, open space?

The dark clouds before her were like beautiful beasts, waiting to sweep Khalani away and consume her.

Her eyes caught on a black-garbed figure walking down the path, hands in his pockets. His head was held high, like he had no fear in the world.

She should turn around and go back.

Right now.

Deadly things shouldn't be confronted.

Her fingers twitched as Takeshi ventured further and further into the storm.

Go back.

She gulped. About to turn around.

But then, as if she wasn't in control of her own body, her foot stepped over the threshold.

Her heart pounded wildly as the first drop of rain brushed against her skin. She paused, waiting for something spectacular or terrible to happen, but nothing did.

The rain was cool, almost soothing, and her fear gave way to a strange exhilaration.

She took another step forward, feeling the wet earth beneath her feet. And then, she started running.

Lightning slashed across the night sky like an artist painting furious brushstrokes above her. But Khalani kept sprinting through the torrent.

"Takeshi!" she yelled, her voice almost lost against the howling wind.

But he froze, his dark eyes locking onto her, a deep frown overcoming his expression.

"What are you doing out here, Kanes?"

"I…I…"

The right words wouldn't come. The rain soaked her hair, and her tan clothing clung to her skin as she stopped just a few feet away from him, mumbling like an inept fool.

Takeshi's lips pressed into a grim line as Khalani failed to explain why she followed him into the downpour like a crazy person.

“Go back to your friends.” His voice was cold and distant as he inclined his head, turning his back on her.

Her fists clenched, and the energy swirling through the air fueled her. Lighting her up from the inside out. “Why do you keep ignoring me?”

“I’m not.”

“Don’t lie to me.”

Takeshi paused, barely glancing her way. “It’s for the best.”

“For who? For me?”

“For both of us,” he snapped, facing her fully.

“Explain it to me then.” She lifted her hands by her sides.

“I don’t owe you anything.” Takeshi’s eyes hardened, retreating behind the high walls he’d carefully constructed.

It was his shield against the world. Keeping everything out.

Especially her.

“Yes, you fucking do,” she shot back, marching forward to close the distance. “You’ve already told me there’s nothing left between us. What more do you have to lose?”

He shook his head, turning away, determined to leave her behind.

“I don’t think so.” She tugged on his wet arm. “You don’t get to run away again, Takeshi.”

“Stop it, Kanes!” He whirled on her, his eyes blazing. “You need to learn when to give up.”

“No! Because someone once made me believe I was strong enough to never give up. Remember?”

Takeshi flinched as her words seemed to transport him back to their grueling training sessions in Braderhelm. Back when he was just a guard, and she was his prisoner. Nothing about their fractured relationship had ever been simple.

Sometimes she caught him staring at her like she was perfectly imperfect the way she was. Like he wouldn’t change *a damn thing*. But other days, he glared at her like she was his worst enemy and greatest regret.

Deep down, she knew she needed to let go.

But Khalani needed answers.

Closure.

So she could give up, too.

“Just tell me why you hate me so much.” She balled her fists, nearly losing the tight hold on her tears. “Then I’ll leave you alone forever.”

“You think I hate you?” Takeshi’s voice dropped dangerously low as he lifted his head.

“I know you do.”

A strange madness flickered in his expression and he stepped even closer, invading her space as if it belonged to him.

“You don’t know *anything*. Do you want to know what I hate, Kanes? I hate losing control. I hate obsessing over something I’ll never have. You know what else I hate? This fucking conversation. You know that I’m no good for you, yet you keep coming back because you like people who hurt you.”

“That’s…that’s not true.”

“Yes, it is. From the day we met, you wanted to be close to death. Here we are on the surface, and you still want the absolute worst things in life.”

Thunder rumbled ominously above them.

Her chest heaved, his words piercing her soul like shards of broken glass, but Khalani lifted her chin, refusing to back away.

“Do you think so little of yourself that you believe you’re the worst thing for me?”

Takeshi’s muscles froze. He licked the drops of rain across his lips, staring down at her like a man trying to prevent himself from being carved open.

“I know I am, Kanes. I rose to the ranks of Captain because I was ruthless—a good soldier willing to tear anyone apart. I didn’t care about anything but locking up prisoners in Braderhelm. That was my duty. All I had. But then you came along and…” He scoffed, shaking his head, as if it didn’t matter anymore.

“I tried to convince myself I wasn’t a monster. That I only hurt people when it was necessary, but we both know that’s a lie. Maybe I could’ve stopped the Warden from killing those prisoners, but I didn’t even try. All I cared about was making sure *you* never died.”

Her muscles instinctively tensed for the hurt she knew was coming. But Khalani needed to hear the truth, no matter how raw or painful.

She’d rather suffer out loud than suffer in silence.

“You were right about me, Kanes. I am a murderer, and I’ve accepted that. When that bastard touched you the other day, I wanted to do more than just break his arm,” he seethed. “I wanted to rip him apart, burn him alive, and make his friends eat the ashes. And it would’ve made my fucking day.

That's who you're dealing with. So, for once in your life, do what's right for you and fucking walk away."

Raindrops dripped from his thick lashes as if the Earth wept in his stead.

Their heavy breaths mingled as the sky fell apart around them. She absorbed his words, letting their meaning course through her.

But when she peered into the dark depths of his gaze, she didn't see evil or malice. She saw another storm. A man baring his soul to the world, preparing for everyone to abandon him because that's all he'd ever known.

Maybe she should've walked away.

Maybe seeing the good in him would lead to her downfall.

But Khalani stepped closer, the rain a forgotten whisper against her skin.

"Don't I get a say in what's best for me?" she whispered.

"Not if you make the wrong decision."

"And right there lies your biggest mistake."

His brows lowered. "And what's that?"

She lifted her gaze, facing the storm head-on.

"Assuming that after being bound in chains, I would dare let anyone else dictate my life."

His black gaze swept over her, from the wet strands of hair clinging to her cheeks, to the way her soaked top molded to her skin, leaving nothing to the imagination.

Despite the chill in the air, the heat between them was hotter than the sun, and for once, she wanted to be consumed by it.

Khalani leaned forward, expecting him to back away and abandon her. But Takeshi's dark gaze pooled with unfathomable want, and he lowered his head.

But there was a sudden whoosh of air, and Takeshi flinched.

Her green eyes bulged when she saw the arrow sticking out of his back.

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13

War begins when one hand extends for help.
And the other breaks it.

Takeshi shoved Khalani to the ground, covering her body with his own. The low whistle of Takeshi shoved Khalani to the ground, covering her body with his own. The low whistle of more arrows whooshed by, surrounding them. The guards on the walls started screaming as a high-pitched alarm echoed through the air.

“Takeshi, your back!” she gasped.

Takeshi momentarily twitched, and in one swift movement, he reached behind and ripped the arrow from his cloak. His eyes were murderous as he threw it to the ground.

The tip of the arrow glowed with a faint, pulsing light, crackling with electricity.

Khalani’s mouth fell open when he reached under the back of his shirt and pulled out a thick leather casing for his blade, a hole embedded in it.

She froze in quiet shock.

If the arrow had been a few more inches to the right…

“Are you ok—”

“I’m fine, Kanes,” he interrupted, locking eyes with hers. “We need to get out of here.”

Rain pummeled their bodies in the middle of the street, and she flinched as more screams pierced through the torrent, but it was difficult to see and everything was disorienting.

Khalani’s head snapped to the left, blood draining from her face when two small figures were flung from the large wall, their wails cut short by sickening thuds on the ground.

A haunting voice started to sing in her ear, a twisted lullaby she couldn’t silence.

You're about to die.

You're about to die.

You're about to—

"Stay with me, Kanes!" Takeshi pulled Khalani to her feet, crouching beside her. He cupped her face, his fierce gaze pulling her in, beckoning her to look at nothing but him.

"We can make it to the house," he declared, eyes darting to the yellow house they'd been staying in. It wasn't far, but arrows continued to rain haphazardly around them, making it a near impossible path to traverse.

"Takeshi." She shook her head, her body refusing to move. "I c-can't."

"Yes, you can," he stated emphatically, his faith in her outweighing the belief she had in herself. "I'll be right beside you the entire time. Do you trust me to keep you safe?"

Thunder rumbled overhead, and the rain seemed to fall in slow motion. Her heart hammered as she stared into his steady black eyes, her only anchor in the storm.

And she knew, in a split second, what the answer was.

On the surface of the Earth, there was no one she trusted more to keep her safe than Takeshi Steele.

Khalani nodded, and his expression solidified with determination, as if her trust *meant* something to him.

He intensely scanned the area, palming his dagger, transforming into the deadly Captain he was trained to be.

"Keep your head down and run. Understand?"

She nodded, rearing back when an arrow landed mere inches from them.

"Go!" he yelled.

She bolted forward, flinching as the rain suddenly intensified, stinging her face like icy needles. Her pulse raced erratically as her legs beat against the wet concrete, faster than she'd ever run before.

A symphony of yells, gunshots, and screams echoed throughout the storm, but she kept her head down and raced forward.

Takeshi didn't leave her side for a second. He kept a large hand on the back of her neck, pushing her forward.

"Help me! Help me!" A middle-aged woman in a beige garment ran toward Khalani and Takeshi, pure terror etched on her face.

Khalani skidded to a stop, reaching out to pull the woman to safety. Their fingertips almost touched when an arrow plunged straight through the

woman’s chest. Khalani froze, her vision tilting as the woman’s eyes bulged in disbelief before crashing to the ground.

It all happened in a span of a second—a lifetime—before Takeshi grabbed Khalani’s arm and pulled her toward the yellow house. He all but broke down the front door and shoved her inside.

The house was eerily dark and quiet compared to the chaos outside. Her entire body trembled as she flicked on the light switch, but nothing happened.

“Takeshi?” She breathed faster.

“Someone cut off the power.” He clutched the blade tighter, peeking through the blinds.

“Who’s attacking?”

“I don’t know.” He started removing various weapons from his body and handed her one of his knives. “Maybe it’s the other tribe they were talking about. The Sinners.”

Her heart skipped a beat as she remembered the Chief’s haunting warning. That the Sinners *ate* people.

Khalani’s entire body stiffened as she remembered.

The others were in the food hall, unprotected.

Winnie was alone.

“We have to go back. We need to grab the others.” She ran to the door, but Takeshi immediately stood in front of it like a barricade.

“Absolutely not.”

“Get out of my way, Takeshi! I’m going out there.”

“Over my dead fucking body.”

“If you don’t move, I will—”

Takeshi’s hand suddenly clamped over her mouth. “Shut up.”

Her first instinct was to bite him, but something in his expression halted her.

He wasn’t looking at her.

He was staring at the hallway behind her. She breathed into his palm, and then she heard it.

A low creak of the wooden floor.

Another.

The faint thud of a door closing.

Someone was in the house with them.

The blood drained from her face, and Takeshi put one finger to her lips.

She nodded, afraid to exhale.

Takeshi’s gaze narrowed as he scanned the empty room. He crept forward, holding a palm back for her to stay put.

Then, he disappeared around the corner.

The silence expanded, like a slow-waking evil stretching its jaws. Khalani gripped the knife he gave her, her knuckles turning white.

She thought she was comfortable in the dark, but the shadowy walls closed in around her, like they were alive. Watching the whites of her eyes. The quivering of her lips.

Another creak, and her head whipped to the far corner of the room.

Nothing.

Not a hint of movement.

The knife shook in her hand.

Khalani took a slow step backward, the front door brushing against her shoulders.

Where are you?

Where are you?

All of a sudden, a crash rang out.

She jumped as two figures tumbled to the floor right in front of her. Takeshi grappled with a large man wearing a black cloak and brown hair cascading to his waist.

Takeshi quickly gained the upper hand, flipping the man over and thrusting his knife toward the stranger’s throat. But the man suddenly gripped Takeshi’s wrists, his arms trembling as the blade hovered inches from his jugular.

Takeshi pressed down harder, the blade inching closer and closer to his throat. The stranger’s face turned beet-red with terror and exertion when he yelled out for help.

Heavy footsteps thundered from the opposite hallway.

A new figure emerged.

This man was heftier, wearing the same black cloak, with blond hair longer than Khalani’s and strange red geometric tattoos covering his face. His eyes locked on the struggle, and he charged forward, wielding a curved scythe.

Aiming straight for Takeshi.

Khalani didn’t have time to think.

She launched herself forward and jumped on the man’s back, stabbing

him in the ribs with all her might as she screamed. He grunted, throwing her off him and she slammed to the ground.

Pain exploded in her skull when her head cracked against the table's corner.

Her vision blurred, darkening as she held the back of her skull and felt warm liquid pool on her hands. She groaned, trying to grip the table to stand, but her legs collapsed under her.

The man clutched his bloody ribs, turning to face her. He growled, baring jagged, yellow teeth.

He lifted the scythe above his head, about to slice her in half.

She futilely held up her forearm to block the hit, praying her death would be quick and painless.

But the man's entire body went taut, blood oozing from the corners of his mouth. He toppled forward, and she hastily scrambled back as his large body hit the floor with a resounding crash. Her eyes widened at the knife protruding from his back.

Takeshi stood behind him, his throwing arm still outstretched.

The other stranger lay dead on the ground, his throat split wide open.

She tried to stand and faltered.

Takeshi prowled forward, kicking the dead man out of the way. He crouched, cupping her face, searching her eyes.

"You okay, Kanes?"

She nodded, shakily rising to her feet. Khalani took a step forward and stumbled, her head feeling like it was underwater.

She was abruptly lifted into strong arms, and Takeshi strode to the door, ignoring her protests.

"Issss… fineeeee," she slurred, touching the sharp pain on the side of her head. Khalani was somehow surprised when she pulled her hand away and still found blood there.

Takeshi's piercing gaze sharpened at the sight.

He glanced back at the bodies, as if a part of him wanted to set her down, turn back, and mutilate the two dead men in a vengeful slaughter. But instead, he walked to the front door, though he didn't open it.

He turned, placing his back against the wood, and slid down to the floor, clutching her tightly to his chest.

"What are we doing?" she asked softly.

"We're waiting until I'm sure it's safe outside."

“Oh.”

The sound of coarse yells and fighting still registered, but they were growing fainter. She tentatively laid her head in the crook of his neck and took a deep breath. She may have imagined him holding her closer.

Khalani didn’t know how long they waited there.

Minutes, hours even.

Before her vision went black, she sent a silent prayer to the heavens, begging that if God was out there and listening, He would keep her family safe.

***

Liquid. Cool liquid seeping down her throat.

A hand cupping the side of her head.

Another touching her leg.

She jolted awake, sputtering against the glass cup held to her lips.

Ari jumped back, her cheeks drained of color, the opposite of the bloodstains splattered all over her blue dress. Her blonde hair, usually neat and tidy, was tangled and knotted, with strands coming loose from her ponytail.

“Hey, you’re okay,” a different voice whispered. “We’re right here.”

She looked to her right and found Serene kneeling beside her bed. Winnie sat in a chair next to her, both of them clutching her hand with relief glowing in their eyes.

“Hey, Khalani girl.” Winnie squeezed her hand.

“Winnie… Serene.” She looked between them, frowning. “W-what happened? How are you guys here? Where is everyone?”

She tried sitting up, but Ari gently nudged her back down onto the bed. “Relax. The stitches in the back of your head are still fresh, so no sudden movements.”

Khalani looked around, realizing they were in the same bedroom she’d been staying in. Her gaze flickered to the door, and Serene correctly assumed where her thoughts ventured.

“Derek, Adan, Brock, and Takeshi are just outside the door. Ari insisted the room be limited to only a few people. After the fight, the Chief ordered everyone to stay in their homes, in case any Sinners were still lurking about,” Serene explained, her gaze hardening as if she were reliving the

long, bloody night.

“What happened to you guys?” Khalani asked, her heart racing. “How did you escape?”

“When we heard the alarm, Brock took us into the kitchen and locked the doors. He went back out to help the Chief and her warriors fight off the Sinners,” Serene replied, a begrudging note of respect in her tone.

Khalani’s lips parted, and she glanced at Winnie, who looked forlorn. Tired. Most of her color had returned, but Khalani rapidly scanned her for fresh injuries.

“Winnie’s okay, dear,” Winnie reassured her. “Ari was checking Winnie’s bandages when everything happened. She locked us in the bathroom, and we waited hours for the fighting to stop.”

Khalani’s attention shifted to Ari, whose crestfallen eyes made her hesitate. They held the deepest notes of loss, fear, and rage.

“Thank you for looking after her,” Khalani said, meaning it with everything inside her.

Ari nodded, her head hanging low. “I have to go check on my other patients. When you’re feeling better, meet the Chief in the log cabin. She’s waiting for all of you.”

Serene turned to Ari with a frown, that piece of information apparently news to her as well.

Not long after Ari left, Khalani stood, noticing her bloody clothes were gone and she now wore a fresh set of beige garments.

She wondered if it was Takeshi that changed her.

“How long have I been asleep?”

“Just through the night and into the morning,” Serene said. “It’s probably midday now. Are you sure you’re okay to walk? You can rest more.”

“No. I don’t want to rest.” She refused to lie down and be useless, not when there were innocent people hurt.

Khalani moved gingerly, feeling the tightness in her fresh stitches.

When she opened the door, four men immediately stood. She gasped as Derek and Adan wrapped her in a tight embrace.

“You scared us to death, Khalani. I don’t think I could handle losing you. Who else would endure my terrible jokes?” Adan admitted, holding her close.

“He’s right.” Derek squeezed her arms, as if he needed to reassure himself that she wouldn’t disappear. “Lord knows I can’t listen to him

twenty-four seven. You're our leader, and without you, everything falls apart."

Leader?

She had no time to process the word before they released her, and Brock clapped her on the shoulder.

"You alright?"

Patches of dried blood were visible on his cloak. Brock's demeanor was calm, but his expression was haggard, like the long night of fighting had taken a heavy toll on him.

"I'm okay," she acknowledged in a low voice. And then, Khalani turned to Takeshi.

He stood by the wall in his black gear, with dark circles under his eyes, and his hair messy, as if he'd scrubbed his hands through it all night. The pinched expression on his face intensified as his gaze roved over her body.

The air thickened, and she could barely swallow past the knot in her throat. The space between Takeshi and her expanded, stretching for miles.

She realized she didn't quite like that.

Khalani walked forward, closing the distance.

Takeshi frowned, utterly still as the gap between them disappeared. His expression was cool. Guarded.

Khalani had always avoided physical affection. After her parents died, she stopped giving hugs or handshakes, preferring to linger in the dark, wondering why others freely offered their touch to strangers.

She was gradually getting used to Serene, Derek, Adan, and Winnie holding her, reassuring her that she wasn't alone. But she rarely initiated contact herself.

Hugs were too intimate. Dangerous.

Sex made sense to her. It was an exchange of two bodies who just wanted to block out the world for a few moments. The faces didn't matter. The person didn't matter. Not when the heart wasn't involved in those transactions.

But her heart didn't feel numb anymore.

It beat a constant drum in her chest, and when she stared at Takeshi, her body wanted to communicate what her lips were unable to.

Without thinking, Khalani reached out and hugged him.

His entire body went rigid, arms staying tight by his side, like he didn't know what to do. Like he was just as scared of holding her as she was.

But then she whispered, “Thanks for keeping me safe.”

Takeshi’s heartbeat hammered against her ear. And then, with the utmost caution, he slowly wrapped his arms around her.

Takeshi didn’t speak. But his words were everywhere.

In the way he enveloped her. In the tips of his fingers.

As if holding her close was his way of saying, “*Thank you for trusting me*.”

To anyone watching, that sliver of contact might have seemed meaningless. After all, a hug is just a hug.

But to her, it felt like a truce, however fleeting it may be.

She backed away, and he let her go.

Khalani turned to the others, afraid of what she might do next if that moment were allowed to continue.

“Ari said the Chief is expecting us at the log cabin.” Her mouth set in a hard line. “We should go see what she has to say.”

The others agreed, and when they left the house, Khalani was surprised Ferren and Jared weren’t posted outside their door.

But when she got her first look at the rest of the town, her knees locked.

The once quaint street was covered in destruction.

Several houses had burned down, arrows were littered across the ground, and trash was strewn everywhere.

Khalani’s fingers chafed together as they walked through the devastation.

The Merry Avenue sign lay in a ruined heap on the concrete, as though the joy in the Desert Spring had been destroyed as well.

Most people stayed inside their houses, if they were still standing. Others lingered at their open doors, gazes narrowing at Khalani and her group as they passed.

Before, the townspeople regarded them with tendrils of fear and disdain.

But now, the people glared at them with pure hatred and vitriol.

She flinched, hurriedly moving down the street, unsure of what harm they’d caused to warrant such hostility.

The bitter scent of smoke and death intensified in the misty air as they ventured deeper into the broken town.

She found the reason why.

In the open field, where Takeshi normally trained with Patreus, there was a massive burning pile. Khalani didn’t immediately understand the purpose

until she saw two guards toss a body into the flames.

They were cremating their fallen.

By the looks of it, there were at least fifty bodies on the pile.

Khalani's hand flew to her mouth as they stopped and stared, the enormity of the night's carnage crashing over them.

Entire families had perished. Men. Women. Children.

Her eyes watered as the image brought her back to the mass execution of prisoners in Braderhelm.

To her parents—

"The Chief is expecting you," Ferren interrupted, his brown hair out of his usual ponytail as he stood in front of the cabin, his voice heavy with grief.

"Ferren," she frowned, "Where's Jared?"

A broken sound escaped him. "Jared…he—" Ferren swallowed his words, unable to finish. "Please go inside."

They exchanged worried glances as they walked past him toward the log cabin.

Inside was chaos.

All the tables had been overturned except for the head table in the back, where the Chief stood, staring intently at a map.

The Chief's red hair was clasped in two intricate braids hanging down by her ears. Her angular, sun-kissed face was streaked with dirt, and the deep circles under her green eyes were unmistakable.

Other warriors surrounded her, with Patreus by her side. Different voices clashed in heated debate.

"We should attack them tonight." Someone slammed a fist on the table.

"And how do you expect to do that, Rayard?" Patreus chided. "Half of our forces are gone, and the Sinners have superior weapons.

"We need to regroup, rebuild and refocus on our mission," another woman declared, staring at the Chief intently.

"But they found a way over our walls. We can't focus on our mission unless we make them bigger."

"How long with that take? Months? Years, even? We'll be dead before then. We need a quicker solution."

"Enough!" The Chief's voice sliced through the clamor. "We have visitors. And they may provide an answer to our problem."

Her focus shifted to Khalani and her group, who stood tensely, waiting

for the floor to be further ripped out from under them.

The Chief gestured for them to come closer.

“Chief,” Patreus said in an uneasy voice. “I’m not sure this is a good idea. You know we’re not supposed to—”

“Silence.” The Chief lifted her hand.

She flickered her gaze between each of them, landing on Brock.

“My warriors and I thank you for your help last night. There would’ve been a lot more deaths if you hadn’t fought by our side. We owe you a debt.”

Brock didn’t respond, just nodded tersely, crossing his arms.

The Chief then shifted her focus to Khalani and Takeshi.

“And we know you killed two Sinners in the house as well. Their tattoos indicated they were part of the Sinners elite forces. Had they survived, they would’ve wreaked more havoc on our town. You should be commended as well.” The Chief lowered her head in recognition.

Both Khalani and Takeshi nodded, though it was Takeshi who deserved most of the credit.

The quiet was tense, but the Chief’s next question stole the air from the room.

“How long will it take you to get to Hermes?”

Everyone, including her warriors, whipped their heads to the Chief, as if they hadn’t heard correctly.

“A few more days,” Brock answered.

The Chief nodded slowly, her steely gaze fixed on them with fierce resolve

“You once told me that you could bring us back weapons from Hermes. Are you still willing to do that?” The Chief set her hands on the table as she stared at Khalani.

Her pulse quickened as she realized what the Chief was offering.

A way out.

“We are,” Khalani answered. “If you let us go to Hermes, we’ll bring back whatever we can to help you fight off the Sinners and protect your people.”

As soon as the words left her mouth, an uproar erupted among the other men and women.

“We can’t trust them, Chief. They are Under-Dwellers!” one girl exclaimed, her voice dripping with disdain.

“Do you honestly believe they’ll return?” another man scoffed.

“We should eliminate them before they have a chance to end us!” a deep voice spat from the crowd.

“STOP!” The Chief slammed her fist on the table, silencing the chaos, commanding everyone’s attention. “Have you all forgotten *why* we are here?” She surveyed the warriors, disappointment etched deeply on her face. “What our purpose is?”

Several gazes dropped to the ground, while others continued to glare at Khalani and her group.

“If you don’t mind me asking,” Adan interjected, frowning, “what *is* your purpose here?”

Khalani noticed the blood draining from Patreus’ face, but the Chief replied smoothly,

“Peace. That has always been our goal. But we have learned that in order to achieve peace, some...violence may be necessary.” She turned back to Khalani. “That’s why we need more weapons to stand up to the Sinners. But my people do have a point. There’s no way to know if you’ll come back.”

“On my life, you have my word that we’ll return,” Khalani declared, stepping forward.

The Chief tapped a finger against her chin, her green eyes intense and probing, but Khalani met her gaze head on, letting the Chief judge the weight of her sincerity.

The people of Desert Spring had fed, clothed, and sheltered them. More importantly, they saved Winnie’s life. If Khalani didn’t return, death would be the only reason.

The Chief’s gaze flickered over their group before settling on one individual in particular. “We will allow you to leave for Hermes under one condition. *He* must remain behind.”

Khalani turned in shock as the Chief pointed at Derek.

“Me?” Derek held a hand to his chest, his eyes wide.

“Yes. You’re our collateral in case the rest of your group thinks about going back on our deal.”

“But why me?”

“You’re a scientist, are you not?” The Chief inclined her head. “We have more use for someone like you in our ranks.”

“But I never told you I was a…” Derek paused, his muscles tensing. “You were listening to our conversations in the house.”

“Did you really think we wouldn’t take extra measures to protect our people, Under-Dweller?” one of the men beside the Chief laughed. “We have ears everywhere.”

Khalani’s hands trembled, her resolve threatening to shatter.

“No,” she stated emphatically. “You’re not keeping Derek, or anyone else. If anyone’s staying, it’ll be me.”

“Absolutely not,” Serene shot back. “No one is being left behind.”

“Then none of you are leaving. We’re only taking him. Those are our terms.” The Chief’s tone left no room for argument as she straightened.

Khalani shook her head, feeling the wooden walls of the cabin compress, suffocating her.

Derek was the closest thing she had to a brother.

He was the first person who had truly *seen* her in prison, the one she could always count on. Without Derek, she might never have escaped captivity.

Leaving him behind was unthinkable.

“I accept the terms,” Derek stated.

Khalani jerked her gaze to him. “What are you talking about? We’re not leaving you.”

“Yes, you are.” He swallowed tightly. “They won’t let us go otherwise. If this is what I must do to help you reach Hermes, then I’ll gladly do that. For you all, I’d do anything.”

She shook her head numbly as the weight of their collective bond shone in his eyes.

“Derek.” Winnie’s chin trembled. “You don’t have to do this. Winnie can stay with you.”

More arguments ensued, but Brock and Takeshi remained silent, their expressions hard, as if the harsh realities of their lives had taught them the necessity of sacrifice. But she didn’t miss their clenched fists and glares directed at the Chief.

“No. You all need to keep going. I’ll be fine.” Derek smiled, but it didn’t quite reach his eyes. “I don’t mind the bed and showers,” he joked, trying to ease their grief.

“But what about the crops? We need your help in Hermes, too,” Khalani insisted, still in denial that this was their only option.

“I know,” Derek conceded. “Just come back fast for me.”

His bottom lip barely quivered, and Khalani cried out, throwing her arms

around him. Winnie, Serene, and Adan quickly joined in, all five of them dissolving into tears.

Even though Khalani knew it was only temporary, she felt like her chest was splintering apart.

The Chief cleared her throat after a few minutes. “Time is of the essence, I’m afraid. If the terms are accepted, the rest of you must leave the Desert Spring immediately. Patreus, ensure they get their packs back.”

Khalani wiped her ever-flowing tears as they reluctantly pulled apart. Patreus nodded grimly, his expression odd as he swiftly exited the cabin.

“Go.” The Chief gestured toward the door. “The sooner you get to Hermes and return, the quicker we’ll all get out of this alive.”

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14

There is never a right time.
There is only now.

If you are to step, make it deliberate
Feel the memories beneath your feet
Let your legs forge a path
One comprised of dreams and grit
Others may follow
But your road is your own
Even if you may turn
Your destination remains the same
When you step, don't look back.

If you are to live, make it meaningful
A million stories spiral within you
Let those dreams escape the heart
Be practical
Be crazy
Leave a mark
Do not worry where other paths lead
For your story won't be the same
You don't have to be greater
But when you live, be the difference

"Khalani!"

She startled, snapping her notebook shut.

Brock stood a few feet away, watching her as the others gathered their belongings, preparing to continue on the treacherous road.

Khalani's eyes had stayed open the past few nights, imagining herself running back toward the Desert Spring to rescue Derek.

Before they left, he hugged Khalani tightly and whispered in her ear, "Don't be afraid. You've already survived one underground city. You have everything inside you to do it again."

In the present, Khalani discreetly wiped away another tear that had leeched out, but she stood, ready to leave.

The faster they reached Hermes, the sooner they could return for Derek.

Winnie fluttered around the abandoned gas station they'd slept in that night, an extra pep in her step that made Khalani's head spin. The group was busy packing their rucksacks as Winnie moved from person to person, insisting they eat the extra food the Chief had provided when they left the Desert Spring a few days ago.

"Serene, your beautiful blue hair is losing its shine. Make sure you stay hydrated."

"Adan, your jokes are getting worse. Have some soup."

"Brock, your muscles are atrophying. Did you eat the beef stew today?"

"Takeshi, *please* stop looking like you're about to commit murder. It's bad for the skin."

"And Khalani." Winnie turned to her. "Turn that frown upside down and eat some beans, for goodness' sake."

She nodded, hastily stashing the notebook in her pack.

"What's that you've been writing anyways?" Adan brushed a hand through his ruffled bronze hair.

"Nothing interesting," she shrugged dismissively.

Poetry was portions of her soul laid out on paper.

She wasn't ready to share that with anyone.

"Is it a diary or something? Secret crushes and all that?" Adan nudged her shoulder, wiggling his eyebrows.

"You nailed it. I just write 'Khalani and Adan' with hearts circling our names over and over again." She rolled her eyes as they exited the building and stepped into the bright sun.

As they traveled during the day, the number of buildings dwindled. The gas station they'd spent the night in was the only large structure they'd spotted in the desert.

Interestingly enough, nearly all the cars on the highway faced the opposite direction, as if everyone had been trying to flee the very place they

were heading.

She rubbed her hand across her forehead as the blazing heat of the sun continued to rain down. To pass the time, she counted her steps.

One…

Two…

Three…

Khalani stopped when she reached one hundred thousand.

She then concentrated on the bright orange rocky hill in front of them, letting that be her next focus. But once they passed it, there was yet another endless expanse of road, desert terrain and distant, jagged hills.

“So,” Serene disrupted the stiff silence, “I have a very important question for you, Khalani.”

“What’s that?”

“If you marry Adan, does that mean we’ll all have roles in the wedding?”

A laugh bubbled out of her. “You know I was just joking about writing our names in a diary, right?”

“Can’t you just let a girl dream about having the best sister in the world?” Serene sighed, a wistful look in her eyes.

Khalani’s heart thumped harder, and she cleared her throat, not knowing how to handle her rising emotion. “If we ever get married, sure. You and Winnie would be my maids of honor.”

Serene made a mini fist pump, and Winnie’s eyes brightened like Khalani just gifted her the world.

“You really would want Winnie to have such a special role?” Winnie’s chin trembled.

“Of course. You could make our dresses too. Otherwise, I might end up at the altar covered in dirt.”

Winnie placed a hand over her heart and bowed her head low. “Winnie would be honored.”

“Who’s going to be Adan’s best man?” Serene pondered.

“Probably Brock.” Khalani’s lips curled up.

“Leave me out of your lovey-dovey crap,” Brock grumbled.

“Nah, Brock’s the ring bearer,” Adan said. “Because he’s so charitable and all.”

Brock shot them the middle finger and walked faster, trying to lose them in the heavy sands.

The atmosphere was light, but Serene’s tone held a hint of mischief

when she asked, “So, what would Takeshi’s role be?”

Her eyes couldn’t help but flutter to him.

Takeshi was at the front of the pack, marching like a man on a mission, ignoring their entire conversation, but every now and then, she noticed his fists clenching.

“Well,” Adan hesitated, “Takeshi could be the…uh…reverend?” he said it like a question.

If the atmosphere wasn’t so tense, she’d burst out laughing.

Takeshi glanced over his shoulder. “The only thing I’ll be is your mortician if you don’t stop talking.”

Adan’s face turned green and he quickly nodded.

Takeshi faced forward, his black cloak flapping in the wind like a dark cloud ready to cover the world.

They continued to trek onward.

Khalani didn’t know everyone’s reasons—what drove each of them past their limitations and fears.

But whatever their motivation, whether it was to save themselves, a dying city, or to venture beyond their wildest imaginings, their footprints remained in the sand.

If no one else, the Earth witnessed the evidence of their resolve.

As they ventured closer to Hermes, the hairs on the back of her neck stood on end. She felt a deep, primal urge to turn around, her body sensing they were on the verge of a terrible mistake.

“There.” Brock pointed toward the horizon.

They finally reached the crest of a ridge, and in the distance lay the largest city they’d encountered so far.

Her mouth was agape as they ventured closer and got a better look at the destruction left behind from the Great Collapse.

Grandiose, golden buildings lay toppled, like a monstrous giant had blown them over. Windows were shattered, and cars lay piled on top of one another.

Khalani wrinkled her nose at the odd, rusty smell in the air as they walked past a broken green sign on the road entitled, *Las Vegas Boulevard*.

She couldn’t comprehend why such a massive city had been built in the heart of the desert.

Everything about it felt strange. The black pyramid-shaped building looming in the distance. The brown and red chips scattered like confetti on

the cracked asphalt. The golden pillars toppled over the sidewalks.

It was an ancient graveyard of opulence.

She carefully stepped over a torn streetlight and her gaze caught on a piece of paper trapped under the rusted metal. She frowned, crouching to pick it up. The crumpled paper was ripped in half, but she could still make out some of the writing:

Daily Vegas Times
BREAKING NEWS
Nuclear War Imminent

The White House has yet to release an official response, but this past weekend, many members of Congress were seen leaving Washington, D.C., to be with their families. Most declined to comment, but Senator Gale Grovenheart stated, "We let in the Trojan Horse, and the enemies have opened the gates," before hastily boarding his private jet to Hawaii. He declined to elaborate, but anonymous sources within the government agree that it is not a matter of if, but when, Russia and China will attack.

These types of talks have occurred before, but none quite as serious since the terrorist attacks in Moscow, Beijing, and New York City that claimed the lives of millions. Military forces remain on high alert, and what was once the theory of "Mutually Assured Destruction" may soon become a reality. There have been talks of bunkers being erected, but even our high-level sources have declined to comment on their exis—

The rest of the page was torn. Khalani's lips pressed together as she let the archaic paper tumble to the ground, the wind sweeping it away like a lost memory.

She shivered as they continued forward. Takeshi palmed a sharp blade, his body tense.

No one spoke.

Everyone's eyes were alert, flickering past the quiet streets and lavish buildings that had been torn to shreds.

"Over here," Brock spoke in a low voice, jogging toward one of the few structures still standing—two massive, metal arches that rose above the street. The rusted beams were adorned with intricate patterns and crisscrossed over one another.

"This is the Gateway Arch," Brock proclaimed, pointing to the structure

overhead.

“We made it!” Serene cried out in relief, nearly collapsing to the ground.

“But where is Hermes?” Adan panted, sweat soaking through his clothes.

“It’s located somewhere beneath us.”

“But I don’t see a dome.” Khalani glanced around with her brows drawn low.

“They don’t have one,” Brock answered. “Hermes isn’t like Apollo. The casinos underground are entertainment enough for the rich.”

“What the hell is a casino?”

“Do you have the walkie?” Brock turned to Adan, ignoring Serene’s question.

Adan dug around in his pack and carefully handed it over. “Here.”

Brock changed the frequency and spoke into the speaker, “Come in, Spade. Spade, come in.”

Khalani didn’t know who Spade was, but they waited in rapt attention, like they were preparing for God Himself to speak.

Just when panic set in, a familiar voice echoed from the walkie. “What comes alive in the shadow of the night?”

Her eyes widened. It was the same voice they’d heard on the surface of Genesis.

“Stars and sin,” Brock replied confidently.

“Brock, is that really you?” the familiar voice asked.

“It’s me, Spade.”

“By the flush, I thought you were a goner.”

“I’m at the Gateway Arch with a group from Apollo,” Brock said. “How long before you arrive?”

A heavy pause followed. “How many are with you?”

“Seven in total. We’re ready to go through the chute entrance into Hermes.”

Spade cursed over the line. “I didn’t think that many would make it across the Death-Zone, but I suppose you’re the only crazy fucker who could manage that. But we have a problem. The chute entrance is being monitored. One of our boys got captured on the last smuggling run. I’ll have to get you into Hermes another way.”

Brock stiffened. “How?”

“The sewers. It’s not going to be a pleasant journey, but it’s the only way I can guarantee your safe passage. I’ll meet you at the Arches at midnight.

Got it?”

Brock’s face looked painfully frustrated, but he snapped, “Understood.”

Spade quickly cut the line and after Brock turned off the walkie, all they could do was wait.

They found some shade in a ruined shop across the street, the windows blown out and the place stripped clean. Serene and Adan sat on the dirty tiled floor and talked with Winnie about the Great Collapse.

“What do you think happened here?” Serene paled at the devastation around them.

“Bombs dropped on all the major cities and eviscerated the Midwest, which housed most of the nuclear silos,” Winnie explained. “According to the Archives, anyone who didn’t secure a spot underground either died from the blasts or starved.”

“But how did the government decide who got a spot underground and who didn’t?” Adan asked.

Winnie hesitated, her face twisting. “Government documents stated that those under thirty and couples with kids were the priority. Everyone else was left to die. But many people who met the strict qualifications weren’t able to get in because the wealthy bribed officials and soldiers for spots.”

“That’s so messed up.”

Winnie nodded, leaning forward intently. “That’s why it’s important for everyone to remember our history. To memorize our twisted scars and mistakes so that we may become better versions of humanity.”

They hung on her every word, captivated by the grim truths of the Great Collapse.

Khalani gave a sad smile and stepped outside for some fresh air.

The hopeful side of her, the one Winnie had brought back to life in prison, believed that humanity could correct its mistakes. Their bleak history of death and cruelty didn’t have to define their future.

But the dark pit inside her stomach continued to expand as she gazed around the ruins of the empty city.

It felt like the same ignorance and capacity for destruction that nearly ended the world was stirring, like something treacherous had awakened.

Her hands shook as she stepped through the door, her boots crunching on broken glass. Takeshi and Brock stood on opposite sides of the store entrance outside.

Brock looked out at the buildings, while Takeshi sharpened his knife.

She winced, the jagged grating of metal against stone providing the only eerie soundtrack to the haunting quiet.

“Hey,” she greeted them awkwardly.

Brock acknowledged her with a casual one-finger salute, not bothering to look her way. Takeshi inclined his head, his fiery gaze locking onto her briefly and making her shiver. But he quickly went back to focusing on his blade, sharpening it as if it was the only thing keeping him calm.

Khalani walked over to one of the ruined cars in front of the store. It looked as if its owner hastily abandoned it there without a thought. Its faded yellow surface was marred with burn marks and every window was blown out.

She leaned against the frame, lacing her fingers behind her head, drawing in a deep breath.

Khalani counted down the seconds, praying midnight would come faster, but the sun stayed high in the sky. Staring. Waiting for their next move.

She gave Brock a sidelong glance, hoping to kill time another way. “How do you know this Spade guy?”

She half-expected him to ignore her, but Brock sighed and walked over, hopping on the hood of the car she was leaning against.

She raised a brow, worried the wrecked car would crumble with his weight, but he didn’t seem the least bit concerned.

“Spade saved my life,” Brock began, his elbows resting on his knees, hands steepled together. “Most Death-Zoners stay in Hermes at least a month after the long trek across the desert. Hermes isn’t like Apollo. They thrive off sin and debauchery, like a terrible jar of whiskey you keep chugging.”

As Brock spoke, she noticed Takeshi slowly drawing closer, the scraping of his knife becoming less frequent as he listened.

“One night in the casino, I was at my usual spot at the bar, drinking my life away, when I heard a commotion. A young woman, desperate to feed her family, had spent the last of her money gambling. She lost of course and was convinced the casino had cheated her. Something about her tears and the uncaring way security had treated her didn’t sit right with me. I caused a scene. Punched a couple of Dealers when they tried to arrest her. Another guard came over and pulled out his pistol.

“But then, Spade stepped in and talked the guard down. I didn’t know then how much influence he wielded in the city, but I did notice the wad of

cash he slipped into the woman's pocket—more than she ever needed. I left, sleeping it all off. But the next day, when I showed up at the bar, Spade was waiting for me.

"He started talking to me every day, wanting to know the little things. My preferences in alcohol and food. What I thought of Hermes. Apollo. He became fully aware of my discontent with the underground cities, and he was the only person I could stand in that wretched place. During my last week there, he confided in me about the resistance group in Hermes and how they could use my help smuggling supplies as a highly regarded Death-Zoner. It was an easy decision for me. They're good people, probably the only good people left underground."

She sat in silence, letting his story weave through her mind.

Hermes sounded completely different from Apollo.

Apollo didn't have casinos—whatever those were—bars, dancing, or any type of late-night gatherings. Debauchery was frowned upon, and any mingling after hours had to be done in secret.

The Council loved to spread fear, rewarding those who betrayed their neighbors in the name of patriotism, even if the accusations were false. Because of that, most people were terrified to get to know one another.

But the desperation in Brock's story, the indifference toward others, treating the poor as expendable…maybe that was a common trait in every underground city.

Or maybe a lack of empathy was a disease that spread long before the Great Collapse.

"So, Spade's the head of this resistance movement in Hermes?" she asked.

Brock hesitated. "Not exactly. I've never met their leader."

"What?" She swung her head.

"Yeah." Brock crossed his arms. "The resistance leader is a very careful man. Apparently, I wasn't trusted enough to meet him, and I've been working with Spade for years. I doubt we'll ever see him."

She gnawed on her bottom lip, the uncertainty like a razor blade hovering over their heads.

Takeshi slipped the blade into his boot, pulling out another one from his vest, the metallic scrape of sharpening resuming as the sun beamed down on them.

Should she be concerned at this point with the number of weapons he

had?

“Aren’t you worried about poking yourself with all those…things?” She waved her hand.

If you looked closely, a ghost of a grin appeared on Takeshi’s face. Though you’d need a microscope to be sure.

“No,” he replied, not breaking his focus from the obsidian blade, his cold and aloof expression firmly in place.

The ensuing silence screamed at her.

It was the empty city. The hours stretching endlessly. The scraping of a knife. His quiet disregard.

Everything eroded her nerves.

Perhaps the lingering mayhem in the ruins rubbed off on her, because Khalani craved to get a reaction out of Takeshi that was more than a single word.

“Hey, Brock, how skilled are you with a knife?” She leaned back on her palms nonchalantly.

Brock looked up at the sky. “Unmatched.”

“Oh?” Her eyes widened, feigning surprise. “You’re probably a really good teacher then, huh?”

Takeshi slowed his sharpening.

Brock tilted his head. “You could say that. Why?”

“Oh, nothing.” She kicked her feet. “I was just thinking we had some time to kill. Maybe you could teach me.”

Takeshi completely stopped what he was doing and looked up, a deep scowl darkening his face.

“Sure.” Brock shrugged, jumping off the car. “Nothing better to do.”

“I can teach you,” Takeshi spoke in a low voice, his black eyes narrowing into slits.

“No, it’s fine.” Khalani waved him off, letting her hand briefly rest on Brock’s shoulder. “Brock’s got me.”

Takeshi’s expression morphed from shock, to betrayal, to anger, before shifting into something more unsettling.

He stood very still, gripping the hilt of his blade so tightly that she was surprised blood wasn’t pooling on the concrete.

An evil grin curled up Brock’s face as they moved toward the empty street. “You’re smarter than I gave you credit for.”

“Not sure what you mean.”

“Sure, you don’t,” Brock said, flipping his blade and catching it by the hilt without even looking. “But who knows, you might actually learn something.”

“Bring it.”

To her surprise, Brock proved to be a good teacher, though he was impatient.

He spent considerable time teaching her how to grip the damn blade. He demonstrated various slashing and thrusting techniques, focusing on her leg placement for maximum force.

She would never admit it to Brock, but even though he obviously knew what he was talking about, she learned better from Takeshi.

The cold Captain knew exactly when to push her buttons and when to offer support—though that last part was more of a rare occurrence.

Even though he drove her crazy, no one else ever made her feel so in tune with her strength. Like she shouldn’t fear the world, but it should dread her.

The entire time, Takeshi didn’t intervene or speak.

He merely watched from the dark corner outside the shop.

Takeshi’s arms were crossed, casually leaning against the building. She couldn’t see his facial expression, but she felt his cold, predatory gaze slide over her body.

Khalani didn’t know how long she practiced with Brock, but her body was worked to exhaustion and the sun had long set.

“Good.” Brock nodded, looking vaguely surprised. “Didn’t expect you to last this long.”

“Someone helped me with that.” She glanced past Brock, frowning when she noticed Takeshi was no longer there.

Brock’s brow raised but he didn’t inquire about the mystery person.

“If you want to keep practicing, stick to the drills I showed you. I’m going inside to check on the others.” He turned toward the store, leaving her alone.

Khalani wiped a hand across her sweaty forehead, the temperature quickly dropping, and only a faint hint of sunlight remained on the horizon.

She took a deep breath and resumed her stance, slowly going through the drills—slicing, thrusting, and jabbing forward—speeding up with each repetition.

Her movements were a bit sloppy, but she was confident that if an enemy

appeared, she'd at least be able to nick them with the blade.

There was a quiet tension in the air and the hairs on her arms stood up. Before she could turn, a large hand covered her mouth, muffling her scream.

She thrust her right hand back, but her wrist was captured and squeezed tightly, forcing Khalani to release her grip on the blade and it clattered to the ground.

"He forgot to remind you to watch your back," Takeshi tutted in her ear and shivers raced through her body.

Her backside was pressed flush against his front, her chest heaving with each breath as anger swept through her, barely overshadowing the warmth pooling in her stomach.

She tried to bite the hand covering her mouth, but he lowered his grip until his palm rested around her throat. Khalani tried to elbow him, but he wrapped his forearm around her, rendering her immobile.

"And you've already relinquished your weapon," he softly continued, as if holding her utterly still was child's play. "I should eviscerate your teacher on principle alone."

"Jealous?" she seethed.

"Do you want me to detail the one hundred ninety-seven ways I thought of killing him, or the thousand ways I plan on punishing you?"

"That's oddly specific."

"Keep provoking me, Kanes. See where that gets you."

"Are you admitting that you care?" she prodded.

He lowered his head, his palm still resting on her neck. "You mistake caring for being annoyed that I have to retrain you. Your grip on the blade was all wrong. Your footwork looked like you were trying to dance rather than stab someone. At this point, you're more likely to injure yourself than an enemy."

"You sure that's the only reason?"

He chose to stay silent. But the untamed energy didn't just flow through him.

The pieces of her that enjoyed toying with danger reared its ugly head, desperate to feel something other than fear before descending back into the underground.

"Maybe I prefer him as my trainer."

The brief tightening of his muscles was her only warning.

One minute she was standing upright. The next, she was sprawled on her back.

Takeshi crouched over her, twirling her fallen blade through his fingertips. “Lie again for me, Kanes.”

“You really are insane,” she gnashed through her teeth, staring into Takeshi’s cold, handsome face.

“Now she gets it.”

His windswept hair was as black as the night sky, and Takeshi’s gaze was as hard as the ground he had her pinned to.

It wasn’t too long ago that he had her restrained in a similar position in the back of a truck, and she felt something else that was—

No.

No.

She needed to get a grip and stop chasing men who didn’t want her—and had made that abundantly clear—into the storm.

Hell, Takeshi *was* the storm. Barreling into her life. Knocking down her inhibitions.

She needed to focus on what was important. And that was getting into Hermes and figuring out how to rescue thousands of innocent people in Apollo who would die soon from crop failure.

“Give me back my knife,” she demanded.

Takeshi kept twirling it through his fingers, staring straight into her green eyes. Like he wanted to dive into her mind and pry out every secret, so nothing was hidden from him.

After a long stare-down, he extended the blade toward her. She snatched it quickly and stood, fighting to regain her composure.

But when Khalani shoved past him, he blocked her path. “If you value the Death-Zoner’s life, don’t do that again.”

“I can talk and train with whomever I want, Takeshi. If you don’t like it, that sounds like a *you* problem.”

A part of her knew that provoking him was an invitation to play with death and all his creatures. But she was too prideful to back down.

His expression hardened, jaw tightening, but Takeshi swiftly composed himself and tilted his head. “You’re right.”

“I am?”

“Yes. You can train and talk with whomever you wish, Kanes. You’re not mine.”

Khalani’s pulse hammered like she was dangling off the edge of a cliff. “I’m not?”

“You say that like a question.”

She pressed her lips into a thin line, determined not to say another word.

Takeshi was the one to break the silence.

“No, you aren’t mine, Kanes. If you were, you’d know it.” He leaned closer, his black eyes scorching. “I don’t like to share.”

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15

When the world ended, something within us died too.

Khalani’s eyes flickered across the tattered buildings, her heart pounding as they stood exposed beneath the Gateway Arch sign.

The clear moon cast a cold, silvery glow over them, cutting through the inky darkness.

The vast emptiness of the city pressed around her, and Khalani’s pulse was a relentless drumbeat ever since her conversation with Takeshi.

He stood off to the side, arms crossed as he methodically scanned the ruined city. His expression was withdrawn and closed off, reverting back to his distant, brooding self. But Takeshi’s words kept spinning like a cycle in her mind.

What would it be like to be his?

They’d be constantly at each other’s throats.

Irritating each other to no end.

And yet, the idea didn’t entirely repulse her. It lingered like a dangerous spark.

“Where is this guy?” Serene muttered beside her.

A sharp crack suddenly resounded from several feet behind them.

They immediately turned, raising their weapons.

A large figure carrying a lantern appeared. Khalani and Serene recoiled, feet shuffling back from the two-legged figure with no face, only a green, plastic shield covering its head and large body.

“Relax. It’s Spade.” Brock stepped forward, though Khalani noticed his fingers tightening around the blade.

The strange figure stopped and lifted the lantern, carefully scanning each of their shocked faces before settling on Brock.

“Where are your radiation suits?” A deep, synthesized voice echoed from the man.

“We don’t need them anymore,” Brock answered.

“What the hell are you talking about?” The figure took a shaky step back.

“That’s why I got arrested, Spade,” Brock explained, lifting his free hand to calm him. “I was attacked by a tribe on the surface without suits during my last run. There’s no radiation on the surface anymore.”

Spade remained silent for a long time.

He then approached slowly, circling each of them with the lamp held up to their faces. “Any nausea, fever, disorientation, diarrhea, or hair loss?”

“No, Spade.” Brock sighed, exasperated. “But we’re going to start losing our hair the longer we stand here.”

But Spade shook his head, continuously muttering, “It can’t be true.”

“There’s a lot the government’s been keeping from us.” Brock’s voice turned cold. “We have much to discuss.”

“Clearly.” Spade looked between each of them. “Before I take you to Hermes, you must know that discretion is key to our group’s survival. The soldiers and the Hermes government wouldn’t hesitate to line us up in front of a firing squad if they catch wind of rebellion.” The synthesized voice deepened, a deadly edge creeping in.

“Trust isn’t given freely in Hermes. It’s earned,” Spade continued. “We have eyes everywhere—people you’ll never meet, see, or hear. Cross us, even once, and you’ll have a bullet in your skull faster than you can say blackjack. Do I make myself clear?”

He waited for each of them to verbally respond “Yes” before nodding.

“Then let’s go.”

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Spade led them down a narrow alley, where he pried open a rusted grate in the ground. The pitch-black hole made Khalani’s hair stand on end. She almost turned around when Spade declared they needed to jump inside.

Adan bravely went first, disappearing into the darkness, followed by a distant thump that made Serene holler, “You okay?”

“Yeah!” he yelled back. “It’s not a far drop. Smells like shit, though.”

Brock and Spade helped lower the others. Spade gestured for Takeshi to go next, but he shook his head. “Her first.”

Spade turned to Khalani. She adjusted the pack on her back and stepped forward, eyeing the hole as panic swelled in her chest.

“It’s alright,” Spade said. “The first jump is the hardest.”

Khalani took a deep breath and nodded.

She’d fought off men twice her size, escaped an inescapable prison, and stared death in the face more times than she could count.

Dropping through a ten-foot hole should be easy.

She sat and her legs dangled over the opening as Brock and Spade grabbed her arms, lowering her down.

“You ready?” Spade yelled as she hung over the void.

No.

“Yes!”

As soon as the word left her mouth, both men dropped her.

She yelped, her heart plummeting to her stomach when she fell, landing with a hard thud. Unknown hands caught her in the pitch-black, steadying her.

“I got you,” Serene’s voice echoed through the dark, rubbing the top of Khalani’s arm.

A moment later, another body dropped, brushing past her quickly, as if they didn’t require any assistance. The familiar, commanding presence sent tingles racing down her spine.

Spade and Brock dropped in shortly after, and the dim light from Spade’s lantern revealed their grim surroundings.

A shallow stream of water ran at their feet and her nose crinkled at the stench. The smell was all too familiar, a cruel reminder of the months she’d spent in prison.

“This way,” Spade commanded, immediately marching forward with Brock trailing behind him. Winnie and Serene flanked her on either side, with Adan close by.

Takeshi took up the rear as usual.

She wasn’t sure if he preferred having a full view of everyone or if he just wanted to be as far from her as possible. Maybe it was a combination of both.

Winnie linked her arm through Khalani’s and wrinkled her nose. “The first thing Winnie would do to this place is add some color to the walls. Things tend to smell better when they feel beautiful.”

A small grin tugged at Khalani’s mouth. Spade glanced over his shoulder, clearly not used to Winnie’s rambling like the rest of them were.

They walked for what felt like hours through the long tunnels, climbing down rickety ladders that groaned unnervingly under their weight. Her body was exhausted, but her mind raced like a transport, the edginess refusing to dissipate.

Khalani’s eyes widened when they approached a white door with a metal latch. Spade heaved it open, and as they stepped through the tunnel, she was startled to find a large glass tube hanging to her right, with a showerhead inside.

“What’s this for?” she asked.

The sound of plastic stretching reverberated along the sewer walls, and she turned to see Spade taking off his radiation suit, revealing a handsome, middle-aged man with short, light blond hair and gray eyes that held a quiet intelligence.

Beneath the plastic covering, he wore a well-fitted black tuxedo and a clean white shirt that looked entirely out of place in the sewers.

He tossed the radiation suit into the glass tube and turned the showerhead on.

“Just in case,” he murmured, almost to himself.

“Why are you dressed so nice?” Serene asked warily as he straightened.

Spade sputtered, glancing down at his tuxedo. “Do they not dress like this in Apollo?”

“No.”

“Hmm. That’s odd,” he muttered, picking up the lamp.

“Aren’t you worried about getting your clothes dirty down here?”

“I have plenty.”

“And you’re sure no one will see us coming in?”

“Positive. The soldiers avoid the sewers, and our boys have a distraction planned to draw any spare Dealers away from the grate.”

“What kind of distraction?” she warily asked.

Spade paused, a faint glimmer of mischief twinkling in his gaze. “Something bloodier than chips.”

Khalani and Serene exchanged worried glances, while Brock simply grinned.

As they continued the long journey down the tunnels, Khalani gradually got used to the horrible smell of the sewers. An achievement she wasn’t

jumping for joy over.

Just when she was about to ask how much further they had to go, a faint light appeared ahead. A large circular opening with interlocking bars loomed at the end of the tunnel.

Something was on the other side.

“We’re here,” Spade declared.

Winnie’s grip tightened around Khalani’s arm.

They quickened their pace, boots splashing against the dirty water. But that wasn’t the only sound. As they neared the barred opening, a deep bass of music reverberated through the air, growing louder with each step, thumping against Khalani’s chest.

Unfazed, Spade crept up to the bars, looking both ways with a sharp eye. He handed the lantern to Brock and pulled a set of keys from his back pocket.

Spade quickly unlocked the chain around the bars and carefully pulled the gate inward, revealing a hidden underground city.

“Welcome to Hermes.”

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16

Humans never rid themselves of savagery.
They simply hid it better.

Khalani stepped through the gate, her senses immediately on high alert as she looked around. They were in an abandoned alley, flanked by brick buildings on either side.

A rocky surface loomed overhead, at least a mile up. In the distance, a deep beat rumbled, and laughter echoed through the air. Her muscles tensed when several figures raced past the end of the alley, but no one seemed to notice their wide-eyed group.

Winnie jumped at the resounding bang behind them as Spade closed the iron bars to the sewer. He slid the keys into his pocket.

“Listen carefully,” Spade instructed. “I’ll lead you to one of our safehouses where you’ll stay for the night. It’s not far, but your outfits are very conspicuous and will attract attention. Fortunately, at this hour, most people are either at the casino or too drunk to stand straight. So keep your heads down and stay close behind me.”

Khalani took a deep breath, trying to calm her frayed nerves as they followed Spade.

They took a right turn at the end of the alley, emerging onto a vibrant cobblestone street. When she lifted her gaze, her blood pressure spiked, and Serene’s mouth formed an *O* next to her.

“Wow,” Winnie whispered.

Neon lights lit up a colorful street, illuminating extravagant storefronts that seemed to pulse with a life of their own. Raucous laughter filled the air, and a myriad of people roamed around with bottles of liquor in their hands.

The men wore impeccable, silky black and white tuxedos, while the women paraded along in skintight red and black dresses that rode up their thighs and revealed an abundance of cleavage.

Khalani crossed her arms over her chest, intrinsically aware of how out of place she looked in her dusty beige pants and oversized shirt. But the people strutting on the street ignored them, taking long swigs of their drinks and bumping into one another.

As she followed Spade, blinking neon signs in front of the strange shops caught her attention.

Stella's Sweet Delights. Queen of Hearts Bar. Othelia's Outfits. Sultry Sin. Laken's Liquors. Dance with the Devil.

The sights, the smells—everything was an assault on her senses.

She gazed up at the dazzling lights and buildings, a strange dichotomy to the massive stone cavern Hermes resided in.

Khalani jumped as an inebriated couple pushed past her.

The man wore a crisp white suit as he hoisted a blonde woman into his arms. Her long legs wrapped around him, and she tilted her head back in bliss while he unabashedly sucked on her chest in front of everyone.

"You're looking a little lonely. I can help with that." A young man with baby blue eyes and long brown hair tied in a ponytail sidled up to her, the smell of liquor on his clothing overpowering.

Khalani tried to back away, but he tossed a heavy arm around her shoulders.

But in the next moment, he was abruptly shoved away, crashing to the cobblestone in a drunken heap. Several onlookers started cackling hysterically while the guy belched and struggled back to his feet.

He wasn't even aware of the 6'5 Captain standing over him.

"Let's go." Takeshi didn't waste another second and grabbed Khalani by the arm, steering her around the couple who started ripping each other's clothes off in the middle of the street.

Once they were safely behind the group, Takeshi quickly released her.

Spade subtly glanced back, making sure they were still following, and continued to move forward, completely immune to the scenes of gluttony, sex, and debauchery surrounding them.

The contrast between Apollo and Hermes was evident in every square inch of the city, especially in its residents. Khalani and her companions were rigid and cold, a product of their harsh environment, while these people were carefree and reckless.

A boisterous crash sounded to her right.

She flinched as an older man in a grey suit punched a short guy wearing

a black top hat clean off a barstool.

A few of the women stopped to watch, the grins on their faces widening as they giggled, whispering to one another. The men openly appraised the fight, shouting words of encouragement, and no one interfered.

“Ladies’ Happy Hour is now!” a woman in a black lace bra announced from behind the bar, ignoring the havoc around her. “Buy two shots, get the third free!”

“Win your chips at the casino in style, gentlemen! Wear Deluxe Tuxedos, and you’ll have winner’s luck, mark my words!” a man with platinum blond hair shouted from the other side of the street. His silver suit sparkled like the moon as he stood outside a colorful store where hundreds of shimmering suits were on display.

“Don’t stop,” Takeshi reminded her, gently pushing her forward.

Khalani was too shocked to do anything but obey.

The endless line of stores, bars, and drunk patrons seemed never-ending until Spade turned into another dark alley.

There were hardly any people in the alley, but the few who were present all nodded at Spade as he passed. They approached a smaller building with a modest sign hanging above the entrance.

The Black Heart

Her brows pulled together as Spade approached the steel door, pushing it open, signaling them to enter. The interior felt like a warm, ancient castle that Winnie had once told her about in books.

The walls were made of stone, and the space was more expansive inside than it appeared from the outside. The large room was dimly lit, with a long bar to the right.

A few men sat on barstools, their white sleeves rolled up as they spoke in low tones.

To the left, two unusual green tables stood a few feet apart, each covered with colorful balls. Surrounding the tables were a group of men with long sticks in their hands. One man aimed his stick at a ball and shot it into a small hole at the corner of the table.

How bizarre.

The room quieted as soon as they walked in. One of the men at the table shifted his hand to rest on the barely hidden pistol in his pocket. Her quickened breathing became audible as her body tensed for a fight.

“Evening, Spade,” the bald man behind the bar greeted with a tilt of his head.

Spade nodded. “Did the drop go well?”

“Boys said it went without a hitch.”

“Good.” Spade walked past the bar and clapped one of the men sitting on a stool on the back. “Finneas.”

“Hey, Spade. And by the flush! Didn’t expect to see you back so soon, Death-Zoner.” The younger man named Finneas grinned, revealing a missing front tooth.

“Likewise,” Brock’s expression was stoic, like he was readying for war.

After a few more greetings to Spade, who was quite the popular guy, he led them to a door in the back of the room that blended in with the wall.

If Spade hadn’t pushed it open, Khalani wouldn’t have even realized it was a door.

They entered a small, circular room with two red couches pushed against the wall and a tall bar in the back. Behind it, a man with pale skin, crisp black hair, and a white suit cleaned bottles. He looked up, eyeing each of them with immediate distrust.

“Keno,” Spade said in greeting.

“Spade,” Keno replied back. “Who’s the company?”

“These are the ones I was telling you about. You already know Brock.”

Keno didn’t look impressed as he glanced between them, his gaze lingering longest on Takeshi. “Are you sure they’re the right ones to help?”

Khalani frowned. Help with what?

But Spade replied, “Absolutely.”

Keno’s lips pressed into a thin line, and a heavy silence settled over the room. Khalani half-expected weapons to be drawn, but after a moment, Keno reached beneath the bar, and she heard a soft click.

The front portion of the bar moved forward and vanished, revealing a long staircase that disappeared into darkness.

Her mouth fell open as Spade descended the steep steps, gesturing for them to follow.

Khalani met Keno’s eyes one last time before taking her first step, his expression hard and unreadable.

She quickly stepped down the stairs, thankful there was a banister for her to hang onto. When she reached the bottom, the area opened into a small room illuminated only by the flicker of candles. The air was considerably

colder, and Khalani rubbed her palms up and down her arms.

“This is one of our safehouses.” Spade turned to them. “There are several bedrooms down here for members who need to hide out for the night. You’ll remain here for the duration of your stay. Well, most of you, that is.”

Her forehead wrinkled, but before she could ask what he meant, Spade gave them a quick tour of the cold space.

The safehouse was definitely not built to impress. There were no decorations, and each room had one bed, a nightstand, and a small closet.

“I suggest you get some sleep now because you won’t have a chance tomorrow.”

“What happens tomorrow?”

For the first time, Spade looked apprehensive.

“Your first assignment. At the casino.”

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17

Bad decisions build character.
Makes you feel better, doesn’t it?

Khalani barely slept that night. In her long-standing nightmares, the Governor wrapped his hand around her neck and squeezed with all his might, grinning sadistically.

But then, his face began to morph until it was Takeshi who held her down. Takeshi’s beautiful black eyes flared with delight as the life slowly drained out of her.

“You made the wrong choice,” he whispered.

She jolted awake with a gasp, her entire body trembling. Khalani rubbed her eyes, trying to calm her ragged breathing. She slipped out of the bedroom in the blue sweatshirt and T-shirt she’d found in the dresser, her bare feet softly padding against the black tile.

In the main area, she found Winnie sitting with her legs crossed at a desk, her monocle perched on her nose, wearing a burgundy dress that spilled over the wooden stool. She labored over a journal, writing furiously.

“Hey, Winnie,” she greeted softly, though the smile didn’t quite reach her eyes.

Winnie jerked up, her cheeks lifting. “Khalani, dear! What are you doing up so early?”

“It’s early?” Khalani’s brows raised as she glanced around the windowless room. “Hard to tell.”

“Ah, you need to grab yourself one of these.” Winnie flipped her wrist and showed her a circadian watch.

Khalani had only seen a few in person.

Circadian watches were quite rare and cost what the average citizen would make after working twenty years in Apollo.

Instead of numbers, the watches displayed symbols for the sun, moon,

and food, helping keep track of time and the best hours to eat underground.

“Winnie found it in the nightstand. She’ll make sure to find one for you too,” Winnie said proudly, patting the seat next to her. “Come sit, dear. You look too pale.”

Khalani obliged and sat down with a huff, stretching her legs out and rubbing a hand between her tired eyes.

“What’s wrong?”

“Nothing, Winnie. Just bad dreams.”

“What terrifies us in the real world manifests in our sleep, so it might then escape. Don’t let that happen,” Winnie implored with a serious look.

Khalani tilted her head back, her gaze fixed on the grey ceiling. She traded one underground city for another, and her anxiety continued to persist like ghosts that refused to end their torment.

She bit her lip and turned to Winnie. “Do you think there are more like him?”

“Like who, dear?”

Khalani hesitated, not wanting to voice her thoughts, but despite her best efforts, she was unable to let him…*it*…go. “The Governor. Do you think there are more machines like him?”

“There almost certainly are.”

“But where did they come from?” Khalani pressed.

“Winnie doesn’t know.” She squeezed her pencil harder. “Winnie doesn’t recall any records in the Archives mentioning the Governor being anything other than human. But someone had to create the machine and place it in a position of power over an entire city. Winnie suspects the maker is still out there.”

“Here?” She tensed. “In Hermes?”

“Possibly. We must keep our wits about us. The key to finding Prometheus and Project Helix may lie in this very city.”

The path to Project Helix starts at Prometheus.

Those were the words written by Timothy Talbot.

To uncover the truth behind Project Helix—something powerful enough to save humanity—they needed to leave Apollo and find Prometheus. The problem was that they were no closer to understanding what Prometheus was than they’d been when they left Apollo.

They might never discover the truth.

But Winnie still held onto hope. And hope was a stubborn, fickle beast.

“What do you know about Hermes?” Khalani probed, leaning forward. “Why is it so different from Apollo?”

Winnie looked up, pondering the question. “Did Winnie end up reading that book? Let me think… Ah, yes! She did.” Winnie’s face brightened and she clapped her hands together.

“There was a book about Hermes that a Death-Zoner brought back a long time ago. It was written by one of their scholars. Initially, when citizens first descended into Hermes, it was quite similar to Apollo. Dark, dreary, and depressing. However, a wealthy individual who owned casinos before the Great Collapse saw the opportunity for greater riches and built the first casino here.

“It was immensely popular, and it didn’t take much time for the Hermes Council to seize control of the wealth and power the casino generated. The difference in Hermes is that the people here didn’t mind the government taking more control. And the kind of authority that comes from the will of the people is the hardest to dismantle.”

“And the casino?”

“The casino continued to grow, bringing with it all manner of greed and crime. We best hope not to cross paths with one of the deadly gangs in this city.”

Khalani gulped, and Winnie placed a gentle hand on her knee.

“Don’t you worry, Khalani dear. Winnie likes Spade. He’ll take care of us.”

“How can you be so sure, Winnie? We just met him.”

“So? Winnie’s a great judge of character.” She tapped her temple with a sneaky grin, coaxing a faint smile from Khalani.

“What are you writing?” she gestured to the notebook on Winnie’s lap, needing a distraction.

“Oh.” Winnie’s cheeks flushed pink. “Winnie knew she couldn’t bring the typewriter, but she still needs to record our journey somehow. She’s been using this notebook instead.” Winnie smoothed her hands over the cover, and Khalani glanced at the last sentence she’d written.

“And they will venture into the jaws of a casino tomorrow, and Winnie prays they will emerge victorious,” Khalani read aloud.

“It’s not done yet. Winnie will wordsmith to make it better,” Winnie added, suddenly shy.

“I think it sounds great,” Khalani smiled, but she jumped when loud

footsteps descended the stairs, only minutely relaxing when Spade appeared, wearing black slacks and a white button-down shirt.

“Good. The two of you are already up,” he noted, staring at them. “I need you to wake the others and come upstairs.”

“Why?” She frowned.

“There are a few people you need to meet.” Without another word, Spade marched back up the stairs, disappearing from view.

Winnie and Khalani exchanged nervous glances before setting about waking the others. It took several attempts to rouse Serene, but Takeshi was already awake. Khalani noted the dark circles under his eyes, wondering if he’d slept at all.

His face was cold as he bounded up the steps, taking them two at a time.

As Khalani climbed up behind him, she formulated a new plan to deal with Takeshi and her complex emotions.

It was brilliant.

It was called the “*Keep Your Distance Plan.”*

Based on her calculations, it yielded a one hundred percent effectiveness rate, if she followed the protocol.

Keno, the barman in the backroom, stood silently as they emerged, signaling for them to enter the larger bar area. The patrons from the night before had vanished. Spade gestured to a long table that hadn’t been there the previous night.

At the table sat four men in slick suits.

Three of them wore grim and unwelcoming expressions, their shoulders held rigid as Khalani and the others took their seats. The man directly across from her looked younger and had a black bandanna covering the lower half of his face—the only person wearing one—while his brown eyes landed directly on her. She couldn’t help but stiffen under his disarming gaze.

Keno entered the door, rolling his white sleeves to his elbows and sitting down at the end of the table. His expression was displeased as his gaze flittered to the four men, lingering on the masked individual across from her.

Spade sat at the opposite end of the table, folding his hands. “Now that we’re all here, we can begin.”

Begin what?

“We can first start with what the hell you were thinking by bringing

foreigners into our city, Spade? And into the Black Heart, no less," one of the men with thick arms and an oversized belly that touched the wooden table spat.

"Mind your tongue. I'm no foreigner," Brock hissed, leaning forward like he was about to slice the man open with a butter knife.

"Yes, you are, Death-Zoner. You were a part of our group, but you haven't been seen or heard from in months. How do we know you haven't divulged our secrets to Apollo, and you aren't here to steal everything out from under our feet?!" the man roared, while a couple others nodded in agreement.

The masked man remained silent, lounging back in his seat, like he was *bored*.

Brock tensed, moving to stand, but Spade placed a calming hand on his shoulder.

"That's enough, Zenith," Spade snapped at the old man. "Brock was captured in Apollo, and his loyalty to us remains true. He holds my full trust. A word against him is a word against me. Do you still have a problem?"

Zenith swallowed at the unspoken threat.

Even though his eyes burned with unsheathed hostility, his protests ended.

"Good," Spade continued. "Now we can finally get to the reason why we're here. First, we need to understand what's happening in Apollo. You mentioned crop failure and the Apollo government killing your people. Tell us everything."

Adan was the one to lean forward and share what Derek had told them about his findings while working in the Research and Resource labs in Apollo. He spoke of the virus discovered in the crops, which was slowly destroying the entire food supply, the negligence of their leaders, and the mass murder of Apollo's citizens.

When he reached the part about their escape from prison and the Governor's inhuman revelations, an oppressive silence fell over their group.

But the men across the table erupted in disbelief and outrage.

"What do you mean he was a robot?"

"That's impossible," another shouted

"Are you hearing this, Spade?" The third man threw up his hands. "I've never heard such an elaborate lie in my life."

The three men shouted obscenities while the masked man, Keno, and Spade remained conspicuously quiet. The cacophony of voices turned into a dull roar in her head. A faint, high-pitched ring became audible.

Khalani shifted in her chair.

The fluorescent lights appeared too bright. The clothes on her back aggravated her skin. Her breaths shortened as a pair of pale blue eyes appeared in front of her.

“Are you sure you’re asking the right questions?”

“Stop!”

Everyone turned to her in shock as she slammed her palms on the table. Even the masked man in front of her looked up in interest.

“You don’t have to believe us,” she said. “I might not have believed it myself if I didn’t see it with my own eyes. But what Adan said is true. Both our cities have been lying to us about the radiation. Who knows what other secrets they’re hiding—”

“Radiation?” the masked man straightened in his chair, talking for the first time. “Explain.”

“That’s why I was imprisoned,” Brock interjected, glaring at Zenith before continuing. “On my way back to Apollo, I was attacked by people on the surface who weren’t wearing radiation suits. They didn’t look sick at all. When I reported what I saw to the Governor, I was thrown into prison. We traveled to Hermes without protection because the surface is no longer contaminated with radiation. Another government lie.”

Zenith’s jaw was on the floor at this point. The masked man tapped his finger on the table, looking deep in thought.

“It’s true,” Spade chimed in. “When I met them at the Gateway Arch, they weren’t wearing radiation equipment.”

“The poison may not have taken effect yet,” one of the tall, lanky men said.

Khalani clenched her fists, feeling like they were repeatedly slamming against a brick wall.

“But if they’re right,” Keno interrupted for the first time, leaning forward intently, “if their Governor admitted to poisoning the crops and killing innocent civilians, whether he was real or not, it stands to reason that the same could happen here.”

“It already *is* happening here,” Spade snapped, his hands clasped tightly. “You know they’ve been rounding up our people and putting them in

hidden work camps. It must be where they have Jack."

At the mention of Jack, all the men at the other side of the table went rigid, even the quiet masked man. The temperature seemed to drop, and Serene frowned. "Who's Jack?"

At first, no one answered.

She noticed Keno subtly shake his head at Spade, but he ignored him. "Jack is our leader. He was taken by the Dealers a month ago. No one has seen or heard from him since. He was the first of our rebel group, and the one who united us all. He was crucial in negotiating peace between the leading gangs in Hermes." Spade's eyes landed on the masked man, who tilted his head in acknowledgment.

"Who are the Dealers?"

"They're an elite branch of our military. Nasty fuckers who do the dirty jobs the government doesn't want its citizens knowing about. We've heard rumors of a weapon they're building in these hidden camps, but no one who's been there has ever escaped. That's where you come in."

They pulled back, instantly wary.

"What do you mean?"

Spade leaned forward, his expression hardening. "If you plan to return to Apollo and rescue your people from the underground, you'll need manpower and firearms. We can provide that. But first, we need your help rescuing Jack."

Her blood pressure plummeted, not liking the direction this was heading.

"How?" Takeshi's deep voice filtered throughout the room.

"Raziel." Spade inclined his head toward the masked man. "He's the Enforcer of the Aces and can get you in."

Raziel, the masked man, regarded Spade with a contemplative look before shifting his attention to them. "One of the Dealer's owes the Aces a favor. He's informed us that their next target for the camps is a married couple. Mr. and Mrs. Davenhue. The capture is scheduled for tonight. We need two of you, one man and one woman, to pose as the Davenhues and meet the Dealer at the casino. He's agreed to take our doubles to the camp instead. We'll equip you with a special device to track your location. Once inside, you'll locate Jack, and in one week, we'll raid the camp and extract you."

The room fell into silence as they wrapped their heads around the insane plan.

“We just got out of prison.” Adan glared accusingly. “And you want two of us to go back in?”

Raziel nodded, his impassive expression not giving anything away.

“Why will it take a week?” she asked.

“We need that time to assemble the necessary firepower. Overrunning the camp won’t be easy, but we’ll have explosives ready.”

“Why can’t two of your members do it?” Serene demanded.

“It needs to be someone the Dealers don’t recognize. They’ve increased efforts in identifying members of our alliance and the risk is too high if they realize who they captured isn’t in fact the Davenhues. You are our best option.”

Khalani swallowed, struggling to push past the colossal knot in her throat.

“No,” Adan growled. “My sister, Khalani, and Winnie are not bait and are definitely *not* going to this camp.”

“Then you get zero help from us, boy,” Zenith hissed. “Nothing comes for free in Hermes. Everything’s a gamble. Either accept that or leave here empty-handed.”

Raziel nodded. “You must decide now so we can prepare the IDs with your pictures by tonight. Who will it be?”

Serene placed a hand on Khalani’s leg, squeezing.

Khalani blanched, understanding, the silent message.

Serene was going to do it. She’d sacrifice herself so Khalani wouldn’t have to.

More unholy images raged in her mind.

Her parents lying on a cold table. Douglas looking back at her before closing the door.

The walls began to cave in, sliding faster and faster.

“I’ll do it,” Khalani blurted out.

Everyone whipped their heads to her, and she sensed the tendrils of icy anger pouring from Takeshi at the end of the table.

“Khalani.” Serene gripped her arm, pulling her attention. “It doesn’t have to be you.”

“Yes, it does,” she said, ignoring the pang in her chest. If anyone was going to put themselves in danger, it needed to be her. “You know how to steal, but I know how to fight. I have the best shot of getting out of there alive. And I won’t let you put yourself in danger over me.”

Serene’s chin wobbled, tears pricking the corners of her eyes as she shook her head in denial.

Raziel cleared his throat, reminding them that time was of the essence. “And which of the men will it be?”

“Me.”

Khalani closed her eyes, elated and terrified by the person who spoke. There wasn’t even a split second of hesitation from the end of the table. Takeshi’s voice bounded across the room like thunder, not offering room for someone to argue against him.

Brock frowned, his gaze flickering to Serene, but he remained irately silent.

“Alright.” Raziel stood, fastening his suit jacket. “I’ll prepare everything for the drop. Have them ready to go by eight p.m. sharp, Spade.” Raziel bounded out the door without another word, slamming it with a thud.

The silence was deafening.

She felt the blood rush of out her face, only beginning to realize what she’d just signed up for.

“Khalani,” Serene turned to her once more, pleading. “You’ve been through so much. You don’t have to do this. I can go.”

“Or Winnie can.” Winnie grabbed Khalani’s hand. “Winnie would rather something happen to her than to you.”

“No,” she snapped, her voice rising. Khalani drew back slightly when Winnie and Serene flinched, taking a breath to calm herself.

“I will do it. I’ll be fine,” she said with a confidence she didn’t feel.

Khalani had been the one to push for going to the surface, convincing everyone to join her.

It was her time to face the consequences of those actions.

Wanting to be alone, she excused herself to the restroom. Her shoulders slumped against the tile wall as the weight of what she’d just agreed to hit her like a ton of bricks.

She was willingly going back into chains. Heading back to prison with the one man she needed to avoid the most.

They’d escaped once before.

But she couldn’t shake the terrible feeling that this time, they wouldn’t make it out alive.

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18

Those who are naked can still be wearing costumes.

She was going to be killed that very night.

Of that, Khalani was certain.

And it wasn't brooding guards or violent criminals that would do her in. It was the six-inch black heels Spade had left for her, along with a dark red dress draped over the bed.

Spade insisted Khalani needed to look her best at the casino, and in Hermes, that meant showing off as much skin as possible without actually being naked.

The red dress had a plunging V-neck, hugged her waist into impossible proportions, accentuated her hips, and ended mid-thigh—no matter how hard she tried to tug it down.

Khalani rubbed her hands down her legs, more comfortable in her old, abysmal prison uniform.

A light knock sounded at the door.

"Come in." Khalani swallowed, combating the urge to rip the dress off.

Serene popped her head in, eyes widening when she got her first look at Khalani. "Wow. I don't even have words."

"That bad, huh?" Khalani subconsciously rubbed her palms down the thin material that barely covered her nipples.

"No." Serene walked in, still staring at her. "You look incredible. Might actually give the Captain a heart attack."

"I doubt he'll be impressed."

Very little caught Takeshi's attention unless its primary use was for murder.

She still didn't understand why he volunteered for the job.

Perhaps he sensed Khalani's mental instability and didn't trust her to break out of the prison camp alone.

“Spade gave you makeup too?” Serene asked, cutting through her spiraling thoughts, sifting through the other items on the nightstand—a hairbrush and a thin iron tool.

“Yeah. But I’ve never worn any. Don’t really know how to use it,” she admitted, her cheeks flushing.

“I’ll help you.” Serene grabbed the beauty products and gestured for Khalani to sit on the bed.

“No, it’s okay. I don’t need it.”

“You’re right, you don’t need it.” Serene seized her shoulders and forced her to sit. “But when everything’s falling apart around you, you can at least control what you look like when it happens.”

Her knee bobbed up and down as Serene brushed powder over her cheeks and eyes, curling her long brown hair with the strange gold tool. Finally, Serene stepped back, a slow smile spreading across her face.

“Well?” Khalani asked, picking at her nails.

“Come see for yourself.” Serene took her hand and led her to the tiny bathroom, where an oval mirror hung above the sink.

When she was abruptly placed in front of it, Khalani’s mouth parted.

Her wide green eyes were enhanced by smoky eyeshadow and extra-long lashes. Her cheeks were dusted with a rosy tint, and her lips were a deep red, glossy color. Brown hair cascaded in curls just past her breasts, the frizz and tangles smoothed away.

Khalani barely recognized the woman in the mirror, as if she’d borrowed someone else’s skin.

And the longer she stared at herself, the faster her pulse raced.

Stepping into the casino, everyone would surely recognize her as an imposter.

She was the wrong person for this.

She was going to get them all killed.

Serene gripped her hand. “Whatever you’re thinking, stop. You look incredible.”

“I don’t know if I can do this.”

“Listen to me. If it weren’t for you, I would’ve still been stuck in prison. There is no one stronger or defiantly beautiful. *That* is who I see. And it’s about time you started seeing it too.” Serene’s heartfelt words were laced with pure conviction, as if she were testifying to the world.

Blood rushed to Khalani’s chest, and she felt her nose tingling.

“No, no. No crying or else you’ll ruin the makeup.” Serene fanned her face frantically. “I lied. You look like shit and we’re all gonna die.”

A burst of laughter escaped her, and she wiped her nose. “You know, most people would cry at that.”

“I know. But you’re not most people. You’re my best friend.” Serene gave her a conspiratorial wink. “Now, this is what you’re going to do. You’re going to walk through this door with your head held high because you’re a badass criminal. Got it?”

“Since when did you become so bossy?”

“Since no one would listen to me otherwise.”

***

When Khalani emerged upstairs, everyone was waiting for her.

Adan enveloped her in a long embrace, urging her to stay safe, not wanting to let her go. He even suggested dressing up like a girl and going in her place.

“I’ll be fine,” she reassured him, not mentioning how much she wanted to crawl in a hole and disappear.

After months together, the thought of leaving, even briefly, was more daunting than she’d anticipated. But Khalani tucked her emotions away until they were fleeting, masking her fear by pretending it didn’t exist.

Brock stood off to the side, his angry scowl deepening when she passed.

“Any words of wisdom?” she asked.

“Don’t be an embarrassment and die.”

Inspiring words, truly.

With a shake of her head, Khalani approached the front bar where Spade, Takeshi, and Raziel talked in low voices.

Her breath hitched when she got her first glimpse at Takeshi.

The black suit seemed custom-made for his body. The shiny fabric hugged his muscular frame and broad shoulders perfectly, and his slicked black hair was gelled to the side, though a few rebellious strands spilled across his forehead.

He looked like danger in its most irresistible form.

For the first time, she saw the sophisticated man who grew up in Genesis—the last surface city in Apollo that was reserved for the wealthy. But when he glanced her way, his muscles went utterly still, and it was the

deadly Captain who stared back.

His magnetic eyes flared as they swept over her face, past her arms, and down her chest, toward the thin fabric clinging to her ribs and thighs.

His dark stare was a brand, a sword's edge gliding over her skin.

For a moment, his jaw clenched, and Khalani caught a flicker of something unreadable in his gaze before he masked it again. A rush of heat spread to her cheeks as she felt the weight of everyone's gaze on her.

"You're a badass criminal. Got it?"

Serene's words rang in her head like a resounding anthem, helping Khalani square her shoulders and lift her chin.

"I must say that you're a vision." Spade was the first to break the silence.

"You have oddly great taste in dresses," she noted dryly.

"I usually prefer taking them off," Spade shrugged, a sly grin forming on his face. "But you prove why some things should be appreciated first."

By that point, Khalani was certain her face was as red as her dress.

"It's time to go," Takeshi said, his deep voice lower than usual, more animal than man, as his icy gaze drilled through Spade.

Short arms suddenly wrapped around her. Khalani barely kept herself upright as Winnie crashed into her, squeezing her for dear life.

"Khalani, girl. You look so beautiful. Too beautiful to be going to a dangerous place like this. Let Winnie go. She can't stand for you to go without her."

"You know I have to go, Winnie." She hugged her back with all the strength left within her. "But I'll come back to you."

"Pinky promise you'll come home," Winnie insisted, her eyes shining with unrestrained fear as she held up her right pinky.

"Pinky promise?"

"It's a binding contract," Winnie explained. "When you swear on a pinky, it means your life is on the line. If you break that promise, bees will come and sting your eyeballs."

"What's a bee?" She frowned.

"Khalani, give Winnie your pinky," Winnie commanded firmly.

There was no arguing with that tone, so Khalani complied, wrapping her pinky around Winnie's weathered finger. Winnie nodded and cupped her face, pressing a kiss to her forehead.

"Give 'em hell, child."

"And *you*." Winnie whirled on Takeshi, jabbing her pointer finger into

his chest. “You bring her back to Winnie alive. Winnie likes you, but if there’s one scratch on her, she’ll skin you alive and make a cloak out of it.”

Everyone’s jaw hung open, but Takeshi didn’t even flinch at her words. He bowed his head as though Winnie’s threat and the responsibility she entrusted to him weighed heavier than gravity.

“You have my word,” he swore, his voice firm and unwavering. “No one will touch her and escape death.”

Khalani momentarily forgot how to breathe.

Repeat after me: Your enemy threatening to maim others on your behalf is psychotic and troubling.

Winnie seemed satisfied with Takeshi’s promise and nodded, as though anything less would’ve been unacceptable.

“A couple last things.” Raziel stepped forward, the black mask still covering his nose and mouth as he held a strange, thin metal device. “I’m going to administer a shot in your arm. It’s the tracker that will inform us of your location. It’s undetectable and will guide us right to you in a week.”

Raziel approached Takeshi first. Takeshi shrugged out of his jacket and lifted his shirt, exposing the veins in his muscular forearm.

If the shot hurt, he didn’t show it.

When Raziel turned to Khalani, she tensed, but the sting was nothing compared to what she’d experienced in Braderhelm. The tattooed number on her wrist was a testament to her pain.

“You’re ready now.” Raziel nodded. “Let’s go.”

***

Khalani, Takeshi, and Raziel passed numerous shops and bars, their vibrant, pulsating lights drawing her attention as she struggled to maintain her balance in heels on the uneven cobblestone street.

Men openly leered at Khalani, some daring to venture a little closer, but when they caught sight of Takeshi and Raziel’s towering forms, they quickly backed off.

She didn’t miss the way every woman eyed Takeshi with ravenous desire, but he stared straight ahead, ignoring them all.

Raziel prowled forward in his black cape with deadly confidence, and it only took Khalani a few minutes to notice men and women ducking their heads or speeding away at the sight of him.

“How long have you been part of the Aces?” she asked, her eyes narrowing on Raziel.

“My whole life.”

“And what exactly do the Aces…do?”

Raziel paused, looking up as if he were deciding the best way to answer. “We dabble in different business ventures. Trading goods. Collecting payments. Providing assistance around the city. Things like that.”

“Is that why people keep avoiding you and look like they’re afraid of losing their limbs?”

His cheeks slightly upturned. “Chopping off limbs isn’t really my style. It’s too messy. I prefer breaking kneecaps, nicking Achilles tendons, and making them run for a bit.”

Swell. Another crazy man to watch out for.

“It would be easier if you just broke the tibia,” Takeshi remarked, still staring straight ahead.

“But where’s the fun in that?”

“Fair point.”

And now they were bonding over which bones were more suitable for breaking.

Did she have a sign on her back that read, ‘Accepting male companions: Only those who avoid therapy?’

When they turned a sharp corner, her gaze stretched wide.

In the distance, the largest building she’d ever seen loomed. It was dazzling white, with thirty massive golden pillars supporting the grand structure, leading to marble steps and open bronze gates. The awe-inspiring architecture looked more like a grand temple to worship ancient deities.

It was even bigger than the Council Chambers of Apollo.

Hundreds of men and women in impeccable outfits ascended the golden steps, their faces alight with anticipation.

“Is that—”

“Yes. That’s the casino. Be on your guard,” Raziel answered, straightening his suit and marching forward.

Khalani forced her mouth to close, smoothing her hands over her dress. Taking a deep breath, she followed Raziel, ignoring the inner voice that screamed for her to run and never look back.

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19

They became so engrossed with winning,
they forgot to care about those who lost.

After passing through the grand gates of the casino, Khalani entered a lavish golden room that left her speechless. Hundreds of unfamiliar machines covered the red-carpeted floor, surrounded by a sea of eager people who kept pulling levers and pressing flashing buttons.

It seemed like the entire population of Hermes had gathered inside the building.

The air buzzed with boisterous cheers, and she coughed as the thick aroma of cigarettes and clashing perfumes filled her lungs.

The rich opulence covered every facet of the room, down to the tiniest details.

Khalani's gaze lifted to the dome ceiling, captivated by a breathtaking mural that was crafted out of diamonds, rubies, and gold. Her eyes swept over the beautiful angels drifting above shimmering clouds, and she tilted her head back further, losing herself in the image.

"Close your mouth. Don't look like you've never been here," Raziel reprimanded, casting a sidelong glance at her.

"I don't understand," she stammered, looking around in pure awe. "Why are all these people here?"

"The casino is where people gamble."

Her brows knitted in confusion, prompting him to sigh.

"It's where people play games to win money. They wager their own funds, hoping to make more in return. Naturally, the casino has ways to ensure it always wins in the end, but people keep returning every night, trying to recover what they've lost. Some gamble away their housing allowance, money for food, or even their children's education. It's a vicious cycle this place thrives on."

“That’s horrible.”

Raziel shrugged. “Losing is good for business. Desperate people do desperate things.”

Takeshi held himself still as he observed the scene with a quiet intensity, his posture unnervingly rigid.

As they moved deeper into the grand space, the lever machines gave way to tables covered in green felt. Some mid-sized tables were surrounded by people intently studying cards, while others had large crowds cheering as someone threw tiny white blocks across them. Men and women shouted and cheered as if their deepest wishes were being granted.

Her gaze flickered to the intimidating guards lining the walls.

Unlike the guests, they wore black metal vests, visible earpieces, and held guns.

The Dealers.

They surveyed the room like bloodthirsty sharks, the kind Winnie had once mentioned lurked in the ocean.

Khalani ducked her head as Raziel led them to a secluded corner where only a few people were playing on machines, lost in their own world.

One of the Dealers stood with his arms crossed and back against the golden wall. He had a sizable frame, a sharp buzz cut, and a neatly combed mustache. His gaze drifted past Khalani and Takeshi, narrowing on Raziel.

“You’re late,” the Dealer grumbled as Raziel approached.

“If I recall, Sylas, the Aces are always on time. Isn’t that what you meant to say?” Raziel inclined his head, and the subtle threat hung in the air.

Sylas swallowed hard, and after a moment his eyes dropped in concession.

“My mistake,” he muttered.

“Splendid.” Raziel’s voice brightened. “Did you get the files I sent?”

The Dealer shifted uncomfortably as he pulled a screened device from his pocket. “Yes. These the Davenhue’s?” He held up the screen, which displayed Khalani and Takeshi’s faces along with their bios.

Clarence and Mars Davenhue.
Ages twenty-one and twenty-five.
Residents of the Second Quarter.
Owners of a bakery.
No children.

Rebellion Sympathizers.

When did Raziel get pictures of them? Takeshi was even smiling in the photo. *Smiling.*

"In the flesh," Raziel grinned, patting Khalani and Takeshi on the back.

Sylas's gaze darted anxiously between them before he nodded, placing the screened device back in his pocket.

"The drop will happen at two a.m. in the Seven Diamonds Lounge. The Davenhues are expected to be early and intoxicated. The Dealers *can't* sense anything amiss. Do you understand?"

"They understand," Raziel said on their behalf.

The two a.m. deadline was only a couple hours away—two hours before they'd be willingly taken into custody and transported to an unknown camp.

She picked at the skin around her nails, eyeing the exit.

Maybe the Aces knew of some other girl that wanted to be behind bars. If Khalani left now, she might be able to escape…

But Serene and Winnie's faces flashed in her mind, and she relinquished her painful grip, realizing the truth.

The only way back was forward.

"And my debt to the Aces?" Sylas asked, swallowing hard.

"Your debt to the Aces will only be settled once we confirm they're safe in the camp." Raziel crossed his arms. "Any deviation from our plans, and I'll make you pay your debt in full myself."

Sylas's face turned green. "I understand." He glanced around. "I must go. Don't forget, two a.m." He hurried off, vanishing into the crowd without another word.

"Fucking rat," Raziel hissed, glaring after him.

"What do we do now?" she whispered, chafing her fingers against the hem of her dress.

"We have some time. Let's get a drink." Raziel turned without another word and stalked across the room, heading toward a lavish bar decked with silver pillars and a marble counter.

Her feet didn't move. Neither did Takeshi's. They remained rooted in place, staring after their mysterious companion as the clock to their arrest ticked down.

"Why does it feel like we're making a huge mistake?" she voiced.

"Because we likely are."

“And yet, we’re still doing this.”

His black eyes flickered to her, lifting a brow. “Are you having second thoughts?”

She was. But it didn’t matter.

The moment Winnie wrapped Khalani in her arms, there was no turning back.

“No. We keep moving forward, like we always do.”

Khalani stood taller, letting the statement not just be words escaping the tongue but a belief within her mind. She recognized the tingles of anxiety coursing through her stomach, her chest, the tips of her fingers.

But no matter how deep her fears ran, she refused to let those negative thoughts paralyze her any longer. If Khalani was entering chains once more, she was going to do it with her chin lifted to the surface.

Takeshi tilted his head. “Spoken like someone who hasn’t given up fighting.”

She gave him a pointed look. “Who said I ever stopped?”

Without waiting for a response, Khalani started toward the bar. After a few steps, she subtly glanced over her shoulder to see Takeshi still standing there, his brow lowered, but an unmistakable flare of desire ignited in his eyes as Khalani sauntered away.

Like *she* was the one about to set him on fire.

People cast admiring glances at her as she passed, their lewd gazes traversing down her body. Khalani stared straight ahead, gaining more confidence with each step. She sent a silent thank you to Serene for ensuring she didn’t look like a cockroach with red lipstick plastered on.

She felt Takeshi’s presence quietly following in her wake.

Khalani found herself swaying her hips slightly more as she walked, somehow managing not to trip in her heels.

At the bar, Raziel leaned casually on the counter like he owned it. The other guests gave him a wide berth, and the bartender’s face was stiff as he set a glass of amber liquid in front of him.

“What’s your drink?” Raziel asked Khalani.

She sputtered, not knowing what to say.

“For her, nothing,” Takeshi interrupted in a deeper tone as he approached the bar. “I’ll take whatever you have that’s strong.”

“Now just hold on.” Khalani turned on him. “You don’t speak for me.”

“Funny. I just did.”

“You’re hilarious. An absolute riot. Stories should be etched in stone detailing your incredible wit and charm.”

“I know,” he replied, unfazed.

“Has anyone ever told you what your face looks like?”

“I’m not—”

“Punchable,” she cut in, emphasizing the *p*. “That’s what it looks like, and what will happen in two seconds if you don’t move—”

“Are you two done flirting or are you gonna order something?” Raziel interrupted, lazily sipping his drink.

Khalani and Takeshi shifted their disdainful glares to Raziel.

If flirting constituted habitually wanting to rip the other person’s head off, then sure. They were absolute pros.

“Just give me what you’re having,” she grumbled to Raziel.

“You sure? It’s strong. Most girls prefer something sweet.”

“If you can handle it, I can.”

Raziel grinned devilishly. “I’m sure you could—”

“Just get her the fucking drink,” Takeshi snapped, placing his elbows on the counter.

Khalani took a small sip from the silver glass handed to her, praying the alcohol would loosen the tension. When her face twisted and her body shivered, Raziel’s lips curled into a smile.

She didn’t understand why people willingly drank liquor—it was like coating your throat in charcoal and setting it on fire.

But for some reason, she went back for another sip. Because what good was freedom if you didn’t make questionable decisions with it?

Takeshi, on the other hand, downed the entire glass in one gulp, his expression unreadable.

It was impossible to tell whether he enjoyed the drink or despised it. But when his gaze shifted to hers, still tinged with irritation, she detected a subtle flicker of challenge.

Alright then.

She tilted her head back, held her breath, and downed the remaining contents in the glass.

“That’s more like it,” Raziel remarked with a nod of approval.

“It actually doesn’t taste that bad,” she lied in a breathless voice, fighting through the burn.

Both men gave her sidelong glances, like she was full of shit, but Khalani ignored them and walked toward one of the strange machines lined against the wall. It had a white screen with bright, bold-red letters flashing JACKPOT repeatedly.

“How do you play?” she asked.

Raziel smoothly glided over, retrieving a metallic card from his pocket. He tapped it against the screen and instantly, various symbols illuminated and danced across the glass.

“Just pull this lever here,” he explained, pointing to a red stick on the side. “The goal is to line up three of the same symbols in a row. Three jackpots will win you the grand prize.”

She bit her lip and tugged the lever back. The symbols on the screen whirled so fast, her eyes couldn’t keep up. She pulled the lever several times, but none of the symbols matched.

Khalani felt a pang of guilt each time she lost Raziel money, but he merely nodded in encouragement. “Keep going.”

Takeshi came to stand by her side, which only intensified Khalani’s desire to win. She started to grasp how easily you could become ensnared by the casino. To continue pulling the lever, gambling your inhibitions away.

Suddenly, the machine lit up on her next pull, and the sound of jingling coins filled the air as three blue diamonds appeared on the screen.

“I won?” She drew back in shock.

“You did.”

“I won!” Khalani spun with a wide smile, clasping her hands.

Takeshi gave her a smoldering grin. The alcohol warmed her stomach as she noticed the suit accentuating his dark eyes and muscular—

No. Khalani promptly turned back around.

She stared at the blue diamonds shimmering on the screen instead. The color reminded her of something. Or someone. The blue shifted, and icy eyes stared back at her.

She jolted out of her seat.

“What’s wrong?” Raziel stared at Khalani like she’d become possessed. Takeshi moved forward, searching her eyes intently.

“I…I.” Words failed her. Khalani turned back to the machine, but the Governor’s cold gaze had vanished, leaving only the blue diamonds shimmering back.

“Sorry, thought I saw… someone watching us.” She scraped a shaky hand through her hair.

Raziel looked uncertain but cast a watchful gaze around the area to be sure. “There’s no one.”

“Right, right. Silly me,” she joked, even though her vision started to blacken. “I just need another drink.”

Raziel hesitated, like that might be the *last* thing she needed, but he replied, “We’ll get you another one at the lounge. It’s time for us to go.”

She nodded, taking a deep breath and preparing to move on. But a muscle in Takeshi’s jaw ticked. She knew he wanted to pull her aside and demand answers, but she avoided his probing gaze.

For her own sanity, she needed to keep up the pretense that everything was fine.

They navigated another lavish hallway, where women in even more revealing dresses strutted past. When they turned the next corner, there were two large doors blocked off by red rope and three massive guards that looked like they ate humans for breakfast, lunch, and dinner.

Above the black wall, seven diamond-shaped lights sparkled and trembled as a deep bass throbbed beyond the doors. Raziel turned to them, his eyes gleaming with anticipation.

“Welcome to the Seven Diamonds Lounge, the crown jewel of Hermes’ nightlife.”

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If we were meant to be alone, we wouldn't have been given two hands.
One to sustain me, the other to cherish you.

Raziel led them past the line of guests waiting outside and strode directly to the front, his long legs cutting through the crowd with ease.

Some people in line protested, but as soon as they noticed the mask covering Raziel's face, their objections quickly faded, and they found somewhere else to direct their attention.

Women openly ogled Takeshi as he prowled forward with his head held high. One woman, with platinum blonde hair cascading in ringlets to her waist, wearing a nearly transparent black mesh dress, reached out to grab his elbow.

"Hey, baby," she cooed, "Dance with me inside?"

Something hot coiled in Khalani's chest.

Must be remnants of the strong alcohol.

Takeshi didn't respond to the woman. He barely glanced her way. He simply wrenched his arm free with a look of disgust and continued walking, leaving the woman's jaw dangling open.

Khalani couldn't stop the small grin tugging at her lips, even if her life depended on it.

When they reached the velvet red rope, Raziel whispered into the ear of one of the guards. He seemed to pass something quickly, but Khalani couldn't catch what it was. The guard, visibly paler, nodded at Raziel and unclipped the rope, letting them through.

She nervously entered a narrow hallway lit only by a line of fiery torches on either side. The air was thick with smoke that swirled and pulsed with each groan of the deep bass that reverberated along the black walls and pounded inside her chest. Khalani hesitated, worried about a potential fire, but Raziel strode confidently ahead.

The music grew louder and louder as she continued to follow him through the tight, dark space.

When the smoke cleared, they stood in a vibrant, grand room with glass-topped bars lining the perimeter and multiple bartenders serving the throngs of revelers. At the center, a massive dance floor was packed with hundreds of people.

The air was humid, dripping with condensation.

Several cages hung from the ceiling, each containing women in lingerie, shifting and arching in an intricate, sexual dance that had multiple men and women in the room glancing upward, lust heavy in their gazes.

Hanging in the back of the club was a large bronze statue. It depicted a man wearing a suit with outstretched arms, as if he were rousing everyone in the room to stand and worship him.

A chill crawled up her spine.

“Who’s that?” she asked Raziel, her voice barely rising above the music.

Raziel followed her gaze. “That’s Milo Hendrix. He founded the first casino here a couple hundred years ago and helped shape Hermes to what it is today. When he died, the city took over his casino and businesses, but his legacy remains.” He dismissed the statue with a nod and turned to the bar. “Let’s grab a drink.”

She felt Raziel move but her eyes remained locked on the statue. Something about Milo Hendrix seemed familiar.

His inanimate, handsome face smiling over the dancing, sweaty crowd. His outstretched arms reminding her of someone else she met. Someone—

“Kanes.” Takeshi tugged on her arm, pulling her out of her trance.

He flicked his head to the bar, where Raziel was already engaged in conversation with the bartender, who nodded vigorously, sweat beading on his forehead.

When they walked over, Raziel handed them tiny clear glasses filled to the brim with a blue, smoky liquid.

“What’s in this?” she shouted.

“It’s a shot.”

Her eyes bugged out. “An actual bullet is in here?”

Takeshi glared at Raziel, who let out a heavy sigh, like he was dealing with mindless children.

“It’s just a small drink to loosen you both up.” He leaned closer, pulling their shoulders together so no one else could hear. Khalani tried to pull

away, but Raziel's grip was surprisingly firm.

"In case you two forgot," Raziel continued, "You're supposed to be a young couple, married and in love. You two look like you're about to fling the other off a balcony and are so tense that even my blade would have trouble slicing through. If you're going to convince the Dealers that you're indeed the Davenhues, you need to act the part and drink what I give. Especially *you*."

"*Me*?" Khalani reared back. "What did I do?"

"Your face is as gaunt as a playing card, sweetness. Just swallow that down and act like you're enjoying yourself. Remember, this might be your last drink for a while." Raziel raised his glass in a mock toast before sliding it under his mask and downing the contents.

She held the shot nervously, glancing at Takeshi who simply stared at her, waiting.

"Aren't you going to tell me to stop?" she tested.

"Would you listen?"

Fair point.

She raised the glass to her lips, making a soft noise in the back of her throat as she swallowed the liquid in one gulp. Surprisingly, the drink had a sweet aftertaste following the initial burn. Her tongue brushed over her lips, and she felt her muscles release their tension.

Okay, this wasn't so bad.

Her entire life in Apollo had been about suppressing desires and serving the underground city with unwavering loyalty. She'd snuffed her feelings to the point where she convinced herself they no longer existed.

But this night might be Khalani's only chance to reclaim those parts she'd lost.

And if they were about to enter captivity, a few hours of freedom to release her inhibitions might not be terrible.

"Can I have another?" she asked Raziel, a little too eager.

Raziel raised a brow, but a glint of amusement danced in his eyes as he snapped his fingers. The bartender quickly appeared and handed Khalani another smoky glass. Raziel offered one to Takeshi, but he held up his hand, declining.

"You're not going to keep drinking?" she asked Takeshi, who just shook his head, leaning against the bar while his lethal gaze swept the room, assessing every exit and potential threat.

“You’re no fun,” she grumbled, but Takeshi either didn’t hear her or chose to ignore her.

After her fourth round, Khalani’s limbs definitely felt looser.

A tingly sensation rose from her fingertips and everything around her seemed to glow a little brighter. She instinctively swayed to the rhythmic beat and turned her attention to the dance floor.

Bodies shifted against one another like splashes of water. The movement was enticing, and the music pounding against her skin was like nothing she’d heard before.

A woman’s sultry voice began to sing over the speakers. Something about her hypnotic words and thumping bass made Khalani want to join the others on the floor.

In fact, she was going to do just that.

“I’m going to dance,” she declared, not asking for permission.

Takeshi’s head whipped toward her, but Raziel merely chuckled and set down his drink. “Go on ahead. I need to have a quick word with your friend. We’ll watch you from over here.”

Takeshi’s jaw clenched, about to argue, but she wasn’t going to stand around and wait for his inevitable objection. She pivoted on her heels and headed straight for the crowd.

The alcohol warmed her stomach as she maneuvered through the guests, all of them lost in the melodic rhythm. Finding an opening in the center of the floor, Khalani finally stopped.

Elated men and women surrounded her, grinding with partners, pushing their bodies together as if they could become one being.

The air was hot and heavy. Her eardrums felt ready to burst from the beat, and her heart pumped faster. For a moment, she considered returning to the bar, but she steeled herself, letting her body be present.

Feeling the music. Letting the scents invade her nose and her vision absorb everything around her.

Khalani felt her body sway side to side. Her arms slowly uncrossed from her chest. Her fingers began to tap against her thigh in time with the rhythm.

“I know you don’t want me, baby. But I can hold myself better than you.”

The woman’s voice sang over the speaker, and the crowd started to sing, knowing every word, tilting their heads back as if the music was an extension of their souls.

“And I’m better off now, my love. Too bad I can’t say the same for you.”

Khalani’s grin widened as she embraced the freedom around her. Her hips swayed more. Her shoulders loosened.

A short girl in a tight blue dress smiled at her, her eyes bright with encouragement while a man kissed her neck from behind. Khalani lifted her arms, closing her eyes as she surrendered to the erotic beat.

For the first time in memory…she was having fun.

And the thought that made her smile even wider?

Winnie would be proud.

An unknown person approached from behind, placing their hands on her waist. She immediately tensed and turned.

A man with blond hair and a captivating smile stood behind her. He pulled her hips closer, encouraging her to dance with him.

Her first impulse was to push him away, but she forced herself to relax. This was her one night to be a different version of Khalani. She could lose herself in the music like the other girls dancing around her, unburdened by the weight of survival.

She pressed her backside into the stranger, letting herself be free.

Khalani didn’t necessarily enjoy the way his fingers gripped her waist or the hot breaths in her ear, but she closed her eyes, pretending it was someone else.

Suddenly, the man behind her was ripped away.

A loud, powerful punch cut through the music, and before she could react, a stronger, taller figure came up behind her.

Goosebumps prickled her skin despite the heat of the room.

The newcomer’s left hand gently cupped her neck, his thumb resting behind her ear, while his right hand pulled her back against him.

She didn’t need to look to know who it was. Even blindfolded, she would recognize Takeshi by his touch alone. No one else was built like him or radiated this chaotic energy that pulled you in before he carved you apart.

Get another drink, the logical part of her brain said. Get some fresh air. Distance herself from the one person who could eviscerate what was left of her fragile heart. She knew Takeshi would let her go the second she asked him to stop.

But every place his fingers brushed felt as though her skin had never been touched there before. As if her body were a desert to explore.

The music echoed louder in her chest, and she swayed back and forth.

“And you know they can’t stop staring at me. But my eyes were made to look at you.”

His fingers spread across her lower stomach, guiding her movements with his hips.

“*They never believed in us, baby. I dare you to make a believer out of me, too.”*

Her hands stretched to the ceiling as Takeshi grasped her elbows and pulled them behind his neck, fastening her to him. His head bent, and she felt his lips trail gently across her skin.

They didn’t need to speak. Their bodies whispered for them.

As if dancing were another way of saying, ‘Hide from the world with me.’

She let her head fall back against him as he held her close, moving his hand down the front of her body. His strong fingers glided past her exposed collarbone, lingered around her breast, and traced a path down her stomach to the hem of her dress.

She breathed faster, the constant, resonant beat matching her racing heart. Everyone disappeared around them, like they were the only ones standing beneath the surface of the Earth.

Her eyes fluttered open as Takeshi’s fingers moved under her red dress. In front of everyone.

She initially glanced around, a terrifying exhilaration taking over her body, but no one was paying attention. The lights dimmed, and the crowd was lost in their own world of desire and bliss.

Takeshi’s deft fingers hypnotically slid back and forth on her upper thigh. Though the dress still covered her, she felt naked to him, nearly groaning as his finger moved slightly higher, teasing against her skin.

Every moment of pleasure she’d ever experienced couldn’t compare to the thrill and heat she felt in that moment. Takeshi’s mouth grazed her ear, his soft tongue sliding against her, and she bit her lip. When his strong hand gripped her thigh, her neck craned back.

Go higher, she nearly begged.

His touch was an electric current burning her alive. Erasing every previous lover from memory—completely ruining her for any other man.

His fingers caressed her neck, and he whispered in her ear, “Breathe for me, Kanes.”

Her breath hitched as his nails gently scraped against her upper thigh.

She pressed her hips back, arching against him, indifferent to who surrounded them. Raziel was probably watching them from the bar right now, but they were lost in a universe of their own making.

“If I touched you right now, what would I find?” Takeshi whispered. She licked her lips, her mind too scrambled to answer.

“Tell me, Kanes. How soaked are you for me?” His teeth tugged the end of her ear.

She gasped, her core on fire. Khalani was certain that at any moment she’d melt at his feet like a burning candle.

So, she pushed him further. “Not in the slightest.”

His chuckle was laced with darkness, his index finger gradually moving up her thigh, tracing higher and higher.

“I want to put my head between your thighs and swallow all your decadent lies.”

Her lips parted.

The human language shouldn’t be so *dirty*.

So capable of obliterating every sentence that came before.

“Tell me one more thing, Kanes. Tell me that you’re not mine.” Takeshi’s voice lowered, taking on a rougher edge, as if the same anarchy that coursed through her veins flowed into him.

Takeshi embodied the ruin in her life. But he didn’t make her want to run. No. He helped her embrace the terror.

Ignoring Takeshi was like running from the sun.

You could hide from it, but its light would always live on the surface, waiting to burn and show you the boundaries of the world.

She clung to her last thread of sanity and said, “I’m not yours.”

Takeshi tilted her head to look at him, cupping her chin between his thumb and forefinger. She lost herself in a sea of black, when he said,

“I’ll let you keep thinking that.”

She gasped as his finger touched her exactly where she wanted and his mouth found hers, devouring her next breath. Their lips melted together, and his tongue stretched out, dancing with hers like the melody that wrapped around them. His left hand gently gripped her neck, and his right index finger rubbed a circle between her legs, showing her without words whom she belonged to.

And he was right. Khalani was soaked.

She tightened her hands around his neck and kissed him back with equal abandon. The world could've ended in a blaze of fire and terror, and she would've still clung to Takeshi, letting her mouth express what she'd been too afraid to voice.

She must've had a similar effect on Takeshi because he groaned and pulled her closer.

Fuck…he knew what he was doing with his mouth. And his hands.

She was convinced that when God created Takeshi, He accidently poured an entire bottle of attractiveness over him and muttered, "Shit."

Takeshi pulled away, just enough for them to breathe, but he still held her tight, reluctant to let go. The shadows in his eyes intensified, like he wanted to hijack time and extend this moment forever.

Suddenly, Raziel appeared at their side, glancing at Takeshi with a knowing smile, clapping him on the back.

"Well done, Takeshi. You played your part perfectly. Couldn't have done it better myself."

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When we die, are we allowed a do-over?
I’m asking for a friend.

Takeshi glared daggers at Raziel, his whole body tense.

She wrenched herself free from his grasp, staring at him in disbelief. The beat of the music shifted, and the air felt claustrophobic.

She opened her mouth, but no words emerged.

Takeshi didn’t touch or kiss Khalani because he genuinely wanted her. He only did it for the mission. To make the Dealers believe they were truly married and in love.

Takeshi turned to her, the crease in his forehead deepening as he saw nothing but raw heartache and betrayal reflected in her eyes.

He took a step toward her.

She drew back.

“Khalani, it’s not—”

“Mr. and Mrs. Davenhue, you need to come with us.” A deep voice cut through the tension, and several Dealers in sleek black gear formed a tight circle around them, blocking their escape.

Khalani’s eyes met Sylas, the Dealer they met in the casino, but his face was cold and impassive, like they’d never met before. He gripped her arm firmly, while two other guards restrained Takeshi, assuming he was the bigger threat.

Raziel was nowhere to be found, probably preening somewhere that his plan was a terrific success.

“What are you doing?” Takeshi growled. He viciously glared at the Dealer’s tight hold on Khalani, like he was one breath away from ripping it off.

He was a phenomenal actor.

“Let’s go,” Sylas snapped, ignoring Takeshi and pushing Khalani forward. She stumbled on her heels, but he dragged her across the floor.

Once the men and women in the club recognized the Dealers, everyone scrambled out of the way.

Sylas propelled her toward a nondescript backdoor exit. The moment he shoved her outside, the stench of rotting trash and cold metal hit her nose, and her heels slid on the slick alley pavement.

Sylas caught her elbow and abruptly slammed her against the brick wall.

Khalani grunted as Takeshi was shoved against the hard wall beside her. His muscles were clenched tight, his expression a mask of controlled rage. Takeshi turned his head, but Khalani refused to look at him.

All he ever did was make a fool of her. And she was done playing the pawn in his sick games.

In a twisted way, what Takeshi had done was beneficial. The Dealers wouldn’t question their story, and she could concentrate solely on the mission.

And once the week was over, she was severing ties with Takeshi Steele for good.

“We have them,” Sylas said into a small radio. “Bring the rail.”

She frowned as a Dealer approached, pulling something from his back pocket. Before she could react, he jabbed a long needle into her neck.

“Ow!” She flinched, placing a shaky hand to her neck. “What…the…”

She blinked rapidly, but the Dealers seemed to multiply.

Khalani turned to Takeshi, who slumped forward as another guard withdrew a syringe from his neck. Her pulse slowed, and she braced herself against the wall. Her heels melted into the concrete, dragging her down.

Further.

And further.

And further.

She thought she saw Takeshi’s hand reaching toward her, but in the next moment, everything went black.

***

“Hey.”

…

…

…

“Hey!”

Someone kicked her foot, and Khalani jolted awake, gasping. She glanced around, disoriented by the bright white light shining down on her.

A blurry figure stood over her, like a ghost brought back to life.

Khalani wiped her eyes, squinting, assuming she was stuck in a nightmare loop. But the image slowly began to clear, revealing a pale girl dressed in white pants and a long-sleeve white shirt with black buttons down the middle.

The girl staring down had messy blonde hair that reached her waist and sharp facial features that tightened in annoyance. She appeared a few years older than Khalani and had strange metal cuffs wrapped around her wrists.

“You need to get up,” the girl ordered, moving toward an open door. She glanced back once more before adding, “If you’re not outside in two minutes, they’ll shock you.” She gestured to Khalani’s wrists before leaving.

Khalani’s eyes widened as she looked down to see similar metal cuffs around her wrists. She patted her hands down her legs, wearing the same white uniform as the girl.

Her gaze darted around frantically.

The bright room she was in was the size of a large closet. White walls surrounded her with one translucent door that lay partially open.

Thirty-Two.

The blood-red number was plastered above the door.

The cell reminded her of a lab, but much whiter, colder, and reeking of despair.

Khalani turned as an influx of people wearing similar uniforms started walking past her cell, barely glancing her way. Their backs were hunched, eyes gaunt.

A low groaning noise reverberated from her left, and she turned.

Takeshi was in the cell with her.

He lay on his back. The white tunic fit snug around his large frame and the metal cuffs around his wrists were clearly visible. His eyes were firmly

closed, still knocked out from whatever the guards had injected into their necks.

Khalani had a fleeting temptation to leave Takeshi for the electrocution he undeniably deserved. But she was smart enough to know that having the Captain alive was her best shot at escaping.

Her limbs felt like lead, each movement slower than the last as she crawled over to him.

“Wake up.” She nudged his arm.

Silence.

“Takeshi.” She shoved harder. “Wake up!”

No movement. Not even a stir of an eyelid.

She stopped breathing, unable to swallow past the knot in her throat. But then she saw the gradual rise and fall of his chest, and Khalani sighed with relief.

But the instinctive surge of worry only stoked the fire burning in her stomach.

She lifted herself on her knees, leaning over his unconscious frame. It was the first time in a while she’d seen him without a cold scowl. Takeshi’s deathly beautiful face finally looked at peace…

SLAP.

Her hand struck his cheek with much more force than necessary, and Takeshi’s black eyes flew open in shock.

In the next heartbeat, she was flat on her back, and Takeshi was on top of her, his powerful hand clutched around her throat.

Her body locked in panic as he squeezed the life out of her. She stared into his menacing gaze, silently pleading, unable to draw in a single breath.

Finally, Takeshi’s expression shifted, his eyes flooding with horror as he realized what he was doing. He scrambled off her, his face drained of color.

She coughed and sat up, heaving.

“Kanes.” He swallowed, genuinely shaken. “I’m so sorry. I thought you were someone else.”

He reached out, but she slapped his hand away.

“It’s fine. I’ll survive. Unfortunately,” she muttered, brushing herself off with trembling hands.

But the anger refused to settle, flaring every time she met his gaze. Khalani stood, not wanting to be in close quarters with him a second longer.

“We need to go outside. Apparently, they’ll shock us if we don’t.”

She indicated his wrists, but he barely looked at them. His face twisted, like he didn't care about anything else going on around them.

"Are you okay?" His voice was deep and guttural.

"I told you. I'm *fine*."

Khalani turned, shoving the raw pain into the deepest recesses of her heart, and walked through the open doorway of the cell without a backward glance.

The bright, sterile hallway stretched out before her. She followed the few figures hastily walking toward the metal door at the end of the hall, and the hard steps behind let her know that Takeshi was on her heels.

When Khalani exited the building, she emerged into a vast, echoing cavern, her footsteps crunching on gravel. The cavern was so immense it made the pit in Braderhelm seem trivial. Scattered one-story buildings stood in quiet rows, contrasting the cave walls that surrounded them.

On the far side of the cavern stood a discreet black building. It had no windows. No one coming in or out. Something about the structure sent shivers up her spine and made her look away.

A few hundred prisoners lined up in ten straight lines in the center of the cavern. Some had a defiant glint in their eyes, while others stared vacantly at the ground, as if hope had long abandoned them.

"Excuse me?" She walked up to a young man with greasy brown hair. "Why's everyone standing here?"

He barely glanced at her, grunting dismissively.

Okay then.

A firm grip on her arm suddenly yanked her forward. Her mouth popped open as the girl who'd entered her cell earlier dragged her to a spot at the end of the line.

"Line up here," the mysterious girl directed, then turned to Takeshi. "You too."

Takeshi narrowed his gaze, not used to taking orders, but he begrudgingly moved behind Khalani, watching everyone with a distrustful eye.

"What happens now?" Khalani turned to ask the girl, but she'd already disappeared further up the line.

Khalani took a deep breath and shifted back and forth, tingly nerves coursing through her limbs.

After a few minutes, the Dealers started inspecting the prisoners. They used batons to strike anyone not standing straight enough or who were slightly out of position. One of the Dealer's scrutinized her in a way that made Khalani's insides crawl, but he slyly smirked before moving on.

A blaring alarm suddenly echoed throughout the cavern. A Dealer with stars on the lapels of his brown uniform barked, "Kneel before Dr. Strauss."

Like a thunderclap, everyone around her immediately dropped to the ground. Khalani glanced around in confusion but quickly followed suit, grimacing as the gravel dug into her knees.

A man appeared in front of the prisoners.

He was short, pale, had white hair that looked like patches of clouds on his head, and he wore a white medical cloak. He slowly walked down the row of prisoners, flanked by two Dealers.

His expression held an unsettling air of detachment as he shifted his focus between each kneeling inmate, holding a clipboard tight by his side.

A suffocating pressure overcame the space. She detected the fresh stench of urine from the girl to her left. Everyone held themselves completely still, breaths shallow, as if even the slightest movement might draw Dr. Strauss' attention.

Who was this man that commanded such terror?

Dr. Strauss continued down her line, a disturbing, maniacal gleam in his gaze. Without warning, his measured steps came to a halt a few feet away, and she kept her eyes trained on the floor, barely breathing.

"Him," Dr. Strauss said in a cold voice and pointed to the man kneeling in front of her.

"No! You can't take me!" The skinny man in front of her lunged to his feet, only to collapse back to his knees, trembling uncontrollably as he clutched the metal bracelets encircling his wrists.

Despite the Dealers' attempts to subdue him, he writhed and struggled with every ounce of strength left in his body.

"*I'm not going into that building*!" he screamed at the top of his lungs.

One of the guards responded by bashing him across the face with a baton. The prisoner slumped to the ground, unconscious.

Dr. Strauss' glare narrowed with pulsing fury. He marched right up to the guard with the baton and slapped him across the face, the crack echoing around the cavern.

“I’ve told you not to touch their heads, you imbecile. Do that again and you’ll be taking his place,” he warned, and the Dealer went white as paper.

“Yes, Dr. Strauss.” He lowered his head in submission, his left hand trembling at his side.

“Take him.” The doctor flicked his head, and two Dealers hoisted the unconscious man under his armpits and dragged him away. Every prisoner stayed completely frozen and silent.

Dr. Strauss clenched his fists as he stared at the empty spot the man left in front of her.

Then, his gaze flickered to her.

She tensed on instinct, her heart battering like a drum. The mysterious doctor kept an eye on her, and she held her breath, silently praying to turn invisible, but without another word, Dr. Strauss turned and walked toward the austere black building.

“Stand!” the Dealer with the golden stars on his uniform yelled.

The prisoners scrambled to their feet, and the collective sighs of relief were audible. The young man to her right blinked, tears streaking down his cheeks as he stared at the empty space the prisoner had occupied.

Like he knew he’d never see him again.

Initially, Khalani had thought the camp was for rebellion sympathizers, but she couldn’t shake the feeling that something more sinister was at play.

“Report to the tunnels!”

The prisoners started shuffling to the left of the cavern, flanked by a dozen Dealers. Khalani caught Takeshi’s eye. His face was set in ruthless determination, but his body remained rigid, as if he were just realizing how much danger they were truly in.

“Let’s go.” He nudged her forward.

“What do you think’s in there?” she whispered, her gaze fixed on the black building.

“I don’t intend to find out.” Takeshi’s voice took on a hard edge. “We need to focus on locating Jack and getting the fuck out of here.”

They followed the crowd of prisoners into a large tunnel with mining tracks running along the rocky floor.

The ceiling was about ten feet high, illuminated by sparse yellow headlights hung at various points. When they passed a large metal bin, prisoners reached inside and grabbed pickaxes.

Khalani pursed her lips but grabbed one too, noticing that the guards tightened their grips around their guns.

“Get working!”

With a collective groan, the prisoners lined up and swung their pickaxes at the orange rock wall.

No.

She had to be living in a sick cosmic joke.

God hated her. That’s what it was.

She barely escaped Braderhelm Prison only to find herself back in another underground prison, doing hard labor in tunnels.

Why didn’t they believe in tasks like cleaning dishes?

And what was scarier was that the prisoners seemed to prefer the arduous mining to whatever horrors awaited in the black building.

When she didn’t move quick enough, one of the guards ventured closer, pressing a red button on a handheld device.

A sharp, electrifying pain sliced through her wrists, and she collapsed to her knees, twitching uncontrollably. The muscles in her neck held tight and her teeth clamped together, fighting the scream building in her throat.

“When we say go, you do it faster. Understand?” The guard’s face was beat red, and spit flew from his mouth.

Takeshi shouted something, lunging forward, but the guard shocked him too. He hunched over, sweat beading on his forehead, muscles trembling as the other prisoners kept pounding away at the walls.

When the electric pulses finally relented, Khalani sucked in a sharp breath, her limbs still shaking on the ground, tasting metal on her tongue.

“Start working, or I’ll triple the voltage next time,” the guard threatened, glaring at both her and Takeshi with disdain.

She braced herself against the rocky floor, struggling to stand, but she ignored Takeshi’s hand for help.

Khalani could handle this without him. She could.

All she had to do was last one week.

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Peer closer and you’ll see all the battles buried in my skin.

Khalani lost all sense of time as they worked. She let the quiet rage fuel her, every echoing slam of metal building into a war cry. Beside her, Takeshi’s pickaxe crashed against the wall, a deep-seated wrath lying beneath his eyes.

Despite her protests, he deliberately took the heavier rocks from her, leaving Khalani the lighter ones to place into the nearby carts. She didn’t miss his white-knuckled grip on the pickaxe.

When a shrill whistle cut through the air, all the prisoners bent over, hands on their knees, panting heavily as they struggled to catch their breath. But Khalani and Takeshi stood tall as they exited the tunnel, accustomed to living in harsh conditions.

“Get in line,” one of the Dealer’s barked as they re-entered the expansive cavern.

Now that the effects of the injection had worn off, she was able to focus on the area around her and get a clearer view of the prison.

The cavern’s ceiling loomed thirty feet overhead, with several large, spiky stalactites hanging ominously. They looked one whisper away from skewering whoever was unfortunate enough to stand underneath.

Bright white lights hung from the four corners of the cavern, casting a harsh glare on them. Ten buildings dotted the cavern. To her right were five white rectangular buildings that appeared to house all the prisoners.

To her left were three large brown buildings, the Dealers moving in and out of them like clockwork. Directly ahead was a small, discreet grey structure, and in the corner, atop a ledge, stood the mysterious black building where Dr. Strauss had vanished.

The only exit appeared to be a long tunnel on the far side of the cavern, where several Dealers were posted.

Nothing in the vast space gave any indication to where the prison camp was located.

For all Khalani knew, they might not even be *in* Hermes anymore.

Most of the prisoners shuffled into line with unsteady gaits, their hands covered in open blisters. At the front, two men used ladles to scoop a murky, brownish liquid into bowls.

Her stomach growled, and just as she slipped into line, a rough jostle from behind nearly sent her flying.

The thin prisoner who bumped into her didn't offer an apology. The middle-aged woman simply shuffled forward, nearly shaking in anticipation.

When Takeshi pulled Khalani back, a smaller prisoner protested, "No cutting!"

Takeshi turned, fixing the man with a glare so blistering it could melt ice. The prisoner's mouth snapped shut, and he quickly found another spot in line to stand.

Khalani bit her lip and faced forward, begrudgingly recognizing the advantage of having Takeshi by her side. For now.

It didn't make her any less tempted to activate his shock cuffs, though.

When she reached the front, she studied the two men distributing the food. Their hair was closely shaven, and they wore slim, grey uniforms that covered their entire bodies, including their necks.

But their expressions were too blank. Too empty as they mindlessly scooped food.

"What's in this?" she dared to ask.

The two men didn't speak. One of them slid his empty focus past Khalani, as if she didn't exist, and stiffly handed her the bowl. The other looked directly at her, but his gaze was lifeless.

She swallowed, hands trembling as she grabbed the bowl and swiftly drew back.

"We have to find Jack and get out of here," Khalani whispered to Takeshi. "Did Raziel give you any indication of who he might be?"

Takeshi shook his head.

Prisoners were scattered around the cavern, some eating alone while others huddled in small groups. Just as Khalani was about to find an empty spot to sit, she noticed the girl who'd helped them earlier sitting against the rock wall beside an older man, possibly the oldest man in the camp.

“Let’s go over here. She might be able to help,” Khalani said.

Takeshi’s gaze narrowed, no doubt preferring to maintain his distance from everyone, but he nodded and stuck close, clutching his bowl like he was prepared to break someone’s jaw with it.

The girl from earlier had her blonde hair pulled up into a disheveled ponytail as she sipped the food. Beside her sat the old man, his grey goatee and wrinkled skin matching his hunched over, frail back. His veiny hands trembled as he clutched his bowl, some of the liquid dribbling onto his beard.

When Takeshi’s and Khalani’s shadow fell over them, the girl glanced up with a deep frown, setting her bowl down cautiously.

“Can we sit with you?” Khalani spoke first.

The girl’s lips set in a thin line, her calculating gaze shifting between Khalani and Takeshi. The silence stretched on as the old man stared at his hands, admiring the silver ring on his finger, petting it adoringly.

“I don’t know,” the girl started. “He doesn’t look very friendly.” She pointed at Takeshi.

“He is,” Khalani lied with a forced smile.

“I’m not,” Takeshi responded at the same time.

Khalani shot him a glare that spoke of imminent murder, but Takeshi simply yawned. *Yawned*.

But the girl seemed pleasantly surprised by his honesty and snorted. “Me neither. Have a seat.”

“Thanks.” Khalani quickly sank to the ground before the girl could change her mind. “Do you mind if I ask why you helped us earlier?”

The girl waved her hand dismissively. “That was only because I didn’t want to hear you scream and break your vocal cords when they shocked you for missing Dr. Strauss’ inspection.”

Khalani gulped, brushing her hand along the metal cuffs. “How the hell do we get these things off?”

“You can’t. If you try removing them without the right device, they’ll pierce your wrists with metal shards. You won’t die immediately, but you’ll bleed out over several hours. I’ve seen it happen.”

Takeshi set his bowl down. Harder than necessary, his forearms bulging. Apparently, that put a wrinkle in the alternative escape plans he was no doubt brewing.

“What’s your name?” Khalani asked.

The girl didn’t answer right away. The awkward silence stretched forever, but whatever the girl found in Khalani’s eyes must’ve satisfied her, because she answered.

“I’m Elise. This is my father, Clyde.” She turned to the old man, her eyes softening. “Dad, can you say hi?”

Clyde stared at the ground, mumbling over and over, “Key. Ring. Save. Key. Ring. Save.”

Elise heaved a deep sigh, the crestfallen expression apparent on her face as she mumbled, “Sorry. My dad’s not feeling the best these days. What about you?”

“I’m Khalani. This is Takeshi,” she said, absently tilting her head toward him, forcing a smile. Takeshi, on the other hand, offered his all-time favorite greeting—a long, uncomfortable glare.

“How long have you both been here?” Khalani cut in, trying to steer the conversation away from themselves.

Elise glanced up in thought. “It’s hard to keep track of time down here, but I’d say at least a couple months. When we first arrived, there weren’t many people, but they’ve brought a lot more over the past few weeks.”

Khalani shifted forward, forgetting her bowl. “Why are you—why are *we* here?”

“Some prisoners have theories, but no one really knows. I was at home, making food for my dad when the Dealers barged in. They said they only wanted me, but I made such a fuss—punching and scratching multiple officers—that they took my dad too, as punishment.” Elise’s voice hardened at the end, her fists clenching.

A response lodged deep in Khalani’s throat. The thought of someone like Winnie being brought there because of her actions, forced into the worst conditions every day…she might’ve ended everything herself to escape the guilt.

“What theories?” Takeshi leaned forward intently.

Elise’s eyes still held a steely edge, but she explained, “Some think we’re mining copper for new electrical devices in Hermes. Others believe the gangs ordered hits on the prisoners and making us disappear is the Dealers way of maintaining control. The best one I’ve heard is that the prison will eventually be used as a fertility camp and they’ll make us fuck each other, have kids, and brainwash us. So, like I said, there’s a bunch of

crazy ideas but no solid answer yet. Try asking the Dealers and they'll just shock you. They love doing that."

"Key. Ring. Save. Key. Ring. Save," Elise's father kept mumbling against the backdrop of despair.

Suddenly a distant scream pierced the air.

Khalani lifted her head, scanning the cavern to pinpoint the source.

Her attention fixed on the ominous black building across the expanse.

"What happens over there?" she asked, her voice tight as the building seemed to stare back at her.

Elise's face paled as she followed Khalani's gaze, her expression turning grave.

"Listen to me, both of you." She turned back, her voice low and urgent. "If you want to survive, stay as far from that building as you can."

"Why? Who is that man from inspection? Dr. Strauss? What will happen to the prisoner they took this morning?"

"Key. Ring. Save. Key. Ring. Save." Clyde spoke a little louder, his eyes widening as he stared at the floor like it was about to rip open and swallow him whole.

Elise placed a calming hand on her father, cooing gently, "It's okay, Dad. It's okay. I'm here."

Clyde's shoulders slumped and he leaned into his daughter, his repeated words slowly becoming a faint murmur. Elise drew a deep breath, steadying herself before speaking.

"Dr. Strauss is the biggest mystery in this wretched place. He's the camp's undisputed leader, but no one knows much about him. We only see him in the morning for inspection where he always picks one prisoner to be taken. He stays in that building all day, doing God knows what. All I know is that whoever goes inside doesn't come out."

The gravity of Elise's warning sank in as Khalani glanced back at the building.

"Hey." Elise snapped her fingers, grabbing her attention. "Don't even look over there. There are cameras all over, and I just know that psychopath of a doctor is watching us. If you want to survive, keep your head down, do the chores they require of you, don't piss off the other prisoners, and never, *ever*, go near that building."

Khalani agreed. But as she sat there, forcing herself not to peek at the black structure, she felt an unsettling pull, a magnetic force looking back at

her across the expanse.

Takeshi continued to shoot her wary looks, but she ignored him, counting down the seconds to the end of the week.

604,800…

604,799…

604,798…

A loud bang interrupted her counting. Her brows furrowed as a couple of Dealers placed two large red bins in the center of the cavern, twenty feet apart. The scene grew even stranger when they haphazardly tossed a yellow ball onto the ground.

Prisoners began to rise, dusting off their uniforms. Some approached the ball, lips turned down and their expressions grim, as if they'd rather tear off their own skin and vanish rather stand there.

Another smaller group of prisoners ventured toward the grey building, where Elise said the showers were located. They were open showers, with no rules against men and women bathing together. Because of that, Khalani doubted she'd be showering that entire week.

The rest of the prisoners gathered toward the back of the cavern, forming a large crowd. When a few cheers echoed back to them, Elise snorted.

"Jack must be up again."

"What did you just say?" Khalani whipped her head.

Elise gave her a confused look. "I said Jack must be fighting tonight."

"What do you mean, 'fighting'?"

"A few months back, a bunch of prisoners committed suicide with the pickaxes," Elise explained. "That's when they started putting out bins for stupid ball games at the end of the day. When that didn't work, they let the prisoners vent their anger by fighting each other. They still get suicides, but you'd be surprised what a little bloodshed does for morale. Dirty bastards ate it up."

Khalani and Takeshi stood at the same time.

"Well, I can't blame you for wanting to see. Nothing else to do," Elise remarked in a bored voice before turning to Clyde. "Dad, you alright here?"

"Key. Ring. Save. Key. Ring. Save."

"Okay, you're fine." Elise rose and joined Takeshi and Khalani as they walked toward the group of prisoners.

The fighting area didn't attract as much pandemonium as the pit in Braderhelm, but they still had to weave through layers of white-uniformed

prisoners to reach the front.

The task became much easier with Takeshi pushing people aside. Standing nearly a foot taller than everyone, the other prisoners needed only one look at the cold promise of death in his eyes before instinctively stepping aside.

When they reached the front of the line, two men were fighting in the middle of the circle. There was no pit, just a gravel floor and a circular wall of prisoners staring into the center with a mix of anger, excitement, and bloodlust in their gazes.

She flinched when one of the men took a hard punch. He dropped to his knees, shaggy brown hair falling to his shoulders and a scraggly beard that desperately needed shaving.

The other fighter stood tall, with sandy grey hair. He appeared to be in his forties, a determined glint in his eyes, a confident demeanor, and a strong build that filled out his white uniform.

The shaggy man struggled to his feet, throwing a flurry of punches, noticeably off-balance.

The middle-aged man dodged them with ease, landing another hard clip to the ear before tripping the man so he landed face-first on the gravel. The man groaned, blood pouring from his nose.

Her gaze lingered on the crimson liquid, raw violence fueling her adrenaline.

“Finish him, Jack!” several prisoners shouted.

Without thinking, Khalani gripped Takeshi’s wrist.

Jack. The middle-aged man was Jack!

Jack stared down at the broken man, utterly silent against the cacophony of voices that urged him to inflict more damage. He squared his shoulders, not even breaking a sweat from the fight.

Everyone studied him intently, waiting for his next move.

From what she knew of men with power, he’d likely deliver further punishment so no one would question his authority—

“Someone take him to his cell and help clean him up,” Jack ordered, striding through the crowd without looking back.

He disappeared behind a line of people, and she panicked, moving to follow, but an alarm rang out across the cavern.

“Break is over,” a voice crackled over the speaker. “Return to your cells immediately or face electrocution.”

“Shit.” Khalani stood on her tiptoes, trying to spot Jack, but the crowd closed in around her, pushing everyone toward the white buildings.

“C’mon.” Takeshi said in a low voice. “We’ll find him tomorrow.”

Frustrated, she glared at the back of his head but let Takeshi guide her through the crowd. They walked to cell thirty-two in tense silence, and once they stepped inside, the clear doors automatically closed.

“Great,” she huffed, facing the transparent barrier. “This is just perfect.”

Takeshi sat with his back against the wall, his left knee propped up and the other leg stretched out. The cell was so small that his boot nearly touched the wall.

“What’s the matter, Kanes? We’re in the camp we’re supposed to be in, and we’ve already located Jack. I say we’re making good progress.”

“I’m not talking about that.” She whirled, letting the full force of her fury hit him for the first time. “When I agreed to this mission, I didn’t know that I would have to share a tiny cell with *you* for a whole week.”

Takeshi studied her for a long moment, his expression unreadable. “Are you angry, Kanes?”

She scoffed. “Gee, I don’t know. Whatever gave you that impression, Takeshi?”

“This is about the club, isn’t it?”

The pressure in her heart built like a cave-in, painfully replaying the harsh truths she never wanted to face.

Takeshi said it himself.

She liked people that hurt her.

That dark, twisted side of her still existed. The part that attracted what you believed you deserved and brought you closer to destruction.

Back in the underground, she re-learned the hardest truth. No matter how hard you try, you can’t change anyone but yourself.

“You played me,” she stated.

Takeshi shook his head adamantly. “That’s not what happened.”

“Did Raziel not instruct you to go out on the dance floor and feel me up? To make it seem like we were in love?”

“He did, but—”

“There is no but!” she yelled. “You took advantage of my feelings and made me look like a fool.”

Takeshi’s charcoal eyes simmered, his expression contorting with darker emotions as he moved closer, taking up the remaining space.

“Do you seriously believe you’re the only one with feelings?”

Khalani froze. She held up a hand, making sure he didn’t take another step closer. “Don’t. Don’t you fucking dare. You don’t get to say that.”

“Why not?” he seethed. “Because you don’t want to hear the truth? You want to believe you’re the only one who cares? That you’re the only one whose heart is ruined?”

“You don’t have a heart, Takeshi!”

Takeshi went utterly still.

Raw hurt flashed across his face. Like the cuffs around his wrists activated and pierced him with a thousand lightning bolts.

Her own chest tightened, nausea building up in her throat.

She’d never seen his expression hold so much pain. Not even in their worst moments.

“Takeshi…I don’t…I didn’t mean—”

“It’s okay, Kanes.” Takeshi quickly composed himself, but the deep wells of misery lingered in the hollow lines beneath his eyes, the tension in his jaw, and the stiffness of his muscles.

It was as if every part of him fought to keep from spiraling out of control.

“You have every right to feel that way. And you’re probably right.” His voice lowered. “My actions hurt you. And you’re the last person I want to hurt. You deserve so much better than this.” He gestured to the cell around them.

But she believed the thing he was really pointing at was himself.

Her chin trembled, tears aching to fall.

It felt like the world was stacked against them.

And no matter how bad they fought. No matter how much they fit together in all the best and worst ways, it seemed like they were destined to crumble and fall apart.

Because he was saddled with the same capacity for self-destruction that shaped her.

She sniffed, struggling to contain her emotions, unable to meet Takeshi’s gaze. He looked past her shoulder, not able to quite look at her either.

“I didn’t want to end like this,” she whispered, her body held taut, summoning all the willpower left within her to stay strong.

Because that’s what was important. What was *needed*.

But she wished she didn’t *have* to be strong.

Sometimes…it would be nice to be weak.

“I didn’t either,” he admitted in a low voice.

It felt like an entire book wouldn’t be able to encapsulate their relationship. The anger, the yearning, the angst, the respect, the pain in letting go.

He lived in a million phrases.

But all she ever wanted to hear was one.

Silence stretched between them, and she was about to ask one last question when the lights suddenly shut off, plunging them into complete darkness.

“We should get some sleep.” He ran a hand through his black locks. “Big day tomorrow.”

“Yeah,” she replied absentmindedly at the reminder, completely numb.

They lay down on opposite sides of the cell. Worlds apart. Her hands folded beneath her, and she stared at the wall, wishing she could rewind time.

“Takeshi?”

“Yeah, Kanes?” His deep voice stroked against her skin.

“I just want you to know that what I said before wasn’t true. I know you have a heart.”

“Kanes, you don’t have to—”

“No, I do,” she interrupted, needing him to understand. Khalani wouldn’t find closure unless she spoke her truth. “I *know* you have the biggest heart, because in another story, I would’ve wanted you to be my ending.”

Takeshi didn’t speak for the longest time.

The old Khalani would’ve regretted those words the moment they left her mouth, but she didn’t.

Her feelings reminded her that she was still human.

And like a candle flickering in the dark, Takeshi let his bleeding heart spill on the floor next to hers.

“In another story, you would’ve been my beginning.”

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23

Release me from myself.

Khalani dreamt of warmth brushing against her skin, the kind of heat that embraces you after a trying day.

Her bare feet cascaded through fresh dirt. A soft smile unfurled on her lips as she wandered through a beautiful garden. The tips of her fingers brushed along petals of colorful flowers that smiled back at her.

If she'd ever lived on the surface, Khalani imagined she would've had a garden just like this.

Laughter, bright and carefree, echoed through the air, drawing her gaze. A little girl with two brown braids ran past her, waving and giggling under the sunlight. Khalani waved back, but the girl suddenly turned toward the distant city that was filled with towering skyscrapers.

Then, a streak cut through the clouds, like a fallen star tumbling from the heavens. Khalani's gaze snapped to the city.

One moment, everything was normal. The flower petals continued to brush against her skin, and the pleasant smile remained on her face. A split second later, blinding white light eclipsed her vision.

She covered her eyes, but the flash was so intense, so overpowering, that the bones in her hands became visible.

When the light died down, she uncovered her face, and her mouth gaped open. A massive mushroom cloud billowed from the city, like an abomination reaching out to swallow everything in its wake.

Khalani scrambled backward as the little girl vanished into thin air. Panic clawed at her throat when she realized the once-vibrant garden was now engulfed in flames.

Someone came to stand beside her. Tall. Masculine.

Her body froze in shock when Governor Huxley gazed upon the destruction with her.

“You know you can’t stop it from happening again,” he said.

Her heart dropped as the flames crept closer, the heat expanding and stretching toward her legs, *burning* her skin…

Khalani gasped and sat up, her hands trembling as she rubbed them up and down her thighs furiously.

“Hey.” Takeshi was in the corner of the cell, sleeves rolled up. His brows pinched together as he saw the panic in her eyes, and he immediately moved toward her, crouching down. “What’s wrong, Kanes?”

Just a nightmare.

Just a nightmare.

Khalani’s chest heaved with each shallow breath, desperately repeating the mantra.

The alarm shrieked throughout the barracks. With a whoosh, the clear door to their cell opened. Prisoners began filing out for morning inspection, and she tried to stand, but Takeshi tugged her back down, his stormy gaze piercing through her.

“Don’t worry about me. I’m fine,” Khalani emphatically stated, nearly convincing herself it was true.

But Takeshi’s scowl deepened, not buying a single word.

“Let’s go!” one of the Dealer’s yelled.

With a curse, Takeshi helped Khalani to her feet. Just as she turned to leave, he spun her around, leaning down.

“Don’t push yourself today.”

“When do I ever do that?” she attempted a light laugh, but Takeshi’s hard gaze narrowed.

“I mean it, Kanes.”

“Yeah, yeah. I’ll try not to stab myself with a pickaxe.”

Khalani thought she heard Takeshi mutter something about tying her up in the cell and leaving her there as they exited the building.

In the expansive cavern, they took their place in the long line of prisoners awaiting inspection. The Dealers prowled through each section, occasionally striking out with their batons or activating the shock cuffs around the inmates’ wrists.

After several minutes, the high-pitched alarm blared, and everyone around her stiffened as Dr. Strauss appeared.

But this time, he wasn’t alone.

Shocked murmurs spread among the prisoners when they saw the inmate

Dr. Strauss had taken out of line yesterday, now standing directly beside him.

The male prisoner stood as tall as the Dealers, without a scratch on him. But his face was chalky pale, his cheeks were gaunt, and the light in his eyes had dissipated.

“Good morning, ladies and gentlemen.” Dr. Strauss proclaimed. “How are we doing this fine morning?”

No one answered.

“That well, huh?” He laughed maniacally, chilling the already cool air.

“Seems we may need to increase our efforts to make you all more productive members of our society. And if you behave well, like this man here,” Dr Strauss gestured to the expressionless prisoner beside him, “maybe it will be less painful for you, too.”

With a nod, the prisoner stepped forward, joining the line of inmates, like he was still one of them.

Her insides prickled as one of the large, burly prisoners stepped out of line.

“When are you going to release us and send us back to our families?” he yelled, the loud tenor echoing across the vast space.

A few Dealers rushed forward, weapons drawn, but Dr. Strauss held up a hand, halting them.

“What is your name?” Dr. Strauss chuckled as he stepped forward.

“Dennis,” the man growled.

Dr. Strauss glanced down at his clipboard, jotting down a note. “Well, Dennis, you ask a great question. And lucky for you, I have an answer. You’ll all leave these walls and return to your families when you are ready.” He paused. “And clearly, you’re not quite there yet.”

Dr. Strauss made a hand gesture and Dennis began to seize, collapsing to the ground. Two Dealers grabbed his trembling body, dragging Dennis across the gravel toward the black building.

Dr. Strauss watched the scene with a smirk playing on his lips.

Silence reigned over the remaining prisoners.

They were afraid to breathe. Afraid to move even an inch.

After Dr. Strauss finally left the inspection area and retreated to his den of nightmares—her new name for it—a Dealer barked, “Get going to the mines!”

As Khalani and Takeshi trudged forward, she noticed a few men

approaching the prisoner Dr. Strauss had taken the day before.

"Reno…Reno, are you okay?" someone asked.

"What the hell happened in there, man?"

"What did Strauss do to you?"

Reno didn't respond. It was as if he couldn't see or hear. Like he was looking *through* them instead of at them.

Reno turned away, ignoring the multiple questions and walked toward the mine, arms barely swaying by his side.

She rubbed her arms, trying to shake off the dread that refused to be expelled.

"This is bad," Takeshi murmured beside her, focusing on Reno's retreating form.

Understatement of the century.

"What did they do to him?"

"Nothing good, I can tell you that," Takeshi glared in the direction Dr. Strauss had left but shot her a determined look. "We have to make progress today."

She nodded, struggling to pull her gaze away from the building, knowing she needed to stay away. But a part of her almost wanted to peer inside and witness the true horrors that lay in the dark.

***

Khalani was lucky her calluses had been so built up.

She swung the pickaxe harder against the sheer rock, wincing as she noticed other prisoners' hands leaking blood onto their tools. The moans of pain echoed around her like a chorus, but she kept pushing on.

Her eyes kept straying to Reno, who was the epitome of a perfect worker.

He didn't talk to anyone. Didn't complain. Didn't tire.

He wielded the pickaxe like he was born with it, working like a madman.

After several grueling hours, her arms begged to be sliced off. She could barely feel her fingers when the guards signaled for them to get food and water.

She watched Reno leave, barely breaking a sweat. The dead look in his eyes only made her more furiously determined to find Jack and escape.

Takeshi must have been on the same wavelength because he pointed

toward the back of the cavern, his sharp eyes honing in on someone.

“There.”

She turned to see Jack sitting next to another prisoner with short, spiky black hair and geometric tattoos covering his neck and hands.

Without hesitation, Khalani and Takeshi made their way forward, ignoring the curious stares from the other prisoners.

“Mind if we sit?” Khalani asked, clutching her bowl tightly as they approached Jack.

“Yes,” the spikey-haired guy prisoner said, barely glancing at her as he devoured his food. He couldn’t have been much older than Khalani but something in his posture made her want to grab a knife.

An untethered tension radiated from him. Slippery. Dangerous.

“Why do you want to sit here?” Jack studied Takeshi with a measured gaze before fixing his attention on Khalani.

“I think we have some mutual friends. They like to gamble—”

“Everyone likes to gamble,” the spiky-haired man interrupted in a harsh voice.

“And they have *black hearts*,” she emphasized, remembering the name of their hide-out.

Jack froze. The other man’s mouth clamped shut, but his glare remained.

“Have a seat,” Jack said coolly, crossing his arms.

Khalani and Takeshi sat on the stone floor, their backs ramrod straight, while Jack and the other man eyed them cautiously.

“So,” she swallowed hard, “We’re happy to finally meet you.”

“Happy?” Jack didn’t take his eyes off Takeshi.

“Well…I bet we’d all be happier if this place had a splash of color, am I right?” she joked, trying to ease the thick tension in the air, but everyone’s expressions remained sternly blank.

“Perhaps we can start with names,” she suggested, clearing her throat. “I’m Khalani. This is Takeshi.” She gestured to Takeshi, who continued to glare at the men, still as a statue.

“Don’t mind him,” she added. “He was punched in the head when he was younger, so he doesn’t talk much. The irritability is permanent, I’m afraid.”

Takeshi ever so slowly swiveled his glower to her. One made of fire and retribution.

“And you two?” Khalani ignored him. “I already know your name is

Jack. What about you?’’ She turned to the spiky-haired prisoner.

“It’s Notyor.”

“Notyor…” she repeated.

“Not your fucking business.”

She blanched and Takeshi shifted like he was about to jam his stone bowl through the man’s eye socket.

“Apologize.”

She pulled back in surprise when Jack spoke.

“You want me to apologize?” The spikey-haired man whirled to Jack in disbelief. “For what?”

Jack simply lowered his head, fixing him with a look that could break glass. The other man’s forearms bulged, veins snaking across his black tattoos.

His jaw clenched, as if it pained him, but he turned to Khalani and grumbled, “Sorry.”

Khalani blinked, stunned that Jack had commanded an apology out of him with nothing but a stare.

How much influence did he wield?

“Now that’s out of the way,” Jack steepled his hands together, shifting his attention to her, “tell me what you know of the Black Heart.”

Taking a deep breath, she quickly explained who they were and their full interaction with Spade and the other gang members in Hermes. Surprisingly, when she mentioned their first conversation with Spade in Apollo, Jack didn’t look surprised. He nodded, motioning for her to continue. But behind his calculating eyes, she could practically see his brain racing.

When she spoke of Raziel, the other man lifted his head in surprise, increasingly invested in her story. By the time she finished detailing the tracking chip and the plan to break them out in six days, Jack’s brows drew tight in consternation.

“Six days,” Jack repeated.

“Yes.”

The spikey-haired men frowned, whispering to Jack, “What makes you think we can trust them?”

“You and your brother know everyone. Have you seen them around Hermes?” Jack asked, keeping his sharp gaze on her.

The other man’s lips pursed, his dissatisfaction growing. “Doesn’t mean

they’re from Apollo. How could *she* cross the Death Zone and survive?”

“Careful,” Takeshi’s calm voice was laced with menace. “*She* has more courage in her pinky then you do in your entire body.”

“What did you say to me?”

“Do I need to repeat myself?” Takeshi asked. “Or should I add stupid and inept to your description, as well?”

“Okay, okay. Let’s get back to the plan,” she interjected, but the spiky haired guy leaned closer to Takeshi.

“If you’re not from here, let me *explain* how things work in Hermes,” he hissed. “Insults aren’t settled with words. They’re paid with blood. I’ll teach you that lesson in the ring tonight.”

Takeshi didn’t move a muscle, a dangerous glimmer flaring in his eyes.

Like he would love nothing more.

“Enough, Ryder,” Jack cut in abruptly. “We don’t have time for your posturing. They are who they say they are.”

“You believe us?” Khalani turned to him in disbelief.

Jack nodded, his expression grave. “I was with Spade the night you first made contact. We were the only ones who knew of Brock’s imprisonment and the plan to lead you to Hermes.”

“Why?”

“Because information in the wrong hands can be deadly. When there’s a stray chip, people get killed. Or captured,” Jack clipped, a flicker of infernal rage reflecting in his tight features.

Silence reigned and Ryder’s teeth clenched next to him.

“We must prepare.” Jack’s expression shifted, a fiery resolve shining through.

“What are you thinking?” Takeshi asked, finally moving his venomous gaze away from Ryder.

“There are several prisoners here we can trust to take on the Dealers when the Aces break in. But we need to get these off.” He gestured to the metal cuffs clamped around his wrists.

Khalani leaned forward. “How?”

“After a prisoner dies, I’ve seen a Dealer use his screen to remove the cuffs. The electric pads operate through retina scans. We’ll need to kill one of them. Once we do that, hopefully, we can get these off.”

Her stomach churned at the thought of more people dying for their freedom, but she pushed the naïve innocence deep into the abyss of her

mind, so it became a dull, muted voice.

Peace was a privilege only the free possessed.

“I don’t like that word, ‘hopefully,” she admitted.

Hope left room for disaster. She wanted assurance.

“That’s all gambling is.” Ryder scoffed. “We take the cards dealt and make the most of it.”

“What about Dr. Strauss?” she asked, glancing at the looming black building.

Jack and Ryder visibly tensed, exchanging uncertain looks.

“That spawn of the devil hides in his lair the majority of the day. The plan is to stick to our normal routine and not draw any attention to ourselves.” Jack shot a warning glare at Ryder, who raised his hands in mock surrender.

“You won’t hear any problems from me. I’m just trying to get out of here and not end up like *him*.”

Khalani followed his gaze to see Reno sitting alone, his back straight as a steel rod. He stared ahead, perfectly still, like he wasn’t even breathing.

“He hasn’t touched his food this entire time,” Ryder said in a low voice.

But then, Reno slowly turned his head, his lifeless gaze locking onto Ryder as if he heard him. Without taking his eyes off them, Reno put his hand in the bowl, scooped up liquid, and brought it up to his mouth, swallowing it down. He didn’t blink as he lowered his hand to do it again.

Khalani quickly turned back around, her heart racing erratically.

“How many days again?” Ryder whispered, genuine fear flashing in his eyes.

“Six days,” Jack breathed harder.

Only six days.

But with the state of the prison, it might as well have been six years.

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24

You are more than your mistakes.

Knots coiled tightly around her neck as she stared at the dim bulb on the opposite wall of the cell. It flickered every few seconds, barely holding onto its power.

The other prisoners probably didn't even notice.

The smallest object driving away darkness.

Any moment, it might dim into nothingness, and only then would they realize what had been lighting their way the entire time.

A low grunt sounded next to her, taking her attention away from the unappreciated bulb. She glanced over at Takeshi doing pushups on the floor.

He maintained a steady, rhythmic pace.

Not slowing down. Not tiring. His face was granite-smooth as he lowered himself to the ground over and over.

"How many is that?" she asked. "A hundred?"

"Or several." Takeshi didn't look at her as he spoke. He just kept driving downward.

The fact that he still had energy to expend after spending hours mining and hauling heavy rocks was beyond her comprehension.

"Doesn't it hurt? Don't you get tired?" She rested her arm on her knee, studying him.

Takeshi paused mid-pushup and looked at her, the hard cords of his triceps bulging even under the dim lighting. "Being tired and feeling pain are just states of mind. We all have limits. I've simply trained my body to extend past those limits."

His defiant words brought her back to their training sessions in Braderhelm.

"I knew you were a quitter."

He’d stand over her in prison, slinging harsh accusations like whips. Takeshi had made it his personal mission to push her harder than anyone else underground, and it only fueled her rage, driving Khalani to work until her bones screamed to break.

A light suddenly went off in her head, like the one shimmering across the cell.

How many chances would she get to be locked in a tiny cell with her longtime nemesis—and maybe get a little payback of her own?

“You know,” she began, “with how fast you’re doing those, you’re probably not working hard enough.”

Takeshi didn’t bother replying, but she noticed his pace quicken, even though he’d already been moving at breakneck speed for an hour without stopping.

“Yeah,” she yawned, feigning boredom. “Definitely looks like you’re taking it easy. I’ve seen Brock do one-armed pushups with no sweat.”

Khalani twisted her lips to smother her grin as Takeshi glared at the floor. He twisted his head, narrowing his gaze.

“I know what you’re doing.”

“Me?” She gestured to herself in shock. “I’m just making an observation. Laziness is weakness, remember?”

He’d said those exact words to her in Braderhelm. And repeating them back gave her more satisfaction than she cared to admit.

Takeshi cursed under his breath, then shifted, putting one arm behind his back while continuing to drive downward with all his weight centered on his right hand, maintaining his fast speed.

She shouldn’t be enjoying this as much as she was.

Maybe the same wickedness lived in both of them.

Takeshi moved furiously, sweat glistening across his skin, and Khalani swallowed as the white fabric of his shirt rode up, revealing a hint of corded muscle.

“Alright. You’ve proved your point,” she interjected, heart racing for no reason. “Please stop before you pass out and become useless to me.”

Takeshi released a dark chuckle and lifted off his hands, casually leaning back against the wall. “That was just a warm-up. I’ll start again in a bit.”

“*That* was a warm-up?” she repeated slowly. “Has anyone ever told you that you’re crazy?”

“Sure. But they usually liked it.”

Khalani swallowed, becoming acutely aware of how physically close they were.

The cell was so small that his legs were centimeters from hers.

The temperature in the room kept rising, and she didn't know if it was coming from his body heat or the anxiety ratcheting up inside her.

She had nowhere to escape. Nowhere to hide.

"You look flustered." He tilted his head.

"Just counting down the days until we're not locked in a cell together," she replied, crossing her arms as she leaned against the wall.

"You didn't seem to mind being close to me in the club," he remarked.

"I thought we were both trying to *forget* that night."

"And how's that worked out for you?" The glint in Takeshi's eyes and the velvet thickness of his voice made her pulse race.

She was immediately brought back to that moment where the music wove through them like living art. Their inhibitions vanquished into thin air and for a few blissful minutes, she'd felt unshackled to the world around her.

Until it was all snatched away.

"Ask me next week and I'm sure I won't even remember."

If she repeated it enough, it might actually come true.

Takeshi's expression, on the other hand, didn't shift, almost like he expected nothing less.

"What about you?" she asked in a low voice, unsure if she wanted to hear the answer.

"Did I forget?" A bitter chuckle escaped him. "Unfortunately, no. I don't think there's any world where I could ever forget you. No matter what. Not even if I tried. And believe me, I have."

The words hung in the air like a forbidden lullaby.

Despite the endless resentment, something unspoken persisted.

Maybe it was the seconds between each breath. Or the way their eyes found each other in the unintentional moments.

But that didn't mean she enjoyed it. It didn't mean hearts had a right to feel without your permission.

"And I'm sure that must be terrible." Her voice went flat, trying to batter down those twisted emotions.

"It has its moments." The corner of his lips twitched in a secret joke—one she wasn't privy to. "But you can't expect me to believe the whole

night was unbearable for you.”

“I may have had fun dancing.” Khalani glanced away, not wanting to admit that before everything fell apart, it was one of the best nights of her life.

“I know. I would’ve kept watching but then that asshole came up and grabbed you.” Takeshi’s voice was calm, but she noticed the muscles in his forearms tightening, like the damage he inflicted wasn’t nearly strong enough.

“Yeah, well, you were only a marginally better dance partner,” she lied.

“Is that why you grinded against me like it was your last night alive?”

“A momentary lapse in judgment,” she countered.

“It’s not the first time you enjoyed being in my arms.”

“Turns out I specialize in poor decision making.”

Khalani was unable to contain the grin forming. Takeshi’s lip quirked up too. And for the first time since they’d been captured, she was able to breathe a little easier as they simply stared at each other in companiable silence.

She pulled her knees to her chest, wrapping her arms around them. “Have you ever thought about what your life would’ve been like if you hadn’t become a guard?”

Takeshi silently stared past her, lost in thought as the tiny bulb of light flickered over his silky hair.

She felt the urge to tuck one piece back so she could see his granite eyes better, but Khalani held her wrists close, retreating into herself before she did something senseless.

“When I was little,” Takeshi’s hypnotic voice drew her attention, “my mother would bring home pallets of color and small brushes in Apollo. The first time, she laid out sheets of paper on the ground, and we dipped our hands in the paint. She hung up a dozen images of our hands overlapping, always saying that I brought color to her world, and she wanted me to spread it.”

Takeshi’s small smile was melancholy, tinged with layers of moments he wanted to keep forever, and others Takeshi looked like he wanted to erase.

“She taught me how to paint and, over time, the whole house was covered with my drawings. But when my stepfather, Hector, moved us to Genesis, she put them in a box and never hung them.” He hesitated, the distance in his eyes increasing. “I used to draw in my room at night when I

heard them fighting and would hide my pictures under the bed. After I found out he hit her and I enlisted to become a guard, I never picked up a brush again. But in another life, I think I would've simply enjoyed painting."

The lines in her forehead deepened as Khalani stared at him.

She thought about what Takeshi must have been like as a child. Caring. Innocent. Wanting to see his mom smile.

Heart made for beauty.

Hands molded for destruction.

But Takeshi didn't want pity. He didn't see himself as a victim. He chose to attack each weakness until it became a strength.

And somewhere along the way, he'd lost the innocent kid who wanted to paint the black and white world in color.

"I'll make you a deal." Khalani leaned her head against the wall, looking her fill of him.

"What's that?"

"When we get back to Hermes, I'll ask Spade or Raziel to track us down some brushes and paint. It's the least they can do after what we've gone through," she spoke rapidly, her cheeks reddening as Takeshi's black gaze bore into her.

The weight of his stare was too physical. Too penetrating. The tiny cell felt like it was shrinking, and she wanted to disappear into the white walls by the time Takeshi finally replied,

"And what is it that you want in return, Kanes?"

She pulled back at his unexpected question.

What did she want? She couldn't even remember anymore.

"Just draw one picture for me," Khalani said instinctively.

"Of what?"

"Anything." She smiled, trying to return some air back to the room. "Wherever your heart takes you."

"I thought I didn't have a heart," Takeshi half-joked but the faintest flicker of pain still lingered in his eyes.

"Takeshi, you know what I said—"

"It's alright, Kanes. You were speaking your truth," he interrupted. "Others who know me well would've said the same thing."

His heavy gaze lifted and it felt like he was warning her that the sweet kid who once painted pictures for his mother was long gone. But Khalani

knew Takeshi pushed people away when they veered too close.

He'd rather be the lonesome killer than be vulnerable.

And that's what art did.

Spread your vulnerabilities out for the world to judge.

"Then you can paint me what it means to be heartless." She raised an eyebrow in challenge. "Do we have a deal?"

Takeshi didn't answer. His burning stare made her believe that if the truth could release, the darkest and most beautiful poetry would spill past his lips.

But after a long moment, Takeshi nodded.

A smile formed on her face, and she leaned forward, extending her pinky.

He frowned. "What are you doing?"

"You have to promise on your pinky."

"My pinky…"

"Yes." She rolled her eyes. "Winnie taught me. Pinky promises are supposed to be unbreakable. If you don't follow through, the world will end, or something like that, and I'll haunt your dreams for eternity."

Takeshi assessed her carefully. She thought he heard him grumble, "*That already happens*."

"What?"

"Nothing, Kanes." He leaned forward and intertwined his pinky with hers. "You have a deal."

They shook their hands up and down, and their pinkies remained locked together, much longer than necessary.

Takeshi was the first to pull away, and they retreated to the opposite sides of the cell. Khalani rested her head on the crook of her elbow.

Before closing her eyes, her gaze pivoted to Takeshi, whose legs were spread out in front of him as he leaned back against the wall. He stared at the hallway, his hooded eyes and alluring face etched in shadows.

But her gaze drifted to his hands.

His fingers absently rubbed the pinky that had held hers.

***

The next few days passed in a chaotic whirlwind.

The guards continued to push their bodies to the breaking point in the tunnels, and Dr. Strauss' demeanor grew more irritable as he chose prisoners to take to his secretive building each morning. And every single one of them wailed the entire way.

Yesterday, Khalani could've sworn she heard God-awful shrieks permeate through the walls of her cell.

Or maybe they escaped from her nightmares.

She couldn't quite tell the difference anymore.

All she could focus on was counting down the days until their breakout and avoiding eye contact with Dr. Strauss at all costs.

Two days left.

That's all they had.

When they were given short-lived reprieves from the mines to eat, Khalani and Takeshi ate with Elise and her cryptic, barely coherent father, because Jack didn't want to draw too much attention to them.

Khalani's eyes were heavy, and she fought to keep her head from drooping into the bowl as Elise rambled absently about the food she'd devour the second they made it back to Hermes.

If they ever made it back to Hermes.

A strong urge tugged at her soul to share their escape plans with Elise.

Elise was the first one in camp to help them without expecting anything in return, and there was something about her that Khalani instinctively *trusted.* But she ignored her instincts and obeyed Jack's instructions to keep their plan secret.

Ryder strolled by, heading toward the fighting area. He cocked his head to Takeshi, staring at him intently. Takeshi narrowed his gaze, his disdain clear as he murmured to Khalani, "I'll be right back."

He rose to his full height and joined Ryder, who spoke to him in hushed whispers.

Khalani found herself staring at the black building, a bad habit she couldn't shake, when a group of male prisoners walked close by.

Khalani didn't recognize them.

Two of the prisoners kept their gazes forward, eyes bright with excitement as they moved toward the fight that was starting. The third man had a round stomach and shaggy brown hair that stuck out in every direction. His gaze flitted in her direction.

Something in his stare made Khalani instinctively reach inside her pocket for a knife that wasn't there. The man licked his lips suggestively, and she prepared for the worst, but he broke away and eventually followed his friends toward the fight.

She shivered, but Elise didn't notice, still chatting about food. "These bastards are definitely going to pay for making me go this long without cake."

"I haven't had cake since I was a kid," Khalani admitted, trying to shake her mind from the unsettling encounter.

Elise whipped her head so fast, Khalani was surprised she didn't break her neck.

"What?! How is that possible? Every kid has cake on their birthday."

Khalani's eyes traveled to the floor. In Apollo, sugar was a luxury only the rich could afford. And Apollo didn't waste any delicacies on orphans.

The truth was, she'd grown accustomed to the disgusting food served in Braderhelm more than anything else in her life.

Elise noticed the quiet shift and placed a hand on Khalani's shoulder. "If…*when* we get out of here, I'll make sure you get some."

Khalani managed a small smile. "I'd like that."

Suddenly, Elise's father's voice grew louder. "Key. Ring. Save. Key. Ring. Save." He twirled the silver ring around his finger, repeating the same strange words as he stared off into the distance.

"Elise, why does your father keep saying that?"

Elise's mouth twisted as she stared at her father. Her eyes grew forlorn. Like she was barely holding it together.

"My mom died a few years ago. Shortly after, my dad had a stroke. Ever since then, that's the only phrase he utters. I don't know why he's so obsessed with the ring. It's not even their wedding ring. It has some weird inscription on the bottom, but it's not from any jeweler I know of in Hermes."

"Really?" She frowned. "What does it say?"

"Hey, Dad, can I see your ring real quick?"

His eyes widened in panic. "Key. Ring. Save. Key. Ring. Save."

"Yes." Elise nodded reassuringly. "I'll keep the ring safe. Can I hold it just for a moment?"

Her dad hesitated, like he'd rather run away than let anyone have it, but he glanced at Elise and his eyes softened, only now recognizing that it was

his daughter. His hand shook as he pried the ring off his finger and gently placed it in his daughter's palm.

Elise smiled warmly at him and showed Khalani the ring.

The silver stone on top was like nothing she'd ever seen. It was thin, rectangular, and had a metal sheen to it.

"The inscription is here." Elise pointed to the underside of the ring, holding it up for Khalani to get a closer look.

She read the delicate cursive writing, and Khalani's lungs ceased breathing as two words shone back at her.

…

Prometheus Inc.

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25

Dispose of my body
and keep the truths buried with it.

Her breath stilled. The sounds around her became muted and she couldn't hear Elise calling her name.

All Khalani could focus on were the words sprawled before her, summoned from a forgotten dream.

Prometheus Inc.

It was the first time she'd encountered the name outside of Apollo.

The only clue Timothy Talbot gave to Project Helix's whereabouts was that the path started at Prometheus. His journal also mentioned that half of the families involved in Project Helix resided in Hermes.

That couldn't be a coincidence.

"Where did your dad get this?" Khalani frantically asked.

"I don't know," Elise stated. "I've never seen him without it."

"But have you asked him what these words mean?"

"Of course, but he never answers me."

Khalani brought the ring up to her face, trying to will more words to appear. Anything to give her a clue of what Prometheus meant.

"Why do you have that look? Do you know what it is?" Elise straightened, a faint glimmer of hope stirring behind her eyes.

Khalani hesitated.

The only other person who knew about Timothy's journal was Winnie, and she promised to keep it a secret.

"I don't know," she swallowed, handing it back. "I can't remember."

Elise's shoulders drooped, and she slowly gave the silver ring to her dad. He reverently slid it back onto his finger, whispering, "Key. Ring. Save. Key. Ring. Save."

Khalani's eyes sank to the floor, confusion and chaos weaving through

her like intricate braids.

Maybe the original owners of the ring knew where Prometheus was. Or Prometheus himself was the man who created the ring, and he held the key to Project Helix's whereabouts.

Or Prometheus didn't mean anything, and she was clinging to a false hope that a long-dead entity would save the world from ruin.

Khalani leaned her head against the cold stone, hating that she was still no closer to answers. She felt Takeshi's eyes slide to her from a distance. As if her frustration was a beacon to him.

She needed space to think.

A shower. That's what she needed.

Khalani had avoided the communal showers up to that point, but she was covered in grime and sweat, and her nose wrinkled when she discreetly sniffed under her arm.

She glanced over at the grey building, and there didn't appear to be any line. Perfect.

"I'm going to shower," she told Elise, rising to her feet.

Elise's brows furrowed, but Khalani marched forward without another word.

A prickling sensation of being watched crawled over her skin, but Khalani ignored it as she made her way to the showers, convincing herself it was just paranoia.

Stepping into the grey building, she let out a relieved sigh when it was empty. A row of shower heads stood along a white wall, completely open.

She quickly undressed, hesitating only briefly before sliding off her bra, but she kept her white underwear on.

After placing her clothes on the bench, she ran barefoot to one of the shower heads. She turned the knob, and her body went utterly rigid as icy cold water streamed out.

Taking a deep breath, she ducked under the freezing stream, teeth chattering as her hands instinctively crossed over her chest. Spotting a tiny bar of soap on the floor, she snatched it up and quickly scrubbed her skin clean.

All she could hear was the spray of water as she worked to untangle the jumbled knots in her hair, each pull tugging against her scalp.

Dirt streamed down her legs and swept toward the drain. A part of her wanted to stay longer, but she couldn't risk someone walking in.

With her hands covering her chest, she shut off the water and hastily shuffled to her clothes.

But Khalani stopped dead in her tracks when she got to the bench.

Her clothes were gone.

“Looking for these?”

Khalani turned to the door, her heavy heart sinking into her stomach. In front of the exit stood the male prisoner who’d walked by her and Elise earlier, a sinister grin spreading across his face as his eyes roamed over her exposed skin.

He dangled her clothes in the air.

“G-give them back,” she stammered, trying to cover as much of her body as possible.

To her surprise, he tossed her clothes just out of reach. But he didn’t leave. He crossed his arms, watching as she scrambled to put the white jumpsuit on as quickly as possible.

“Where did you say you were from?” he asked, a sadistic gleam in his eyes.

“I didn’t.” Her heart raced as she zipped up her uniform with trembling hands.

“You have a strange accent.” The man cocked his head, focusing his startling grey eyes on her.

“I’m from the slums,” Khalani replied in a panicky rasp, getting her arms through the sleeves.

Get out of there.

Get out of there.

“The slums, eh?” The prisoner took another step forward, invading her space. Her thoughts. “Can’t say I remember seeing you. And I know everyone in Hermes.”

“Well, you know what they say. Big place. Easy to get lost in.”

“Not really.”

Finally managing to pull on her uniform, she straightened, looking for the exit. He stood directly in her path.

“Get out of my way.”

“Why?” The prisoner tilted his head as if he were genuinely confused.

“Because I’m leaving,” she declared, eyeing the door he was still blocking.

“I saw the way you were looking at me earlier. I’ve been down here so

long, and I know you want this just as much as I do.”

“You’re insane,” she hissed, inching ever so slightly to the right.

“Don’t worry, darling.” He smiled gently. “I have my men guarding the exit. No one’s going to bother us. I can make this quick and easy for you.”

Her chest heaved rapidly as the edges of her vision narrowed, honing in on the door.

Just a few more steps.

The prisoner moved a fraction closer, his gut nearly touching her.

That was when Khalani bolted around him.

She raced to the exit, yanking on the door handle. But it was locked.

She braced her right foot against the wall, gripping the handle with both hands as she pulled with all her might. But the door refused to budge.

Sickeningly twisted laughter echoed off the tiles behind her.

“Help!” She banged her fist against the door, praying someone would hear her.

Terror washed over her as the man just stood back, letting her scream. Like he enjoyed watching his prey, savoring their fears before they realized escape was impossible.

“TAKESHI!” Khalani screamed at the top of her lungs in a last-ditch effort.

Suddenly, a rough hand clamped around her mouth and yanked her backward. She was thrown to the ground and gasped as her left wrist bent awkwardly in the fall.

But she didn’t have time to focus on the pain. The prisoner shoved her shoulders down, pinning her beneath him.

Khalani bucked her hips wildly. “Get off of me!” she yelled ferally. She tried pushing him, but he tightened his legs around her, refusing to budge.

The excitement shining in his eyes was the thing nightmares were made of. He leaned forward, putting his meaty hands on her shoulders, holding her down as she struggled.

“Stop fighting and it won’t hurt as much,” he whispered.

He shifted against her, trying to take off his uniform. But when he lifted his hand, she pounced.

Khalani put the full weight of her fury and rage into her fist, and punched him in the throat, just as Takeshi taught her.

The man clutched his neck, choking on his next breath.

Using the distraction, she slid out from under him, but his hand closed

around her ankle, yanking her back. With her other foot, she kicked him square in the face.

His head whipped back, and she scrambled to her feet, running toward the door, planning to crash into it with her body to break it open.

But a rough hand seized her bicep, spinning her around. All she could focus on were his furious grey eyes before he punched her square in the face.

The force sent Khalani crashing into the wall. Her vision grew hazy, blood dripping down her lip, but she couldn't register the pain. All she could focus on was the incensed prisoner charging at her again, his teeth clenched in a snarl.

Khalani wobbled on her feet, holding up her fists.

If this was to be her final moment, she wanted to be found with her knuckles bloody and nails sawed off because she fought to her last bitter breath.

He was one step away—

Bang!

The door slammed open.

The prisoner halted, eyes widening in shock when a large figure barged in, looking like death himself.

Takeshi's apocalyptic gaze immediately centered on her.

At first, his eyes softened in relief, but he slowly took in the rest of her. From her still-wet hair to her swollen, bleeding lip, to her trembling arms and uniform that was half undone from the assault.

Takeshi's expression morphed into a face you'd imagine the devil might possess—a cold and terrible beauty. The air around him grew frigid. Perilous.

His head swiveled toward the prisoner, who crossed his arms.

"What the fuck are you doing here?" the man asked.

Takeshi took a measured step forward, blocking Khalani from his view.

Despite his words, the prisoner backed up, sensing the menacing void surrounding Takeshi.

"This has nothing to do with you, man. Just turn around and walk out."

Whatever expression Takeshi wore made the man pale further.

"Nothing to do with me?" Takeshi's voice was so deep it was unrecognizable. "The moment you laid a hand on her, you chose death."

The prisoner scrambled for the door and Takeshi lunged. He grabbed a

fistful of the prisoner’s hair, driving his knee into the man’s stomach.

The prisoner doubled over, heaving before Takeshi gripped his neck and slammed the man’s head into the floor with enough force to crack the tile beneath them.

The prisoner’s head lifted, the front of his face completely smashed and broken. Takeshi flipped him over and straddled him, just as the man had done to Khalani.

Takeshi proceeded to punch him in the face. Over and over.

He took his time between each hit, relishing the blood that splattered across the white tile, studying the areas on his face that hurt the most and relentlessly attacking those weaknesses.

Between punches, the prisoner twisted his head to find Khalani standing in the corner, frozen and completely hypnotized by the scene before her.

“Help…me,” he rasped through missing teeth.

His words only served to stoke Takeshi’s fury further.

“You don’t deserve to look at something beautiful before you die,” Takeshi growled.

With chilling detachment, he bent forward. The prisoner’s whole body flailed as Takeshi plucked out his eyes.

Khalani found her back sliding down the tile as screams echoed around her. Her vision blurred, and the ache in her head intensified.

Three Dealers suddenly barged into the building, their eyes widening as Takeshi went back to savagely punching the prisoner into a bloody pulp.

“Stop!” one of them yelled, but Takeshi ignored the newcomers, continuing to inflict his deadly punishment.

The Dealers scrambled for their pads and Takeshi immediately started seizing as they shocked him. But Takeshi’s upper lip curled and he kept hitting the prisoner on the floor, *ignoring* the pain.

“What the…” The Dealers cranked up the voltage. Takeshi shook uncontrollably but his fists remained clenched as he fell to the floor. Khalani’s heart raced in sheer panic as they kept shocking him.

Watching Takeshi suffer stirred something deep within her. She thought she was vulnerable to pain before, but this hit her with the strength of a mountain.

“Don’t hurt him!” she yelled, but the Dealers ignored her.

“Get them to their cells!”

A hand wrapped around her arm, hoisting Khalani to her feet.

The Dealer motioned her toward the exit, and she wobbled, holding her hands out to steady herself. The guard grunted at her slow pace and shoved her forward.

Takeshi snarled something behind her, but she couldn't make out the words as she was escorted out of the building.

She reared back when she saw two prisoners lying on the floor right outside the door. Their chests moved, so they weren't dead, but they must've been the ones guarding the door for the man who tried to rape and kill her.

Judging by their unconscious state, they encountered the menacing Captain of Braderhelm Prison.

"Big fucking mess," the Dealer snarled, tightening his grip around her arm as he pulled her toward the barracks.

The pounding in her head intensified, and she leaned into the officer's grip to keep moving. A flash of blonde hair appeared in her vision, and her heavy gaze flickered up to see Elise with her jaw hung open.

"Are you okay? I heard a shout from the shower building and got worried…Khalani?" The lines contorting her face deepened as Khalani's head tilted.

All she wanted to do was lie down—

"Here," the Dealer grunted, unceremoniously shoving her toward Elise, who caught her with a huff. "Both of you get to your cells," he snapped, uncaring of her physical state.

Elise immediately wrapped an arm around Khalani's waist, helping her shuffle awkwardly toward the barracks. Khalani groaned as her eyelids didn't want to stay open.

She was reduced to motor function, only able to focus on placing one foot in front of the other.

"What happened to you?" Elise grunted.

"Took shower…broke in…punched…Takeshi saved…" Her words came out slow and garbled.

Elise made an angry noise when she got a better look at the nasty cut on Khalani's lip and began to piece the story together.

Her brain felt like the bowl of soup they'd eaten every day.

One moment, they were walking through the barracks hall, and the next, she slid down the white walls of her barren cell. Elise helped ease her head down, her face chalky pale as she stared at Khalani.

“Into your cells!” one of the guards yelled, and Elise hesitated.

“Isss okay. Not want you…in trouble,” Khalani whispered, embracing the cool tile on her cheeks.

Elise frowned, but Khalani’s eyes started to drift closed as she heard footsteps exiting her cell. She fought to keep her head up, but her entire body felt like someone was pressing down on her.

No.

She needed to stay awake. She needed to wait for Takeshi.

To see if he was okay.

Without concern for his own safety, Takeshi had leaped to her defense, meting out justice the only way he knew. The least she could do was remain conscious when they brought him back to say…thank you.

She just needed to stay…

Awake…

Her eyelids fluttered.

Before blissful unconsciousness stole her away, Khalani was gathered into strong arms and held close.

Like she was the most important being in the universe.

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26

I often wonder if the world changed me,
or if that decision was my own.

Khalani jolted awake when the shrill screech of the alarm sliced through the white walls of her cell, shattering the only peaceful sleep she'd had in weeks. But her eyes remained stubbornly closed, preferring a life in slumber versus the awaiting anarchy.

"It's okay, Kanes. I've got you."

That resonant, deep voice penetrated her senses, and her eyes flew open. She was sprawled over Takeshi, lying on his chest. One of his hands rested on her lower back, while the other cupped the back of her head. His long fingers were gently entwined in her hair as he held her steady.

The blaring alarm faded into the background.

The throbbing pain in her head receded.

Takeshi studied her intently, an unfamiliar emotion sweeping through his dark gaze—concern, perhaps, or something deeper, drawing her in like a burning fire.

Something so captivating shouldn't exist in a world that was colored in pain.

Takeshi scanned her face, his muscles clenching as the light gave him a better view of the deep cut on her lip and what was no doubt a bruise forming on her cheekbone. His hair was tousled and unkempt, as if he'd been running his hands through it all night.

"Are you okay?" she asked, the memories of the guards brutally shocking him still replaying.

"You're the one who was brutally attacked, and you're asking if *I'm* okay?" Takeshi's voice deepened, staring up at her in brutal shock and awe.

"My face and head hurt," she admitted. "But I'll be fine."

She felt his gentle hands imperceptibly tighten around her, his expression contorting like he wanted to say everything but didn't know how.

"You need to get up," an urgent voice called from her right. "I heard the Dealers are on the warpath today."

Khalani turned to see Elise standing outside their cell. Her eyes swept over Khalani's face, sucking in a harsh breath at the evidence of her assault. "How are you feeling?"

"I'm okay." Khalani stifled a groan as she stood, vertigo nearly sending her sprawling back to the ground.

A strong grip immediately steadied her waist.

"Maybe you should lie back down."

But she shook her head. "I can handle it."

Takeshi paused, a muscle in his jaw jumping like he was seconds away from locking her in the cell and leaving her there the rest of the day—just like he used to do every single night in Braderhelm.

But he bore witness to the determination in her eyes. The conviction to not show weakness or be a burden.

So, without a word, he released her, letting Khalani stand on her own.

Elise's frown deepened as Khalani marched past, clearly not the only one thinking that the last thing she should be doing was leaving her cell and working in the mines.

But Khalani was used to ignoring pain and abuse, shoving it deep into her mind and pretending the trauma didn't exist.

Not healthy, surely. But effective.

Prisoners lined up for inspection. Some winced at the sight of her bruises, while others shot her hard, accusatory glares. No doubt believing she was responsible for another prisoner's death.

If only they knew the truth.

In line, Khalani noticed Takeshi's stare become oddly fixated on something in the crowd.

His breath stilled.

His fists clenched by his sides.

She tried following his gaze…

"Stand up straight for inspection!"

Khalani's head snapped forward as the Dealers walked through the line of prisoners. Several glared daggers in Takeshi's direction, clutching their pads with white-knuckled grips.

The guards made them stand in line for much longer than usual.

Khalani continuously shifted her weight side to side, her legs turning numb as she blinked to stay awake. After an hour, she teetered, her legs nearly giving out, and Takeshi cursed next to her.

But one of the Dealers shouted, “Get on the ground for Dr. Strauss!”

It was the one time she felt grateful to sink to her knees.

When Dr. Strauss entered the area, his eyes were colder than normal. He scanned the lines of prisoners with a scowl, tapping his pen against the clipboard, the only sound piercing the quiet.

“Do you all know why you’re here?” Dr. Strauss asked calmly.

No one answered. Even the guards averted their gaze.

“No takers?” Dr. Strauss slowly walked down her line. Khalani stared at the ground, willing herself to stay upright.

“You’re here because you are impulsive. Disobedient. *Rebellious*. Like spoiled rotten children,” he spat. “You’re here to be guided into a better life. One with meaning. But some of you just…*refuse* to be saved.” He threw his clipboard to the ground, and everyone flinched, staring at the floor like their lives depended on it.

As if remembering himself, Dr. Strauss took a deep breath, picked up his clipboard, and straightened his white lab coat.

She lifted her head and suddenly, his cold gaze met hers.

Khalani froze, feeling like razor sharp claws had suddenly latched onto her. But for some reason, she refused to look away.

He placed a hand on his chin, slowly drumming his fingers as he studied the only prisoner who dared to stare back at him.

The audible sound of crying filtered through the space, breaking Dr. Strauss’ concentration. He turned to a younger girl with long, mousy brown hair, her shoulders trembling as tears streamed down her face.

“What’s this? Are you crying because of your sorry deeds on this earth, or do you want to be saved?” Dr. Strauss stepped in front of her.

The girl didn’t answer, she just sobbed harder, her back bowing and her limbs quaking.

“Take her,” Dr. Strauss commanded, and the guards quickly moved to action.

“No! Noooo!! *Please*!”

No one responded to her wails. Everyone seemed to bend closer to the ground, trying to disappear through it.

“Get to work!” the Dealers yelled as the girl was dragged further away, her cries slowly receding, never to leave the forsaken cavern.

Khalani shakily rose to her feet, wiping the gravel off her knees. Takeshi’s brows were drawn in a deep scowl as he strode over to her.

“You’re paler than normal,” he said, almost like an accusation.

“Thanks. I didn’t get much sun growing up.”

“Kanes.”

“Takeshi.” She met his dark stare head-on.

“You shouldn’t work while you’re still injured.”

“Because I’m sure if I ask for a break, they’ll happily comply and fetch me a rocking chair.” She rolled her eyes and turned to follow the prisoners, trying her best to walk in a straight line even though it felt like she was trudging through thick mud.

Takeshi gave her *that* look. The one that said she was insufferable and begging for punishment.

But he begrudgingly marched by her side, close enough to catch her if she fell.

“Not sure why you’re upset,” she remarked, inhaling deeply to ward off the nausea. “What would you have done if I asked for a break when I was your prisoner?”

“What do you think?” he deadpanned. “I would’ve fetched you a rocking chair.”

She laughed out loud, a sound rarely heard in the prison camp, and several prisoners shot her odd glances.

Even in the midst of pain and impending doom, the quiet and distant Captain who loathed her the first moment he set eyes on her was the one to make Khalani laugh.

The world had definitely gone mad.

She took a deep breath as she grasped the thick pickaxe, the guards watching every movement with sharp eyes.

To her surprise, she noticed Elise and Jack hovering close by.

Even Ryder nodded at her in solidarity.

It reminded her of an important lesson. One she’d been close to forgetting.

There were far more good people in the world than there were bad. It didn’t always seem that way because evil tended to be louder.

But hope resided in the quiet moments.

It was the subtle glances of unity from strangers. The gentle touch of Takeshi’s hand wrapped around her hair in the middle of the night. It lived in Serene’s laugh and Winnie’s conviction to make the world a better place.

That was why she lifted the pickaxe and started hammering away.

If others didn’t have a voice, she would scream for them. Because that’s what life had taught her.

To give all of herself.

Hours later, she nearly fainted with relief when the alarm sounded. She nearly puked on the floor when they left the tunnels. It felt like her head was banging against a brick wall.

When Khalani sat with her bowl of food, she put her head between her knees, trying to find stability on the solid ground.

Soft hands pulled the sweaty hair off her neck, tying it into a messy bun. She lifted her head and found Elise sitting back, nodding at her.

“Better?”

Khalani managed the barest smile. “Yeah.”

Right at that moment, Jack and Ryder appeared. And much to everyone’s surprise, they sat down with them.

“What are you doing?” she frowned, under the impression they were supposed to be keeping their distance in camp.

“We need to talk.” Jack stared pointedly at Elise and her mumbling father, who fiddled with the Prometheus ring on his finger. “Leave us,” he commanded.

“No,” Khalani shot back, fighting through the dizziness. “They’re staying.”

“They’re not a part of our group.”

“They’re a part of *my* group.” Her voice lashed out like the snap of a chain.

From the moment they entered camp, Elise was the only one to look out for them. Despite her reservations, she showed up for Khalani when she didn’t have to.

Khalani refused to leave camp without ensuring Elise and her father escaped as well.

Jack’s lips formed a pale, thin line as Elise cocked her head in confusion. It wasn’t until Takeshi gave a subtle nod of approval that Jack turned his attention to Elise.

“What’s spoken here doesn’t leave this group. Betray us, and I’ll bury your father’s limbs in every corner of Hermes,” he warned in a chilling voice that sucked the air out of the cavern.

“Unlike *some* people, I know how to hold my tongue, Jack,” Elise hissed, leaning forward. “But threaten my father again, and I’ll slice every artery you possess with your own deck of cards.”

“Good. Glad we have a mutual understanding.” Jack nodded, seemingly unfazed by her threat, as if her violent promise actually made him *more* comfortable.

“What’s the plan?” Takeshi cut in impatiently.

Jack turned to him, taking a deep breath. “Ryder and I have communicated with some of our members here in camp. They’re all in place and ready to act. Tomorrow, when the Aces arrive, we’ll attack the Dealers and take off these cuffs.”

“How are they going to break in?” Khalani’s stiff spine straightened, the pain and nausea momentarily forgotten as anticipation filled her veins.

“Spade is smart enough to know that a big distraction is needed to get us out. I’d expect something…explosive.”

Khalani and Takeshi tensed, unsure if they’d heard correctly, but Jack continued, “I don’t know exactly *when* they’ll strike tomorrow, but we need to be ready the second it happens. Once we’re free of these cuffs, we make a run for the tunnel exit. Don’t worry about anyone else. Got it?” He met both of their eyes with a serious look while Elise sat there with her mouth agape.

“Are you telling me we’re going to be rescued tomorrow?” Her tone was awash with disbelief.

“Yes.” Khalani grabbed her hand. “We’re going to get you and your dad out of here.”

“But you have to be willing to fight and accept the possibility that we could all die tomorrow by doing this,” Ryder added, narrowing his gaze.

Elise glanced at her father, who was lost in thought, continuously mumbling gibberish as he petted his ring.

Tears shimmered in her eyes, but a second passed and her expression solidified before turning to Jack. “Count us in. We’re not spending another minute in this godforsaken place.”

An unrestrained energy rushed through Khalani’s limbs as they finalized their escape plans. Like she could run for miles and take on the Dealers

right then and there.

But they had to wait.

One. More. Day.

When they went back to work in the tunnels, the clanging of metal felt like a closing act. A final hurrah to what was hopefully the last time she'd ever have to see a pickaxe again.

Takeshi remained broodingly quiet, taking over most of her load. But she sensed a frenzied storm building within him.

When they finally got their last break of the day, Takeshi murmured to her, "Stay here."

Before she could question him, he marched toward the fighting area.

Khalani frowned and followed him without a second thought.

When Ryder sidled up next to her, she crossed her arms tightly over her chest. "What do you want?" she snapped.

"I can't check to see how you're doing?"

"No."

"You look like hell." He observed bluntly.

"Thanks. I'm sure women back in Hermes are weeping over the loss of your irresistible charm."

Ryder placed a hand over his heart. "I'm hurt. Truly. I just wanted to see —where are you going?"

Ignoring him, Khalani pushed through the crowd of onlookers gathering to watch the next fight. She craned her neck left and right, searching for Takeshi among the prisoners.

A few seconds later, she found him.

The crowd parted for him as he stepped into the center, eyes blazing as he scanned the audience with predatorial focus.

What the hell was he doing?

"Who are you fighting?" one of the prisoners asked.

Takeshi's gaze halted on someone, his muscles visibly tensing.

"Them." He pointed at two prisoners in the crowd.

The men he stared at glanced behind them, unsure if he meant someone else. But when his gaze didn't waver, they puffed their chests.

"He can't fight two people."

"That's suicide."

Whispers rippled through the crowd as the two men stalked forward into the center of the fighting circle. Khalani's green eyes flared when she

recognized them. It was the same two prisoners who guarded the shower doors while she was attacked.

“Are you sure you want to fight us both?” one of the men laughed. “You can’t catch us unaware this time and we won’t hold back.”

The corner of Takeshi’s lips lifted, but his black eyes burned with a promise of violent retribution.

“That’s what I’m counting on.”

Khalani squeezed to the front of the crowd as the two men flanked him, moving in opposite directions. Takeshi remained preternaturally still, arms held loose by his side, waiting for the attack.

With a grunt, both men launched forward, simultaneously throwing punches at either side of Takeshi’s face.

He ducked so fast she barely caught the movement. He put one hand on the ground, swung his leg around, and knocked one guy off his feet.

At the same time, Takeshi twisted and punched the other man in the sternum, sending him stumbling back into the crowd, clutching his chest as if he’d been hit by a sledgehammer.

The first man shot back up, amusement completely wiped off his face. He held up his fists, dancing on his feet, and sprang forward. Takeshi dipped and dodged each punch aimed at him, anticipating every movement.

Takeshi moved like water, effortlessly and without restraint. His expression was a blank canvas, eerily calm as he faced his opponents, but the depth of fury in his eyes betrayed the thin control slipping away.

The other guy was still struggling to breathe as the prisoner fighting Takeshi was starting to labor in his movements. The wide punches grew increasingly desperate as none of the hits managed to meet their target.

Takeshi, on the other hand, didn’t slow. Didn’t lift his fists. Almost like he was toying with him. Making it last a little longer.

The prisoner growled when he realized the same thing and snarled, “I wish I was the one to fuck your little bitch in the showers.”

Khalani’s breath hitched.

Her gaze cut straight to Takeshi, whose cool demeanor shattered. He lowered his head, upper lip curling. His eyes didn’t flare with vengeance.

They were outlined in pure annihilation.

When the prisoner swung again, Takeshi caught his fist just inches from his face. The man barely had time to register the shock before Takeshi struck him directly in the jaw.

The prisoner’s head flew back, and in the next instant, Takeshi wrapped his arm around the prisoner’s elbow, bending his fingers back until they touched his forearm in the shape of a rainbow she’d once witnessed in Genesis.

With a loud crack, Takeshi snapped the man’s arm.

The man let out a terrible scream as he fell to the ground, cradling his elbow that was facing the wrong direction, tears streaming down his face.

Multiple prisoners around her covered their mouths, their faces scrunching in horror at the brutal sight.

But Khalani swallowed, refusing to look away.

Takeshi stepped over the man cowering beneath him, mumbling for mercy. Judging by the bloodthirsty expression on Takeshi’s face, there would be none.

But the second burly prisoner recovered and wrapped his arms around Takeshi, lifting him off his feet.

Takeshi threw his weight forward, flipping the man over his head, sending him crashing to the ground next to his wailing friend.

The man’s eyes widened just before Takeshi slammed his foot between his legs. The prisoner’s face went purple before he screamed.

But Takeshi wasn’t finished. He lowered himself to the ground, bracing his left hand on the prisoner’s shoulder and began to rain down punches with his right fist, each blow stronger than the last.

No one moved.

Everyone seemed frozen in awe. Khalani’s chest lifted in rapid breaths as splatters of blood flew onto Takeshi’s cold face.

“*In another life, I think I would’ve simply enjoyed painting.*”

Takeshi’s words played back to her as his fists colored themselves in red.

She visualized him as a child.

Drawing pictures with his mother. Smiling at her with those innocently beautiful black eyes. Watching the person he loved most disappear and being forced to guard a deadly prison.

That inherent need to protect had morphed into something unforgiving, and it was laid bare for everyone to witness and judge.

As splashes of red streaked across his face, she realized one brutal truth.

It wasn’t Takeshi’s fault for how he adapted to a brutal life he never chose.

Apollo stole his passions. Khalani refused to let this cruel world take away anything else.

“Takeshi.” She stepped into the circle, drawing multiple eyes. His fist froze midair at the sound of her voice, and he turned his head.

In that moment, she barely recognized him. Drops of someone else’s blood splayed across his face like war paint. His teeth were clenched like some wild animal she read about as a little girl.

A scared part of her wanted to let his demons take over and forget the dangerous Captain entirely.

But no matter how much they fought, or resented one another, Takeshi never ceased to protect her in the most visceral way possible.

Ruining himself so she wouldn’t have to.

Khalani lifted her head, anchoring her feet to the ground, refusing to walk away.

“Takeshi,” she said louder. “Let them go.”

“They hurt you,” he rasped. His grip around the man’s uniform tightened, ready to continue the onslaught. It was clear in his mind that their mere involvement in Khalani’s suffering warranted death.

“Yes. And they’ve learned their lesson. Please stop.”

Please come back to me…

Those words hovered on the tip of her tongue, but she swallowed them to the deepest pits of her heart.

Takeshi hesitated, teeth clenched, like the *last* thing he wanted to do was stop. But he didn’t break away from her unrelenting gaze.

She stared right back, letting him witness her belief that Takeshi was stronger than the deaths that forged him.

Just like her.

Takeshi inhaled sharply, rising to his full height as he slowly backed away from the two men on the ground. She sighed in relief when he moved toward her, but he paused, looking around at the crowd of prisoners, seeming to make eye contact with each one.

“Those two are alive for one reason, and that’s her.” His strong voice lifted across the circle as he pointed at Khalani, and even she held still at the force beneath it. “If anyone so much as *looks* in her direction the wrong way, you’ll resent your mother for giving birth to you.”

The tension in the air thickened, making it hard to breathe.

Suddenly, the high-pitched alarm pierced the air, and everyone flinched. At first, no one moved as they stared back at Takeshi with wide eyes and pale faces, but they slowly began to disperse.

A few prisoners helped drag the unconscious man away. The man with a broken arm quickly stood, practically running as tears streaked down his red face.

The sight shouldn't have brought her satisfaction, but it did.

Takeshi stayed still as everyone moved around them, and no one dared to look in her direction.

She bit her lip, shifting on her feet at the renewed friction.

"Takeshi…I—"

"Kanes," he interrupted, heaving in a deep breath, letting her know that his thin patience was a second from extinguishing. "Let's go back to our cell."

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27

It’s not about being perfect.
It’s about letting your failures go.

Khalani tapped her foot against the cold tile floor of her cell.

She rested her chin on her knee, back firmly against the wall as she stared at Takeshi.

Even in the shadows, his features were sharp and honed. He sat against the opposite side of the cell with one leg stretched out, eyes firmly closed.

He wasn’t asleep though.

His muscles were too tense, jaw too tight to be in slumber. Like a loaded gun lifting, preparing to wreak havoc.

She didn’t know what to say.

Maybe silence and pretending to ignore each other’s existence was the only defense left.

Maybe that’s what she wanted.

No.

Yes.

The lines between her needs and her fears blurred until she couldn’t distinguish one from the other.

All Khalani could do was tap her right foot against the floor, the staccato beats providing the only sound in the stiff quiet.

“How long are you going to keep doing that?” Takeshi asked, his eyes still closed.

“Not sure.” She halted mid-tap. “Were you planning on being silent the whole night?”

“Probably.”

“Then I think I’ll keep doing it.”

Takeshi tilted his head back and stared at her, his dark irises drawing her in like a magnet. She licked her lips, careful to avoid the cut, and his

attention flickered to her mouth. The temperature in the cell rose as they silently appraised one another.

“How are you feeling?” he finally asked.

“Better.” The truth. “My face hurts but I’ll survive.”

Takeshi’s muscles held taut, his infernal energy wrapping around her like a cloak.

“I’m sorry,” he whispered, so low, she almost didn’t hear him.

“For what?”

“For ever agreeing to this plan. For letting them bring you here.”

“You didn’t *let* them do anything.” She shook her head. “It was my decision.”

“And I should’ve tied you down and forced them to take someone else.”

“You don’t think I can get the job done?”

“That’s not it, Kanes.”

“Then what is it?! I told you that I’m fine,” Khalani insisted, raising her voice.

Takeshi’s jaw ticked, stubbornly keeping his mouth shut as his gaze drifted to the door.

Ready to be done with the conversation.

“Don’t do that,” she snapped, not letting him off the hook. “Don’t shut me out. Just tell me the truth. You think I’m too weak, right? Isn’t that what you’re trying to say?”

Takeshi’s stare shifted, his intense and heady gaze nearly leveling her. “You shouldn’t have to ask me that. Your strength is *never* a question to me. I know you can fucking handle everything thrown at you.”

“So what’s the problem? We made it this far and we’re getting out of here soon.”

Khalani held onto that hope for dear life, because if the trackers embedded in their bloodstream failed, they’d likely die in that cavern.

“They hurt you.” Takeshi breathed sharply, staring at her like she was the air he didn’t want to breathe.

Khalani rolled her eyes. “I told you I’m f—”

“Do *not* say that word again,” he interrupted, the deep tenor in his voice lashing out. “Not when I can see the marks on your face.”

“So what?” she scoffed. “They’ll heal. And that’s why you trained me to fight in the first place, remember?”

“Yes. But I’d rather you not have to use those skills at all.”

“What are you going to do? Lock me in a bedroom when we get out of here?” She laughed incredulously.

He raised an eyebrow, like that was the most intelligent suggestion he’d heard all week.

“No. There will be no locking or hiding.” She couldn’t believe she had to utter those words. “I’ll fight harder and train more, so you don’t think of me as a burden,” she grumbled, crossing her arms and staring at the creaks in the white tile.

For once, Khalani wished she didn’t have to prove her worth to everyone. She wanted people to look at her and already believe she was strong.

“Khalani, look at me.”

Her true name flowing across his tongue was the only thing that made her glance up.

“You’re never a burden,” he stated. “I *know* you can handle everything life throws at you and punch back even harder. But if something happened to you—” Takeshi cut himself off, his muscles clenching before glancing away.

Khalani stood, heart pounding against her chest like it might break free. The tremor in her hands betrayed her rippling emotions as she turned away, peering into the empty, white hallway beyond their cell.

The memory of his previous words still haunted her, festering like an open wound.

When Takeshi told her things were over between them, she hurt in places that couldn’t be touched. When he played with her feelings in the nightclub, he made her out to be the biggest fool beneath the surface.

Some wounds heal with time. But hers only deepened.

“Why do you feel the need to protect me, anyway?” Khalani took a deep breath, bitterness coating her tongue. “I don’t even matter that much to you.”

“Is that what you think?”

“It’s what I know.”

“Then you haven’t been paying attention.”

“You haven’t given me much else to go off of!” She spun, glaring back at him. “If I recall, you were only *too* happy to tell me that everything was finished between us. You’ve already said goodbye more times than I can

count. But who am I kidding? Was there ever really an ‘us’ in the first place?”

The chaos inside of her was finally starting to break free, and Takeshi stared at her, a thousand emotions flickering across his face.

He slowly stood, stepping right into her space.

But Khalani didn’t budge.

She tilted her chin up, refusing to back away despite the coils of electricity wrapping around her spine.

Takeshi took another measured step forward, forcing her to inch back until her shoulders hit the wall. Barely an inch separated them as he towered over her.

“I’ve always been a good liar,” he whispered.

Her brows pinched together. “What the hell does that mean?”

“It means that no matter how many times I told myself we were done, I knew I’d never be over you. You’re the kind of special no one ever forgets.” His pitch-black eyes bore into Khalani, demanding that she listen.

“I’ve tried very hard to keep my distance, but my control slips by the minute. When you look straight at me, all I want to do is finish what we started that night in prison and make you completely mine. So let me make one thing clear. It doesn’t matter what happens between us. From now until the day I bleed out, I will always want you. I will always keep you safe. Even if you weren’t mine,” he gritted his teeth, “I would still protect you. Just know that if anyone gave you so much as a paper cut, I would end their existence.”

The weight of his truth hit her like a battering ram, destroying her barriers. Eviscerating all trains of thoughts and reason.

The only thing that remained was a relentless spark soaring through her limbs, making her feel like she needed to jump out of her skin.

“Takeshi…”

“I don’t expect anything back, Khalani. I just…I needed you to know the truth for once.” He didn’t fully meet her gaze, like he expected her to finally walk away after his proclamation.

Khalani had never stepped foot in an ocean.

Winnie told her about them a few times in Braderhelm Prison.

There used to be giant bodies of water on the surface, stretching as far as the eye could see.

Apparently, you could jump in and duck your head all the way under, and the waves would take over.

That's what this moment felt like.

Powerful waves crashing against her, pulling her deeper and deeper into the unknown.

She held her breath and stared into his eyes. Truly *looked* at him.

And what she saw was a man embedded with violent instincts and buried scars. Who fought for his beliefs. Who truly listened—not just thought about what he wanted to say next.

He pushed others to realize their strengths, and beneath the steel armor was a beating heart that bled with passion, fervor, and love.

But maybe that last word wasn't correct.

Maybe that was the emotion screaming out of *her* skin, growing in intensity ever since she opened the poetry book Douglas gave her in Apollo.

She thought love was the beginning of her story, but stories always have an ending. A point where you turn the final page and it takes your breath with it.

But love doesn't have an ending.

Love endures.

It walks this earth with no face, concept of time, or reason.

It simply is. And simply will be.

That was the thought going through Khalani's head when she closed the distance and kissed him.

At first, Takeshi didn't kiss her back.

But then, he wound his arm around Khalani's neck, fastening her to him and kissed her like it was their last night on Earth.

Her lips moved against him with equal abandon. She slid her tongue into his mouth, and Takeshi groaned, pulling her closer, sliding his other hand to her lower back.

She wrapped her arms around his broad shoulders and stood on her toes, breathing his intoxicating scent in, begging for time to stop.

In one fluid motion, Takeshi lifted her off her feet.

She instinctively wrapped her legs around him, letting out a small noise as he slid his hand from the back of her neck to the front of her throat. He gently squeezed, pulling her breaths into his own as he licked her tongue, holding her as if someone would have to kill Takeshi to make him let go.

Khalani winced when the edge of his teeth caught her lip, but she refused to let anything or anyone ruin that moment. But Takeshi drew back an inch, noticing the flicker of pain she desperately tried to hide.

“Did I hurt you?” Takeshi asked, his voice gravelly and his lips deliciously swollen. The raw emotion in his eyes blended with the deep fury simmering just beneath the surface.

“I’m okay. Just a scratch,” Khalani reassured him.

His eyes softened—actually *softened*—as he gazed at her. Takeshi cupped the side of her face and gently kissed her cheeks, her forehead, her nose, the tops of her eyelids, her jaw.

His lips were an apology.

Not just for the pain others had caused, but the hurt he’d dealt. For all the times they spent at each other’s throats instead of in each other’s arms.

But he hesitated and said, “Khalani, before we continue, I need to ask you something.”

Her eyes crinkled as he set her down.

“What?”

“Why did you stop me from killing those two men earlier? Is it because you’re ashamed of my past? Of the things I’ve done?” A vulnerability he normally didn’t show pooled in his dark gaze as he waited for her answer.

She considered his question, wanting to unbury her truths with him.

“I’m not ashamed of your past, Takeshi,” she stated firmly. “We’ve all made mistakes. I stopped you because for too long, you’ve let the ugliness of this world define you. I realized that you’ve spent so much time watching over others that you forgot what it’s like to have someone protect you. And I thought…maybe *I* could be that person.”

Khalani’s muscles locked into place, her heart laid bare on a silver platter.

Her eyes strayed to the floor, but Takeshi put his finger under her chin and pulled her gaze toward him.

And every moon and star in the sky couldn’t compare to the sheer beauty and power reflecting back at her when he said,

“You already are.”

She stilled, his deep voice reverberating through her very soul.

They didn’t have to say those three words.

No sentence could ever be enough.

Their lips met at the same time, and she started unzipping the back of her uniform. Takeshi growled and snapped his hand around her wrist, halting her movement.

“Khalani,” he exhaled harshly, “if we keep going, I won’t be able to restrain myself. So, if you don’t want this to move any further, tell me now. This is your only chance to say no.”

Their eyes met in the dark, the finality in his deep tone reverberating around them.

If they continued, everything would change.

She hated change. Change was terrifyingly uncomfortable, like an itch that couldn’t be reached.

But she didn’t want to go through life wondering about the what ifs.

She determinedly lifted her chin and finished unzipping her uniform.

Takeshi was tensely still, not taking his gaze off her face once.

Power coiled in her fingertips.

There was strength in the way she took control of her own body, in the way Takeshi watched her, like nothing could tear his focus away.

She slid the fabric down her legs, stepping out of her boots as the uniform fell to the ground.

Khalani stood completely bare, her arms hanging by her sides, allowing Takeshi to look his fill.

He stared at her as one might look at a long-lost painting.

Like Khalani had when she gazed upon the city of Genesis for the first time. With complete awe and an inner knowledge that she’d never be the same after the sight.

She felt his gaze move over her, slow and deliberate. All the way from her breasts, to her waist, to the tips of her feet, as if every part of her was worthy of attention and reverence.

Even the parts others would overlook. Especially those.

The silence extended as he kept studying her, and she swallowed, her nerves kicking in. After a moment, Khalani placed one hand over her stomach and moved the other to cover her chest.

“I don’t think so.” The deep timbre in his voice sent goosebumps down her arms.

He moved closer, his body completely overshadowing hers. Takeshi gave her a pointed look, and she gathered her self-confidence, letting her arms fall free again.

“You’re perfect,” he breathed, but Takeshi wasn’t looking at her body. He was staring straight into her eyes. Her heart skipped a beat, the heat in the room so intense, they could’ve been standing under the burning sun and not noticed the difference.

Despite his earlier words, Takeshi’s hands remained tense at his sides.

“Aren’t you gonna touch me?” she challenged, a playful edge to her voice.

“I’m enjoying the view.”

“And what do you think?”

“I think you’re mine.”

Oh.

My.

God.

Her heart raced overtime, and her mind had to scramble to form a coherent sentence. “Pretty presumptuous to think I’m yours. What if there was someone else I had my eye on down here?”

The spark in his eyes brightened. Fighting was their own twisted brand of foreplay, and he loved it just as much as she did.

“That so?” His palm grazed her waist. “What’s their name?”

“Why do you want to know?” She fought to stay calm as his finger brushed over her breast, lightly pinching, setting her ablaze.

“So I can kill him tomorrow,” he said matter-of-factly.

“You’re unhinged.” She laughed.

“Now you’re getting it.”

Takeshi’s wicked grin widened, and she was once again struck by his raw beauty. Without another word, he grabbed a fistful of her hair, bent her back, and wrapped his mouth around her nipple.

A gasp escaped her lips as he bit gently, the vibrations of his groans sending electric currents rippling through her body. Takeshi pulled her back up, devouring her mouth again. They kissed each other like people starved. As if they didn’t need air because they were each other’s oxygen.

With her lips pressed against his, Khalani reached around his neck and started unzipping his uniform, needing to feel all of him. Takeshi quickly unfastened the zipper himself, pulling it down and discarding it roughly across the cell.

Her hands roamed over his bare chest, feeling his heart beating like a drum.

Seeing him in action was one thing. Feeling his muscles tense beneath her fingertips was entirely different.

Biting her lip, she let her hands glide lower. When her fingers grazed his hard length, Takeshi sucked in a sharp breath.

She grinned, the thought of him coming undone because of her made her feel even more powerful.

Khalani wanted to do so much more than touch him. She wanted to make him lose control and have this moment embedded in his veins for eternity.

Just as it would be for her.

Khalani lowered to her knees, but he pulled her back up.

“Takeshi, what—”

She made a small yelp when Takeshi twirled her around so her back was flush against his chest. One arm wrapped around her, fanning the skin directly under her breasts, and the other dipped between her legs.

“If you think I’m going to cum before you, think again.”

She gulped, her head falling back against his shoulder as his thumb flicked against her, while a finger slipped inside her.

His movements quickened, and Khalani felt like she was traversing a wild peak. Climbing the tallest mountaintop. Each grind against Takeshi ignited a molten fire inside her, the heat intensifying with every stroke.

Pinpricks entered her vision. She didn’t know what was happening. Had never experienced this rush with any other partner.

When she reached back, he groaned in her ear as her hand traced him up and down, matching his pace. His heart pounded against her back, a primal beat as they slowly fell apart together.

His thumb flicked as he eased another finger inside her, and she had to stifle the moan that teetered on the edge of her lips. Every movement, every shift, elicited sparks that raced through her body, burning hotter and stronger with each passing moment.

“That’s it, beautiful. Let go for me,” he commanded, just as out of breath as she was, and with another brush of his thumb, the muscles in her core started convulsing.

Her body felt like it was on fire. Like she was burning from the inside out.

Euphoria coursed through her veins as her hand continued stroking him, his whole body tensing before he came apart with her.

Takeshi cursed and he gripped her hand, moving up and down with her.

That was even hotter.

She leaned against him, her body trembling like her limbs consisted of molten liquid, still reeling from the powerful high.

“Oh my God,” she rasped, out of breath.

“No. Just me.” He pulled her tight against him and slid down the wall. She felt each rise and fall of his chest as he laid her down on the ground and held her close. Her head rested on his forearm, while his other arm wrapped around her waist.

It was a possessive hold. Protective. Like an animal guarding its treasure.

If someone had told her in Braderhelm Prison that Takeshi would be holding her like this, she would’ve laughed and dismissed the idea outright. Not even if hell froze over would she have believed them.

But life had a way of gifting you the most unexpected things when you didn’t pay attention.

Khalani arched her back slightly and wriggled her hips, feeling him harden against her once more.

“Stop that,” he said in her ear.

“Stop what?” She shifted a little, and he gripped her waist, fingers squeezing in warning.

“Khalani, I need you to stop right now. When I make love to you for the first time, it won’t be in this cold cell. But if you keep moving your hips like that, I won’t care anymore. So fucking *behave*.” He bit her ear.

Sounded like a reasonable plan to her.

“What if I said pretty please?” she asked in a light voice.

“You’re going to be the death of me, Kanes. Go to sleep.”

She grinned but complied, for now. After the mind-blowing release he’d given her, her body was utterly exhausted. And they needed all their strength and energy for what would transpire in the morning.

Tomorrow, they would escape and be free. Together.

Takeshi tucked her closer, chasing her nightmares away. And for the first time in forever, she found a bright future in the shadows of a dark world.

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28

From a distance, they laugh. But venture closer, and you'll realize they were always screaming.

Khalani's body was wrapped around something warm. Steadfast.

Her eyelids refused to open, and she nestled closer to the fiery heat that encased her like a shield. She released a heavy, contented sigh and eased deeper into a peaceful sleep.

Bright lines danced around her in a pleasant dream. She walked on the surface, the magnificent sun coating her in its rays.

Takeshi walked beside her, nudging her arm. She turned to him with a small laugh, and he mouthed something unintelligible.

"What?" she asked, grinning.

"Wake up," he said.

Her brow pulled down low, and he repeated loudly, "Wake up."

She sat up with a gasp, realizing that it wasn't the sun shining down on her but the harsh, bright light in the barracks powering on.

Khalani instinctively moved to cover her chest, only to realize she was already wearing her uniform. She drew back, confused, but then remembered Takeshi gently waking her in the middle of the night to put it on.

"So no one loses an eye tomorrow," he'd whispered conspiratorially.

Rubbing her face, she yawned as Takeshi sat up with her. For the first time, he finally looked like he slept through the night. But his expression was cold and calculating as he stood, the volatile Captain ready to take on the world.

"You okay?" he asked.

"Tired." She stretched her arms over her head, resisting the urge to sink back down to the ground.

“And you wanted me to keep you up all night.” A smirk tugged at his lips, and her heart sputtered.

“Like you would’ve lasted that long,” she joked, lifting to her feet.

“Oh, Kanes.” Takeshi let out a dark chuckle. “I can’t wait to make you choke on those words.”

A wild visual entered her mind.

Takeshi tilted his head, eyes full of mirth, as if he knew *exactly* what she was thinking.

The door to their cell opened, and prisoners began filing through the hellish space toward inspection.

Her cheeks reddened as Takeshi stepped aside, holding out his hand for her to pass with a mischievous grin.

She smoothed the wrinkles in her uniform, tucked the stray hairs behind her ears, and cracked her neck from side to side, trying to ignore Takeshi’s dangerously tempting words that whispered in her ear, like a mini-villain perched on her shoulder.

She felt the heat coming off him as he followed close behind. If it were up to Khalani, she’d grab him by the arm, walk right back into the cell, and finish what they started last night, uncaring of the consequences.

One more day and she’d be able to.

They took their place in line, and the seconds felt like hours as the guards scrutinized the prisoners. She tapped the side of her leg incessantly, eyes darting around.

When the alarm rang, her body stiffened.

Dr. Strauss quickly entered the vicinity, and everyone dropped to their knees, keeping their eyes fixated on the ground.

“How are you all doing today?” Dr. Strauss asked, abnormally cheerful.

No one dared to respond as he walked through the long lines of prisoners, checking his clipboard.

The faster this would go. The faster they would get home.

Home.

Where her family was. Winnie. Serene. Derek. Adan.

She glanced over at Takeshi, her heart expanding, piercing through the dark environment around her.

Dr. Strauss’ boots came closer, and she pulled her wandering gaze back to the ground, waiting for him to choose the next unfortunate prisoner to be taken away to the unknown.

“Interesting,” he muttered just behind her shoulder. She flinched, feeling the heat of his stare burn into the back of her neck.

Keep walking. Keep walking.

“Let’s go with you today.”

Khalani didn’t know who he was addressing. She lifted her head to find other prisoners peeking at her, their eyes alight with fear, pity, and a glimmer of relief.

Suddenly, two guards were at her side, lifting her aggressively under her armpits. She screamed, kicking and fighting back with everything she had, but they merely lifted her off the ground like a toy.

“NO!”

A bellowing roar erupted behind her.

It sounded like punches were being thrown, and a few guards yelled, fear coating their voices before the buzzing of shock cuffs activated.

Takeshi’s voice continued ringing out in agony and fury. She tried to turn her head, but the Dealers forcefully dragged her away, with Dr. Strauss’ footsteps following closely behind.

Panic surged through her chest as they crossed the cavern toward the black building. Sliding glass doors she never noticed before opened, and she was pulled inside the dark structure.

She struggled relentlessly against her captors as they dragged her further into what appeared to be a…reception area.

A young woman in a white pantsuit sat behind a large marble desk. Her blonde hair was pulled tight into a high bun, and her narrow gaze fell on Khalani, lips pursing in disgust.

But when Dr. Strauss entered, she stood immediately, a wide smile plastered on her face.

“Good morning, Dr. Strauss.”

“Good morning, Rebecca. It’s going to be a good day today. I can feel it.” Dr. Strauss walked past her without a glance.

Rebecca flushed, watching him leave and adjusting her outfit. Once he left, she sat, quietly beaming to herself. Khalani nearly gagged as the guards followed Dr. Strauss, carrying her through double doors.

Her eyes widened as they entered a lab.

The lights were drawn low and multiple empty gurneys lined up in neat rows. But what really drew her gaze were the several glass pods along the wall, filled with bubbling blue liquid.

When she got a closer look at one of the tubes, she screamed, frantically trying to scramble back, but the guards held her firmly.

Floating in each tube were the prisoners chosen from previous inspections.

Khalani's eyes locked onto the female prisoner selected yesterday. Her arms floated limply by her sides, her brown hair spread out behind her. The girl's eyes were completely shut, and a thin plastic tube was inserted into her nose and mouth.

Was she alive?

Khalani's gaze darted to the other glass tubes filled with prisoners, none of whom appeared conscious.

"W-what the hell is this place?" she stammered, dread filling her lungs as the guards forced her deeper into the lab.

Dr. Strauss ignored her and walked toward another male in the room who wore a similar white lab coat. He was younger, with short blond hair, his sharp eyes scanning a screen in front of the pod.

"How are we looking today, Seth?"

Seth lifted his head and glanced at the old prisoner floating in the liquid. "One one five zero didn't make it through the night."

Dr. Strauss tsked and studied the screen himself.

"Damnit. This continues to prove that age is a limiting factor. Something we need to fix." He tapped his chin, deep in thought. "Empty him out and acidify the remains. What about the other subjects?"

"Subjects remain stable," Seth stated, switching his gaze to the young girl that was taken yesterday. "One one four five continues to present with hyper beta wave activity after her preliminary session. Band frequency stabilization is unlikely at this point. We may need to dispose."

"Hmm." Dr. Strauss studied another chart, his calculating gaze intent on the screen.

The Dealers maintained a tight grip around her arms as they waited in the center of the room. For what, she wasn't sure. But with every exchange between the two doctors the sweat along her brow increased and her knees weakened.

"Let's give it another day. If there's no improvement in her chart, we terminate the subject from the trial," Dr. Strauss said without remorse.

"Yes, sir." Seth nodded, looking at Khalani for the first time. She recoiled at the emptiness in his gaze, but all she hit were the hard arms of

the Dealers holding her.

She was completely and utterly trapped.

Dr. Strauss finally turned to her, his expression cold and devoid of sympathy. “Put her on the gurney there.”

She thrashed and fought like a demon unleashed from hell. She dug her nails into their arms, trying everything to break free, but Khalani was no match for their brute strength. The Dealers eventually got her on the gurney and put straps over her body.

When she managed to kick one of them in the face as they tied her thigh, the Dealer growled, retaliating with a hard punch to her stomach. She heaved in a choking breath, her abs screaming in pain as the guards took advantage and finished securing the straps around her.

Khalani couldn’t move. Could barely focus. Her blood pressure plummeted when she heard the only exit slamming and locking shut, trapping her with two mad scientists.

Dr. Strauss leaned over her, staring down at Khalani with an odd expression. A gleam of excitement flickered in his eyes, as if this was his favorite part of the day.

“You’re a pretty one,” he remarked.

Khalani spat in his face, eyes burning with vitriol.

Dr. Strauss didn’t react with anger as she expected. He merely smirked, wiping the saliva off his chin, and smearing it against the fabric covering her ribs.

“Attitude is optimal for the aftereffects. You also appear to have a strong will to live. That’s good. Should help with the next phase.”

Her brows furrowed as Dr. Strauss moved out of her line of sight. She tried to lift her head, but the black strap around her forehead held her captive.

She could feel Seth’s creepy gaze on her, the anticipation heavy in the air. Shifting her hands, she attempted to stretch her fingers toward the latch of the strap, but Dr. Strauss reappeared, rolling a metal tray beside her.

“Now, I can’t say this will be pleasant,” he began, organizing several instruments on the tray. “But if you just accept it, this will go a lot easier for you.”

Khalani’s eyes widened at the sharp knives glinting menacingly on the tray. A cramp formed in her neck, and she could barely inhale.

Breathe. *Just breathe*, she told herself.

What she needed to do was stall him for as long as possible.

If she kept Dr. Strauss talking, maybe the Aces could save her in time.

“What are you going to do to me? What’s the point of your research?” she asked frantically.

Dr. Strauss’ eyes brightened as he turned toward her. “I’m so glad you’re interested. Most just scream, never understanding the gift I’m about to give them. Seth, grab the chip.”

“You’re telling the subject?” Seth asked in shock.

“Perhaps learning their purpose will have a positive impact on the trial data. We’ll study the effects. If it doesn’t work, the subject will be terminated. Grab it.” His voice hardened when he wasn’t immediately obeyed.

Seth walked away without a word and shortly returned, handing something to Dr. Strauss. Dr. Strauss smiled and held it in front of her face.

It was a small green chip, similar to the mini circuit board she’d seen once as a child. In school, the teachers showed pictures of old computers, wanting to teach the youth how obsessed humans were with technology and how only through our trust in the Governor of Apollo could they attain peace and order.

“This is a very special device,” Dr. Strauss explained, holding the chip steady. “It’s a transmitter chip. The purpose is to take over certain functions, like an override system. *This* is what we’ll be inserting into your brain.”

Her mouth fell open and every ounce of blood drained from her face.

Inserting…into her brain.

The sheer notion was more invasive and terrifying than anything her worst nightmares could have conjured.

Keep him talking!

Keep him talking!

“W…w-why?” Her breaths were shallow, and it was the only word she could form.

Dr. Strauss sighed, seemingly displeased by her unenthusiastic response.

“Simply put, humans have a knack for rebelling against authority. If left to our own devices, we elicit destruction at every corner. History never lies. Nor does it fail to repeat. To put a stop to that, we need a strict hand to guide us into a better future. And once this proves successful, we’ll distribute these chips to the other underground cities, starting with Apollo.”

Her chest heaved as his words sank in.

They were implanting chips into people’s heads to turn them into mindless puppets.

She licked her lips, her mouth suddenly dry as images of the Governor flashed in her head. Alexander Huxley was a machine that controlled their lives without anyone knowing.

Could this be connected?

“You mentioned humans.” She swallowed tightly. “Does that include you?”

For the first time, Dr. Strauss frowned, almost as if he couldn’t compute what she said. “I…yes. Of course that would include me. Wh-why w-wouldn’t it?” He looked down in thought and his neck twitched momentarily.

“You alright, sir?” Seth stepped forward.

Dr. Strauss shook his head and straightened. “Yes. Of course, I’m fine. Now, where were we? Ah, yes! Where you come into play.” He returned the chip to Seth and his expression transformed back to glee, as if the past few seconds didn’t even happen.

Dr. Strauss donned blue elastic gloves. “We’ve learned that to get your brain to accept the change, certain areas need to be impaired—primarily the temporal lobe and the limbic system. Unfortunately, a certain level of pain is necessary for this type of degradation. It’s unavoidable, I’m afraid. But now that you understand the great purpose you’ll serve to better our community, I’m sure you’ll accept this with open arms.”

He grabbed a long scalpel from the tray and started cutting her white uniform open, revealing her bare thigh.

“I don’t accept anything! You’re fucking insane!” She pushed against the restraints with all her strength, but they wouldn’t budge.

Dr. Strauss frowned but lowered the sharp blade toward her skin.

“No! No! Please don’t!”

Dr. Strauss paused and he actually gave her a warm smile. “You’ll thank me for this one day.”

Then he pressed the cold blade to her leg and began cutting.

She screamed and thrashed against the restraints, tears streaming down her face as her voice choked and cracked in agony, begging him to stop, pleading for someone to save her.

But no one answered, and her cries of terror stayed within the dark corners of the room.

She screamed till her voice was raw and blackness crept into her vision. Seconds later, her eyes drifted closed, granting her a merciful escape from the pain.

If there was one prayer Khalani needed answered…it was to never wake up.

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29

Ruin waits for no one.

Takeshi

They had her.

Khalani.

Kanes.

His reason.

When Khalani was carried away from him, a blanket of shadows covered Takeshi’s vision, his fury igniting to levels few had ever lived to witness.

The electric pain tearing through his body felt like molten wires clenching around his spine. Even then, it took the highest voltage possible to knock him unconscious and keep Takeshi from murdering every last Dealer beneath the surface.

When Takeshi finally awakened, both his hands were chained around a metal bar in the open cavern.

A Dealer kept a close eye on him, barking orders for him to stay seated with his legs stretched out. The guard’s hand coiled tight around his gun, holding it for dear life.

As if that would save him.

The second Takeshi was free of these chains, he’d sprint to the black building and eviscerate any guard in his path.

In another part of his mind, he mused over various torture techniques.

The Dealers would merely die for their involvement. But Dr. Strauss would receive a special version of hell so painful that bathing in fire would be considered a respite.

His gaze flickered again to the building where she was taken, and he discreetly tugged on the chains, searching for a weak point. His shoulders strained tight, but the pain was inconsequential.

All that mattered to him was taken away.

Before Khalani, Takeshi had resigned himself to a life without love. His unspent torment, regret, and fury were channeled into locking criminals behind bars each dark night.

But then, a lonely girl, whose head barely reached his chest, walked into prison.

At first, he dismissed her as an insignificant nuisance, no different from the countless other prisoners in Braderhelm.

The fragile figure before him seemed ready to shatter under the weight of a single breath, and he doubted that she'd survive one week in Braderhelm Prison.

But when Khalani wasn't looking, his attention unconsciously drifted to her. There was something in her expression that caught him off guard.

Maybe it was the loneliness in her gaze. The tension that never left her shoulders. Or her naïve, kind heart that stood out amid a sea of criminals, making him continuously resist the urge to shake her.

What he didn't realize was that a fierce tenacity lived within that small frame. Despite the constant fights, hardships, and challenges she faced, Khalani conquered each one with a resilience that rivaled the most violent criminals.

When she asked him to train her, Takeshi's muscles locked up, and he fought the urge to throw away the keys to her cell for even suggesting such a terrible idea.

For her. For him.

With the way his mind kept straying to her, he didn't trust himself to be that close without steel bars separating them.

But a dangerous part of him longed to see just how far he could push her, yearning to find her breaking point.

So, he agreed.

With each training session, the pull toward her became harder to resist. The tight shorts hugging her legs were a test of focus. The exhilaration in her eyes when she conquered a task challenged his own resolve. He pushed Khalani like he pushed himself, to the ultimate limits.

Suddenly, Takeshi found a new purpose in prison.

Khalani Kanes was it.

He never told her this, but the trainings with her were the highlight of his day, his year. In a world so shrouded in darkness, she was a flicker of light

that grew brighter with each passing day.

For the first time, he closed his eyes at night and looked forward to waking up.

But when he saw Khalani on the ground during Guard Barron's attack, a rage like no other coursed through his quaking limbs.

Someone dared hurt her. The prisoner who brought him peace. The broken girl who had her entire world swept away but kept fighting to be a better version of herself.

Takeshi completely lost it and killed Guard Barron without a single ounce of regret.

When he lifted Khalani into his arms, she fit perfectly against his chest. Takeshi gazed down at her, and as certain as the oncoming night, an unspoken vow resonating deep within him.

No one would harm her and live.

He carried Khalani to his room, uncaring of the rules or consequences. All that mattered was laying in his bed. In pain.

Despite this, she was the one trying to calm *him* down, still thinking about others over herself. His lungs ached to scream at her, but his lips begged to brush against her smooth skin, to extinguish any traces of pain.

Takeshi's control was at its most fragile point when she lay next to him in bed and his finger grazed hers. His hand twitched, wanting to thread itself into hers.

No, he wanted to do so much more.

But she fell asleep, exhaling softness, while he inhaled her peace.

When Takeshi woke, he stared into her lovely, sleeping face, and a strange sensation clutched his chest. It injected straight into his heart, compelling Takeshi to reach out.

To tell her the truth…but he pulled back.

Reality crashed into him, like a steel door slamming shut in his face.

Nothing would change their positions. She was still a prisoner, and he was the Captain who locked her bars shut. No reality existed where they could be together. Such fantasies were delusional.

So, he pushed her away.

And every day it clawed his skin from the inside out.

His mind kept screaming, urging him to reach out, to make everything right, to return to the way they used to be. By the slimmest thread of

control, Takeshi kept his distance, reminding himself that it was for her benefit.

When she beat Dana in the pit, he didn't merely feel proud—he was always proud of her—but when she finally realized her own strength, it was like the sun burst through the underground and shined down upon her.

Khalani was always beautiful, even covered in dirt and grime, but witnessing her determination and relentless spirit made his heart stir, something it hadn't done in years.

She cast a spell on him, drawing him further in with each passing day, and Takeshi was helpless to ask to train her again.

Just one last time, he told himself.

That would be it.

But then she opened her soul to him, and no force beneath the surface could've stopped him from kissing her.

There once was a cliff in Apollo that Takeshi used to dive from as a kid. It wasn't very tall, but all the local kids would stuff mattresses under the drop zone and leap off, one after the other.

His mother only saw him do it once before she ran over, grabbed his arm, and pulled him back inside, yelling at him for scaring her half to death. But in that one moment of free-fall, he was weightless, and nothing mattered in the world but the air flowing over his body.

That's what kissing Khalani felt like.

He wanted to dive into her skin and memorize every freckle, bump, and imperfection—everything that made Khalani uniquely her—because every square inch was a masterpiece.

In the casino, he was incredibly close to knocking Raziel unconscious, wrecking their mission, and taking her away so no one else could lay their eyes on her in that fucking dress.

Raziel reminded Takeshi to play his part correctly.

But he wasn't pretending.

Every touch and moment with her made him hyperaware of his body.

Nothing else took up space in his mind. Nothing else mattered.

And that was the problem.

Takeshi wasn't talkative or affectionate. He preferred to spend his time studying everyone else for weaknesses.

He never spoke of the eerie sensation inside him. The discomforting need for destruction that'd been present ever since he graduated from

training in Genesis.

Takeshi hid those volatile thoughts well. But that side of him had grown in intensity ever since he tore off the Governor’s head.

But when Takeshi was with her, he wanted to be the opposite.

He yearned to give her, the beautiful girl who dwelled in the dark, the same peace she’d selflessly given him.

Khalani accepted Takeshi for who he was, not who she wanted him to be.

So, he was done.

Done denying her. Done fighting this inexplicable pull between them.

His eyes closed as the right word finally surfaced. Love.

He loved her.

Loved her with every ounce of his being.

Loved her like the stars love the night sky.

And once freedom was theirs, he’d spend every moment proving it.

The Dealer continued to watch him with tense eyes as Takeshi discreetly pulled on the chains.

When the prisoners finished their morning shift, they entered the cavern for food. The head Dealer strode over, his pale hand resting on the butt of his rifle, the stars on his black uniform gleaming under the harsh, white light.

“You finally calmed down, or do we need to shock you again?”

Takeshi gritted his teeth, fighting the urge to spit in the guard’s direction. But he held tightly to his thin control, thinking of only one person.

“You won’t have any problems from me.” Lies. They would face plenty of problems from him soon enough, but he needed to bide his time and wait for the perfect opportunity.

“Good.” The Dealer stepped forward and unlocked Takeshi’s chains.

He stood, stretching his tight shoulders and caught Jack’s sharp eye across the cavern.

Jack inclined his head, a signal.

Tingles spread across Takeshi’s body as he walked over, constantly swiveling his head toward the black building.

The logical part of him kept repeating the same reminder. As much as he wanted, he couldn’t just go barreling across the cavern and breaking down the door. The Dealers would simply shock him again.

But who knew what horrors they were inflicting on her right now?

How scared she must be.

“Hey.” Ryder snapped his fingers as he sat with them. “I know what you’re thinking, but you have a better chance of saving her once the Aces arrive.”

“And when is that exactly?” he seethed.

Jack took a deep breath and massaged the bridge of his nose. “I don’t know.”

The bowl of food they gave him nearly cracked in his hands.

“Tell me what we’re supposed to do again when your group arrives?” Elise asked, her whole body tense. She kept glancing at the black building too, the worry for Khalani evident in her eyes.

She could live.

“I’ve already informed some of the other prisoners here that I trust. Once the Aces arrive, most of the Dealers will head for the main tunnel. That should leave only a few guards keeping an eye on the prisoners, and they can’t shock everyone at once. That’s when we attack. We overwhelm them, deactivate the cuffs, grab their weapons, and help the Aces fight,” Jack stated, his voice strengthening with each word.

“What about the ones who can’t fight?” Elise’s gaze locked on her strange father, who kept muttering over his ring.

“They should stay the hell out of our way.” Ryder cracked his knuckles as he eyed the guards.

Takeshi sat calmly, but his mind was anything but. He scanned each Dealer, studying their vulnerabilities, looking for any way to exploit them in the most painful way possible. Ungodly pressure raced up his spine as his focus centered on the building across the cavern.

Takeshi used to believe that not kissing Khalani was the ultimate test of patience. Laughable. He’d go a thousand lifetimes without touching her if it meant she’d be free of torment.

“What’s important is that we all rush the guards at the same time,” Jack continued. “If we don’t get this right, we all d—”

A low rumble echoed throughout the cavern.

Everyone whipped their heads toward the tunnel on the opposite side of the camp. The only exit out of the prison.

An empty mine cart raced past the guards on the bumpy metal tracks and stopped in the center of the cavern.

The Dealers brandished their guns, their confused expressions turning lethal. A few brave guards slowly approached the cart, the lines in their forehead deepening.

Takeshi stood with the rest of the prisoners. Everyone arched their necks, trying to get a better look. Jack nodded to him, and he quietly shifted toward the remaining guards while their attention was riveted on the cart.

“What is it?” The head Dealer yelled as one of the larger guards peaked inside. Everyone held their breath as he reached inside and grabbed an oversized teddy bear.

“It’s just a stuffed toy,” he shouted back, holding it up.

The Dealer immediately went rigid, raising his hand in slow motion. “WAIT—”

BOOM.

The teddy bear exploded.

The man holding it disintegrated into pink mist.

The force of the blast threw Takeshi back against the stone wall. His ears sang a high-pitched tune and dust filled the air.

Takeshi tasted blood in his mouth and grunted as he slowly got to his feet. He rubbed his ringing ears, disoriented as horrifying screams amplified around him.

As the dust began to clear, his eyes raced across the multiple prisoners and the Dealers unconscious on the ground. Ryder was helping a stumbling Jack to his feet.

Takeshi’s chest tightened when he saw Elise shaking her father on the ground. His leg and arm were bent at an awkward angle, clearly broken, as he mumbled into Elise’s ear, trying to lift his hand toward her. Tears streamed down her chalky face as she tried to get him to move.

Takeshi turned away. He knew a mortal wound when he saw one.

“It’s the rebels!” the head Dealer yelled, blood running from his head down his pale cheek.

Through the dusty cavern, more than a dozen men appeared, revolvers in hand. Takeshi recognized Spade in front, leading the charge. He’d traded his crisp suit for black leather pants and a black cape. He shouted orders to his men as they charged ahead.

The head Dealer lifted his gun shakily and fired at them. The Aces ducked for cover behind various rocks, returning fire.

Despite the bomb, the Dealers still outnumbered the Aces and rushed forward, continuing to shoot.

Takeshi twisted his head as Jack limped toward him.

“Now.” Jack gritted his teeth and nodded to a couple of other male prisoners who crept behind an unsuspecting guard and choked him from behind.

Takeshi didn’t waste another second. He found the nearest Dealer rising to his feet. Without hesitation or remorse, he rushed him. Takeshi punched the guard twice in the stomach, wrapped his arms around his head, and swiftly broke his neck. The man’s body fell to the ground in a forgotten, lifeless heap.

It all happened in a matter of seconds.

A nearby guard turned at the sound and his mouth popped open.

With unsteady hands, he lifted his gun, but Takeshi was faster. He pulled a blade from the dead man’s belt and threw it across the space. The dagger embedded into the Dealer’s shoulder, throwing off his aim.

That was enough time for Takeshi to charge the guard, slamming him to the ground. He straddled him and punched the wide-eyed Dealer in the face.

Takeshi wanted to continue the onslaught, but unfortunately, he didn’t have time for that.

He pulled the pistol from the man’s pocket, wrestling his mouth open. Takeshi shoved the barrel between his lips and pulled the trigger.

Blood splattered across Takeshi’s murderous face. He wanted to bathe in it, that need for violence inside him growing stronger.

He reached into the guard’s back pocket and pulled out a touchpad. It had facial recognition, and luckily, only the back of the guard’s head was unrecognizable.

After some searching, Takeshi found the option to deactivate his shock cuff. He immediately pulled the bands off his wrists, throwing them against the wall, the satisfying clang echoing back to him.

Takeshi swiveled his head to Jack and Ryder, who were in the middle of removing their cuffs.

A cacophony of screams and gunfire surrounded them as the Aces continued to fire their weapons at the Dealers, providing the distraction they needed.

“Go!” Jack yelled. “We’ll take care of the rest. Go save her.”

He didn’t need to be told twice.

Takeshi grabbed the handgun and removed the knife from the dead man’s shoulder.

Takeshi sprinted along the back wall, away from the gunfire. He tightened his grip on the weapons as he prepared to draw blood.

He ran faster than he’d ever had in his life, his focus locked intently on the black building.

And death rode behind him like a pair of wings.

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If you stay silent for what is wrong,
you won’t be able to stand for what is right.

If misery possessed a name.

The Earth would remember Khalani Kanes.

The crumbling walls of her home were built upon grief. The uneven floors were scattered with heartbreak. And the patchy ceiling had been battered by disaster.

Behind bars, she’d fought to redefine her destiny. She wanted her story shaped not by suffering, but by her quiet lessons in forgiveness, love, and a monstrous will to defy death.

But no matter which direction she ran or how tightly she shut her eyes, ruin refused to let her escape its clutches.

Khalani’s head rolled, and her heavy eyelids stirred.

Everything hurt.

Pain was as constant as the oxygen surrounding her. She inhaled the coarse despair and sobbed softly.

Khalani lost track of how long she’d been tortured. Her arms and legs had been dissected like flayed meat by the time she blissfully passed out.

The cruelest surprise was when she first woke to find that her limbs had no deep cuts or evidence of mutilation. Her skin was smooth, almost perfect. Like the torture was only a figment of her imagination.

The first time Dr. Strauss carved illustrations into her skin like a kid with a demented crayon collection, he told her that Hermes developed a serum capable of healing wounds at a rapid rate.

So, he continued cutting her skin away, layer by layer, until all that remained were her brittle bones. And when she passed out, he’d simply wait for her to awaken, only to start all over again.

Seconds felt like weeks. Hours transitioned to decades.

She stopped talking long ago. Whenever she begged him to stop, Dr. Strauss merely *grinned* and dug the scalpel deeper into her skin.

Seth, the other doctor, stood nearby, his eyes fixed on a screen displaying strange, curved lines, as he adjusted the nodes attached to her temples and the back of her head. He remained stone-faced, even as she screamed so hard that her voice cracked, and all that escaped her mouth was a silent wave of agony.

There had to be peace. Reprieve.

But not even sleep kept her in its protective embrace.

Her eyes moved behind her eyelids as the sound of shuffling feet approached.

“Looks like our pretty subject is awake.”

No.

No!

Just let me die.

Khalani shook her head, tears slipping down her cheeks as Dr. Strauss appeared above her, holding one of his sharp, bloody instruments. She trembled as he lowered the scalpel to her knee, her body bracing for the impending agony.

BOOM.

The whole building shook and several instruments fell off the tray.

“What was that?” Seth asked, frantically looking around.

Dr. Strauss put down the instrument and snapped off his blue gloves, rushing out of the room. But Khalani’s body still quaked.

In the back of her mind, it felt like she was waiting for something…or *someone*. But she had a hard time recalling *who*.

Losing her memory. Her identity…

Your name is Khalani. Your name is Khalani.

She repeated the phrase, fighting to remember who she once was.

When the terrifying sound of Dr. Strauss’ footsteps returned, her shaking intensified into full-blown tremors. She bit her lip so hard that blood painted her teeth.

“The rebels have broken into the camp,” Dr. Strauss snarled, rushing to the computers. “Activate the remaining subjects.”

Seth paled. “But, sir! They’re not ready.”

“Do it!”

Seth jolted and scrambled to a keyboard, typing furiously.

It sounded like water boiling behind her.

Khalani managed to tilt her head ever so slightly and found the pods the prisoners were floating in were slowly being drained of whatever blue liquid was inside them.

Her muscles shook as the glass casings opened and the prisoners stepped out, completely naked.

They stood like statues, eyes vacant, droplets of water tracing down their skin, pooling on the floor.

“What are your orders?” Seth asked, gulping as his eyes darted to the motionless bodies.

“Have them attack the rebels.” Dr. Strauss’ focus remained locked on the computer screen.

Seth turned, swallowing nervously. “But what about—”

He jolted, blood seeping out of his mouth. Her eyes widened as Seth collapsed to the floor, a massive knife protruding from his back.

A broader figure stepped through the doorway.

The dim lights above flickered, casting brief flashes of light across the intruder’s bloody face and white uniform.

“Takeshi,” she whispered, his name returning to her like an answered prayer.

His dark eyes locked onto Khalani strapped to the gurney, and the energy was sucked out of the room.

In an instant, Takeshi wrenched the knife out of Seth’s back and rushed to her side, sawing through her bindings.

It was only then that she noticed the tremor in his hands. His cold eyes roved over her body, searching for injuries.

Physically, he wouldn’t find any, thanks to the advanced medicine she’d been continuously administered. But her mind…

“I’m so sorry, Khalani. I came as fast as I could.” His expression was broken beyond repair as he looked down on her.

But all that repeated through her sluggish brain was one thing.

He came for her.

He didn’t abandon her like she’d nearly given up on herself.

A single tear slipped down her cheek, and Takeshi tensed, watching it fall. His jaw clenched as he ferociously cut through the last bindings when a figure punched him in the head, knocking Takeshi off his feet.

Her mouth fell open as the gun hidden in Takeshi’s pocket flew across the floor.

“Takeshi!” she shouted as one of the expressionless prisoners from the pod charged him. Takeshi flipped to his feet and quickly brandished the knife, meeting his attacker head-on.

The prisoner was fast—faster than humanly possible—easily dodging every strike.

Khalani gnashed her teeth, trying to wriggle free from the final binding holding her to the gurney. More punches and heavy hits echoed around the cold lab, and she yelled as she broke through the last restraint and stood on shaky feet.

The symphony in her chest raced to a cataclysmic crescendo as Takeshi grunted, wrestling with his attacker on the ground.

She bolted for the gun, snatched it up, and aimed at the prisoner Takeshi was fighting.

But she hesitated.

The prisoner might have family back in Hermes who loved him. There still might be a part of him deep inside, pounding against the cages of his mind, begging to be let free.

But Khalani steeled herself, her finger tightening around the trigger.

To protect those she cared for, she’d do *whatever it took*.

The problem was, Takeshi and the prisoner’s bodies were rolling, centimeters away from one another. She wasn’t as good a shot as Brock and there was a high risk her bullet would hit Takeshi instead.

The prisoner slammed his fist into Takeshi’s face again, like a boulder slamming down, and Takeshi coughed up blood.

Think, Khalani.

Think!

Dr. Strauss was on the far side of the lab, frantically typing away on his computer. The other prisoners stood motionless, like lifeless puppets.

But with another rapid flurry across the keyboard, their blank expressions shifted. One by one, they slowly turned their heads toward Takeshi.

And they began to march forward.

Takeshi was already struggling with one of Dr. Strauss’ creations. How would he be able to handle five?

He couldn’t.

Her hands trembled around the pistol as the other prisoners got closer, their sole focus on Takeshi.

She raised her gun and without hesitation pulled the trigger. Sparks flew at the end of the room, and Dr. Strauss leaped back.

Her heart sank when she realized her bullet hadn’t struck him at all.

Instead, it hit his computer.

The prisoners continued advancing, but something strange happened. They stuttered in their steps, each one pausing intermittently as their heads twitched.

Takeshi seized the opportunity and stabbed the prisoner on top of him in the throat. He twisted the knife, ripping out a chunk of the man’s jugular. The prisoner toppled to the ground, still reaching for Takeshi, like he needed to complete his orders, even in that ruined state.

Takeshi rose, slower than usual, his chest heaving. The remaining prisoners kept advancing, despite their limbs convulsing uncontrollably.

The creepy vision would supply her nightmares forever.

She raised the gun once more, shooting the prisoner on the far right. The bullet struck him in the shoulder, and the prisoner staggered, but he didn’t make a sound of pain or even flinch. He continued advancing forward, ignoring the blood leaking from his shoulder.

“Takeshi! We need to go!”

Takeshi’s fist tightened as his turbulent gaze fixed on Dr. Strauss, but the prisoners closed in, blocking their view.

“Takeshi, please!” Her voice broke, and that made Takeshi run back to her. He took the gun and wrapped a protective arm around her.

“Let’s go.”

They sprinted out of the lab and into the reception area.

The woman from before sat motionless at the desk. Khalani spared her only a brief glance, noticing her mouth hanging open and a gaping bullet hole through the center of her forehead. Without a second thought, Khalani looked away, refusing to waste even a moment of sympathy on the cruel woman.

She had heard Khalani screaming but didn’t say anything. Didn’t protest. Only came in once to ask Dr. Strauss if he would like some coffee.

Silence is support.

They burst out of the black building, and Khalani took a deep breath, nearly crumpling from the torture she’d endured. But Takeshi held her

upright, his arms tightening around her waist.

“I’m going to get us out of here,” he promised, his eyes burning with conviction. She nodded, drawing from his strength as chaos erupted around them.

Gunshots and screams rang out as lines of Dealers charged forward, firing at the Aces who retreated toward the tunnel entrance. About twenty stood firm, and Khalani’s pulse raced as she noticed several bodies lying motionless on the ground.

She recognized Spade, Raziel, and a few men from the Black Heart helping Jack and Ryder as they limped toward safety.

Relief flooded her when she spotted Elise and several other prisoners flanking the cavern, dodging bullets as they made their way to the tunnel.

Tears streamed down Elise’s face, and Khalani’s eyes widened.

Where was her father?

But then, someone else came into view.

“Brock!”

“There they are!” Brock screamed, turning to Takeshi and Khalani as they raced forward. Brock fired at another Dealer, hitting him squarely in the chest. More shots rained down and everyone ducked.

“We’re too outnumbered. Prepare to seal the tunnels!” Spade waved his arm, and everyone began retreating.

Takeshi pushed Khalani ahead, covering her back.

“Keep going,” he commanded. “Don’t stop, Kanes.”

Brock ran alongside her, glancing at her—and even Takeshi—with relief. He had deep lines under his eyes, as if he’d been nonstop worrying the entire week. Shots fired behind them, some zipping dangerously close.

One hundred feet ahead, dozens of empty transports waited.

“Go! Go! Go!” Spade yelled.

Half of the survivors scrambled into the vehicles, engines roaring to life as they sped off into the distance.

“Get ready to fire!” Raziel gestured to a man standing nearby with a metal device in his hands.

They were almost to the tunnel when another flurry of gunshots thundered out. Khalani ducked her head, still running furiously, when a deafening roar rang behind her, followed by a heavy crash.

Khalani stopped and turned.

Her body froze as Takeshi collapsed to the ground, a puddle of blood

pooling across his back.

It felt as if time had come to a standstill. Each bullet suspended in midair. The terrifying screams faded into silence.

No.

Not Takeshi.

Not fucking Takeshi.

Takeshi lifted his head and searched for her, his gaze filled with longing.

As if she were the only thing he ever wanted to see in the world.

“Go,” he mouthed.

Like hell.

Khalani ran back for him, but Brock snatched her around the waist, lifting her off the ground.

“No! Get off me! We need to get him!”

She kicked and screamed, fighting him with all her might. Twisting her head, she saw the remaining Dealers rushing the tunnel. Running *toward Takeshi*, who struggled to rise, but his large body collapsed back to the ground.

“Brock, go back! We have to save him!” she cried, but Brock squeezed her tighter, his strong arms carrying her toward one of the empty transports.

“I’m sorry, Khalani. We can’t save him.” His voice was more distressed than she’d ever heard. But it didn’t matter.

What mattered was the man who knew her better than anyone else in the world—the man who had helped her find her strength, who pushed her when she needed it and embraced her dark heart, was just beyond her reach.

Khalani continued to thrash and fight against Brock like a feral monster.

A world without Takeshi was a living prison she didn’t want to survive in.

“Go fucking back! Please go back!!”

She refused to accept it. Khalani would gladly return to the black building and endure a million more torturous sessions if it meant Takeshi was safe.

Her furious screams continued to bounce around them, but everyone ignored her.

Brock carried her struggling body past the tunnel entrance, and Raziel nodded to the man with the device. He clicked a button, and the entrance shook.

An explosion rang out and rocks tumbled down, sealing the tunnel.

“NO!!”

Tears of agony streamed down her face as she was loaded into the transport. Her last glimpse was of the Dealers surrounding Takeshi, guns raised, while he lay unconscious on the ground.

Rocks blocked her blurry vision, and it felt like her heart stopped beating. Like her body couldn’t handle the pain and shut everything down.

Because the last thing she heard before the transport sped off into the dark abyss…was the fatal sound of a final gunshot.

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If I forget you, I forget the world.

If my heart could speak
The beats would lament and roar
I think it would terrorize my flesh
Refashion me from the inside out
Take all the power from me
And not let my doubts do the talking.

I thought time was on my side
That the end was some mystical line
One I would face when my knees grew weak
And you were as ancient as I
But time possesses no allies
Tomorrow comes, with or without you
Try to stop the pendulum from swinging
And you'll miss the world passing you by

If my heart could speak
It would present its scars as a warning sign
To not let your words go unheard
To not rely on time to fix relationships
Because if my heart could have spoken
It would've said everything you meant to me
So I wouldn't have to find closure apart from you.

Khalani let the felt-tipped pen slip from her fingers. Her journal fell next, hitting the hard ground as if it, too, could no longer endure the vocation of misery within its pages.

She stared blankly at the pristine white sheets neatly folded on the bed.

She used to enjoy sitting on the floor.

If Khalani concentrated hard enough, she could remember the soft glow in Douglas's eyes when he first spotted her, a lonely figure eating scraps on the cobblestone streets of Apollo all those years ago.

He used to be the only person she could open up to without fear of judgment or misunderstanding.

Some people want friends for conversation.

Khalani wanted those who didn't need to fill the silence.

But when Douglas died, he took a part of her with him.

And Takeshi…

A treacherous tear slipped from the corner of her eye.

All the losses she'd endured seemed to pale in comparison to the torment she felt now. Her skin prickled, stretched too tight, as if it might tear apart.

Khalani didn't eat. Didn't sleep.

She'd lost track of the days since their escape from the prison camp. The transport ride to Hermes had been hours of jarring bumps and suffocating quiet.

Brock kept glancing back at her. Khalani's stare was vacant, her eyes bloodshot, her body swaying with the wind like an empty vessel ready to tip over.

A part of her *wanted* to fall over. To knock her head out and escape this hellish domain.

That had to be her life's purpose.

To test just how much suffering the human body could endure.

Otherwise, it didn't seem possible that the day after Takeshi and Khalani finally set aside their differences and admitted their feelings for each other…was the day they lost it all.

Bang!

She flinched, rubbing her weary eyes, rocking back and forth as the gunshot replayed relentlessly in her mind.

It couldn't be true.

Takeshi can't…be…

She slammed her head back against the hard wall.

Her body jolted, but she still didn't feel anything. A twisted part of her craved the torture now.

Maybe it wouldn't be such a bad thing to forget…

“Khalani.” Winnie knocked on the door. “Can Winnie come in?”

Khalani didn’t answer. Her gaze remained fixed on the white sheets.

What if she went back?

The idea coiled inside her like a flickering ember ever since their escape.

Takeshi couldn’t be dead.

He was too obstinate. Too stubborn. Too full of *life*.

He’d fought for her survival more times than she could count, and she was beginning to realize that single-minded dedication ran through her, too. She felt it coursing through her veins and in the very air she exhaled.

He saved her. It was her time for her to rescue him.

An indistinct murmuring sounded behind the door before the knob turned slowly. Winnie walked in, but Khalani continued staring straight ahead, running through any feasible plan in her head.

All she needed were weapons and a transport.

Khalani wasn’t exactly sure how to get back to the camp, but she’d find a way, even if it meant scouring through every underground tunnel.

She felt the weight of Winnie’s concerned gaze.

When they returned to the Black Heart, Spade had warned them to stay inside and keep a low profile because the Dealers were looking for the prisoners who’d escaped.

Brock quietly explained to the others what happened to Takeshi, while Winnie and Serene held her in her arms all night as she sobbed.

They never left her side.

In the morning, when she finally got up to use the bathroom, she found Adan sitting outside her door, as if he’d stayed there all night.

Brock was close by, deep lines creasing his forehead, days-old scruff shadowing his face.

Their eyes held an unwavering commitment.

A promise that they wouldn’t let Khalani lose herself. And if she did, she wouldn’t face it alone.

She cried harder when they hugged her, because she’d never felt luckier or more broken.

Khalani was reunited with her family, but it wasn’t complete.

Not even close.

From their downturned eyes and tight expressions, she wasn’t the only one mourning Takeshi.

He may have been brooding, cold, and made you want to sleep with one eye open, but he somehow *fit* into their dysfunctional group.

She noticed the way Takeshi's lips quirked at Serene and Adan's banter, the warmth in his eyes for Winnie, the way his muscles tensed when they were forced to leave Derek behind, and even the begrudging respect he held for Brock.

They were his family, too.

Her fists clenched, chin trembling. Winnie said nothing.

Instead, she sat beside her, resting her head on Khalani's shoulder, and gently intertwined their fingers.

Together, they sat in silence.

Maybe it was only for a few seconds. It could've been hours before Khalani lifted her head.

"How long have I been down here, Winnie?" She cleared her throat, her voice raspy and hoarse.

"Three days. Winnie's come to check on you every day. There's so much she has to tell you, but she knows you're in pain."

Khalani's lips quivered. "It hurts so much, Winnie."

"She knows, sweet girl." Winnie tightened her grip. "It's okay to feel everything. Or nothing at all. Sometimes, emptiness takes up the most space."

Her chest moved shallowly. Her emotions were in such a whirlwind, she didn't know what to do with them. The anger, sadness, and determination were like waking beasts that clawed at her.

How can one body deal with such calamity?

"Winnie, when Sarah died, were you angry?" she asked, breaking the silence.

Sarah was Winnie's only child who'd succumbed to the flu in Apollo because Winnie didn't have enough money for proper medicine.

That story lingered within her, holding a lifespan of its own.

Winnie shifted. For a fleeting moment, Khalani worried she had overstepped, but Winnie interlocked their arms, holding her closer.

"Winnie was very angry. For the longest time, fury was all she had."

"How did you overcome it? How do you see past it?"

"We don't ever see past it," Winnie stated. "Some scars aren't meant to be covered up. Our imperfections and wounds are what make us beautiful, not this perfect façade we try to show the world. We overcome obstacles by

accepting the frailty of life and how precious it is. And for those we have lost, we carry on their memory and live the life they would've wanted for us."

Khalani's chin trembled and her tears rained down like a storm. "It's not fair, Winnie. None of this should've happened. I don't know w-what to do or h-how to handle it."

"Look at me, sweet girl." Winnie cupped her cheeks, her own eyes pooling with tears. "You once told Winnie that she was your favorite teacher, but the truth is, you've taught her more about strength and believing in herself than anyone in the world. *That* is why Winnie knows you'll make it through this. You're her greatest inspiration."

Winnie tenderly wiped away Khalani's tears with her thumbs and gazed deeply into her eyes. The infinite swell of love in those spheres was so vast, an entire universe couldn't contain it.

"I missed you so much, Winnie." Khalani sobbed. "Whenever I'm away from you, everything falls apart."

"Winnie did too, child." Winnie wrapped her in a warm hug. "Like a whale misses singing in the sea."

"What's a whale?" She sniffled.

"Just like Winnie. Big. Beautiful. And terrible at singing."

Khalani's lips pulled into a faint smile.

"Winnie misses Takeshi, too. He had such a big heart that very few understood. Winnie saw it, though." Winnie's voice lowered, her shoulders slumping.

Khalani breathed faster.

He did have a big heart. *Does* have a big heart.

The gnawing ache in her chest expanded, threatening to swallow her whole. And as more time passed, the worse it became.

She needed to go back.

Khalani sat up straighter, urgency coursing through her. "You said there was something else you needed to tell me, Winnie?"

"Winnie has been waiting for you to gather your strength before she told you the news." She paused for dramatic effect, taking a deep breath. "Winnie found it!"

"Found what?" Khalani frowned.

"Prometheus!"

"What do you mean?"

“In the past couple of days, Winnie has been talking to that one girl who escaped with you. Sad but beautiful. A little cold too, but some warming up from Winnie was all it took to thaw her walls.”

“Are you talking about Elise?” Her eyes widened, forgetting that Elise made it back with the other survivors.

“That’s the one!” Winnie snapped her fingers. “Elise. A terrible thing that happened to her father. But after speaking with her the past couple days, she showed Winnie the heirloom her father left behind. His ring.”

“Prometheus Inc.,” Khalani whispered, another fragment of her memory resurfacing.

“Yes!” Winnie threw up her hands. “Winnie immediately knew this must be a clue leading us to Project Helix. While you were at the camp, Adan helped the Aces fix one of their old computers from the Great Collapse. In Hermes, they don’t keep all their knowledge locked away like Apollo did. But after some digging through their Collapse files, he discovered a clue about Prometheus.”

Khalani leaned in. “What did he find?”

“When the residents first settled here during the Great Collapse, they took a census and recorded each person’s former occupation. A few individuals had the words Prometheus Inc. listed.”

“They worked there?” That didn’t make much sense.

“Exactly!” Winnie exclaimed, her eyes glimmering with fierce determination. “Adan located their headquarters. It’s in the remnants of the old California state. After we get Derek back, that’s where we must go next.”

“California,” Khalani repeated. She’d learned about the old states in school but knew very little about that one.

“Yes.” Winnie grasped her hands. “You can’t give up now, Khalani. Takeshi wouldn’t ever let you give up. And the path to Project Helix starts at Prometheus, just like Timothy Talbot said! Once you finish resting up, we can gather supplies and go. We’re in this together, right?”

Khalani could barely breathe through the hole in her chest.

They weren’t all together. A crucial piece was missing, and that meant she couldn’t leave.

Not yet.

But if she revealed her plan to rescue Takeshi, Winnie would either talk her out of it or, worse, insist on accompanying her.

She refused to risk anyone else.

“Of course we’re in this together, Winnie. Maybe we should take a few days to regain our strength, and then we can plan the trip,” she offered.

It might take far longer than a few days to save Takeshi, but Khalani kept that part to herself.

“You’re right, dear.” Winnie nodded. “In fact, we should start gathering our strength now. Come upstairs and eat something. I’m sure everyone would love to see you.”

Khalani licked her chapped lips, only now noticing the severe dryness of her mouth and the painful ache in her stomach that grew more intense by the second.

But Khalani fiddled with the tips of her fingers, digging her nails into her skin.

She didn’t know how to go upstairs. How to hide her intentions. One look at her face, and they’d surely figure out her plans.

“You don’t have to speak with anyone you don’t want to,” Winnie insisted, squeezing her hand tighter. “Winnie and Serene will be right there with you.”

After a moment, Khalani took a deep breath nodding.

Winnie kept her arm linked with Khalani’s as they ascended the stairs and entered the Black Heart.

Keno nodded at them at the top, his expression more anxious and wary than she’d remembered.

As they entered the bar area, Serene rushed forward and wrapped Khalani in a tight embrace.

“Are you okay? I’ve been so worried! Look at your hair! It’s a mess! I’ll fix it. I’ll fix everything. I’m so sorry I wasn’t there for you. Even for him.” Tears shimmered in Serene’s eyes as she held Khalani tighter.

“It’s okay,” Khalani choked out, trying to hold onto her emotions with the little strength she had left.

She wanted to disappear downstairs, so the people she loved wouldn’t have to witness her falling apart.

It was far easier to crumble alone.

“It’s not okay,” Serene stated emphatically. “But we’ll make it better. I’m never letting you out of my sight again. Even when you need to…you know.”

Khalani forced a half-smile, yet another barrier added to her plan.

Adan pulled her in for a hug next. “You alright there, Khalani?”

“As good as I can be,” she replied, her voice barely above a whisper.

Brock brought her a bowl of stew when Khalani sat down, and she raised a brow.

“I know food isn’t going to make up for it.” Brock sighed. “A million bowls might not even make up for what happened. I’m sorry for pulling you away, but you know that’s what he wanted me to do.”

Khalani found it tough to swallow, trying not to break in the crowded room of people staring at her.

“I’m not mad at you, Brock. You did what you had to do. Thank you for coming for us.” She meant the words.

He nodded, his gaze falling to the floor, but he sat close to Serene, who didn’t pull away from him like she used to.

Maybe they’d finally found some common ground while Khalani and Takeshi were away. The thought made her grip the spoon tighter as she forced the food into her mouth.

Everything reminded her of Takeshi. The chill in the air, the light in Winnie’s eyes, the warmth of her friends’ embraces.

She needed to escape tonight.

Khalani noticed Jack and Ryder nearby, speaking with Spade, whose lips pulled into a tight grimace.

Elise sat at a table by herself, playing with the ring on her finger as she stared at the stone floor, her back bent over as if a cinder block weighed down her shoulders.

But before Khalani could get up and speak with her, Spade prowled forward. The few Aces members left in the room glanced up as he spoke.

“We’ve received word that the Dealers are sending patrols through the streets. They’re trying to find out who broke into the camp. They know people escaped and are hiding in Hermes. We need to continue staying low for the next few days, maybe even weeks.”

“Do they know it was us?” one member asked, anxiety creeping into his voice.

“We don’t think so,” Spade replied, running a hand through his hair. “But we can’t be too sure. That’s why we need to be extra cautious. Some of our undercover members will continue to bring supplies here. Once things die down—”

The door to the Black Heart suddenly crashed open, and several Dealers stormed in, weapons drawn.

“Don’t move! We’re searching the place for terrorists.”

“On whose orders?” Spade challenged, stepping forward.

“I don’t need to answer that.” The officer shoved the gun barrel into Spade’s chest, forcing him to raise his hands slowly.

“Check them.”

One of the Dealers held a device to Spade’s head. It beeped and turned red.

Tension filled the room as everyone held their breath. The Dealer continued to scan the heads of various members, each time the device flashing red.

When he approached Jack, the device abruptly flashed green.

“Sir! This is one of the pris—”

His head was blown away in an instant as Ryder discreetly pulled out a gun and blew his brains across the door.

Pandemonium erupted.

Members of the Aces lunged at the Dealers, grappling with them as gunshots rang out. Shots fired toward the back of the room, and everyone ducked for cover.

“This way!” Brock shouted, shielding Serene as they all sprinted toward the side entrance. Gunfire echoed all around them, and Khalani’s heart raced as she pulled Winnie with her.

“Where do we go?” Serene yelled as they burst through the door and emerged onto a dark alley.

“I think we need to…” Brock turned and suddenly stopped. His eyes widened, face paling as if he’d just seen a ghost.

“What?” Khalani turned and her mouth fell open. Emerging from the shadows was a figure clad in black.

Her body trembled and she shook her head in disbelief, her mind playing tricks on her.

The figure stepped under a pulsing streetlamp, revealing his black hair, obsidian eyes, and icy expression.

It was Takeshi.

In the flesh.

Takeshi was *alive*.

She didn’t know how it was possible, but there he stood, impossibly real.

Khalani ran toward him without a second thought.

“Takeshi!’ she yelled, her heart leaping in her chest, feeling weightless, the boiling pressure inside of her unraveling.

“Takeshi!” Khalani cried again, leaping forward.

But he didn’t catch her.

One moment, she was soaring into his arms.

The next, she crashed to the ground, and Takeshi crouched above her, pressing a sharp knife to her throat, spilling blood.

“*How do you know my name*?” he growled, his eyes an unrecognizable, pitch-black void.

Khalani’s heart ceased beating, and before the end, they saw one another only as strangers.

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THE ADVENTURE CONTINUES…

US DEFIANT FEW

COMING SOON

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